# A HOUSE OF GRACES

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A NOVEL OF ROME

AD 111–112

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are the products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Historical figures who appear in these pages are imagined at moments the record does not describe.

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**MATURE CONTENT — 18+**

This novel contains explicit sexual content, sexual coercion, slavery, violence, torture and death. It is intended for adult readers.

Set in EB Garamond
First edition

*"Gratia quae tarda est, ingrata est."*

A favour that comes late is no favour at all.

PUBLILIUS SYRUS

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CHAPTER

# ONE

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The house woke before its mistress, as houses do. By the fourth hour of the December morning the water carrier had come and gone, leaving the courtyard flags dark with spill; the baker's boy had left his basket at the back door and been paid in copper by the cook; and Bathyllus, who kept the door and had once kept the peace in a gladiator's barracks, had already turned away two beggars, a woman selling Egyptian charms, and a young man who claimed to have an appointment and did not.

Antonia Cassia heard all of it from her room above the garden, the way a captain hears his ship. The creak of the well rope. The shuffle of the kitchen slaves sweeping yesterday's ash. The thin, irritable clatter of the secretary's stylus being sharpened on the stone sill. She lay a while longer under the coverlet, because the morning was cold and because lying still was one of the few luxuries she had never learned to be bored by. Then she rose, and Sabina came in with the basin, and the day began.

Sabina was twelve, small for it, with a slave's careful hands and a free child's habit of asking questions. She held the towel while Cassia washed, and said, "There was a man at the door before light. Bathyllus wouldn't wake you."

"What kind of man?"

"A man with a lantern. He had a horse."

"Then he was somebody's man, not his own." Cassia dried her face. "What did he want?"

"He said his master would send word at the proper hour."

"He said it in Latin?"

"He said it in Greek," Sabina said, "and then he said it again in Latin, louder."

Cassia smiled at that, and the smile made her look younger than forty-two and also more dangerous, because it was the smile of a woman who had learned that most men repeat themselves. She let Sabina dress her in a plain stola the colour of undyed wool and a mantle the colour of wine lees, and she put on no gold, and she did not look at the mirror longer than it took to pin her hair. The mirror was silvered glass from Alexandria, and it had been a gift from a man who had wanted something, and she had forgotten which man.

At the desk in the small room behind the atrium, Hermeros was waiting with the tablets. He was fifty-seven, a freedman of the house, bald as an egg and neat as a receipt, and he had been with her since the year she had bought the house and discovered that a fortune is not a thing a woman can carry alone.

"Show me," she said.

He showed her. The wine from Campania, forty amphorae, of which six had soured on the road and would have to be sold to a tavernkeeper who did not ask questions. The silk merchant from Berytus, who had promised payment on the Ides and would not pay. The knight who owed forty thousand and had sent a gilt cup instead of money, which was an insult with a handle on it. The baker, whose rent was three months late and who had a sick daughter. The sum that would be needed for the Saturnalia, which was less than the sum that would be needed for the Kalends, which was less than the sum that would be needed if certain people in the city decided to remember that the lady of this house had once been something other than a lady.

"Call the knight's debt," Cassia said.

"He is a knight."

"He is a knight who owes me forty thousand and thinks a cup will do. Call it. Politely. In front of his wife's uncle, if you can arrange it."

Hermeros made a small mark. "And the baker?"

"Let him be until the spring. The daughter?"

"Still ill."

"Send Narcissus with the green jar. Not the blue. The green." She turned a tablet over. "The house is full tonight?"

"Senator Proculus, four at his table, and the grain man Comptus with two. Proculus has asked for the garden room."

"Proculus always asks for the garden room. It is February in his soul." She set the tablet down. "Give him the painted room and tell him the garden is being re-

planted. He will complain, and then he will be pleased to have been lied to. Put Comptus next to him. Comptus talks when he is nervous, and Proculus cannot resist correcting a man who talks."

"And the women?"

"Ione at Proculus's shoulder. Chrysis on the other side, if she will. Dama to sing after the second course, not before. The man has no ear before the second course." Cassia stood. "And tell Celer that if the fish sauce is as thick as it was at the Ides, I will give his kitchen to the boy and let him watch."

Hermeros wrote it down, although he had written it down a hundred times before, because writing it down was his way of loving her.

The house was not the largest on the Esquiline. It was not even the most beautiful, though it had a peristyle garden that had cost more than some senators' estates and a bath suite that had ruined a marble merchant. It was simply the most quietly expensive house in Rome, and the price of entering it was not money. Money was the least of it. Men came to the House of the Graces because they could not say certain things in the Senate, or to their wives, or to their own mirrors; and Cassia had built her fortune on the truth that a man will pay almost anything for a room in which he is not required to be himself.

She had bought the house with money that had been made in a brothel and laundered through a shipping venture and a brickworks on the Tiber, and she had bought it from a man who had lost it at dice and had wept at the sale. She had kept his cook and his doorkeeper and his gardener, and she had changed everything else. The garden she had made larger. The atrium she had left plain, because a plain atrium made the garden look richer. The strongroom she had built herself, behind a false panel in the tablinum, and in it she kept the household's money, the deeds, the wills of three men who trusted her more than their own families, and a cushion that was not a cushion.

Her name had been given to her by a man who had bought her and then, in the way of such men, decided that he preferred to own a partner than a slave. Antonius Felix had been twenty years older and had had no children and had believed, wrongly, that gratitude was a debt that could be collected. He had freed her in his will and left her his fortune and the name. She had buried him in a tomb on the Via Appia and had paid for the inscription herself, because she had discovered that the dead are easier to be generous with than the living.

The city knew all of this, or most of it, and the parts it did not know it invented. The city said she had been a whore, which was true. The city said she had poisoned her patron, which was not; he had died of a dropsy and a bad temper. The city said she kept a book of every secret told in her house, which was true, and which was the reason half the men who came to her door came a little afraid. The city said she had no family, no name, no past. On that point the city was wrong in the way that mattered, but it was a long time since she had corrected anyone.

There were three Graces painted in the dining room, standing in a row with their hands on one another's shoulders. Aglaia, Euphrosyne, Thalia. Splendour, good cheer, abundance. The painter had been paid to make them look like Cassia and two of her women, and he had done it badly enough that it was a joke and well enough that it was a compliment. Guests liked to name which was which. They were always wrong. Cassia had learned long ago that men see what they have come to see, and that the skill of a hostess is not to correct them but to arrange the room so that what they see is useful.

At the fifth hour the household assembled in the atrium to hear the day's orders, and Cassia stood at the foot of the impluvium with her hands folded and told them. There were twenty-three people in the house, counting the children, and she knew every name, every debt, every ailment, and every grudge. She knew that Philumena the hairdresser had a brother in the vigiles who could be asked to forget a fire. She knew that Celer's wife in the Subura was pregnant again and that Celer was frightened. She knew that Bathyllus had a bad knee and would not admit it. She knew that Ione had been saving money for two years and had not yet said what for, and that Chrysis had a brother somewhere, sold south, and had not yet asked her to look for him.

She knew all of this the way she knew the accounts: because she had learned that people are not so different from money, and that both are best understood when you know where they came from and what they are doing to be spent on.

"Tonight," she said, "the senator Proculus is our guest. He is a vain man, and he has a good memory for slights. Do not give him one. He will drink more than he should and say less than he means. If he asks you about the emperor, you admire the emperor. If he asks you about the Senate, you admire the emperor. If he asks you about his son, you have heard that the young man is the hope of his house, and you have heard it from someone who knows."

A ripple of laughter. She let it run, then raised one finger.

"Mistress Chrysis will not be alone with anyone tonight. If a guest asks, he is told she is promised to the house. If he insists, he is told to ask me." Her eyes moved to Chrysis, who was standing with her hands clasped and her gaze on the floor, and who was nineteen and had been in the house for five years and still flinched at the word *promised*. "And no one goes into the strongroom, for any reason, at any hour, even if I send them. If I send them, it is not me."

They dispersed. Chrysis lingered. Cassia had known she would.

"Domina," she said.

"Not now."

"It is only—"

"Not in the atrium, where the walls have ears and the ears have mouths. Come to the garden before the guests."

The garden was winter-thin, the roses cut back to black sticks, the box hedges dark and wet. A fountain played in the middle of it, a bronze boy holding a dolphin, and the water came out of the dolphin's mouth with a sound like distant conversation. Cassia sat on the stone bench and put her hands in her sleeves.

Chrysis stood before her. She had been born somewhere north of the Danube, in a village whose name she no longer remembered, and she had been sold twice before she came here. She had black hair and grey eyes and the kind of beauty that made men lower their voices. She was also, Cassia thought, the only person in the house who did not know how beautiful she was.

"Well?"

"My brother," Chrysis said. "I have heard where he is."

Cassia said nothing.

"A man came to the kitchen door. He says he has seen him. In Puteoli. He is with a fuller. He is not well. The man says for two thousand sesterces he can be bought and brought."

"Two thousand is not a small sum."

"I know it."

"And the man who tells you this is a man who sells information, and information about a boy he has never met is worth exactly what a frightened sister will pay for it." Cassia watched her. "What is his name?"

"Gaius."

"His name. Not the boy's."

Chrysis hesitated. "I do not know his name. I did not ask."

"Then you have not heard where your brother is. You have heard a story that has your brother in it." Cassia's voice was not unkind. "I will have Hermeros ask. If the boy can be found, he will be found. But I will not buy a rumour, and I will not have you buying one either. If this man comes again, he is to be sent to me."

"He will not come again if he thinks there is nothing to be had."

"Then he was not selling your brother. He was selling your hope, which is cheaper and never runs out." Cassia stood. "Tonight you will sit beside the senator and you will be charming and you will not think about Puteoli. Tomorrow we will think about Puteoli."

Chrysis's eyes filled, but she did not cry. She had learned that too. "Yes, domina."

"Chrysis."

"Yes?"

"You are not to give that man money. Not a copper. If he is what he says, he will come back. If he is not, he will find easier fish." Cassia touched her cheek, once, briefly, the way one might touch a statue to see whether it was warm. "Go and have Philumena do your hair. The braid, not the coils. The braid makes you look like a girl who has not yet decided what she is, and men pay for that."

Chrysis went. Cassia stayed in the cold a while longer, listening to the fountain, and thought about the price of a brother, and about the fact that she had once had a price put on her own head. It had been reckoned in sesterces. It had also, in a way she had never been able to explain to anyone, been reckoned in something else.

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The guests came at the ninth hour, which in December was already dusk. Proculus arrived first, as a senator should, with his son and two clients and a litter that had been cleaned for the occasion. He was sixty, with the soft hands of a man who had never held a tool and the hard eyes of one who had held a grudge. His son, Aulus, was twenty-four and had the look of a man who had been told all his life that he was promising.

Comptus came next, alone but for his secretary, a narrow man with inky fingers. Numerius Vibius Comptus was an equestrian who moved grain for the annona and had made himself useful to men who moved armies. He was forty-four, going grey at the temples, and he had a wife and three children and a habit of looking at Cassia as though she were a question he had almost answered.

The last to arrive was a knight named Felix, who had not been invited and had sent word that he would be grateful for a word. Cassia had him shown into the small room off the atrium, where the light was bad and the seats were low, and she kept him waiting long enough to look at the ceiling and admire the paint.

Marcus Aquilius Felix was thirty-five and handsome in the way a knife is handsome. He had been a delator for six years, and he had grown rich on other men's terror, and he had the manners of a man who had learned them from a book. He wore a signet ring with a bird on it, which was not his family's, because he had no family worth a bird.

"Domina," he said, and kissed her hand.

"You are not on the list."

"I am aware."

"Then you will understand if I ask what you want."

"A word. Not tonight. A word at your convenience." He smiled. "I have recently come into possession of a document that I think would interest you."

"Documents are rarely interesting. People are."

"This one concerns a physician."

Cassia did not move. Her face did not change. But something behind her eyes closed like a door.

"Physicians are always interesting," she said. "They know too much and they charge too much. Which physician?"

"One who is dead," Felix said. "And one who is not."

She looked at him for a long moment. Then she said, "You may have five minutes after the second course. Not before. And you will not speak to my women."

"I would not dream of it."

"You would dream of it. Every man dreams of it. But you will not do it." She rose. "Come. The senator will be wondering whether I have forgotten him, and a senator who wonders is a senator who talks."

The dining room was warm and smelled of rosemary and roasting fish and the cedar oil the slaves had rubbed into the tables. The walls were painted with scenes of the countryside: vines, a villa, a hunter with a spear, a woman in a yellow dress carrying a basket. The three Graces stood in the alcove, their painted hands on one another's shoulders, their painted eyes on the guests. Lamplight moved over them, so that they seemed to breathe.

Cassia took her place at the head of the middle couch, and the room arranged itself around her. Proculus reclined at her right, his son at his feet. Comptus at her left, with Ione. Chrysis on the outer side, where she could be seen and not touched. Dama stood behind the wine, young and dark and beautiful in the way that made men uncertain of their own taste. The first course came: eggs, olives, oysters, a dish of mushrooms in garum, bread still warm from the bakery next door.

"Tell me," Proculus said, when the oysters were gone, "is it true what they say about the emperor's new forum?"

"That depends what they say."

"That it cost more than the Dacian war."

"The Dacian war cost the emperor a great deal of trouble," Cassia said. "The forum cost him money. He has more money."

Proculus laughed too loudly. "They say you have more money than the Senate."

"Then they say too much, and you should not repeat it."

"I am among friends."

"You are among my friends," Cassia said, "and I am not sure you have been introduced."

Comptus laughed into his cup. Proculus, who was not stupid, decided to be amused. "I have missed you," he said.

"You have missed my cook."

"That too." He leaned closer. The wine had loosened him. "I am told the Asian command will be decided before the spring. Corvinus wants it."

"Does he?"

"He has the votes. He has the name. He has that mother of his, who is worth three tribes on her own." Proculus bit an olive. "But there is talk. There is always talk."

"Talk is the cheapest thing in Rome," Cassia said. "I sell it myself."

"This is not my talk. This is talk with a document in its hand."

She did not look at Felix, who was seated at the far end of the room with a cup he had not touched. She picked up a mushroom and ate it slowly.

"Documents," she said, "are like mushrooms. You should know where they were picked before you put them in your mouth."

Proculus laughed again, and the laugh turned into a cough, and his son thumped him on the back with more enthusiasm than was required. The talk moved on to the games, the price of mules, a Vestal who had been seen at a wedding she should not have attended. At the second course the fish came in on a silver platter, and Dama sang, and Ione leaned into Proculus's ear and said something that made him put down his cup.

Cassia watched the room the way a general watches a field. Proculus was talking now, and the wine was talking with him. Comptus was quiet, which meant he was worried. His secretary had told Hermeros that the grain fleet had lost two ships off Sicily, and that Comptus had been asked to explain it to a man who did not accept explanations.

Young Aulus had had too much wine and was leaning toward Chrysis, not quite touching her, but close enough that his intention was visible from across the room. Cassia saw Chrysis's hands tighten on the edge of the couch. She saw the girl look toward the door, and then toward her. She saw her decide to endure it, because enduring it was what she had been trained to do.

"Aulus," Cassia said.

The young man turned, flushed. "Domina?"

"Your father is telling us about the grain fleet. It is a subject on which he is very fine. You should listen. You may be asked about it one day, when you are in the Senate, and it would be a pity if you had spent your youth learning only one thing."

The room went quiet. Proculus's face did something complicated. Aulus's flush deepened. He started to speak, and his father put a hand on his arm.

"The lady is right," Proculus said. "Sit back. Listen. You might learn something."

"I was only—"

"Sit back."

He sat back. Chrysis breathed. Cassia lifted her cup to Proculus and said, "Your son has spirit. It is a fine thing in a young man. It is a better thing when it has a rein."

"You have a gift," Proculus said, "for making a compliment sound like a sentence."

"I have a gift for both. It is the same gift."

Comptus said, quietly, "The grain fleet lost two ships."

"I heard."

"One of them was carrying my name."

"Then your name is on the bottom of the sea, and you should be glad it is not on the Senate's list." She turned to him. "What do you need?"

"Time."

"Time is what I sell least of."

"Then a friend on the prefect's staff."

"I have no friends on the prefect's staff. I have acquaintances who owe me. It is better." She thought. "Come to the house on the day after the Ides. Bring the manifest. Bring the names of the men who signed it. Do not bring your secretary, because your secretary has been talking to someone, and I do not yet know who."

Comptus's face did not change, but his hand did. "You are sure?"

"I am never sure. I am often right." She touched his wrist. "Eat. The fish is good, and a worried man should eat."

When the plates were taken away, Ione came and sat beside her, which she did not usually do in front of guests. Ione was twenty-seven and had been in the house for nine years, and she had the beauty that improves with use, like a knife. She was Greek, from a family that had once had a name in Ephesus and had lost it to a war and a bad loan. She spoke three languages and could do sums in her head and had never once asked Cassia for anything outright, which was how Cassia knew that she wanted a great deal.

"You gave the girl to the senator's son," Ione said, quietly, watching the room.

"I gave her nothing. I took her away from him."

"He will be back."

"Then I will take her away from him again."

"And when you are not here?"

Cassia looked at her. "I am always here."

Ione smiled, and it was not a warm smile, though it was a beautiful one. "You are always here, domina. But the house is not only you. The house is all of us, and some of us will be here when you are not, and some of us will have to make our own arrangements." She turned her cup by the stem. "I am not asking for anything."

"You are asking me to think about it."

"I am asking you to think about what happens to a girl like Chrysis when the house is sold, or the house is closed, or the house is raided by men with a warrant and a grudge. You think about the future. You must have thought about it. You have thought about everything else."

"I have thought about it," Cassia said.

"And?"

"And it is not a conversation for the dinner table."

Ione inclined her head. "No. It is not." She rose, and then, because she was Ione, she said one more thing, softly, with her back to the room: "You should know that the grain man has been to see Pactus twice this month. I have it from his secretary's woman. He is not as frightened as he looks. He is frightened of the wrong thing."

She went back to her place. Cassia sat with her cup and did not look at Comptus, and thought about the wrong thing, and about how a man who is frightened of the wrong thing is more dangerous than a man who is frightened of the right one.

At the third course Felix rose and came to her, and she led him into the little room off the atrium, where the lamps had been turned down and the painted ceiling was lost in shadow.

"Five minutes."

He did not waste them. "There is a man in the city who is preparing an accusation against Lucius Sulpicius Corvinus. The accusation concerns the death of his father, twenty-four years ago, at Tibur. The man has a witness. The witness is old and frightened, and has been paid a little, and will be paid more. The accusation will be laid before the consul after the Kalends. I am not the man. I am the man who knows the man."

"Why tell me?"

"Because everyone knows that the lady of this house remembers everything, and because I would rather be your friend than your enemy."

"You have been my enemy for six years."

"I have been your competitor," Felix said. "It is not the same."

"It is the same when you lose." She looked at him. "What do you want?"

"Two hundred thousand sesterces."

"That is a great deal for a rumour."

"It is a small sum for a life."

"Whose life?"

"Whosever you choose," Felix said. "The witness can remember the physician. Or the physician's daughter. Or the lady who carried the cup. Memory is a house with many doors. I am offering you the keys."

Cassia stood very still. In the other room, Dama was singing, and the sound came through the wall as though from another world. She thought of a summer twenty-four years gone, of a closed door, of the taste of honey and bitter almond. She thought of the way a man's face changes when he is certain he has won.

"Five minutes are over," she said.

Felix smiled. "I will come for your answer on the day after the Ides."

"Come on the Ides. I do not like to be kept waiting, and I do not like to be hurried, and a man who arrives early shows that he does not trust his own case."

He bowed and went out. She stood alone in the little room for a moment, and then she went back to her guests, and her face was the face of a woman who had heard nothing at all.

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The house emptied slowly. Proculus was the last to go, because Proculus was always the last to go, and at the door he took Cassia's hand and said, "You are wasted on this house."

"I am not wasted anywhere," she said. "I am invested."

He laughed, and his litter carried him away, and the doorkeeper closed the door and shot the bolt, and the house let out its breath.

The slaves cleared the tables. The women went up. Celer came out of the kitchen with flour on his arms and asked, with the dignity of an artist, whether the fish had been acceptable, and Cassia told him it had been excellent, and he went

back to his kitchen satisfied. She walked the rooms as she did every night, checking the lamps, the locks, the shutters. In the dining room the three Graces looked down at the wreck of the feast. Someone had spilled wine on the floor, and the stain was already drying to the colour of old blood.

She was in the corridor when Chrysis came to her, wrapped in a mantle, her hair down.

"Domina."

"I told you. Tomorrow."

"I know what he is," Chrysis said. "The man who says he has my brother. I know what he is. I know he is probably lying. But if there is one chance in a hundred that he is not, and I do nothing, then I am the kind of person who does nothing." Her voice shook, but it did not break. "I do not want to be that kind of person."

Cassia looked at her for a long time. The lamp between them was burning low, and the smell of the oil was sharp.

"Neither do I," she said. "Go to bed. In the morning, we will find your brother. I will pay the man, and if he is lying, I will have Bathyllus explain to him the difference between a lie and a theft. If he is not lying, we will bring the boy here and Narcissus will look at him, and he will be fed, and he will sleep in a bed with a roof over it. And you will owe me nothing but the truth about what he is to you."

Chrysis stared at her. "Why?"

"Because I was once sold," Cassia said, "and no one came."

She had been nineteen when the man had come for her, and she remembered the cart, and the smell of the road, and the way the driver had counted the money twice. She remembered the door of the room at Puteoli and the sound of the bolt. She had spent a great deal of her life since then arranging things so that she would never again be on the wrong side of a door, and she had discovered that the arrangement was never finished, and that a bolt is a thing that can be put on either side.

She said it flatly, without pity, the way one reports the weather. Chrysis's eyes filled. She took Cassia's hand and pressed it to her lips, and Cassia let her, and then sent her to bed.

It was past midnight when Bathyllus knocked at the door of the tablinum. He had a folded tablet in his hand, sealed with wax the colour of rust.

"A man brought it," he said. "A steward. He would not wait."

"From whom?"

"He said his master would be known to you."

Cassia broke the seal. The wax was stamped with a raven, wings spread, a small thing and old. She knew the seal before she knew the hand. She had seen it on a letter once, a lifetime ago, a letter that had been read to her by a man who could read and who had been paid to read it slowly.

She unfolded the tablet.

*L. Sulpicius Corvinus to Antonia Cassia. I will do myself the honour of calling upon you on the day after the Ides, at the tenth hour. I trust the house receives.*

There was no greeting, no closing, no explanation. Twenty-four years, and four lines.

Cassia stood in the lamplight with the tablet in her hands. Her face was calm. Her hands were not. She set the tablet on the desk, and then she picked it up again and read it a second time, as though the words might have changed, and then she held the edge of it against the flame of the lamp and watched the wax soften and the wood begin to blacken.

She did not burn it. She put it down, and sat, and looked at the raven until the lamp guttered.

"Bathyllus," she said.

"Domina."

"When he comes, he is to be shown into the garden room. Not the atrium. Not the painted room. The garden room, where the light is behind him and the door is at his back."

"And if he brings his lictors?"

"He will not bring his lictors. He will bring his pride, and it is heavier." She turned the tablet over. "And Bathyllus—"

"Yes?"

"Have the boy bring more lamps. I want the room bright enough that I can see his face."

CHAPTER

# TWO

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The Kalends of January opened grey and cold, with a wind off the Tiber that smelled of silt and smoke, and Rome put on its best face anyway. The city had been preparing for a month. The shopkeepers had washed their awnings and hung them with laurel; the wine sellers had chalked the prices of the good Caecuban on their boards; the priests of half a hundred temples had been up since dark, killing birds and reading their livers and arguing about the omens in the way that priests argue when the omens are good but not perfect. The emperor was to dedicate his forum. The emperor was to take the consulship for the sixth time. The emperor was to give games, and a distribution, and a speech that everyone would pretend to have heard and no one would remember.

Antonia Cassia had been invited to none of it. She went anyway.

They left the house before the third hour, while the streets were still full of carts and the vigiles were still arguing with the carters about the load limits on the Via Lata. Bathyllus walked in front with a staff and the expression of a man who had been told to keep the peace and was looking forward to failing. Behind him came Cassia in a plain litter, with Tertulla beside her and Ione on the seat opposite, dressed in a blue that was too expensive for the morning and exactly right for the afternoon. Hermeros brought up the rear with a purse and a face of mild disapproval. The purse was for bribes. The face was for the account books.

They went down the Clivus Suburanus into the old city, where the streets narrowed and the insulae leaned out over the road as though trying to hear the news, and the crowd thickened with every step. Porters with baskets. A man selling hot sausages from a brazier. Two women with a child between them, arguing about whether the child had been cured or had only stopped crying. A group of young men in matching cloaks, drunk already, singing a song about the emperor's bridge over the Danube that had never been finished and had cost a

great deal. A beggar with no legs, who knew Cassia's litter by its curtains and called out to her by name, and to whom she gave a silver piece without stopping.

"You are too generous," Tertulla said.

"I am not generous. I am superstitious. He has been at that corner for eleven years, and he has outlived three of my enemies."

Tertulla laughed. Vibidia Tertulla was thirty-nine and had buried two husbands and had the kind of money that made her unmarriageable and the kind of wit that made her unwelcome at half the dinner tables in Rome. She had been Cassia's friend for six years, and her lover for two of them, off and on, in the way of two women who had both decided that the world had taken enough from them and they would keep this one thing for themselves. She was not beautiful, exactly, but she had a face that improved when she was interested, and she was interested in almost everything.

The crowd at the forum was already enormous. The new complex stood where the old slums had been, and the men who had lived in those slums had been moved somewhere else, and the men who had built the new complex had been paid, and the men who were now looking at it had been told that it was the greatest thing ever built by human hands, which, on that morning, in that light, with the incense and the garlands and the noise, it almost was.

They had a place in the portico of the Basilica Ulpia, arranged for them by Comptus, who had arranged it for a great many people and had been paid in favours by all of them. The basilica was vast. Its columns were grey granite from the quarries of Mons Claudianus, each one dragged across Egypt and floated across the sea and hauled up the Tiber and set upright by men who would never see the finished building. The roof was gilded bronze, and the floor was marble in a pattern that made the eye want to follow it, and the apse at the end held a statue of the emperor that was larger than the emperor and, Cassia thought, better looking.

Beyond the basilica stood the two libraries, one Greek and one Latin, facing each other across a small courtyard with a fountain. Beyond them, the column was still in its scaffolding, a great wrapped thing with workmen crawling on it, the spiral of carved soldiers and ships and bridges emerging from the top down as the masons worked. And in the middle of the new square, on a bronze horse, the emperor sat with his hand raised, and the horse had its mouth open, and the pigeons had already found it.

"Look at it," Tertulla said. "They have taken the heart out of the city and put a monument in its place."

"They have taken the slums out of the city," Cassia said. "It is not the same."

"It is the same to the people who lived in them."

"People who live in slums are used to being moved. It is the ones who live in houses who are surprised." Cassia watched the workmen on the column. "My father—" She stopped.

Tertulla looked at her. "Your father?"

"I have no father. I was thinking of someone else's." She turned away. "You are not afraid," Ione said, from the other side of the litter, "of being seen."

"I am afraid of being seen in the wrong company. It is not the same."

"You are a freedwoman in a city where the emperor's grandmother sold fish. There is no wrong company, only the wrong witnesses."

Cassia looked at her. "That is either the wisest thing you have said or the most dangerous."

"Can it not be both?" Ione turned her face to the light. "I want to see the libraries. I have heard there is a copy of Sappho there that cost more than a house."

"There is a copy of Sappho there that is kept in a box and shown to no one. It is the most Roman thing about the building."

"I should like to see it anyway."

"Then you will have to marry a senator, or become one. I do not recommend either." Cassia drew her mantle closer. "Do you know why I came today, Ione?"

"Because you were not invited."

"Because I was not invited." Cassia watched the standards go by. "A woman in my position is always being told what she is not. She is not respectable. She is not senatorial. She is not the sort of woman one invites to the dedication of a forum. If she stays at home, she agrees with them. If she goes, she makes them say it to her face, and a man who says a thing to your face is a man you can answer."

"And if he does not say it to your face?"

"Then he says it behind your back, and you find out from someone like Felix, and you charge him for the information." Cassia smiled, without warmth. "I have been in this city for twenty years. I have learned that the only thing more expensive than being seen is being invisible."

Ione was quiet for a moment. Then she said, "And the senator Corvinus? Is he here because you were not invited?"

Cassia did not look at her. "The senator Corvinus is here because it is the Kalends, and because he is an augur, and because a man like that would come to the opening of a door if there were a crowd to see him do it."

"That is not what I asked."

"No," Cassia said. "It is not."

"Where is Comptus?"

"With the grain men. He will be here. He is always here, and always where he should not be, and always sorry."

A trumpet sounded from the direction of the old forum, and the crowd turned like a field in the wind. The procession was coming. First the lictors, then the priests, then the colleges of the augurs and the pontiffs in their striped robes, then the consuls, then the senate, a long river of white wool and purple borders, and above it all the standards and the eagles and the smoke of the incense. The people cheered. Some cheered because they loved the emperor. Some cheered because they were being paid to. Most cheered because the man beside them was cheering, and because a crowd in Rome is a thing that runs on its own momentum until it hits something.

Cassia did not cheer. She stood with her hands folded and watched the faces go by, and she read them the way she read the room at a dinner: the ambitious, the frightened, the bored, the drunk. There was Proculus, sweating under his toga, his son beside him looking as though he had been dressed by a committee. There was Pactus, tall and lean and smiling, walking with the ease of a man who had never had to ask permission for anything. There was the young Publius Sulpicius Corvinus, twenty-one and trying to look older, his hair combed forward in the fashion, his shoes too new.

And there, behind the consuls, in the place of honour that his augurate gave him, was his father.

Lucius Sulpicius Corvinus walked with his head up and his hands at his sides. He was forty-five and looked it in the way that men who have spent their lives outdoors and in the Senate look it: weathered, straight, the grey at his temples cut short. His toga was white as a Vestal's, and his shoes were old and good. He had the face of a man who had been handsome at twenty and had never quite forgiven the world for noticing that he was handsome still. He did not

look at the crowd. He looked at the middle distance, where men of his kind looked, and the crowd looked at him, and Cassia looked at him, and for a moment the noise of the forum seemed to her like the noise of water over stones.

Then his head turned. It was not a large movement. It was the smallest movement in the world, the movement of a man who has been told there is someone behind him and has decided to be certain before he looks. His eyes found her across the width of the basilica, through the crowd, through the smoke and the standards and the twenty-four years.

He looked away.

Cassia's hands were cold. She put them in her sleeves and kept her face as still as a painted wall.

"You know him," Tertulla said, quietly.

"Everyone knows him."

"That is not what I asked."

"No," Cassia said. "It is not."

• • •

The ceremony went on for a long time. There was a sacrifice, and a reading of the decree, and a speech by the consul, and another speech by a man from the treasury who had been told to keep it short and had not. The emperor spoke last. He was a big man, broad and grey and careful, and he spoke in the voice of a soldier who had learned to speak in public because it was part of the job. He spoke of the city, and of the generations who had built it, and of the duty of a man to leave behind him something better than he had found. The crowd cheered at the right moments. Cassia watched the faces of the senators, who were watching the crowd, and understood that every word the emperor said was being weighed by a hundred men who were each calculating what it would be worth to them.

When it was over, the crowd began to move, and the movement was the dangerous part. The porticoes filled with people looking for their friends, their patrons, their wives. A child was separated from its mother and began to scream. A litter was overturned and its occupant, a fat man in a green cloak, was helped up by three strangers and robbed by a fourth. The vigiles appeared, and then the Praetorian guard, and the crowd opened for the guard in the way that water opens for a keel.

Cassia kept her party together by main force, her hand on Ione's wrist and Bathyllus's shoulder in front of her. They were in the portico of the library now, where the light was dimmer and the noise was muffled by the shelves of scrolls beyond the wall, and the smell of cedar and dust and old papyrus was so strong that it seemed to be a kind of silence.

"Wait here," Cassia said. "Bathyllus, the door."

She had intended to go to Comptus. She had intended to find out what he had learned from the grain office, and to be seen finding it out, because a woman who is seen to be informed is a woman whom men think twice about crossing. Instead she found herself standing before a bust of the divine Augustus, looking at a face that had been dead for a hundred years, and hearing footsteps behind her that she had been hearing, in one form or another, since she was eighteen.

"Domina."

She turned.

He was alone. That was the first thing she noticed; a man of his rank was never alone in public, and the fact that he had made himself alone was a statement. The second thing she noticed was the smell of him. Wool and cedar and the faint, clean smell of the oil his mother used in the house. She had not smelled it in twenty-four years, and it went through her like a blade.

"Senator."

"You are well."

"I am rich. It is often confused."

He did not smile. His face had the closed, careful look of a man who had spent his life in rooms where every word was recorded. "I sent a letter."

"I received it."

"You did not answer."

"I answered by receiving. It is the custom."

"You are not a customary woman."

"No," Cassia said. "I am not."

But before Corvinus could say more, a woman came into the portico with two slaves behind her and the particular stillness of a person who has decided to be noticed without appearing to want it. She was thirty-seven or so, with dark hair dressed high and a face that had been beautiful and had settled into something more useful. Her stola was the colour of cream, and her jewels were old

and heavy and worth more than the house Cassia lived in. She stopped a few paces away and looked at Cassia with an expression that was not hostility and was not welcome.

"Domina," Corvinus said, and there was something in his voice that had not been there before. "My wife."

Aemilia Celsa inclined her head. "I have been looking for you," she said to her husband. "The consul's wife is asking after the games. She has a scheme for a pantomime that will require a great deal of money and a great many virgins, and I have been sent to find out which of the two is in shorter supply."

"Tell her the virgins," Cassia said.

Aemilia's eyes came to her. They were grey, and steady, and not at all surprised. "You are the woman my mother-in-law prays about."

"I am honoured. I did not know she prayed."

"She prays for the destruction of her enemies. It is a form of religion." Aemilia's mouth moved, almost a smile. "I have never been inside your house. I am told it is beautiful."

"It is comfortable. Beauty is a word men use when they want to pay less."

"And what word do you use?"

"Profitable."

Aemilia laughed, a short, dry sound, and for a moment she looked younger and much more tired. "I have heard a great deal about you," she said. "Some of it from my husband, most of it from women who have never met you. I find that the women who have never met you are the ones who know the most."

"They are the ones with the most to say."

"Yes." Aemilia looked at Corvinus, and then back at Cassia, and something passed between the two women that had no name. "I am told you receive senators."

"I receive everyone. It is the business."

"Do you receive their wives?"

The question hung in the air. Corvinus said, "Aemilia," in a voice that was almost a warning, and she ignored him.

"I receive anyone who comes with good manners and a reason to be there," Cassia said. "Wives are rarer than senators. They are also usually better company."

"Then perhaps I will come," Aemilia said. "One day. When I have a reason." She turned to her husband. "The consul's wife is waiting. You should come and be seen to be bored. It is what you are for."

She went out, her slaves behind her, and the portico seemed larger and emptier for her going.

"She does not know," Corvinus said.

"She knows everything," Cassia said. "She is a senator's wife. It is her profession."

A group of senators came past the end of the portico, talking loudly about the sacrifice, and Corvinus waited until they were gone. When he spoke again, his voice was lower.

"Felix came to me. He came to me before he came to you. He wanted three hundred thousand from me and he told me he had already spoken to you, and that you had agreed to help him."

"Then he lied to you."

"Did he?"

"Which part?" She looked at him. "I did not agree to help him. I agreed to hear him. There is a difference, and it is the difference between a whore and a hostess."

His jaw tightened. "You always did know how to put a knife in a compliment."

"I learned from the best." She said it before she could stop herself, and saw the blow land. He took it without moving, the way he had always taken things, and she hated him for it, and hated herself more.

"The accusation is being prepared," he said. "It will be laid before the consul within the month. It concerns my father."

"I heard."

"From Felix."

"From a senator who had drunk too much. Felix merely confirmed it." She held his eyes. "You have nothing to fear from me, Lucius. I have kept your secret for twenty-four years. I have kept it through the fire and the plague and the year I had nothing to eat but bread and olives. I am not going to give it away now, when I have finally built something worth keeping."

"Something worth keeping," he repeated, and looked around the library, the shelves, the scrolls, the marble, the whole vast monument of it. "You have done well."

"I have done what I could."

"You always did." He said it without warmth. "My mother is ill."

"I am sorry to hear it."

"No, you are not."

"No," Cassia said. "I am not. But I am polite, and I am sorry to hear it in the way that one is sorry to hear of a storm at sea. It is a great deal of weather and none of it mine."

He looked at her for a long moment. In the dim light of the library, with the dust moving in the shafts of sun, he looked younger than he had in the procession, and tired, and something else that she did not want to name.

"I need to know what you will say," he said. "If they come to you. If they ask you about Tibur."

"They will not come to me."

"They will come to your household."

That stopped her. She had thought of Felix, and of the Senate, and of the slow machinery of the law, but she had not thought of the household. The household was hers. The household was the one thing in the world that was entirely hers, bought and paid for and built out of people no one else had wanted.

"On what charge?" she said, and her voice was steady.

"Parricide."

The word hung in the air between them. A man who killed his father was sewn into a sack with a dog and a cock and a viper and thrown into the Tiber. The law had been old when the Republic was young. It was not often used. It was never used against a man who could afford a good lawyer, unless someone with power wanted it used.

"They cannot touch me," Cassia said. "I am free. I have been free for sixteen years. Free women are not put to the question."

"No," he said. "But your slaves are."

She looked past him, through the doorway, to where Bathyllus stood with his back to them, and beyond him to the crowd, and beyond that to the house on the Esquiline where Sabina was learning her letters and Chrysis was waiting

for news of her brother and Thais was counting the linens and Celer was shouting at a boy about a fish.

"Then you had better hope," she said, "that your secret is worth more to me than they are."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only answer I have." She stepped closer to him, close enough that no one else could have heard, close enough that she could smell the cedar and the wool and the faint, clean oil. "Listen to me, Lucius. I have spent twenty-four years making sure that what happened at Tibur stayed at Tibur. I have paid for it. I have paid in ways you cannot imagine, and in some ways you can. I am not going to destroy my house to save yours. But I am not going to destroy yours to save mine, either, unless I have to. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

"Then we have an understanding."

"We have a truce."

"Call it what you like." She turned to go.

"Cassia."

She stopped. He had not used her name in twenty-four years. He had called her domina, and then he had called her nothing at all, and now he said her name like a man setting down a heavy thing he had been carrying for a long time.

"There is something else," he said.

"There is always something else."

Before she could answer, a shadow fell across the doorway. Decimus Iunius Pactus stood there with a cup in his hand and a smile that had been polished by years of public life. He was forty-nine, tall and lean, with the sort of weathered good looks that made men trust him and women regret it. He was a new man, which in Rome meant a man whose grandfather had not been a senator, and he had spent his whole career making the old families forget it and the new ones remember it.

"Corvinus," he said. "I did not know you were a patron of the libraries."

"I am a patron of nothing," Corvinus said, "except my own household."

"A harsh doctrine. The gods are patrons of everything, and look how well it has worked for them." Pactus's eyes slid to Cassia, and his smile changed, became more real and more careful. "Domina. We have not met. I am Pactus."

"I know who you are."

"Then I am flattered, and also slightly afraid."

"Men who say they are afraid are usually the least afraid men in the room."

"Not I. I am afraid of all sorts of things. Failure. Debt. My wife's cook." He sipped his wine. "I am told you keep the best table on the Esquiline."

"I keep a table. The rest is gossip."

"Gossip is the only currency that has never been debased." He glanced at Corvinus, and then back at her. "I hope you will permit me to call on you. I have a proposition that requires discretion, and I am told you are the soul of it."

"Come," Cassia said. "Bring your proposition. I will decide whether it is worth the salt."

"I would expect nothing less." He bowed, and went out, and the portico was quiet again.

"That man," Corvinus said, "is the reason the Asian command is not yet decided."

"I know."

"He will use you."

"Everyone uses me. I am a house. That is what houses are for." She looked at him. "The difference is that I decide what I charge."

Corvinus looked at the doorway where Pactus had stood, and then at her, and his face closed like a hand.

"The child," he said.

The library was very quiet. Somewhere beyond the wall, a man was laughing, and a cart went past on the stones, and the fountain in the courtyard played its endless, patient music.

"There was no child," Cassia said.

"Cassia—"

"There was no child. There was a girl who was told there was a child, and there was a liar who told her, and there was a grave with nothing in it, and there was a woman who has spent her life not thinking about it. That is all there is. If you have come to me for absolution, you have come to the wrong house. I sell pleasure. I do not sell that."

She walked away from him, past the bust of Augustus, past the shelves of scrolls, past Bathyllus, into the noise and the light. She did not look back. She had learned long ago that a woman who looks back is a woman who is followed.

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They came out of the forum into the late afternoon, when the light had gone the colour of old bronze and the city was beginning to think about dinner. The crowd had thinned. The workmen on the column had gone home, and the scaffolding stood against the sky like a cage for a bird that had not yet been caught.

Cassia walked. She had sent the litter ahead and told the others to go with it, and Tertulla, who knew her, had not argued. She walked up the Via Lata with her veil over her hair and her hands in her sleeves, and the city closed around her the way it always did, indifferent and alive. A baker was taking bread out of an oven. A woman was shouting at a man on a balcony. A dog was eating something in the gutter that had once been a pigeon. Two boys were playing at gladiators with sticks, and one of them had tied a rag around his head like a retiarius, and the other was pretending to be the emperor.

She stopped at a fountain to drink and to let an old woman fill her jar first, and while she stood there she saw, across the street, a girl in a brown cloak buying figs from a stall. The girl was fifteen or sixteen, with a plain face and a sulky mouth and the unmistakable bearing of a house that had money. She was not alone. She had a slave with her, a thin woman with a basket, and the slave was looking around in the way of a slave who has been told to be somewhere she should not be.

The girl turned, and Cassia saw her eyes. They were her father's eyes. They were also, in the way that these things happen, the eyes of the portrait in the atrium of the house on the Palatine that Cassia had never seen, and the eyes of a man who had once stood in a garden at Tibur with his hands full of roses.

The girl saw Cassia looking and did not look away. For a moment they regarded each other across the street, the freedwoman and the senator's daughter, and the noise of the city went on around them, and neither of them moved.

Then the slave touched the girl's arm, and the girl turned, and they went off toward the Palatine, and Cassia stood with her cup of water and watched them go.

"Domina," Bathyllus said, behind her. "The house."

"Yes," she said. "The house."

She walked on. The water was cold in her stomach, and the memory of cedar was in her throat, and somewhere behind her, in the new forum, a workman was

hammering at the column, fixing another piece of the emperor's glory into place. It would stand for a thousand years, she thought. It would outlast her, and Corvinus, and the Senate, and the whole squabbling city. It would outlast the secret. That was the thing about stone. It did not care what it was built on.

At the corner of the Clivus Suburanus, a man was waiting for her. He was a small man in a brown tunic, with the look of a clerk, and he stepped out of a doorway as she passed and said, quietly, "The lady is to know that the midwife is alive."

Bathyllus moved faster than a man his size should have. His hand closed on the man's collar, and the man did not resist. He looked at Cassia with the flat, patient eyes of a man who had been paid to deliver a message and had been paid enough to be calm about it.

"What midwife?" Cassia said.

"The one from Tibur," the man said. "The one who was at the birth. She is old, and she is not well, and she has been asking for the lady. She says she has something to give her."

"Who sent you?"

"No one sent me. She paid me with a ring." The man held out his hand. In his palm was a small bronze ring, worn thin, with a pattern of two snakes twined around a staff. Cassia had seen it before. She had seen it on the hand of a woman who had held her down on a bed in a cell at Tibur and told her to push, and had told her afterward that the child had never breathed.

She took the ring. It was cold, and lighter than it looked.

"Where is she?"

"At Tibur. In the village below the hill. The house with the fig tree." The man pulled free of Bathyllus's hand and straightened his tunic. "She says the lady should come before the spring. She says the lady will want to hear what she has to say."

He went away down the street, and Bathyllus looked at Cassia, and Cassia looked at the ring in her hand.

"Domina?"

"Go home," she said. "Tell Hermeros to bring the strongbox to my room. Tell Thais to come to me. And tell no one else anything."

She began to walk again, faster now, the ring closed in her fist. The city went on around her, buying and selling and eating and dying, and above the rooftops

the new forum of the emperor shone in the last of the light like something that had been built by gods who had never had a mother, and never been told a lie.

CHAPTER

# THREE

◆ ◆ ◆

The house of the Sulpicii stood on the slope of the Palatine where the hill turns its shoulder against the Circus, and it had stood there, in one form or another, for four hundred years. It had been burned in the year of the great fire and rebuilt; it had been seized in the civil wars and recovered; it had been mortgaged twice and redeemed twice, and the second redemption had cost the family a vineyard in Etruria and a great deal of pride. The walls were old republican stone, plain and massive, and the door was cedar and bronze and had been repaired so often that there was hardly an original piece of it left. A stranger might have thought it shabby. A Roman would have known that it was the opposite of shabby, because a house that does not need to look rich is a house that has been rich for a very long time.

The atrium was high and dark and cold in winter, and along one wall stood the imagines: the wax masks of the Sulpicii, each in its wooden cupboard, each with its name and its offices painted underneath. There were consuls there, and praetors, and a censor, and a man who had been sent as ambassador to a king in the East and had come home with an eye missing and a treaty. The masks were wax and would melt in a fire; they were also, in the strange arithmetic of Roman memory, more real than the men had been. On feast days a slave was paid to open the cupboards and anoint the masks with oil, and the whole atrium smelled of wax and old wood and the particular dust of a family that had been important for four hundred years.

Sulpicia Varia had the masks polished twice a year. She had done it herself when she was younger. Now she had a woman in to do it, and she sat in her chair and watched, and complained about the woman's technique.

She was sixty-seven and dying, though the household had agreed not to say so. The growth had begun in her breast two winters before, and the physician

had wanted to cut it out, and she had refused, and then she had allowed him to cut into it, and then it had come back, and now it was a hard, hot thing under her collar that she carried around with her like a purse she did not intend to open. She had grown thin. Her face had become all bone. But her eyes were the same as they had always been, pale and cold and entirely without self-deception, and when she rang the little silver bell beside her chair, the whole house came running.

On the morning after the Kalends, the house came running.

Her son came first, because he was the eldest and because he had learned, at an early age, that the cost of not coming was higher than the cost of coming. He came in his formal tunic, with his hair combed and his chin shaved, and he stood at the foot of her couch and waited to be told what he already knew.

"You were seen talking to her," Sulpicia Varia said.

"Yes."

"In the portico of the library. In front of half the Senate."

"There were three senators and a man from the treasury. The rest was crowd."

"Three senators is a crowd in this city. Three senators is a pamphlet." She shifted in her chair, and the movement cost her, and she did not allow it to show. "What did she want?"

"She wanted nothing. She was there because she had not been invited."

"And you spoke to her because?"

"Because she is a source of information."

"She is a source of something." The old woman's mouth was a thin line. "You are forty-five years old, Lucius. You have a wife, a son, a daughter, and a career that is not yet over. You have the augurate and the consular rank and the Asian command within your reach. And you are standing in a public portico talking to a woman who could destroy you with a single sentence, and you are telling me it is because she is informed."

"She is informed. She knows about Felix."

"Then pay Felix."

"Felix wants three hundred thousand."

"Then pay him three hundred thousand."

"I do not have three hundred thousand."

Sulpicia Varia looked at him for a long moment. Then she laughed, a dry, papery sound that turned into a cough. The slave behind her chair moved forward and she waved him away.

"You do not have three hundred thousand," she said. "You have a house on the Palatine that is falling down, a vineyard in Etruria that has not made a profit since the drought, a son who owes money to half the moneylenders in the city, and a daughter who must be married in the spring to a man whose family will want a dowry that you do not have. And you have the Asian command, which would pay for all of it and which you will not get if this accusation reaches the consul. And you are telling me you cannot find three hundred thousand sesterces."

"I am telling you I cannot find them honestly."

"Honestly." She said the word as though it were a bad smell. "Your father would have found them."

"My father," Corvinus said, "would have found them by selling someone."

"Yes," his mother said. "He would. And the house would still be standing, and the name would still mean something, and I would not be lying in this chair watching my son lose everything his grandfathers built because he has developed a conscience at the age of forty-five."

The room was silent. The slave by the door studied the floor. Outside, in the corridor, a servant went past with a basket of linen, and the sound of her feet was very loud.

"I have not developed a conscience," Corvinus said, at last. "I have developed a memory. They are not the same."

"They are worse." His mother closed her eyes. "Send for the steward. Tell him to sell the Etrurian vineyard."

"It is the last thing we have."

"It is a vineyard. I am the last thing we have." She opened her eyes. "And tell your wife I want to see her. And send the girl to me. She has been at the mirror again, and I will not have her married with paint on her face like a Greek."

He went out. In the corridor he stood for a moment with his hand against the wall, and the cold of the stone went through his palm and up his arm. He thought about the portico, and the noise of the crowd, and the way she had said *I was once sold, and no one came,* which she had not said to him, but which he

had heard, somehow, in the middle of everything else. He thought about the library and the smell of cedar and the twenty-four years.

Then he straightened his tunic and went to find the steward.

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The women of the house were in the small room off the garden, where the sun came in through a window of clear glass and the loom stood against the wall. Aemilia Celsa was at the loom, because she was always at the loom in the morning, and because a woman who is always at the loom cannot be accused of idleness. She had been weaving the same length of cloth for a month. It was a good cloth, the colour of wheat, and it would make a fine mantle for her husband, and she had no intention of finishing it.

Sulpicia Varia Minor was on the stool by the window with a book in her lap. She was fifteen and had her grandmother's bones and her father's eyes and a mouth that was always on the edge of something. She was not reading the book. She was watching the garden, where a blackbird was pulling at the ivy, and she was thinking about the Lupercalia, and about a boy.

"Your grandmother wants you," Aemilia said, without looking up.

"I know."

"Then go."

"In a moment."

"Now."

Sulpicia put the book down and went, and Aemilia wove four more lines of the wheat-coloured cloth before she set the shuttle down and said, to the empty room, "She is going to be a great deal of trouble."

The girl came back a quarter of an hour later with her face washed and her hair bound and a sulky set to her shoulders that meant her grandmother had been at her. She sat down on the stool again and said, "She wants me to marry Aulus Proculus."

Aemilia did not stop weaving. "Does she."

"She says he is steady. She says his father is a fool but the son will inherit, and a fool's son is better than a clever man's daughter, whatever that means."

"It means she has been talking to the lawyers."

"I do not want to marry Aulus Proculus."

"Then you had better find a husband who will be more useful to your father and less annoying to you, and you had better do it quickly." Aemilia looked up. "You are fifteen. You have perhaps a year before the choice is made for you. If you want a say in it, you will have to be cleverer than the choice."

The girl stared at her. "Did you choose my father?"

"No."

"Do you regret it?"

Aemilia considered the question longer than a mother should. "I regret very little," she said at last. "It is a luxury I was not raised to afford. Your father is a decent man, and a proud one, and he has spent his life trying to be the man his father was and the man his mother wants, and he has failed at both. That is not the worst thing a husband can be." She picked up the shuttle. "If you want a reason to dislike him, you will find one. Everyone does. But do not pretend it is his fault that the world is arranged the way it is. It is not his fault. He merely profits from it, which is worse, and which he knows."

Sulpicia was silent. Then she said, "The woman at the forum. The one he was talking to."

"What about her?"

"Grandmother says she is a whore."

"Your grandmother says a great many things." Aemilia's hands moved. "The woman is a freedwoman with a fortune and a house full of senators. She is not received in any house on this hill, and every man on this hill has been to hers. That is not a whore. That is a mirror. When you are older, you will understand the difference, and you will find that the mirror is more frightening."

"Are you afraid of her?"

Aemilia looked at her daughter for a long moment. "Yes," she said. "But not for the reason you think."

◆ ◆ ◆

In the afternoon Corvinus went down into the Forum to see a man about a loan. The man was a banker named Sittius, who had a stall under the Basilica Julia and a face like a closed door, and who had lent money to three generations of Sulpicii and had been repaid by two of them. The negotiation took an hour and ended with a rate of interest that was only slightly worse than ruin.

Coming out, Corvinus found his son waiting for him.

Publius Sulpicius Corvinus was twenty-one, and he had his father's height and his mother's colouring and none of either's restraint. He was dressed in the newest fashion, which meant his tunic was too fine for the season and his cloak was too short for the weather, and he had spent the morning, Corvinus suspected, doing something expensive.

"Father."

"Publius."

"I need to speak with you."

"You need money."

"That too." The boy fell into step beside him. They walked along the edge of the forum, past the stalls of the money changers and the lawyers and the men selling hot wine, and the boy talked, and the father listened, and neither of them looked at the other.

"It is the Asian command," Publius said. "Everyone says you will have it. Pactus is telling everyone you will not. He says a man with a son like you cannot be trusted with a province."

"And what does he mean by a son like me?"

"He means my debts. He means the gambling. He means the girl in the Subura." The boy's voice was carefully light. "He means that I am not serious. That is the word he uses. Not serious."

"And are you?"

"I am twenty-one."

"So was I, once."

"Yes, and you were serious. You were serious because grandfather made you serious. He made you stand in the atrium and look at the masks and tell him what each one had done for Rome, and if you got it wrong he beat you." Publius laughed, without humour. "I have heard the story. Everyone has heard the story. You tell it at dinner when you have had wine, and everyone laughs, and mother looks at the table."

Corvinus stopped walking. They were in the shadow of the basilica, and the noise of the forum went on around them, and a pigeon was pecking at something on the pavement between their feet.

"Your grandfather," he said, "was a hard man."

"He was a monster."

"He was a Roman of the old school, and he believed that the family was more important than any man in it, and he lived by that belief, and he made other people live by it, and he died by it." Corvinus's voice was flat. "I did not beat you. Perhaps that was my mistake. I have spent my life trying to be a different sort of father, and I have produced a son who thinks that a debt is a thing that happens to him."

Publius's face flushed. "I did not come here to be lectured."

"Then why did you come?"

"Because I need thirty thousand sesterces and you are the only man in Rome who can get them without asking me what they are for."

"What are they for?"

"For a girl."

Corvinus looked at him. His son looked back, defiant and frightened and twenty-one, and for a moment, in the middle of the forum, with the pigeons and the money changers and the noise, Corvinus saw himself at twenty-one in a garden at Tibur with his hands full of roses and a girl's laughter in his ear, and he felt the ground move under him.

"What girl?"

"None of your business."

"Publius."

"She is not a respectable girl. She is a girl in a house. Not that kind of house," he added, quickly, seeing his father's face. "A house of women. A decent house, kept by a freedman named Scaurus. Her mother is dead. She is free, and she has been promised to a sailor in Ostia, and the sailor has paid a deposit, and if I do not pay the rest he will take her." He stopped. "I have made a mess of it."

"Yes," Corvinus said. "You have."

They stood in the shadow of the basilica and looked at each other.

"I will not give you thirty thousand sesterces to buy a girl," Corvinus said. "I will give you ten thousand to pay your debts, and you will come with me to the moneylender and you will sign the agreement in your own name, and if you default he will take your horse and your rings and your cloak, and you will walk home in your tunic, and the whole city will see you do it."

"Father—"

"That is the offer."

The boy's jaw worked. Then he said, "And the girl?"

"The girl is not a transaction. If she is free, she cannot be bought. If her mother has promised her to a man in Ostia, then the promise is the business of her family and not of yours. If you want her, you will have to be a man who is worth wanting, and that is not something I can buy for you."

Publius stared at him. Then he laughed, a short, bitter laugh, and said, "You sound like mother."

"I have been told worse."

"No," the boy said, and turned away. "No, you have not."

He walked off into the crowd. Corvinus watched him go, and then he stood for a while in the shadow of the basilica, with the noise of the city going on around him, until a clerk came up and said, "Senator? The banker is waiting for the signature."

He signed. The rate was worse than he had feared and better than he had deserved. He came out of the banker's stall with the tablet under his arm and walked up the hill through the Forum and the Velia, past the arch of Titus and the vendors of fruit and the men selling copies of the new decree, and by the time he reached the Palatine his legs ached and his mind had gone quiet in the way it did after a day of small humiliations.

The house was cold. It was always cold in January. His mother kept her rooms warm out of a sense of her own importance, but the rest of the house was heated only when there were guests, and there were rarely guests now. He went through the atrium without looking at the masks, which was a habit he had developed as a boy and had never broken, and found his wife in the garden, wrapped in a mantle, watching the light go out of the sky.

"You are late," Aemilia said.

"The banker wanted to explain himself. Bankers always want to explain themselves. It is how they justify the interest."

"Did you get it?"

"Some of it. At a rate that would make a Carthaginian blush." He sat down on the bench beside her, and she moved a little to make room, which was the closest thing to affection that had passed between them in a week. "Publius came to see me."

"I know. He came home in a temper and kicked the door of his room and then asked the cook for bread and cheese, which is his way of apologising." She looked at him. "What did you say to him?"

"I told him I would not buy him a girl."

"Good."

"You do not ask who she is."

"I do not need to. He is twenty-one and he has been in love four times this year, and each time it has been the end of the world and each time the world has survived." Aemilia drew her mantle closer. "What else?"

"I told him he should be worth wanting."

She turned her head. "That was either very cruel or very kind."

"I do not know which. I have never known which." He looked at his hands. "My father would have beaten him. My father would have beaten him and then bought the girl and then beaten him again for the expense. And the terrible thing is that the house would have been stronger for it. The boy would have learned to be afraid, and fear makes men careful, and careful men keep their money. I have not beaten him, and he is not careful, and I am borrowing money at twelve per cent from a man who used to sell olives in the Subura."

"Your father is dead," Aemilia said. "You cannot keep measuring yourself against a dead man. He will always win. He has the advantage of not having to live with the consequences."

Corvinus laughed, once, without much sound. "You sound like her."

"I know. It is why I am still here." She said it without malice. "Your mother sent for me this morning. She wants the girl married to Aulus Proculus by the summer. She wants the vineyard sold. She wants the Asian command and she wants the accusation dealt with and she wants the masks polished before the Kalends of February, and she wants it all done by other people, because she cannot do it herself anymore."

"She is dying."

"Yes."

"She will not admit it."

"No. She will not." Aemilia was quiet for a moment. "I have been in this house for nineteen years. I came here at eighteen and I did not know what a family was. I thought it was a thing you joined, like a priesthood or a guild. I thought there would be rules and I would learn them and then I would belong." She looked at the dark garden. "There are no rules. There is only your mother, and the masks, and the money. And now there is this accusation, which no one will explain to me, and a woman on the Esquiline whom no one will name, and a

husband who goes to the forum in the morning and comes home at night with a face like a closed book."

"I am sorry," Corvinus said.

"I did not ask for an apology. I asked for the truth." She turned to him. "Whatever it is, I can bear it. I have borne worse than the truth. What I cannot bear is being the last person in my own house to know it."

He looked at her. In the fading light, with her hair coming down and her mantle clutched at her throat, she looked like a woman who had been beautiful once and had put the beauty away in a chest, and had never taken it out again because there was no occasion to.

"Not tonight," he said.

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only one I have."

She rose. "Then it will have to do." At the door to the house she stopped. "Lucius. The girl. If she is not to marry Aulus Proculus, she will have to marry someone. Find her someone. Not for the family. For her. There is a difference, and it will matter to her, and it may one day matter to you."

She went inside. Corvinus stayed in the garden until it was fully dark, and the slaves came out with the lamps, and the house on the Palatine settled into the night with the sound of old stone cooling and an old woman coughing in her room above.

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The house on the Esquiline had a visitor that night, and Cassia, who had been expecting one, was not surprised when Bathyllus came to the tablinum with his face set in the expression he reserved for young men with money.

"There is a party at the door," he said.

"Whose?"

"The Sulpicius boy. And two others. They have been drinking, and one of them has brought a jar of wine as a gift, and they are all wearing their cloaks like men who have never been told no."

Cassia put down her pen. She had been going over the accounts with Hermeros, and the lamp was low, and her eyes were tired, and she had spent the whole day thinking about a midwife in Tibur and a ring with two snakes on it.

"Where are they now?"

"In the street. The boy sent his name up as though it would open the door by itself."

"Did it?"

"Not yet." Bathyllus's mouth twitched. "I thought you would want to decide."

"Bring them in. The boy only. The others can wait in the garden and be looked at."

"And the wine?"

"Take it and thank them. It is probably the best thing they own." She stood and smoothed her stola. "And Bathyllus—"

"Yes?"

"Put them in the small dining room, not the painted one. Let them see the house but not the Graces. I want the boy to understand that there is a part of the house he has not been invited into."

The young man who came into the small dining room ten minutes later was handsome and drunk and trying to hide both. He had his father's height and his father's eyes, and he had the particular swagger of a boy who has been told all his life that the name he carries is a shield. He stopped in the doorway and looked at Cassia, and his face did something complicated.

"Domina," he said, and bowed too low.

"You are Publius Sulpicius Corvinus."

"I am."

"Then you are welcome in my house." She gestured to the couch. "Sit. You have come a long way, and you have brought wine, which is more than most men bring."

He sat. A slave brought cups, and the boy poured for both of them, and his hands were not quite steady. He drank too fast, and then he said, "You know my father."

"I know of your father."

"You know him."

The room was quiet. In the garden, one of his friends laughed, loudly, and was hushed.

"Yes," Cassia said. "I know him."

"He does not know I am here."

"I had assumed not."

"He would be angry." The boy turned his cup. "He is always angry, but he is quiet about it. He has made a career of being quiet about it. You know what he is like. You must know. Everyone knows what he is like except him."

"What is he like?"

"He is a man who has never made a mistake in his life, and who cannot understand why everyone else keeps making them." Publius drank. "He gave me ten thousand sesterces today and made me sign a paper. He thinks that is generosity. He thinks that is being a good father. He thinks that if he is careful enough and quiet enough and respectable enough, the world will not notice that the whole thing is a lie."

Cassia set her cup down. "What whole thing?"

The boy looked at her. The drink was in him, and the anger, and something else — a hurt that had been growing in him for a long time, like a tooth.

"The house," he said. "The name. The masks. My grandmother sitting in her chair talking about honour. My mother weaving the same cloth every day of her life. My father going down to the forum to borrow money from a man he despises so that he can keep up a house that is falling down, and then coming home and telling me that a man must live by the truth." He laughed. "The truth. The truth is that this city is a game, and the people who win are the ones who admit it, and my father has spent his whole life pretending not to play."

"And you?" Cassia said. "Are you winning?"

The boy's face changed. For a moment he looked very young, and very like his father, and not at all like a man who thought the city was a game.

"I came here," he said, "because I wanted to see what it looked like."

"What what looked like?"

"Your house. You." He looked around the room. "My father will not say your name. My grandmother prays about you. My mother mentions you at dinner as though you were a disease. I have lived my whole life in a house where you are a thing that is not spoken of, and today I saw my father stand in a public portico and talk to you as if the whole world were not watching, and I thought — I thought I should see for myself."

"And what do you see?"

He looked at her for a long time. The lamp was between them, and the wine, and the noise of his friends in the garden, and the whole weight of the house above and around them.

"I see a woman," he said, "who is not a monster."

"No," Cassia said. "I am not."

"Then why does he hate you?"

The question was so naked, and so young, that she almost answered it. She looked at the boy's face, which was his father's face, and at his hands, which were not his father's hands, and she thought: he does not know. He does not know anything. He has been raised in that cold house with the masks on the wall and the mother in the chair, and no one has ever told him the truth about anything, and he is drowning in it.

"Your father does not hate me," she said. "He hates what I know."

"What do you know?"

"Everything," Cassia said, "that your family has spent a great deal of money to forget."

The boy stared at her. Then he said, quietly, "Tell me."

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because it is not mine to tell, and because you are drunk, and because the telling of it would cost more than you can pay tonight." She stood. "Go home. Tell your friends the evening was a success and the lady of the house was beautiful and nothing happened. It is the most useful lie you will tell this year."

He did not move. "If I come back? Sober?"

"Then I will consider it."

He rose, unsteadily. At the door he turned and said, "My father said something today. He said I should be a man who is worth wanting. What does that mean? What does it mean to be worth wanting?"

Cassia looked at him. In the lamplight, with his cloak askew and his face open, he looked like a boy who had come a long way to ask a question and had been given a riddle instead.

"It means," she said, "that you should find out what you are worth and then make sure it is true. Most men never do. They spend their lives being told what they are worth by other people, and they believe it, and they die believing it. Your father is one of them. He is worth a great deal to the Senate and the army and the name on the wall, and he is worth almost nothing to himself, and he has never once noticed the difference."

The boy's face worked. Then he bowed, and went out, and she heard him collect his friends in the garden, and the three of them go laughing and stumbling down the Clivus Suburanus into the dark.

Bathyllus came in to clear the cups.

"Domina."

"Yes?"

"The boy's father will hear of this. He has eyes on the hill, and eyes in the street, and the boy is not careful."

"I know."

"And the boy knows something, or he thinks he does. He will talk."

"He will not talk. He is too frightened of his father." Cassia picked up her pen. "But he will come back. And when he does, he will be sober, and he will ask me again, and I will have to decide what to tell him."

She looked down at the accounts. The figures swam. She set the pen aside and sat for a moment with her hands flat on the desk, and then she said, "Bathyllus, send word to Tibur. Tomorrow. Not through Hermeros. Through the woman who sells flowers in the Subura. Tell the midwife that I will come before the spring, and that she is to stay alive until I do."

"Domina."

"And Bathyllus—" She looked up. "The boy is not to be admitted again. Not unless I say so. Not unless I am here."

"Yes, domina."

She was alone then, with the lamp and the accounts and the ring on the desk before her, two snakes twined around a staff, worn thin by twenty-four years of someone else's hand.

CHAPTER

# FOUR

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The Baths of Agrippa opened to women at the fourth hour, and by the time Cassia arrived the dressing room was already full of the particular noise of Roman women pretending not to look at one another. There were senators' wives and bankers' widows and the daughters of men who had made their money inannounced and were now buying their way into the equestrian order one marriage at a time. There were two actresses, who were not respectable and did not care. There was a woman who had been a vestal until a scandal had retired her, and who now came to the baths every day and sat in the hottest room until she was red, as though she were trying to sweat out the memory. And there was Tertulla, already undressed and wrapped in a linen sheet, arguing with the attendant about the temperature of the oil.

"It is rancid," she said.

"It is the best oil in Rome, domina."

"Then Rome has gone off." Tertulla saw Cassia and waved. "There you are. Come and smell this. It is either oil or a mistake."

Cassia smelled it. It was oil, and it was not rancid, though it had been in the jar a long time. "It is fine. Stop tormenting the girl. She did not press the olives."

The attendant looked grateful. Tertulla looked betrayed. They went through into the tepidarium, where the air was warm and wet and smelled of steam and perfume and bodies, and the mosaic floor showed a Triton with a following of sea creatures, and somebody had dropped a bronze strigil and left it where it lay.

The bathing was a ritual, and like all rituals it was mostly about being seen. The actual washing took a quarter of an hour. The rest was politics. Cassia sat on the marble bench with her feet in the warm water and let the steam open her lungs, and the room arranged itself around her the way rooms always did.

"Did you hear about the grain fleet?" said a woman on her left, who had a face like a spoon and a husband in the annona.

"I heard two ships were lost."

"Three. The third went down off Corsica and the cargo was insured in Alexandria, and the insurer is refusing to pay, and the prefect is furious." The spoon-faced woman leaned in. "They say Comptus is finished."

"They have said that before."

"They have never said it with a warrant."

Cassia turned her head. "What warrant?"

"There is a man from the treasury asking questions. A man named Felix."

The steam curled between them. Cassia's face did not change.

"Felix asks questions for a living," she said. "He has been asking them for years and he has never once found an answer."

"He found one this time. He has been to the grain office twice, and to the prefect's house, and to the house of a man in the fourth cohort who signed the manifest." The woman lowered her voice. "They say he is not working alone."

"Who is he working for?"

"Nobody knows. That is the interesting part." The woman smiled, pleased to have something to trade. "You should be careful, domina. They say he has been asking about your house as well."

"Then he will find that it is very clean," Cassia said, "and that I charge by the hour."

The woman laughed, uncertain whether she had been insulted, and drifted away to tell someone else.

Two women came through from the dressing room, and one of them was the wife of a praetor and the other was the wife of a man who hoped to be a praetor, and they saw Cassia and made the small adjustment of the head that is not quite a greeting and not quite a cut. Cassia watched them go by with her hands folded in her lap.

"You could buy them both," Tertulla said, "and they know it."

"Buying is easy. It is the being bought that people resent." Cassia smiled at the praetor's wife, a wide, warm, entirely genuine-looking smile, and the woman faltered and then, because she was well brought up, smiled back before she could stop herself. "There. Now she will go home and be angry with herself all afternoon."

"You are a terrible woman."

"I am a student of human nature. It is the same thing with better manners."

A young woman came and sat down on the bench opposite, with a nurse behind her and a look of determined friendliness. She was perhaps twenty, and pregnant, and clearly at the baths on the advice of a physician who had told her that warm water was good for the child and had not told her what to do about the women who would look at her.

"You are Antonia Cassia," she said.

"I am."

"I am Lollia. My husband is in the fourth cohort of the vigiles. He says you are the most dangerous woman in Rome." She said it with pleasure, as though she had been given a present. "I have wanted to meet you for a year. My mother says I am not to speak to you and my husband says I am not to speak to you and the priest says I am not to speak to you, and I have decided that a woman with three men telling her what to do must have something worth hearing."

Cassia laughed. It was the first unguarded laugh she had given all morning, and it surprised her. "What do you want to hear?"

"How did you do it?"

"Do what?"

"All of it. The house. The money. The men who come and go and are afraid of you. My husband is a good man and he is afraid of his commander, and his commander is afraid of the prefect, and the prefect is afraid of the emperor, and the emperor is afraid of the army, and nobody in the whole city is afraid of me." Lollia's chin came up. "I would like to be afraid of something other than my mother-in-law."

The steam curled. Tertulla was watching them both with amusement and something like tenderness.

"You will not like the answer," Cassia said.

"I have not liked many answers."

"Then here it is. I did it by being useful to people who could hurt me, and by making sure that I knew one thing about each of them that they would not want known, and by never once asking for a favour without offering something in return. I did it by working when other people were sleeping, and by remembering every name and every debt, and by never letting a man see me cry. And I did it by being willing to be disliked." Cassia leaned forward. "You are pregnant, and

you are young, and you are pretty, and you have a husband who is a good man. Do not do what I did. It is a poor bargain. Be liked. Be liked and be useful and be patient, and in twenty years you will have a house full of children and a husband who does not flinch when you come into the room, and that is worth more than all the gold in my strongroom."

Lollia stared at her. Then she said, "But you have the gold."

"Yes," Cassia said. "I have the gold."

She stood, and Tertulla stood with her, and they went through into the hot room, and behind them Lollia sat with her hands on her belly and her nurse fanning her and a look on her face like a woman doing arithmetic.

Tertulla came and sat beside her, close enough that their shoulders touched. "Felix," she said.

"Felix."

"You are not surprised."

"I am never surprised. It is bad for the digestion." Cassia closed her eyes. "He came to the house after the Saturnalia. He wants two hundred thousand and he offered me a document, and I told him to come back after the Ides, and I have been thinking about him ever since."

"Two hundred thousand for what?"

"For a memory. His words."

"Whose memory?"

"Mine," Cassia said. "Or near enough."

Tertulla was quiet. Then she said, "You could pay him."

"I could. And then he would come back next year, and the year after, and the price would go up, and by the time I was fifty I would have bought my whole life back from him three times over. That is not a bargain. That is a subscription." Cassia opened her eyes. "There is only one way to deal with a man like Felix."

"Which is?"

"To make him more afraid of you than he is greedy for your money." She stood. "Come. I want the hot room before the consul's wife takes it, because she will want it for an hour and she will talk about her son the whole time."

The caldarium was a furnace. The floor was too hot to stand on without wooden sandals, and the air was so thick with steam that the bathers were only shapes, pale and moving, like fish under ice. Cassia climbed to the highest

bench, where the heat was worst, and lay back with a folded cloth over her eyes, and let the sweat run.

Tertulla climbed up beside her. Their hands found each other in the dark of the cloth.

"You are frightened," Tertulla said, quietly.

"I am warm."

"You are frightened. You talk about subscriptions and bargains when you are frightened. When you are calm you talk about the price of fish."

Cassia said nothing. The steam hissed. Somewhere below, a woman laughed, and someone else shushed her, and the attendant came through with the bucket, sloshing water on the coals.

"I have spent twenty-four years," Cassia said at last, "building a wall. Every brick is a favour, a debt, a secret, a friend. I have been very careful. I have never once asked for more than a man could give, and I have never once let a man leave this house without knowing that I knew something about him that he would not want his wife to know." She lifted the cloth from her eyes. "And now a man I have never liked is standing outside the wall with a chisel, and the wall is made of people. My people. They will not put me to the question. They will put them to the question. And they will break, because everyone breaks, and then they will say things about me that are true and things that are not, and the Senate will not care which is which."

"You could go away."

"Where?"

"Anywhere. You have money."

"I have money in Rome. In Alexandria I have a letter of credit and a cousin of Hermeros who may or may not be honest. In Antioch I have nothing. In Athens I have a debt I have never collected." Cassia sat up. "And if I go, I am a woman who ran. A woman who ran is a woman who was guilty. The whole city will say it, and they will be right, and my house will be sold for debts within the year, and the people in it will be sold with the furniture."

"What do you want?"

Cassia looked at her. In the steam, with her hair flat to her head and her face flushed and her eyes steady, Tertulla looked like the only solid thing in a room made of vapour.

"I want," Cassia said, "to be the one who decides."

She leaned over and kissed her. It was not a public kiss, though it was not exactly private either; the steam hid them, and the women around them were occupied with their own sweating and their own gossip, and in Rome a kiss between two women in a bath was not a scandal, provided that neither of them was married to a man who cared. Tertulla's mouth was warm and tasted of the mint they gave out at the door. Her hand came up and rested on Cassia's neck, and her thumb moved once, slowly, against the pulse there.

"Not here," Tertulla murmured.

"No," Cassia said. "Not here."

They went down to the small pool in the corner, where the water was cold, and Cassia stepped in and gasped, and the shock of it went through her like a knife and cleared her head. Tertulla followed, and they stood in the cold water with their arms around each other, and the noise of the baths was a long way off, and for a moment Cassia allowed herself to be held.

"Whatever happens," Tertulla said into her ear, "you are not that girl any more. You are not the girl in the cell. You are the woman who owns the house. Remember that when you are frightened. You are not the one who gets sold. You are the one who does the selling."

Cassia laughed, and it came out broken. "That is the most Roman thing anyone has ever said to me."

"I have been practising."

They came out of the pool and were drying themselves when the attendant came to say that a lady was asking for the domina. Cassia, with her hair still dripping and her skin still cold, wrapped herself in the sheet and went out into the colonnade, where the winter sun was coming in low and gold and the water of the great pool was green and still.

Aemilia Celsa was sitting on the stone bench by the pool, dressed, composed, with a fan in her hand that she did not need. She had come alone. That in itself was a statement, because a senator's wife did not go to the public baths alone unless she wanted to be seen doing it.

"Domina," Cassia said.

"Domina." Aemilia looked up at her, and her eyes were the eyes of a woman who had been awake all night. "I have come to ask you a question, and I would like you to answer it honestly, because I have had enough of being lied to by people who love me."

"Ask."

"Who is Psyche?"

The name went through Cassia like the cold water. She stood very still, with her hair dripping onto the mosaic, and the whole great colonnade seemed to hold its breath.

"Where did you hear that name?"

"My mother-in-law said it in her sleep. Three nights ago. She said it twice, and then she said, 'Tell her nothing,' and then she woke up and asked for her medicine and would not look at me." Aemilia's fan did not move. "I have been in that house for nineteen years. I know every name in it — the slaves, the freedmen, the tenants, the creditors, the cousins in Gaul. I have never heard the name Psyche. And when I asked the old steward, he went the colour of a fish and said it was a woman who used to do the mending."

Cassia sat down on the bench beside her. It was not a friendly gesture, and it was not meant to be; it was the gesture of a woman who has decided that the conversation will be long.

"Psyche was a midwife," she said. "She was at Tibur, in the summer of the year eighty-eight. She was at a birth."

"Whose?"

"Mine."

Aemilia's fan stopped. For a long moment she did not move at all. Then she said, "There was a child."

"There was a child."

"What happened to it?"

"I was told it was born dead. I was told it did not breathe. I was told it was buried in the garden at Tibur, and I was not allowed to see it, and three days later I was sold to a man in Puteoli and put on a cart, and I did not come back to Rome for four years." Cassia's voice was even. "The midwife is alive. She is old and she is ill and she has sent me a ring and a message, and she says she has something to give me. I do not know what it is. I do not know whether she is telling the truth or whether she wants money or whether she has gone mad in her old age. But I am going to Tibur before the spring, and I am going to ask her."

Aemilia turned to look at her. Her face was white. "Why are you telling me this?"

"Because you asked. Because you came here alone to ask. Because you have been lied to by people who love you, and I know what that does to a person, and I would not wish it on a dog." Cassia drew the sheet closer around her shoulders. "And because whatever is coming, it is coming for your house as much as mine, and I would rather have one person inside that house who knows the truth than a whole family who does not."

Aemilia was silent for a long time. The sun moved on the water. In the distance, in the women's hall, someone dropped a bronze basin and the sound rang off the marble.

"He is my husband," Aemilia said at last.

"Yes."

"And you hate him."

"I do."

"Why?"

Cassia looked at her. There were a hundred answers, and most of them were true, and none of them were ones she would give to this woman on a stone bench in a public bath.

"Because he was there," she said, "and he did nothing. And because he has spent twenty-four years being a good man in public in order to make up for the one thing he did in private, and it has worked. He has been consul. He is an augur. Men listen to him. And I have spent twenty-four years being a woman no one will listen to, and I have had to buy my hearing." She stood. "That is the answer. You may do with it what you like."

Aemilia rose too. She folded her fan and put it in her sleeve, and she looked at Cassia for a moment with an expression that was not friendship and was not enmity.

"I will not tell him I came here," she said.

"I know you will not."

"How do you know?"

"Because you did not bring a slave, and you did not use the north entrance, and you have been sitting with your back to the door the whole time we have been speaking." Cassia almost smiled. "You are a very good liar, domina. You have spent nineteen years learning it. It is the only thing that house teaches anyone."

Aemilia's mouth twisted. "My daughter thinks I am at the temple of Juno."

"Then you had better go to the temple of Juno, or the gods will be angry and your daughter will be suspicious, and I do not know which is worse."

Aemilia turned to go. At the edge of the colonnade she stopped and said, without turning round, "The girl. Publius's girl. Her name is Calpurnia. She is in a house in the Subura that belongs to a man named Scaurus, and she is not a whore, and her mother is dead, and she has been promised to a sailor in Ostia. He has paid a deposit. If my son does not pay the rest, she will be on a boat by the Kalends of March."

"Why are you telling me?"

"Because my son will ruin himself over her, and I have no money, and you have a great deal." Now she did turn, and her face was hard. "I do not like you. I do not approve of you. I think your house is a blot on this city and I would not let my daughter cross your threshold. But I am a practical woman, and my son is going to make a mistake, and there is no one else in Rome with money and no children who might understand."

Cassia looked at her for a long moment.

"Come to the house," she said. "Not the baths. The house. On the day after the Ides, in the morning, before the men are awake. We will talk about your son, and about the midwife, and about what your mother-in-law knows. And bring the girl, if you can do it without a scandal. It is time she saw a house that is not a tomb."

* * *

The house was quiet that evening. Cassia bathed again at home, in her own bath, with Sabina pouring the water and Philumena doing her hair afterward, and she ate a light supper in the small room with Tertulla and Ione and Thais, and she did not talk about the baths.

Thais was fifty-four and had been with her since Puteoli. She had been the woman who ran the house in those years, when the house was three rooms above a bakery and the guests were sailors and the money was bad. She was small and brown and neat, and she could read and write and do sums and had never in her life been surprised by anything a man did. She came to Cassia's room after supper with the keys at her belt and said, "You have not asked me about the boy."

"The boy?"

"The flower seller came. She had word from Tibur." Thais sat down without being invited, because she had earned that. "Psyche is alive. She is very old and her eyes are bad and she lives with her granddaughter's family in the village under the hill. She has a box that she keeps under her bed. The granddaughter does not know what is in it. The granddaughter is frightened of it."

"Frightened why?"

"Because the old woman talks to it." Thais's face did not change. "She calls it by a name."

Cassia sat down at her desk. The lamp was lit, and the shutters were closed, and beyond them the city went on with its noise, indifferent as always.

"What name?"

"'The little master,'" Thais said.

Cassia put her hands flat on the desk and looked at them. They were a woman's hands, jewelled, soft, and they had once been a girl's hands, red from the wash water, and there was a scar across the left thumb from a knife in a kitchen in Puteoli. She looked at the scar for a while.

"Thais," she said. "What do you remember of the day I came to Puteoli?"

"Everything."

"Tell me."

Thais was quiet. Then she said, "You came in a cart. You had a cloak that did not belong to you and no shoes. You had been bleeding for three days and you would not let anyone look at you. You sat in the kitchen and would not eat, and when the man who owned the house came in and told you what you were to do, you looked at him as though you were measuring him for a coffin. I thought: that one will either kill him or own him. I was right both times."

"He died of a fever."

"He died of a fever three years later and you had bought the house by then and you were not sorry." Thais's mouth moved. "I remember that you would not say the word 'child.' For two years you would not say it. If a customer's child came into the kitchen you would leave the room. If a woman on the street was carrying a baby you would cross the road. And then one day you said it — we were counting the wine and you said, 'The child of the wine merchant is sick,' and you went on counting — and after that you were all right, or you were better, or you were a different kind of not all right."

"What kind?"

"The kind that builds a house," Thais said, "and fills it with people, and never has a child of her own."

The lamp guttered. Cassia reached out and turned the wick up, and the light steadied.

"Go to bed," she said. "Tomorrow I want the strongbox brought up, and the black book, and I want you to write down everything you know about Felix. Every debt, every woman, every bribe. Every man he has ever ruined. I want it all."

"For what?"

"Because a man who has ruined other men has enemies, and enemies are cheaper than friends." Cassia opened a drawer and took out a small box of cedarwood, and set it on the desk, and did not open it. "And because I am going to make him choose between the money and his life, and I need to know which one he loves more."

Thais rose. At the door she said, "And the boy? In Puteoli. The fuller's boy. Chrysis's brother."

"What about him?"

"Two thousand sesterces is not a great deal of money."

"No," Cassia said. "It is not."

"You could buy him and give him to her, and she would be yours forever."

"I do not want her to be mine forever. I want her to be free and to know it." Cassia looked up. "There is a difference, Thais. I have spent my whole life learning it."

Thais went out. Cassia sat alone for a long time with the cedar box in front of her. Then she opened it.

There was nothing in it but a letter. The papyrus was brown at the edges and had cracked along two of the folds, and the ink was faded to the colour of rust, and the handwriting was the careful, upright handwriting of a young man of twenty who had been taught to write by a Greek tutor with a stick. She did not read it. She had read it so many times that she could have recited it in the dark, and had done, on bad nights, in Puteoli, when the clients were gone and the house was quiet and the only sound was the sea.

She held it for a while. Then she put it back in the box and closed the lid, and put the box back in the drawer, and locked the drawer, and put the key in the fold of her belt where it had lived for twenty-four years.

Sabina came in with the evening lesson, which was letters. She had learned her alphabet from Thais and her numbers from Hermeros and her manners from everyone, and she could now read a line of Virgil slowly and with great seriousness, as though each word were a coin she had been asked to test with her teeth. Cassia sat her at the little table with the wax tablet and the stylus and heard her read.

"The arms and the man I sing," Sabina read. "Who first from the shores of Troy..." She stopped. "Domina, why does it begin with arms? Is it a song about weapons?"

"It is a song about a man who carries them."

"But it says the arms and the man. As though the arms were the important part."

Cassia looked at her. Sabina was twelve, and thin, and her hair was tied back with a strip of leather, and she had the flat, direct gaze of a child who has not yet learned to be embarrassed by her own intelligence.

"Perhaps the poet thought they were," Cassia said. "The arms are what the man is for. The man is what the arms are used by. A line like that is a way of saying that you cannot separate the two."

"That is a sad thing to begin a song with."

"It is a Roman thing to begin a song with."

Sabina considered this, and then wrote the line again on her tablet, in careful letters, and Cassia watched her do it and felt the old, strange, painful thing that she had felt for twenty-four years whenever a child did something well.

"Domina," Sabina said, without looking up, "did you have a mother?"

The room was very quiet. The lamp hissed.

"I did," Cassia said. "She died when I was small."

"What was she like?"

"She smelled of lavender. She used to sing when she was working. She had a bad temper and a good laugh, and she could not sew, and she used to tell me that the gods were not in the temples, they were in the kitchen, because that is where the food was." Cassia's voice was steady. "I do not remember her face. I remember the smell of lavender and the singing and the bad temper. That is all."

"That is a lot," Sabina said.

"Yes," Cassia said. "It is."

"Will you teach me to write a letter?"

"Who would you write to?"

"Nobody," Sabina said. "I would just like to be able to."

Cassia put her hand on the girl's head for a moment, and then took it away, because tenderness in this house was a thing that had to be measured out in small doses, like medicine.

Ione came in as Sabina was leaving. She had been out, and she was still in her cloak, and her cheeks were pink with the cold, and she stood in the doorway and watched the child go with an expression that Cassia could not read.

"She is getting clever," Ione said.

"She is getting educated. It is not the same. Cleverness is what she was born with."

"You are fond of her."

"Yes."

"More than you are of the rest of us."

Cassia looked at her. "I am fond of all of you. It is not a competition."

"Everything is a competition." Ione came in and sat down, uninvited, in the chair by the desk. "I have been thinking about what you said at the Saturnalia. That you were not a customary woman. That you had built something worth keeping."

"I did not say that."

"You said something like it. It does not matter. What matters is that I have been in this house for nine years, and I have no house of my own, and no money of my own, and no name. I have a room, and a share of the gifts, and a future that depends on your health and your temper and the goodwill of men who think of me as furniture."

"You are not furniture."

"I know. That is why I am talking to you." Ione leaned forward. "I want to buy my freedom."

Cassia was silent.

"I have saved," Ione said. "Not enough. I have a man who will lend me the rest. He is a wine merchant in the Vicus Longus, and he is fat and he is fifty and he has a wife, and he wants me to keep a house for him, and I do not want to keep a house for him, but I want to be free more than I want anything else." Her voice did not shake. "I am telling you because I would rather buy my freedom

from you than run away from you, and because I think you would rather have the money than the scandal."

"How much do you have?"

"Forty thousand."

"And the man will lend you forty more."

"Yes."

"And what will he want for it?"

Ione's mouth twisted. "What do men always want?"

Cassia looked at her for a long moment. Then she said, "I will not sell you to him."

"You will not—"

"I will free you," Cassia said. "For nothing."

Ione stared at her. "Why?"

"Because you asked me a fair question and because you have been honest with me for nine years, which is longer than most wives manage, and because if I keep you here against your will, you will poison the house, and I like the house." Cassia picked up her pen. "There will be conditions. You will stay until the spring, and you will train the girl who takes your place, and you will not take any of my clients with you, and you will not tell anyone what you know about me. And you will not take the wine merchant's money, because a woman who takes a loan from a man like that is not free, whatever the paper says."

Ione's eyes were bright. "I do not know what to say."

"Say nothing. It is not a favour. It is a transaction, and I am getting the better of it." Cassia looked down at her accounts. "Go and tell Thais. She will draw up the papers, and she will be unpleasant about it, and then she will cry in the kitchen, and you will pretend not to notice."

Ione rose. At the door she said, "You are not what they say you are."

"I am exactly what they say I am," Cassia said. "I am also other things. Most people are."

There was a knock at the door of the house, and Bathyllus's voice, and then Hermeros's, and then a third voice, young and high and frightened. Cassia went out into the atrium. A boy stood there with his cloak wet from the street and his hair plastered to his forehead, and in his hand he had a wax tablet with the seal broken.

"From whom?" Cassia said.

"From the senator Corvinus," the boy said. "He said to give it to you and no one else and to wait for an answer."

She took the tablet and turned it to the lamp.

*They have found the physician's assistant. He is in the house of Pactus and he is talking. F.*

No greeting. No closing. The same four lines, the same terrible economy, twenty-four years later.

Cassia looked at the boy, who was shivering, and at Bathyllus, who was watching her, and at Hermeros, who was pretending to be interested in the accounts, and beyond them at the dark garden where the roses were black sticks and the fountain played its patient music in the cold.

"Tell him," she said, "that I will come to him. Tomorrow, at the ninth hour, at the house of my friend Tertulla, which is on the Caelian and has two doors. Tell him to come alone and to come by the garden door. Tell him that if he brings a lictor, or a friend, or a slave who can read, I will have him thrown out of the house and he can explain to the Senate why he was there."

The boy nodded and ran.

"Domina," Hermeros said, when he had gone, "is that wise?"

"No," Cassia said. "It is necessary. Wisdom is what you do when you have a choice."

CHAPTER

# FIVE

◆ ◆ ◆

Tibur, in the summer of the year eighty-eight.

The villa stood on the shoulder of the hill above the falls, where the Anio came down out of the hills and broke itself white on the rocks and then ran green and slow through the meadows below. The house was old and cool and full of the sound of water. It had a portico with a vine on it and a garden of clipped box and a small bathhouse with a mosaic of dolphins that had been put in by the great-grandfather and repaired by every generation since. From the terrace you could see the whole wide plain and, on a clear day, the smoke of Rome, thirty miles off, hanging over the city like a stain.

Cassia had come to Tibur with the household in the month of June, as she had come every summer since she was twelve. She was eighteen. She was a maid to Sulpicia Varia, which meant that she carried the mistress's fan and her medicine box and her writing things, and stood behind her chair in the afternoons, and was invisible in the way that a good maid is invisible, which is to say that she saw everything and was seen by no one.

She had been born in Rome, in a room over a laundry near the Circus, to a woman named Daphne who had washed clothes for the Sulpicii and had died when Cassia was nine. She did not remember much of her mother. She remembered the smell of lye and lavender, and a song about a boat, and hands that were always red and cracked and always gentle. When Daphne died, the household had kept the child, because a child is an asset and the Sulpicii had never thrown away an asset. She had worked in the kitchen, then in the linen, then in the mistress's rooms, and she had learned to read and write from the steward's clerk, who had taught her in exchange for nothing more than her company and the occasional slice of bread and honey, and who had died of a fever in the year eighty-five and left her the notebook he had copied his accounts into.

The family came to Tibur in June, and the young master came in July.

Lucius Sulpicius Corvinus was twenty. He had been away for two years — a military tribune with the legion in Syria, then a winter in Athens, then a slow road home through the islands — and he came up the hill from the road in the late afternoon with dust on his boots and a sunburn on his neck and the look of a man who has discovered that the world is larger than the house he was raised in. He was tall and lean and there was a new scar on his forearm and a new way of standing. Cassia saw him from the terrace, where she was shaking out the mistress's cushions, and he looked up and saw her, and neither of them spoke.

That evening there was a dinner. The father presided: Marcus Sulpicius Corvinus, fifty-three, consul twice, a man with a face like a coin that had been in circulation too long. He had the family's height and none of its grace. He was a hard man and a proud one, and he had spent his whole life in the conviction that the world was divided into men who were equal to him and men who were not, and that the second category was very large and the first very small. His wife sat at his right, silent and beautiful, with her fan and her medicine box and her pale eyes. She was forty-three that summer. She looked ten years younger, and she had the kind of composure that comes from never having been contradicted by anyone who mattered.

They talked about the war in the north, and the emperor's temper, and the price of the villa's wine. The young master said little. He ate slowly and looked at the garden and once, when the conversation turned to the household and the steward listed the slaves who had been bought and sold that spring, he looked at his father with an expression that Cassia, standing behind the mistress's chair with the fan, could not read.

After dinner he found her in the garden.

"You are Daphne's girl," he said.

"I am."

"I remember you. You used to bring the water to the men in the vineyard."

"You used to drink it and say thank you."

"Did I?"

"Every time. The others did not."

He looked at her for a long moment. The light was going, and the cicadas were loud, and the water from the falls came up the hill as a low, continuous sound, like a crowd very far away.

"I am sorry about your mother," he said.

"Thank you."

"I was at school in Rome when she died. I heard about it. My mother said she had been a good servant." He paused. "It seemed a small thing to say."

"It is a small thing," Cassia said. "It is also more than most people said."

He laughed. It was a surprised laugh, a young man's laugh, and it changed his face entirely. "You are not what I expected."

"What did you expect?"

"I do not know. A maid."

"I am a maid."

"Yes," he said. "That is what surprised me."

* * *

The summer went like this: a garden, a fountain, a boy who came to the kitchen for bread and stayed to talk. It was not a seduction. That is what Cassia would have said afterward, if anyone had asked her, and no one did for twenty-four years. It was not a seduction, because a seduction is a thing one person does to another, and this was a thing that happened to both of them at once, the way a rainstorm happens, the way a fever happens.

He found excuses. He came to the kitchen for water, for bread, for the key to the bathhouse, for a message he could have sent a slave for. He sat on the bench by the door and watched her work and talked about Syria, about the desert, about the strange gods he had seen and the men he had met and the letters he had tried to write home and torn up. He asked about her, and listened to the answers, which was the most dangerous thing of all. He asked what she thought of the poems of Catullus, which he had been reading in Athens. She had not read Catullus. The next day there was a copy of Catullus in the kitchen, left on the bench as though it had grown there.

She read it at night by the lamp in the slaves' corridor, and when she came to the poem about the girl's sparrow she cried, and she could not have told anyone why.

He kissed her first in the store-room, between the jars of oil and the baskets of figs, in the hot dead hour of the afternoon when the whole house was asleep. It was a clumsy kiss, and brief, and afterward he stepped back and said, "I should

not have done that," and she said, "No," and neither of them moved, and then he did it again.

They met in the vineyard, in the little stone hut where the pruner kept his tools. They met in the bathhouse after the house was asleep, in the cold pool, with the dolphins looking at them from the wall. They met in the meadow below the falls, in the long grass, with the water roaring and the sun on their backs, and he traced the scar on her thumb with his finger and asked where she had got it, and she told him, and he said, "You will never have another scar like that. I will see to it." He said it with the absolute seriousness of a boy of twenty, and she believed him, because she was eighteen, and because the light was gold, and because no one had ever promised her anything.

He told her about his father. He told her in pieces, in the dark, with his head in her lap. He told her about the atrium and the masks and the beatings that were not beatings but "lessons," and the way his father could make a room cold by walking into it, and the way his mother had learned to be a wall. He told her that he was afraid of becoming his father, and she said that he would not, and he said, "How do you know?" and she said, "Because you are afraid of it. Your father is not afraid of anything."

She did not tell him about herself. There was not much to tell. She had no story, only a life: the laundry, the kitchen, the corridor, the lamp, the book. She told him about her mother's song and about the steward's clerk who had taught her letters, and he listened as though these were the adventures of Odysseus.

The mistress watched them. Cassia knew it, the way one knows that a spider is in the corner of a room. Sulpicia Varia said nothing, did nothing, gave no sign. She sent Cassia to the village with a message and sent the young master to the vineyards with the steward, and arranged the days so that they were never alone in the house at the same time, and it made no difference at all.

One afternoon in the middle of August she kept Cassia behind after the other maids had gone and made her sit on the stool by the window and read to her from a book of letters. It was a book of Pliny's letters, and the one she chose was about a man who had lost his wife and could not stop writing about her.

"Read that again," the mistress said, when she had finished.

Cassia read it again.

"Now tell me what it is about."

"A man who is grieving."

"No," Sulpicia Varia said. "It is about a man who wants everyone to know that he is grieving. There is a difference. The first man weeps in the dark and says nothing. The second man writes a letter and has it copied and sends it to eleven friends." She took the book back and closed it. "You are clever. Cleverer than the maids I have had. Cleverer, I sometimes think, than my son."

"I am not, domina."

"You are. He is good and he is honest and he is not clever, and that is why he will be eaten alive in this city unless he learns to be quieter than he is." She looked out of the window at the garden. "You are clever, and you are pretty, and you are a slave, and those three things together are the most dangerous combination a woman can have. Do you know what happens to women like that?"

"No, domina."

"Either they are destroyed, or they learn to be the ones who destroy." The mistress turned back to her, and her pale eyes were steady. "I have been watching you since you were twelve. You have a good heart and a bad temper and you do not forget anything. Those are useful things. They will not save you, but they are useful." She stood. "Go and tell the cook that I want the fish plain tonight, with no sauce. He will be offended. Let him be offended. It is good for cooks."

Cassia went. At the door the mistress said, "And Cassia. Do not be alone with my son in the afternoons. The house is not as empty as it looks."

In the last week of August she missed her bleeding. She did not think about it at first. Then she thought about it, and counted, and thought about it again, and one morning she was sick in the gutter behind the kitchen, and Melissa, the under-cook, a sharp-eyed woman who had seen everything twice and been surprised by none of it, looked at her and said nothing, and then, later, left a cup of mint tea on the bench where Cassia would find it.

She told him on the terrace, at night, with the plain dark below them and the smoke of Rome gone and the stars very close.

He was quiet for a long time. She watched his face and saw, for the first time, the thing that she would see again and again for twenty-four years: the way he went still when he was afraid. Not pale. Not shaking. Still, like a man in a temple waiting for the augury.

"Then we will be married," he said.

"Your father will never permit it."

"Then we will go away."

"Where?"

"Anywhere. I have money of my own — not much, but enough. We could go to Syria. I have friends there. There is a farm near Antioch that belongs to a man who owes me a favour." He took her hands. "Cassia. Look at me. I am not my father. I will not do what he would do."

"I know," she said. She did not know. But she wanted to say something that would make it true.

They had four days. On the fifth day the steward came for her in the middle of the afternoon and said that the master wished to see her in the tablinum.

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Marcus Sulpicius Corvinus was standing at the window with his hands behind his back. He did not turn when she came in. The room was hot and smelled of ink and old paper and the wax of the seals. There was a bust of his father on the desk, and a letter open beside it, and a cup of wine that had not been touched.

"Close the door," he said.

She closed it.

"You have been fucking my son."

The word was not shouted. It was placed on the desk like a coin, precisely, in the tone of a man who has already decided what everything is worth.

"I have not—"

"Do not." He turned. His face was calm. "I have eyes in this house. I have had eyes in this house since before you were born. The gardener saw you in the vineyard. The bath slave saw you in the pool. The girl who does the linen saw you on the terrace at night with your hands in his hair." He came around the desk. "You are pregnant."

She said nothing.

"You are pregnant," he said again, "and you will tell me the truth, or I will have the physician examine you in front of the household, and then I will have you whipped for insolence, and then I will sell you to a man I know in Puteoli who buys girls for his house and does not ask them questions."

"Yes," Cassia said. "I am pregnant."

"By my son."

"Yes."

He looked at her for a long moment. Then he sat down behind the desk and poured himself a cup of wine and drank it off, and set the cup down, and said, in the same calm voice, "You have been in this house since you were twelve. You have been fed and clothed and taught to read, which was not my doing and which I have always thought was a mistake. My wife is fond of you, in her way. You have had a better life than most of the people in that kitchen, and you have had it because we are a family that takes care of its own." He looked up. "And this is how you repay us."

"I love him."

"You are a slave."

"He loves me."

"My son is twenty years old and has been in the East for two years and has never in his life been told no by a woman. He does not love you. He wants you. There is a difference, and it is the difference between a man and a boy." He reached for the letter on the desk. "He will be sent to Syria at the end of the month. There is a staff posting with the governor. I had intended to refuse it. I will accept it now."

Cassia stood very still. The room was hot. Somewhere outside, a bird was calling, over and over, the same three notes.

"And me?"

"You will be sold. Not here — there is no market at Tibur, and I will not have the household talking. You will go to Puteoli, to a woman named Lusca, who keeps a house and is discreet, and who will pay me a fair price for a girl with a pretty face and a child in her belly. She will take the child off your hands. It will be exposed, or sold, or given to a farm; I do not care which. You will not see it." He set the letter down. "That is the arrangement. You may go."

She did not move. She was eighteen years old, and she had been a slave all her life, and she had learned in that life that there is a moment in every conversation when a person with power has finished speaking and is waiting for you to be afraid. She had seen it a hundred times. She had never been on the other side of it before.

"Does your wife know?" she said.

His eyes narrowed. "What?"

"Does she know about Puteoli? About Lusca? About the child?"

"That is not your concern."

"She will find out. She always finds out. She knew about the girl in the kitchen at Rome, the one you sent away in the spring. She knew about the wine merchant's daughter. She knows everything, and she says nothing, and one day she will say something, and it will not be to you."

The blow came fast and flat, an open hand across the face, and it knocked her against the door. She tasted blood. She stood up, and put her hand to her mouth, and looked at him.

"Get out," he said.

She got out.

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Sulpicia Varia came to her that night, in the corridor by the linen room, with a lamp in her hand.

Cassia was sitting on the floor with her back against the wall. Her face was swelling. She had been sitting there for three hours, because there was nowhere else to go, and because the house was small and every corner of it had a door that led to a room where she had been happy.

The mistress stood over her. She was in her nightgown, with her hair down, and without her jewels and her fan she looked smaller and older and strangely ordinary.

"He has told you," she said.

"Yes."

"And you believe him?"

"Why would he lie?"

"He would not lie. He is many things, but he is not a liar." Sulpicia Varia set the lamp down on the floor between them. "My husband has made arrangements. I have come to make a different one."

Cassia looked up at her.

"I have no power in this house," the mistress said, "except the power of a woman who has been married to that man for twenty-six years and has learned where the keys are kept and which of the servants can be trusted and which of the physicians is in debt. I cannot stop him selling you. I cannot stop him sending my son away. But I can make it easier." She crouched down, her skirts folding on the stone, and her face came into the lamplight. "I can make it quick. There is a draught I can give you, on the night it happens. You will sleep. You

will not feel the birth as you would otherwise feel it, and you will not remember much of it afterward. And when you wake, it will be over, and you will be on the road, and you will not have to carry the memory of it for the rest of your life."

"Why would you do that?"

"Because you are a person," Sulpicia Varia said, "and because I have watched you grow up in this house, and because I have no daughter of my own, and because I do not wish to think of you in that room at Puteoli remembering what was done to you here." She paused. "And because I am a practical woman, and a girl who screams is a girl who is remembered, and I do not want this house remembered."

Cassia looked at her. In the lamplight the mistress's face was kind, and tired, and entirely sincere.

"Will the child be buried?" Cassia said.

"Yes."

"Here? In the garden?"

"By the fig tree. I will see to it myself."

"Will you tell me when it is done?"

"I will tell you," Sulpicia Varia said. "I will tell you before you go."

She reached out and took Cassia's hand. Her own hand was warm and dry and very steady.

"Drink what I give you," she said. "Drink all of it. And when you wake, do not look back."

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They came for her in the last week of September, on a night with no moon.

She had been having pains since the afternoon. The physician had been and gone, and the midwife had come at dusk with her bag and her bronze ring and her quiet, competent hands. Psyche was sixty that year, a small woman with grey hair and a face like a walnut, and she had delivered half the babies in the village and had never lost a mother. She put her hand on Cassia's belly and said, "Soon. Before morning. You will have an easy one; I can tell." And Cassia, who had been told that nothing about her life would ever be easy, had almost laughed.

The room was a cell at the back of the villa, next to the storeroom. It had a bed and a stool and a small high window, and the door had a bolt on the outside. There was a lamp on the stool and a basin on the floor, and the walls were white-

washed, and someone had scratched a fish into the plaster, a child's drawing, very old.

Sulpicia Varia came at the ninth hour with a cup in her hand.

It was a small cup, silver, and the liquid in it was dark and smelled of honey and something bitter underneath.

"Drink it now," she said. "All of it. It will make the pains easier, and it will help you sleep between them."

Cassia took the cup. She was eighteen years old and in pain and frightened, and the woman who had been kind to her was standing over her with a lamp, and outside the door a man was waiting to put her on a cart in the morning.

She drank it.

It tasted of honey and then of almonds, and then of nothing at all.

The room went soft at the edges. The lamp became three lamps, and then a smear of gold. She heard the door open and close, and voices, and the midwife saying something in a low voice, and the mistress answering, and then a long silence in which the only sound was the blood moving in her own ears.

The pains came and went, and she floated above them, and at some point she was pushing, and the midwife was telling her to push, and there was a great pressure and a tearing and a wet rush, and then a silence that went on too long.

Then a cry. Thin and furious and alive.

"A boy," Psyche said. "A fine boy. Look at him."

Cassia tried to open her eyes. The room was dark and turning. She saw, through a haze, the midwife's hands, and something small and red and moving, and then a shadow came between her and the light.

"Give him to me," Sulpicia Varia said.

The midwife said something. Cassia could not hear the words. She heard the tone — a question, a protest.

"Give him to me," the mistress said again, "and remember what you were paid, and what you were told, and what will happen to you if you forget it."

The baby stopped crying. Cassia heard the small, wet, working sounds of a newborn being wrapped in cloth, and then the sounds were muffled, and then they were somewhere else in the room, and then they were at the door.

"Psyche," the mistress said. "The cup. All of it. And then you will go to the steward and tell him it is done, and you will say nothing to the girl, and in the morning you will tell her the child did not breathe."

"Domina, he is breathing now—"

"He will not be breathing by the time she wakes," Sulpicia Varia said, "because he will not be here. Do you understand me?"

"Give him to me," the mistress said again, "and do what you were paid to do."

And then Cassia's body, which had been holding her up out of the dark for a long time, let go, and she went down into it, and the last thing she heard was the crying, going away, getting smaller, until it was only a sound in a dream.

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She woke in the morning to a grey light and a pain like a knife and the taste of almonds in her mouth.

The room was empty. The basin had been emptied and the floor washed. The lamp had been taken away, and the bed had been changed, and she was clean and dressed in a plain shift, and there was a cup of water on the stool.

She got up. It took a long time. She went to the door and found it unbolted, and she opened it, and the corridor was empty, and the storeroom door was open, and the morning light was coming in through the colonnade at the end.

Psyche was in the kitchen, drinking a bowl of broth. She looked up when Cassia came in, and her face did something complicated.

"Where is my son?" Cassia said.

The midwife set the bowl down.

"Domina," she said.

"Where is my son?"

"Stillborn," Psyche said. "He did not breathe. It happens. He was a fine boy, but he did not breathe, and the mistress took him to be buried."

"You said he cried."

"The medicine makes you dream." The midwife's eyes were steady. "You were dreaming. I am sorry. He did not breathe."

Cassia stood in the kitchen with her hand on the table. The room was warm. The fire was lit. Somewhere a dog was barking, and a woman was singing, and the world was going on exactly as it had gone on before.

"I want to see him," she said.

"He is buried."

"Then dig him up."

"Domina—"

"Dig him up. I want to see him. I want to see his face."

Psyche looked at her for a long moment. Then she said, "The mistress has given orders. You are to be on the cart by the third hour. If you are not on the cart, the steward has been told to tie you to it." She picked up her bowl again. "I am sorry. I have delivered a hundred babies in this village and I have never lost a mother, and I have lost three children, and it never gets easier, and there is nothing I can say to you that would help." She drank her broth. "Eat something. The road to Puteoli is long."

The cart came at the third hour. It was a farm cart, driven by a man who did not look at her, with a load of wine jars and a folded blanket on the boards. The steward walked her to it. The household watched from the doors and the windows — the cook, the gardener, the girl who did the linen, the boy who fed the pigeons. No one said anything. There was nothing to say that would not be reported.

The last thing she saw of Tibur was the fig tree at the corner of the garden, with the morning sun on it, and the earth below it disturbed.

She was in Puteoli by the evening of the second day. Lusca's house was three streets up from the harbour, with a green door and a lamp over it, and a woman with dyed hair and a fat, kind, entirely merciless face who looked her over the way a farmer looks at a horse.

"Eighteen," Lusca said. "Pretty. Not too thin. What did she have?"

"A boy," the driver said. "Stillborn."

"Good. No brats to worry about." She took Cassia's chin in her hand and turned her face to the light. "You will do. You will do very well. Get her inside and fed, and then we will see about the blood."

The green door closed. The bolt went across. Somewhere in the house a woman was laughing, and a man was shouting about a cup, and the sea was three streets away and could be heard in every room, like something enormous breathing in its sleep.

A woman came out of the kitchen with a bowl of soup and a hunk of bread and stood in front of her. She was small and brown and neat, and she looked at Cassia the way a physician looks at a wound, without pity and without disgust, and she said, "Eat."

Cassia did not move.

"Eat," the woman said again. "You have been on a cart for two days and you have a fever coming and if you do not eat you will be no use to anyone, including yourself." She put the bowl into Cassia's hands. "My name is Thais. I run the kitchen and the accounts and the girls when Lusca is drunk, which is most of the time. You will do as I say and you will not cry in front of the clients and you will not run, because there is a man at the back door with a stick and he is quicker than he looks." She turned to go, and then turned back. "And you will not believe anything they tell you in the first month. Not the men, not the girls, not the mistress. Nothing. Do you understand?"

"Yes," Cassia said.

"Good." Thais looked at her for a moment longer. "What was his name?"

Cassia's mouth opened. No sound came out.

"The child's name," Thais said. "Or the father's. Either."

"I do not know," Cassia said. "I never gave him one."

"Then give him one now," Thais said, "and keep it to yourself, and never say it out loud in this house. A name is the only thing they cannot take from you if you do not tell them what it is."

Cassia stood in the dark of the entrance hall with her hands at her sides and thought about the cry. She had heard it. She knew she had heard it. And for twenty-four years afterward, whenever she was very tired or very ill or very close to sleep, she would hear it again — thin and furious and alive, going away from her, getting smaller, until it was only a sound in a dream.

CHAPTER

# SIX

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Tertulla's house on the Caelian was smaller than Cassia's and older than the Republic, and it had two doors: one on the street, where the clients came, and one in the garden wall at the end of an alley where the rubbish was put out. Cassia came by the garden door. She came alone, with her veil over her face and a lamp under her cloak, and Bathyllus walked behind her at a distance of twenty paces with a knife in his sleeve and an expression of profound disapproval.

"An hour," he said at the gate. "If you are not out in an hour, I am coming in."

"Two."

"An hour and a half, and I will knock loudly and embarrass you."

"That is the most insubordinate thing anyone has said to me this year," Cassia said, "and it is January."

The garden was small and bare and smelled of wet earth and rosemary. Tertulla was waiting at the door of the little dining room with a lamp in her hand and a face that was doing its best to be neutral and failing.

"He is here," she said.

"I know."

"He came by the garden door and he stood in my atrium and looked at the ceiling for a long time and then he said, 'This is a very old house,' and I said, 'Yes,' and then neither of us said anything for a quarter of an hour." Tertulla's mouth twisted. "I do not like him."

"You do not have to like him."

"I have to watch him look at you. That is different." She put her hand on Cassia's arm. "I will be in the kitchen. If you need me, scream. If you do not need me, scream anyway, and I will come and be rude to him."

She went out. Cassia stood in the corridor for a moment, with the lamp and the cold and the smell of rosemary, and then she opened the door.

He was standing by the window with his back to her, in a dark cloak, his hands behind his back. It was the posture of his father; she had seen it in a tablinum at Tibur twenty-four years before, and the sight of it went through her like a blade.

"You came," she said.

"I said I would."

"Men say a great many things."

He turned. In the lamplight he looked older than he had in the forum; the lines around his mouth were deeper, and there was a greyness under his skin that had not been there at the Kalends. He had not slept. She recognized the signs because she had not slept either.

"Thank you for seeing me," he said.

"Sit down, Lucius. You are making the room smaller."

He sat. She sat opposite him, with the table between them, and for a moment neither of them spoke. The lamp burned. Somewhere in the house a door closed, and there was the sound of a woman laughing, very far away.

"Tell me what you know," Cassia said.

He told her. It took a quarter of an hour, and it was worse than she had feared.

Felix had come to him in December, before the Saturnalia, with a demand for three hundred thousand sesterces and a story. The story was this: a man named Faustus, who had been the assistant to the physician who had attended his father in his last illness, was now living in a room above a wine shop on the Aventine, and he had been talking. He had been talking to a woman named Psyche, a midwife, who had been at Tibur in the summer of eighty-eight. He had been talking to the old steward, who was retired and lived in a cottage near Ficulea and had a bad chest and a daughter who was not married. He had been talking, in fact, to anyone who would listen, and he had been paid to talk by a man who was not Felix, and Felix knew who the man was and would not say.

"And the accusation?"

"Parricide. That I procured the death of my father." Corvinus's voice was flat. "It is absurd. It is legally absurd. A man cannot be accused of parricide on the word of a physician's assistant and a midwife and a steward who is dying.

But it does not have to be true to be laid. It only has to be laid before the consul, and then there is a trial, and a trial is a year, and in a year the Asian command is gone, the augurate is gone, the house is gone, and I am a man who was accused of killing his father and was acquitted, which in this city is worse than being convicted."

"Who is behind it?"

"Pactus. It must be Pactus. He has wanted the Asian command since he was praetor, and he has never had the name for it, and he knows that if I am out of the way the lot will fall to him."

"Pactus is a new man. He cannot afford a scandal. If it comes out that he hired a delator to destroy a consular, the emperor will eat him alive." Cassia shook her head. "No. If Pactus is involved, he is a partner, not the principal. There is someone behind him who wants the Sulpicii damaged and has the money to pay Felix and the patience to wait."

"Who?"

"I do not know yet. I will find out." She looked at him. "Now tell me the rest."

"What rest?"

"The part you have not told me. The part you have been carrying for twenty-four years. Tell me what happened that night. Tell me what you knew, and when you knew it, and what you did."

He was silent for a long time. The lamp guttered, and he reached out and turned the wick up, and the light steadied, and his face was closed and careful and entirely without defence.

"I knew my father had found out," he said. "He told me on the twenty-first of September. He called me into the tablinum and he told me that he knew, and that I was a fool, and that the girl would be sold and the child disposed of, and that I would be on a ship to Syria before the month was out. I argued with him. I told him I would marry you. He laughed at me." Corvinus's hands were flat on the table. "I told him I would go to the governor of the province and ask for a posting and take you with me. He said that if I did, he would have you sold to a house in Puteoli and he would make sure I never found you. He said he had done it before, with a girl in Rome, and that I would forget you in a year, and that in ten years I would thank him."

"And you believed him?"

"I believed he could do it. I did not believe I would forget you." He looked up. "I went to my mother. I thought — I do not know what I thought. I thought she might help. She was always the one who could manage him. She listened to me and she said that she would speak to him, and that I was to do nothing, and that she would send word to you. And then the next morning she came to me and told me that you had gone into labour in the night, and that the child was dead, and that you were dead."

Cassia sat very still. The room was cold. She could hear her own breathing, and the lamp, and the rain that had started outside, a thin, steady rain on the roof tiles.

"She told me you were dead," Corvinus said. "She told me you had a fever and the child was stillborn and you died before dawn. She had the steward bring me the physician's certificate. I did not see the body. I did not ask to see the body. I was twenty years old and I believed my mother, and I got on a ship to Syria three days later, and I did not come back to Rome for two years, and when I came back the villa at Tibur had been sold and the household had been broken up and there was no one left to ask."

"She sold me," Cassia said.

"I know."

"She sold me to a woman named Lusca, who kept a brothel in Puteoli, and I was there for four years, and I was beaten and I was used and I was made to do things that I will not tell you and that you will not ask about, and I survived because I am the kind of woman who survives, and I bought my freedom with money I earned on my back and with the help of a man who was kind to me and died of a dropsy, and I have spent twenty-four years building a life out of the wreck of that night." Her voice did not rise. "And you got on a ship."

He did not look away. "Yes."

"And you did not come back."

"I came back. Two years later. The house was empty. The fig tree was still there. I stood in the garden and I could not remember your face. I could remember your voice and the way you held your head and the way you read Catullus out loud in the kitchen, and I could not remember your face, and I thought that was the worst thing that had ever happened to me." He laughed, once, without any humour at all. "I was a fool. I was a boy. I have been a boy for twenty-four years, and I am tired of it."

Cassia looked at him across the table. The rain came down. The lamp burned. Somewhere in the house Tertulla was moving about in the kitchen, and the sound of her was small and ordinary and comforting.

"There is something you should know," she said.

"Tell me."

"The midwife is alive. Psyche. She is old and she is ill and she lives at Tibur, and she has sent me a message. She says she has something to give me." Cassia watched his face. "She was there that night. She delivered the child. She told me he was stillborn, and I heard him cry, and I have spent twenty-four years telling myself that I dreamed it."

Corvinus's face changed. It was not a large change. It was the change of a man who has been holding a door shut for a very long time and has just felt the wood begin to give.

"He cried," he said.

"He cried. And then your mother took him out of the room, and the midwife gave me something to make me sleep, and when I woke the room was clean and the child was buried under the fig tree and I was on a cart to Puteoli." Cassia leaned forward. "If she has something to give me, Lucius, it is not a ring. It is not a memory. It is either a grave with a body in it, or it is a name."

"A name," he said.

"A name and an age and a place. There is a boy somewhere in this world who is twenty-four years old and who does not know who his mother is. I am going to Tibur, and I am going to find out, and I am going to bring him home if he is alive." She said it without emphasis, as though she were discussing a shipment of wine. "And you are going to help me."

He was silent. She watched him and let the silence work, because silence was one of the tools of her trade and she had learned to use it as a carpenter uses a plane.

"Who else knows?" she said. "About the witnesses. About the accusation."

"Felix. Pactus, if he is behind it. My mother, though she will not admit it. The old steward at Ficulea, who is frightened and dying and has a daughter who is not married." He rubbed his face. "And a man in the prefect's office, I think. Felix said something about a manifest. I did not understand it at the time."

Cassia's head came up. "The grain manifest."

"What?"

"Nothing. Something else. Something that may be useful." She was already thinking — Comptus, the manifest, the clerk with the inky fingers who had been talking to someone. A chain of small men, each holding one link. "Go on."

"That is all. That is everything I know."

"Then we have something to work with. A frightened steward can be reassured. A clerk can be bought. A delator can be broken. Your mother is the only one who cannot be dealt with, because she does not want money and she does not want safety. She wants the past to stay where it is." Cassia's mouth tightened. "And the past is not going to stay where it is, because the midwife is alive and I am going to Tibur."

He was silent.

"You owe it," she said.

"I know."

"Do you? Because this is not a favour, Lucius. This is not a debt I am calling in to make you feel better. This is a child. If he is alive, he has been raised by whoever your mother sold him to, and he has been told whatever they told him, and he has no idea that there is a woman in Rome who has been listening for him for twenty-four years." Her voice was steady. "And if he is dead, then I want to stand at the grave and I want you standing beside me, because I did it alone the first time and I will not do it alone again."

He looked at her. His eyes were wet, and he did not wipe them, and she did not look away, and in the long silence that followed, the rain stopped as suddenly as it had begun, and the room was very quiet.

"Yes," he said. "I will help you."

"Then we have a bargain."

"We have a bargain."

She stood up. She did not know what she had intended to do — to leave, to call Bathyllus, to go into the kitchen and let Tertulla be rude to him. What she did instead was walk around the table and stand in front of him, and he stood up, and they were close enough that she could smell the cedar and the wool and the rain on his cloak.

"You are still wearing the same oil," she said.

"My mother's housekeeper buys it. I have never thought to change it."

"I hated it. For twenty-four years, I hated the smell of it. I would smell it in a crowd and I would have to stop walking."

"I am sorry."

"Stop saying that."

"I am sorry," he said, and then he laughed, a wrecked sort of laugh, and she put her hand flat on his chest, to stop him, or to steady him, or to feel whether he was real.

The kiss was not like the kisses in the vineyard. It was not young and it was not easy and it was not a promise of anything. It was a collision. He made a sound against her mouth, and his hands came up and held her face, and she gripped the front of his tunic and pulled him down and kissed him back as though she were trying to take something out of him by force.

They broke apart. Both of them were breathing hard.

"That is not part of the bargain," she said.

"No."

"It is a very bad idea."

"Yes."

She kissed him again.

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Afterward they lay in Tertulla's bed, in the room with the blue ceiling, and the rain had started again and was ticking on the roof. The lamp was low. Corvinus's arm was under her head, and her hand was on his chest, and she could feel his heart going, slow now, steady, like a man who had run a long way and stopped.

"That was a mistake," she said.

"It was."

"We are going to do it again."

"Probably."

She laughed, and then stopped laughing, because the laugh had turned into something else in her throat, and she lay still until it passed. He did not say anything. He stroked her hair, and waited, and after a while she was able to breathe normally again.

"Tell me about your life," he said. "Not the war. Not the Senate. The life."

"There is no life. There is the house."

"Tell me about your wife."

He was quiet. "Aemilia is a good woman. She is cleverer than I am and she has known it since the second year of our marriage and she has never once said so. She came to me at eighteen with a dowry and a trunk of books and a great deal of hope, and I gave her a cold house and a mother who hated her and a husband who was somewhere else even when he was in the room." He looked at the ceiling. "I have tried to be kind to her. Kindness is not the same as love, and she knows the difference, and she has never complained. That is the worst of it. She has never complained."

"She came to see me at the baths."

He turned his head. "She did what?"

"She came alone, without a slave, and she asked me who Psyche was." Cassia watched his face. "She knows something is wrong. She does not know what. She has been in that house for nineteen years and she has been lied to by everyone in it, and she is beginning to understand that the lies are not for her protection."

Corvinus closed his eyes. "I should have told her."

"Yes."

"I did not know how."

"Men never do. That is why women learn to read faces." She propped herself up on one elbow. "If we survive this, Lucius, you will tell her. Not because it is good for the family, and not because it will make you feel better. Because she is your wife and she has earned the truth, and because a house built on a lie will fall on the people inside it, and I know that better than anyone in Rome."

"Tell me about the house."

So she told him. She told him about buying it with money from the brothel and the brickworks and the shipping venture, and about the strongroom behind the panel, and about Thais and Hermeros and Bathyllus, and about Sabina learning her letters and Celer and his fish sauce and Chrysis and her brother. She told him about the clients, and the games, and the parties, and the way a senator will tell a woman things at midnight that he would not tell his own brother at noon. She told him about the black book, though not where it was kept.

"And you are happy?" he said.

"I am busy."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only answer I have." She turned her head on his shoulder. "Happiness is a thing that happens to other people. I have a house, and a fortune, and

twenty-three people who depend on me, and a seat at every table in Rome that matters, and no one has called me a slave in sixteen years. That is not happiness. It is better than happiness. Happiness can be taken away."

"Can it?"

"Everything can be taken away. That is the first thing I learned and the last thing I will forget." She sat up, pulling the coverlet with her. "Now. The bargain. What do we do about Felix?"

He sat up too. The mood changed, the way it does when two people who have been lovers remember that they are also, in the eyes of the world, two parties to a negotiation.

"Felix wants three hundred thousand," he said. "I do not have it. If I sell the vineyard, I will have perhaps a hundred and fifty. My mother has jewellery. My wife has a dowry, which is not mine to touch. The house is mortgaged to a banker named Sittius."

"Then we do not pay him."

"He will go to the consul."

"Let him. A delator who goes to the consul with a story and no evidence is a delator who gets fined." Cassia pushed her hair back. "The question is not Felix. The question is who is paying Felix. Find that out and we can break him. A man like that has no loyalty. He has a price, and when someone else offers a better price, he will sell his patron in a heartbeat."

"How do we find out?"

"I will find out. I have people in this city who owe me favours, and one of them is a clerk in the office of the prefect of the grain supply, and another is a woman who does the hair of the wife of a man who is close to Pactus." She looked at him. "You will do something else. You will go to your mother and you will ask her what she knows about the midwife."

He was silent.

"She gave me the cup, Lucius."

"I know."

"She told me it would make it easier. She told me the child would be buried under the fig tree. She stood in the room while the midwife took him away, and she told her to remember what she had been paid." Cassia's voice was very calm. "I have spent twenty-four years believing that she was the only person in that house who was kind to me. I would like to know whether I was wrong."

"My mother is dying."

"I know."

"She has perhaps three months. Perhaps less. The physician will not say, but I have seen it before. She is in pain all the time now, and she does not sleep, and she has begun to talk about my father as though he were in the next room." He looked at his hands. "If I ask her, she will tell me the truth, and it will kill her."

"Then it will kill her," Cassia said. "She has had sixty-seven years and a house on the Palatine and a son who has spent his whole life trying to please her. I had a night in a cell and a cart to Puteoli. I am not going to be careful with her feelings."

He looked at her for a long moment. Then he nodded.

"I will ask her," he said. "But not tonight. Tomorrow. When she is awake and lucid and has her medicine." He got up and began to dress. "And Cassia—"

"Yes?"

"Whatever she says. Whatever she did. I did not know. I want you to know that I did not know."

"I know," Cassia said. "That is the worst of it."

He stopped with his cloak half on. "What?"

"If you had known, you would have been a monster. If you had known and done nothing, I could hate you cleanly, and it would be simple, and I would be free of you." She pulled the coverlet up. "But you did not know, and you did not come, and you married a woman you do not love and you have spent twenty-four years being a good man in a bad house, and I cannot hate you cleanly. I have tried. I have tried for twenty-four years. It does not work."

He came back to the bed and stood over her. In the lamplight his face was tired and open and entirely without defences.

"I will come to Tibur with you," he said. "When you go. I will find a way."

"You will not. If you are seen on the road with me, the whole city will know by the Ides, and then the accusation will not matter because the scandal will be worse." She shook her head. "You will stay in Rome and you will do what I tell you. That is the bargain."

He bent down and kissed her forehead, and then her mouth, and then he went out. She heard him in the corridor, and the garden door, and the rain, and then Bathyllus's voice, low and unfriendly, and then nothing.

She lay in the bed for a while with her eyes open. Then she got up and dressed and went into the kitchen, where Tertulla was sitting at the table with a cup of wine and a face like a thundercloud.

"Well," Tertulla said.

"Well."

"Are you going to tell me, or am I going to have to guess?"

"You are going to have to guess," Cassia said, and sat down, and poured herself a cup, and drank it in one go. "And then you are going to be angry with me, and I am going to let you, and then we are going to have supper."

Tertulla looked at her for a long moment. Then she reached across the table and took her hand.

"I am not angry," she said. "I am frightened. There is a difference."

"Yes," Cassia said. "I know."

* * *

On the Palatine, the lamps were still burning in the old woman's room.

Corvinus came in out of the rain and stood in the doorway of the atrium, dripping, and looked at the masks in their cupboards, and at the small bronze lamp that burned before them, and at the slave who had come to take his cloak and was waiting, patiently, to be told what to do.

"Leave it," he said. "Go to bed."

Aemilia was standing at the end of the corridor, in her nightgown, with a lamp in her hand.

"You are wet," she said.

"It is raining."

"I heard the door. I thought it was a thief." She looked at him. "You have been with her."

He did not answer.

"I am not going to make a scene in the corridor at midnight, and I am not going to weep, and I am not going to ask you to choose, because I know what you would choose and I do not want to hear it said out loud." Her voice was perfectly steady. "I am going to ask you one thing. When this is over — whatever this is — will you tell me the truth? All of it? Not the version that protects me. The truth."

"Yes," he said.

She looked at him for a long moment. Then she stepped aside to let him pass.

"Your mother has been asking for you," she said. "She has been asking for you since the ninth hour. She will not say why. She has sent the boy out twice to look for you in the street." She turned away. "Whatever she wants, Lucius, hear her out. She is dying, and dying people are the only honest people in this city."

The slave went. Corvinus walked through the house to his mother's room and found the door open and the physician's boy asleep on a stool outside it. He went in.

Sulpicia Varia was propped up on her pillows with her eyes closed. Her face was the colour of candle wax, and her hands on the coverlet were so thin that he could see the shape of the bones. The room smelled of camphor and sickness and the lavender they put in the linen.

She opened her eyes.

"You went to her," she said.

"Yes."

"You smell of her."

"I know."

"Did she tell you that I poisoned your father?"

The room was very quiet. The lamp on the table burned without a flicker. Outside, the rain had stopped, and the night was cold and clear, and the stars over the Palatine were the same stars that had shone on a garden at Tibur twenty-four years before.

"No," Corvinus said. "She told me that you gave her a cup."

"I did."

"Did you kill him?"

His mother looked at him for a long time. Her eyes, in the ruin of her face, were still the eyes he had known since he was a child: pale and cold and entirely without self-deception.

"Not with the cup," she said. "The cup was for her, and it was only poppy and honey and a little of the stuff the physician used for the pain. It was not poison. She was not poisoned. She was asleep." She shifted, and winced, and went on. "Your father died of an apoplexy, in his bed, at the third hour of the morning, and the physician was called and he signed the certificate and he was

paid for his signature, and I have never told anyone in this house a word of what happened before that, and I am not going to tell you now."

"Did you kill him?"

"I did not put anything in his cup," she said. "I put something in his wine at dinner, and he drank it, and he went to his room, and he was dead by morning. It was not enough to kill a strong man. He was not a strong man. He was a bully and a coward and a man who beat his son with a strap and called it education, and his heart was bad, and the physician had told him two years before that he must not excite himself." She closed her eyes. "I did not know whether it would kill him. I hoped it would. I have hoped it every day for twenty-four years, and I have confessed it every month to a priest who is now dead, and I am not sorry."

Corvinus stood by the bed. His hands were shaking. He was forty-five years old, and a consular, and an augur, and he had spoken in the Senate a hundred times, and he could not think of a single thing to say.

"The child," he said at last.

"What child?"

"Do not. Do not do that. The child. My child. The boy she was carrying." He heard his own voice rise and did not stop it. "The midwife is alive. She is at Tibur. She has something to give her. What did you do with my son?"

Sulpicia Varia opened her eyes. She looked at him with an expression that he had never seen on her face before, and that he would think about for the rest of his life: not guilt, not defiance, but calculation.

"He is dead," she said.

"Is he?"

"Yes."

"Then where is the grave?"

"Under the fig tree. As I told her."

"Then I will have it opened."

"No," his mother said, "you will not." And for the first time in the whole of his life, her voice was not cold; it was frightened. "You will not open that grave. You will not go to Tibur. You will not speak to the midwife. You will let this die, Lucius, as I have spent twenty-four years making sure that it dies. There is more at stake here than a girl and a brat. There is the house. There is the name. There is the Asian command, and the augurate, and everything your father and his father and his father's father built." She pushed herself up on her elbows. "If

this comes out, we are finished. Not disgraced. Finished. There is no house, no name, no money, no marriage for your daughter, no future for your son. You will be the man who killed his father, or you will be the man whose mother killed his father and who said nothing. Either way, you are finished, and the Sulpicii are finished with you."

Corvinus looked at his mother. The rain had stopped. The lamp burned. Somewhere in the house, his wife was asleep, and his children were asleep, and the masks in the atrium looked out of their cupboards into the dark.

"Then I am finished," he said.

He turned and went out. Behind him, in the room, his mother called his name once, and then again, louder, and then the physician's boy woke up and came running, and there was the sound of a woman weeping, which was a sound he had never heard in that house before, and which he would hear in his dreams for years afterward.

CHAPTER

# SEVEN

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The Lupercalia fell that year on a day of thin sunshine and a wind that came off the hills and smelled of snow. By the second hour the streets around the Palatine were packed, and by the third the whole lower city had poured into the Circus Valley and the Forum and the slopes of the hill, and Rome was doing what Rome did best, which was to turn a sacred rite into an excuse for a party.

The house had been awake since dawn. The women were doing one another's hair, which on a festival day was a serious business and involved a great deal of shouting. Celer had been up since the third hour making honey cakes for the household and a dish of lentils for the workers, because Celer believed that a festival without lentils was a pagan festival and a pagan festival was bad for the digestion. The kitchen boys had been given the morning off and had spent it in the street throwing nuts at a cat.

Chrysis had not wanted to go. She had been quiet since the Saturnalia, and quieter since the news from Tibur, and she stood in the doorway of the kitchen with her mantle already on and her face set in the expression of a woman who has decided to be brave in public and is not looking forward to it.

"You will go," Cassia said.

"I do not want to."

"You will go, and you will laugh at the men with the goatskin, and you will eat something, and you will come home tired, and tomorrow you will feel better. That is what festivals are for." Cassia straightened her collar. "And Chrysis. If anyone speaks to you in the street, you will be polite and you will keep walking."

"Who would speak to me?"

"Nobody. That is the point." Cassia looked at her. "The man who came about your brother has not come back. That is either because he was lying, or

because he is waiting for you to become frightened enough to pay him. Either way, he will come back, and when he does, he will come to the house, and I will deal with him. You will not."

Chrysis nodded. At the door she stopped and said, without turning, "Domina. If my brother is alive, and if he is bought and brought here, what will he be? To me, I mean. Will he be my brother, or will he be a boy I have bought?"

Cassia was silent for a moment.

"He will be both," she said. "That is the difficulty."

Cassia did not go to the Lupercal. She had gone once, at nineteen, and had been struck across the back with a goatskin thong by a young man in a mask who had laughed and run on, and she had felt the sting of it for two days and had not become pregnant, and had drawn her own conclusions. But the house went. The house always went. Thais took the women in a body, with Bathyllus in front and two of the kitchen boys behind, and even the ones who had to work that night were allowed the morning, because a festival is a thing that belongs to everyone, including the people who have nothing else.

Sabina went with Thais. She had been given a new cloak and a handful of nuts and a mask of a laughing satyr that was too big for her, and she came back at the fifth hour with her mask askew and her hair full of straw and a look on her face that Cassia recognized, because it was the look of a child who has seen the city for the first time and has begun to understand that it is not a thing that has been arranged for her benefit.

"There were men with no clothes on," Sabina said.

"There are always men with no clothes on. It is the point of the festival."

"They had a goat. They cut its throat and smeared the blood on two boys and then they laughed and ran." Sabina's eyes were wide. "One of them had a knife and he was laughing. And a woman was screaming because a man had hit her with the thong and she was bleeding."

"Did she want to be hit?"

"I do not know. She was laughing too." Sabina frowned. "I did not understand it. Everyone was laughing and there was blood. Is that what a festival is?"

Cassia looked at her. The child was twelve years old and had just discovered the central fact of the city, which was that it was built out of things that were funny and things that were cruel and could not always tell them apart.

"Some of it," Cassia said. "The rest is bread and wine and the day off."

"I liked the part with the bread," Sabina said.

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Cassia watched the festival from the roof.

The house had a flat roof over the kitchen wing, reached by a narrow stair and a door that was kept locked, and from it you could see the whole valley of the Circus and the slope of the Palatine with its palaces and its temples, and the smoke rising from a hundred cooking fires, and the river shining away to the west like a length of bronze. Tertulla came up to join her, and Hermeros, and Chrysis, who had been silent for days and who stood at the parapet with her arms wrapped around herself.

"They will be at the Lupercal now," Tertulla said. "The priests will be sacrificing a dog and a goat, and the young men will be anointed, and then they will run."

"I know how it goes."

"You have not told me why you are watching."

Cassia looked at the crowd. It was a moving thing, a single organism with a thousand heads, surging along the valley and up the Via Sacra and around the hill. You could see the bright spots in it: a woman's yellow mantle, a litter with a gilded pole, a group of youths in matching red cloaks carrying a goat's head on a pole. You could hear it as a single sound, a low roar with laughter in it, and occasionally a scream.

"I am watching for a girl," she said.

"Which girl?"

"The senator's daughter."

Tertulla came and stood beside her. "Why?"

"Because she will come."

"How do you know?"

"Because she is fifteen and her grandmother is dying and her mother is unhappy and her father has a secret, and because a girl in that house will do anything to find out what the secret is." Cassia's eyes moved over the crowd. "And because she has been told all her life that my house is a place of sin, and there is nothing more attractive to a clever girl than a sin she has been told about."

"Cassia. If that girl comes to your door—"

"She will not come to the door. She is too well brought up for that. She will come to the festival with a slave and she will slip away in the crowd and she will stand in the street and look at the house from a distance, and then she will go home and lie about it." Cassia pointed. "There. By the fountain. In the blue cloak, with the plain mask."

Tertulla looked. "How can you tell?"

"Because she is standing still. Everyone else is moving. A girl who has run away from her slave does not move; she stands and looks and tries to decide whether she has made a mistake."

The blue-cloaked figure was standing at the corner of the street by the fountain, a hundred paces away, with a cheap clay mask over her face and her hood up. She was alone. She was looking at the house, and then at the street, and then at the house again.

Cassia went down the stair.

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She came out of the garden door into the alley and walked around to the front of the house, and the festival crowd filled the street and the noise was enormous. The girl saw her coming and did not move. She was tall for fifteen, with her hood up and the mask covering the top half of her face, and her hands were clasped in front of her in the way of a girl who has been taught to stand.

"You are lost," Cassia said.

"I am not."

"Then you are waiting for someone, and the someone has not come, and you have been standing here for a quarter of an hour, and your slave is looking for you in the crowd and will find you in a moment and will be very frightened and will tell your mother." Cassia smiled. "Take off the mask."

The girl did not move.

"Take it off," Cassia said, "or I will call the vigiles and tell them there is a young woman of good family alone in the street at a festival, and they will take you home to your father, and you will have to explain why you were standing outside my house."

The mask came off. The face underneath was young and fierce and frightened, with her father's eyes and her grandmother's bones, and a mouth that was trying very hard not to tremble.

"I am Sulpicia Varia," she said.

"I know."

"How do you know?"

"Because I have seen your father's face, and because you have his eyes, and because you are standing exactly the way he stands when he is trying not to be afraid." Cassia looked at her. "What do you want?"

The girl's chin came up. "I want to know what you did to my family."

The noise of the festival went on around them. A man with a drum went past, and a group of women with garlands, and a dog running with something in its mouth. Cassia looked at the girl in front of her and felt, absurdly, a kind of tenderness.

"Nothing," she said. "I have done nothing to your family. Your family has done a great deal to me."

"What does that mean?"

"It means that you are fifteen years old and you have been sent here by a curiosity you do not understand, and that if I told you the truth you would not sleep tonight, and you would go home and say something to your mother, and she would say something to your father, and the whole city would know by the Ides." Cassia took her arm. "Come. You cannot stand in the street. There is a wine shop on the corner with a room at the back, and the woman who owns it owes me a favour, and we will have a cup of hot wine and you will tell me what you think you know."

The girl came. She came because she was fifteen and because the alternative was to go home, and because Cassia's hand on her arm was firm and warm and entirely without menace.

The back room of the wine shop was small and dark and smelled of wine and wet wool and the sausages that were frying in the front. Cassia sat the girl down on a bench and ordered hot wine with honey and a plate of bread and olives, and the girl sat with her hands around the cup and looked at her.

"You are not what I expected," Sulpicia said.

"What did you expect?"

"A monster."

"I am a woman who runs a business. It is the same thing to some people." Cassia drank her wine. "Now. What do you think you know?"

"I know that my father goes to your house."

"Your father has never been to my house."

The girl's eyes widened. "But—"

"He has never been to my house. He came to a house on the Caelian, once, to speak to me about the accusation that is being prepared against him, and before that I spoke to him for a quarter of an hour in a public portico in front of half the Senate. That is all. Whatever you have heard, whatever your grandmother has said, whatever the servants whisper, that is the truth." Cassia set her cup down. "Your father is not my lover. He was, once, a very long time ago, before you were born, and it ended badly, and he has spent his life since then trying to be a man his father would have approved of, and I have spent my life trying to be a woman who does not need anyone's approval. That is the whole of it."

"That is not the whole of it."

"No," Cassia said. "It is not. But it is as much as you are going to get from me today."

The girl was quiet for a moment. Then she said, "My grandmother is dying."

"I know."

"She talks in her sleep. She says a name. Psyche. And she says, 'Tell her nothing.' And my mother went to the baths and came home and would not speak to anyone, and my father came in at midnight soaked to the skin and went to my grandmother's room and there was shouting, and then my grandmother was crying, and my grandmother has never cried in her life." Sulpicia's voice was steady, and her eyes were bright. "I am not a child. I am fifteen, and I am to be married next year to a man I have met twice, and I am to spend the rest of my life in a house like that house, with the masks on the wall and the lies in the corridors. I would like to know what I am marrying into."

Cassia looked at her for a long time. The girl looked back. She had courage; that was certain. Whether she had judgment was another matter, and judgment was the thing that could not be taught in an afternoon.

"Not today," Cassia said. "Today you will go home, and you will tell your slave that you were separated in the crowd and that you are sorry, and you will be forgiven because you are fifteen and pretty and your family is important. And then, if you still want to know, you will come to me on a day that is not a festival, with your mother's knowledge, and I will tell you what I can." She leaned forward. "But understand me, Sulpicia. What I tell you will not make you happy. It will not make your family better. It will not make your marriage

easier. It will only mean that you know, and knowing is a burden, and once you have it you cannot put it down."

"Tell me about my grandmother," Sulpicia said. "Not the illness. The other thing. The thing no one will say."

"Your grandmother is the cleverest woman I have ever met and the most frightened," Cassia said. "She has spent her whole life making sure that nothing in that house is ever out of place. Not the masks, not the linen, not the marriages, not the servants. She believes that if everything is in its proper place, nothing bad can happen. And when something bad does happen, she puts it somewhere, and she shuts the door, and she never opens it again." She turned her cup. "You are like her. You have her bones and her courage and her hardness. You will need all three. But you will have to learn to open doors, or you will end up in a chair in a cold room, counting the linen, with a son who is afraid of you."

The girl stared at her. "You are not afraid of my grandmother."

"I am terrified of your grandmother."

"You do not sound it."

"Because I have spent twenty years learning not to sound afraid. It is a skill, like spinning. It can be learned." Cassia leaned back. "You are to marry Aulus Proculus. That is what your grandmother wants."

"How did you know?"

"Because his father is a fool and his mother is dead and the boy is weak and will inherit, and because your grandmother has never in her life made a match that did not improve the family's position by at least one step." Cassia's mouth twisted. "Aulus Proculus is not a bad man. He is a boy who has been told all his life that he is promising, and he believes it, and he will spend his inheritance proving it. If you marry him, you will run his house and his money and his career, and he will be grateful for it until the day he decides he would like to be the one in charge, and then there will be a scene, and then he will have an affair, and you will have a son, and the whole thing will settle into a shape that is comfortable for everyone except you."

"You are very cheerful about it."

"I am honest about it. There is a difference." Cassia reached across the table and touched the girl's wrist. "If you must marry him, then marry him, and make yourself the one who holds the purse and the keys and the clients' names. Do

not spend your life waiting for him to be worthy of you. He will not be. Spend it making sure you are never in a position where his worth matters."

"I would rather know," the girl said.

"Everyone says that at fifteen."

"I am not everyone."

Cassia looked at her. Then she smiled, and it was a real smile, and it made her look, for a moment, like the girl she had been in a garden at Tibur with a book of poems in her lap.

"No," she said. "You are not."

She walked the girl back to the edge of the crowd and watched her find her slave, a thin woman with a basket who fell on her with a cry, and then she stood for a while in the street with the festival going on around her. A group of young men went past with goatskin thongs, laughing, and one of them struck a woman on the shoulder and she shrieked and laughed and hit him back. A child was selling sparrows in a cage. A man was asleep in a doorway with a wreath on his head.

Then the shouting changed.

It happened quickly, the way it always did. A knot of men in the middle of the street, a scuffle, a scream that was not laughter, and then the crowd surging backward, and a woman shrieking, and the bright sudden smell of blood in the cold air. Cassia was pushed against the wall of the wine shop. Bathyllus was there, somehow, his arm across her, his staff raised. The crowd opened and closed like water, and in the middle of it a young man was lying on the stones with his hands around his belly and his mouth open, and another young man was standing over him with a knife, and then the knife was gone and the young man was running and the crowd was closing over the body.

"Keep moving," Bathyllus said. "Domina. Keep moving."

They got her back to the house. She stood in the atrium with her hands shaking and her veil torn, and Thais brought her a cup of wine, and she drank it and sat down on the edge of the impluvium and looked at the water.

"There was a boy," she said. "In the street. He was stabbed."

"I heard," Thais said. "They have taken him to the temple of Aesculapius. He will probably live. They usually live. It is the ones who are stabbed in the throat who do not."

"He was someone's son."

"Yes," Thais said. "He was."

Cassia put her face in her hands. She did not cry. She had not cried in twenty-four years, not properly, not since a cart on the road to Puteoli, and she was not going to start now, in the atrium, in front of the household, with the festival going on outside.

"Send word to Tibur," she said. "Today. Not tomorrow. Today. Tell the granddaughter that I am coming within the month, and that she is to keep the old woman alive, and that if she sends me word that the old woman is dead before I get there, I will know that she was paid to let it happen, and I will come anyway, and I will be less polite."

Thais went. Cassia sat by the water and watched the light move on it, and outside the festival went on, and the city ate and drank and laughed and killed itself in small ways, and the sun moved across the roof of the House of the Graces and began, slowly, to go down.

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He came after dark, in a mask.

She was in the garden room with the lamps lit and the shutters closed, and Bathyllus brought him in without a word and shut the door behind him. He was wearing a dark cloak and a cheap clay mask of a comic actor, and he took it off and stood there with his hair flattened and his face tired, and Cassia felt her heart turn over in her chest like a fish in a net.

"You are mad," she said.

"I know."

"Half the city saw you at the Lupercal. If anyone recognized you—"

"Nobody recognizes a man in a mask at a festival. That is the point of the mask." He put it down on the table. "And I could not wait. I have been to Tibur."

She went very still.

"I did not go myself. I sent a man — a freedman of mine, a Greek, discreet, who used to be a courier for the governor of Syria. He went up the day after the Ides and he came back this morning." Corvinus sat down. "The midwife is alive. She is very old and she is blind in one eye and she lives with her granddaughter's family in a house with a fig tree in the yard. There is a box under her bed. She will not let anyone touch it. She says she is waiting for a woman from Rome."

"Did he see her?"

"He saw her. He told her he came from you. She wept. She said —" He stopped. "She said, 'Tell her I did what I could, and I have kept it all these years, and I am not afraid of her.'"

Cassia sat down slowly on the couch opposite him. The lamp between them was steady. She could hear her own breathing.

"And Felix himself?" she said. "What has he done since the Saturnalia?"

"He has been to the consul's clerk twice. He has been to the prefect of the grain supply. He has been seen at the house of Pactus, and at the house of a man named Scaurus in the Subura, who keeps a house of women and lends money." Corvinus's mouth tightened. "And he has been to my son. Publius came to me last week and told me that a man had approached him in the forum and asked him questions about his grandfather, and offered him money for letters."

"Did he take it?"

"No. He came to me. He was frightened, and he came to me, and I —" Corvinus stopped. "I was proud of him. It is the first time in his life he has done something I could be proud of, and it took a delator to bring it out of him."

"Bring him to the house."

"What?"

"Not to mine. To Tertulla's. He is twenty-one and he is frightened and he has begun to understand that his family is not what he thought it was. If we are to fight this, we need him on our side, and he will not be on our side if he finds out the truth from a stranger." Cassia looked at him. "Tell him something. Not everything. Enough that he knows he is trusted."

"He will hate me."

"He will hate you less than he will hate being lied to." She paused. "And Lucius. Your daughter came to see me today."

He went white. "She what?"

"She came to the festival with a slave and slipped away and stood in the street outside my house for a quarter of an hour, and I brought her into a wine shop and gave her hot wine and told her nothing." Cassia held his eyes. "She is fifteen years old and she is cleverer than her brother and she is frightened of nothing, and she is going to find out the truth whether we tell her or not. If you want to control how she finds it, you will tell her yourself, before someone else does."

"And Felix's men?"

"They have been there. Two of them, three days before my man, asking questions at the inn and the bathhouse and the shrine of Hercules. They did not get to the old woman. The granddaughter turned them away — she is frightened of them, but she is more frightened of the box." He looked at her. "They will go back. If they go back with money, or with a warrant, they will get in. We do not have much time."

"Then I will go tomorrow."

"Cassia—"

"Tomorrow. Or the day after. I will not wait for the spring." She looked up. "And you will not come with me."

"I said I would."

"And I told you what would happen if you did. The whole city is watching your house. If you leave Rome for two days in the middle of an accusation, Pactus will know by the evening of the first day, and he will send a man after you, and then it will not matter what the midwife says because the story will be that the senator fled to Tibur to silence a witness." She stood. "You will stay. You will be seen in the forum every day. You will go to the Senate and make a speech about the grain supply and be photographed in the act of being an ordinary, innocent, boring man. And I will go to Tibur with my own people, and I will come back with the truth, whatever it is."

He looked at her. In the lamplight, with the mask on the table between them and the shutters closed and the festival dying down outside, he looked like a man who had been given a sentence and was trying to decide whether to appeal.

"I hate this," he said.

"I know."

"I have spent twenty-four years letting other people decide what happened to you, and I am doing it again."

"No," Cassia said. "You are doing what I tell you to do. That is not the same thing." She came around the table and stood in front of him. "Lucius. Look at me. I am not the girl in the vineyard. I am a woman with a house and a fortune and twenty-three people who depend on me, and I have been making my own decisions since I was twenty-two years old. I do not need you to protect me. I need you to do what I say, and to be in the forum tomorrow, and to be dull. Can you be dull?"

"I have been dull for twenty-four years."

"Then it should come naturally."

He laughed — a real laugh, surprised out of him — and reached up and took her hand and pressed it to his mouth. Then he pulled her down and kissed her, and the mask fell off the table and broke on the floor, and neither of them cared.

Later, in the dark, with the festival finally over and the city gone quiet, she lay with her head on his chest and listened to the house settling around them. Somewhere a door closed. A lamp guttered and went out. The wind came off the hills and rattled the shutters and smelled of snow.

"Lucius," she said.

"Yes."

"If the boy is alive. If he is alive and we find him." She stopped.

"Yes?"

"What will you do?"

He was silent for a long time. She felt his chest rise and fall, and his hand move in her hair, and she thought he was not going to answer.

"I do not know," he said at last. "I have a son. I have a daughter. I have a wife who has done nothing wrong. I have a name that is four hundred years old and a house that is falling down and a mother who is dying and who has done something that I cannot yet think about without wanting to put my fist through a wall." His voice was low. "And I have a woman I have not been able to forget for twenty-four years, and a child I did not know I had, and no idea in the world what I am supposed to do with any of it."

"You will have to choose."

"I know."

"And you will not choose well. No one ever does." She turned her face into his shoulder. "But you will choose, and you will have to live with it, and so will I. That is what people do. They choose, and they live with it, and they die, and the house goes on."

"The house goes on," he said, and there was something in his voice that she could not read — grief, or bitterness, or the beginning of a decision.

She did not ask which.

In the morning he was gone before the light, and the mask was in pieces on the floor, and Bathyllus had swept up the worst of it and put the pieces in the hearth. Cassia stood in the garden room with a cup of hot water and looked at the broken clay in the ashes, a comic actor's grin in two halves, and thought

about the fact that every mask in Rome was made of the same cheap stuff, and that underneath them all, the faces were all the same.

CHAPTER

# EIGHT

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The slave market stood in the shadow of the Temple of Castor, in the hollow of the Forum where the ground had been paved over the ruins of the old republican shops, and it opened at the third hour and closed at noon, because the dealers had discovered long ago that a man who is hungry is a man who bargains badly. There were pens along the portico and a raised platform in the middle, and on the platform, in the morning light, stood the merchandise.

Cassia came in a plain litter with Hermeros and two of the kitchen boys, and she stood at the edge of the crowd with her veil drawn and her hands folded, and she looked at the platform and did not allow herself the luxury of feeling anything.

There were forty of them that morning. A group of Gauls, big and fair and frightened, with the chalk marks on their feet that meant they were new to the city and had not yet learned to run. A Greek boy of sixteen with a lyre and a pretty face and the sort of eyes that had already learned what his price was. Two women from the Danube, sisters perhaps, holding hands. An old man with a cough who had been a gardener somewhere and would not last the year. A Nubian with a brand on his shoulder. A child of six or seven, alone, with a placard around his neck that said *good with animals.*

The placards were the worst of it. They listed everything: the origin, the skills, the languages, the flaws. *Runaway, twice. Epileptic. Barren. Speaks Greek and Latin, reads, writes, honest. Mute. Sings. Bad temper.* The dealers wrote them in chalk or paint and hung them around the neck, and the customers came and read them the way they read the edicts on the walls of the Forum, and the people wearing them stood very still and looked at nothing.

The dealer was a man named Verus, who had a stall under the portico and a slave to do the shouting and a bad chest and a good memory, and who had been

in the trade for thirty years and had bought and sold, by his own estimate, nine thousand people. He knew Cassia by sight. Everyone in that business knew her by sight, because she had been sold twice herself and had once stood where his stock was standing now, and because there is no trade in the world with a longer memory than the trade in people.

"Domina," he said, when she came under the portico. "You do me honour."

"I do you business. There is a difference."

"There is. But honour is cheaper." He coughed into his hand. "Your man has been here. He wants the northern boy. The sick one."

"I want the northern boy."

"He is not much. He is fourteen, maybe fifteen, he has been beaten and he has a cough and he does not speak unless he is spoken to. I would not sell him to a farm. He would not last the season. I would sell him to a house, if the house were patient." Verus looked at her. "Four thousand."

"Two."

"Four. He cost me two and I have fed him for a month and I have had a physician look at him, which was a waste of money, because the physician said what I already knew." Verus spat. "Three and a half, and I will throw in the blanket."

"Three, and you will throw in the blanket, and you will tell me who else has been asking."

The dealer's face did not change, but his eyes did. "I do not talk about my customers."

"You do not have customers for a boy who is not on the platform. You have a boy in a back room and a knight who came asking and a woman who is offering you three thousand in cash." Cassia smiled. "I am not asking you to betray a confidence. I am asking you to tell me something I already know, so that I do not have to pay someone else to tell me. It is cheaper for both of us."

Verus looked at her for a long moment. Then he said, "Three thousand two hundred, and the blanket, and I will tell you that the knight had a bird on his ring and did not give his name and came twice."

"Three thousand two hundred," Cassia said. "Done."

She had been sold twice. The first time she had been twelve and had stood on a platform in Rome with her mother's song still in her head and a placard around her neck that said *quick, clean, honest, can sew.* The second time she had

been eighteen and had not stood on a platform at all; she had been sold in a back room at Tibur, with a steward counting the money and a woman holding the lamp, and that had been worse, because a platform is at least public, and a public thing can be witnessed, and there is a kind of mercy in having witnesses. No one had witnessed the second sale. She had gone into that room a maid with a name and had come out of it a thing with a price, and the price had been written down in a book, and the book had been put in a drawer, and the drawer had been locked, and the woman who kept the key had gone to bed and slept.

She looked at the platform, and the placards, and the people wearing them, and she made herself look at each one, because she had learned that the only way to survive a thing like this was to see it clearly and not look away.

Hermeros had done the negotiating in the days before. He had found the fuller's household at Puteoli and had learned that the fuller had bought two boys from a dealer in Rome three years before, and that one of them had been sold on to a farm at Aricia, and that the other was still there, and that the fuller would sell him for three thousand sesterces, which was more than the boy was worth.

"He is not on the platform," Hermeros said. "The dealer is holding him in the back. He wants to sell him privately."

"Why?"

"Because he is sick, and a sick slave on the platform is bad for business." Hermeros's face was carefully blank. "And because a man came asking about him last week. A knight. The dealer would not say which one."

Cassia's hands tightened on her veil. "Felix."

"It is possible."

"Then we buy him today, and we buy him quietly, and we do not ask the dealer any questions that will make him raise the price." She looked at the platform. "How much does he want?"

"Four thousand now."

"Pay it."

"Domina, four thousand is—"

"Pay it," Cassia said, "and then take him to the house and have Narcissus see him before I do. I do not want to see him in this place. I want to see him in a bed with clean linen."

Hermeros went. Cassia stayed at the edge of the crowd and watched the platform, because she had learned a long time ago that a woman who is seen to be impatient is a woman who is charged more.

The auction went on. The Gauls were sold to a builder. The Greek boy went to a household on the Quirinal for a sum that made even the dealer raise his eyebrows. The two sisters were sold together, which was a mercy, and to a brothel keeper, which was not. The old gardener was not sold at all, and was led away at noon to be given bread and water and kept for the next market, and Cassia, who had seen the old gardener, and who knew what happened to old men who were not sold, found that she was looking at the child with the placard and thinking about a cell at Tibur.

The child looked back at her. He had a smudge of dirt on his cheek and the flat, patient eyes of a person who has learned that looking at the crowd is a way of surviving it.

Verus took her through the portico to the back, past a curtain and a counter and a room where a clerk sat with a ledger and a pot of ink, and into a yard where the stock that was not for the platform waited in the shade. There were eight of them. A woman with a baby at her breast. Two boys asleep against the wall. A man with a broken arm in a sling. And, in the corner, a boy sitting on a stool with a blanket around his shoulders and his hands in his lap.

He did not look up when they came in.

"Melanthus," Verus said. "This is the lady."

The boy looked up. He looked at Cassia for exactly as long as it took to see her, and then he looked at the ground again, and she understood in that moment that he had been looked at by a great many people in the past month, and that each of them had been deciding what he was worth, and that he had learned to make himself small so that the decision would be quick.

"Leave us," Cassia said.

Verus hesitated. "Domina—"

"Leave us. I will not steal him. I have a house full of witnesses and a doorkeeper who could break you in half." She waited until he had gone, and then she crouched down in front of the boy, which hurt her knees, and which she did not allow him to see. "I am not going to touch you. I am not going to ask you to stand up or turn around or show me your teeth. I am going to ask you one question, and you may answer it or not."

The boy said nothing.

"Did they take you from your village, or were you born a slave?"

"Taken," the boy said. His voice was a scrape.

"Did they take your sister too?"

The boy's head came up. For the first time there was something in his eyes that was not the flat patient waiting. It was fear, and under the fear, something else, something that had been kept alive in the dark for five years and had not quite gone out.

"Yes," he said.

"Domina," Hermeros said, at her elbow.

She turned. The boy was standing behind him, between two of the dealer's men, with a blanket around his shoulders and his feet bare. He was fourteen or fifteen, thin to the point of gauntness, with the pale skin and light hair of the north and a bruise fading on his cheekbone. He was not looking at her. He was looking at the ground.

"His name is Melanthus," Hermeros said. "That is what the fuller called him. His own name is something else. He does not say it."

"Melanthus," Cassia said.

The boy looked up. His eyes were grey and old, and there was nothing in them at all: no fear, no hope, no curiosity. She had seen that look before. She had worn it, once, in a house in Puteoli, in the first month, before Thais had taught her to keep her name to herself.

"Come," she said. "You are going to a house where no one will touch you."

The boy said nothing. He came.

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The house on the Esquiline received him the way it received everything: with hot water and clean linen and a great deal of noise. Thais took charge. She had the boy put in the small room off the kitchen where the under-cook slept, and had the under-cook moved in with the kitchen boys, and had a bath drawn, and had Celer make broth, and had Narcissus come at once with his bag.

Narcissus was sixty-one, a Greek from Pergamon with a face like a walnut and the manners of a man who had once been rich. He had been the physician of a consular household until the consular had died and the household had sold him, and Cassia had bought him for the price of a good horse and had never re-

gretted it. He examined the boy in the small room with the door shut, and came out after half an hour and sat down in the kitchen with his hands on his knees.

"Well?"

"His back is bad. There are scars, old ones, from a whip, and newer ones from a rod. He has been beaten on the soles of his feet. There is a cough that has been in his chest for a long time and could become something worse, and he is underfed, and he has a fever that comes and goes." Narcissus's face was impassive. "He will live if he is fed and kept warm and not beaten. He will not live if he is sent back."

"He will not be sent back."

"Then he will live." Narcissus reached into his bag. "There is something else. He does not speak much, but when he does, he speaks Greek with a northern accent, and he remembers a village and a mother and a sister. He remembers a raid, and men with swords, and a cart. He remembers his sister's name."

Cassia's heart turned over. "What is the name?"

"Chrysis," Narcissus said. "He says it the way a child says a prayer. He has been saying it for five years."

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Chrysis was in the corridor when Cassia came out. She had been standing there for an hour, because no one had told her to go away, and because Thais had looked at her and decided that this was not a thing that could be managed by orders.

"Is it him?" she said.

"Go in," Cassia said. "He is tired and he is frightened and he may not know you. Do not rush at him. Do not cry. Sit down on the stool and talk to him about the village, and if he does not answer, keep talking."

Chrysis's face was white. "What if he does not remember me?"

"He remembers you," Cassia said. "He has been saying your name for five years."

Chrysis went in. Cassia stood in the corridor with her back against the wall and listened. There was silence for a long time, and then a sound, a single, terrible, broken sound, and then two voices, low and quick and urgent, in a language she did not speak. She stood there with her eyes closed and her hands flat

against the plaster, and she thought about a cart on the road to Puteoli and a cry going away from her, getting smaller, until it was only a sound in a dream.

Thais came down the corridor with a lamp and stopped when she saw her.

"Domina."

"I am all right."

"You are not all right. You are standing in a corridor in the dark with your hands on the wall."

"I am all right," Cassia said again. "I am not the one who was sold."

Thais looked at her for a long moment. Then she set the lamp down on the bracket and put her arms around her, and Cassia let herself be held, which was a thing she allowed perhaps twice a year, and only in the dark.

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They ate together that night in the small dining room, all of them: Cassia and Thais and Chrysis and the boy, and Hermeros, who had been invited because he had done the buying and because Cassia wanted him to see what he had bought. The boy had been bathed and dressed in a clean tunic and had been given a bowl of broth and a piece of bread, and he ate slowly, watching everyone, the way a dog that has been kicked watches a room.

"Melanthus," Cassia said.

The boy looked up.

"That is not your name."

He said nothing.

"Your name is your own. If you want to tell us, you will tell us. If you do not, we will call you Melanthus until you do." She set down her cup. "I bought you today for four thousand sesterces, which is more than you are worth, and I did it because your sister asked me to. I am not your mother. I am not your mistress. I am the woman who owns the house you are sitting in, and I own the roof and the bread and the bed, and I do not own you. Do you understand the difference?"

The boy looked at her. His eyes were old and grey and entirely without illusion.

"You bought me," he said. His voice was hoarse from disuse.

"Yes."

"Then you own me."

"No," Cassia said. "The law says I own you. The law is a thing men wrote down. It is not the truth." She leaned forward. "The truth is that when a person is bought and sold, something is done to them that cannot be undone by a piece of paper. You are not the same as you were before. You will never be the same. But that does not mean that I am the same as the man who sold you, or the fuller who beat you, or the men who took you from your village. It means that I have bought you, and that you are in my house, and that I will not beat you, and that in a year, if you want it, I will free you and give you money and a trade and a name that is your own. That is the difference."

The boy looked at her for a long time. Then he said, "Why?"

"Because no one did it for me," Cassia said.

Chrysis made a sound. Cassia did not look at her.

"Eat your broth," she said. "Tomorrow Narcissus will put something on your back and it will hurt, and the day after that it will hurt less. In a week you will be able to walk to the end of the street. In a month you will be able to work, if you want to work, and if you do not want to work you will have to learn to be bored." She picked up her cup. "There is no shame in being bored. There is a great deal of shame in the world, and most of it is deserved, but boredom is not one of the things anyone should be ashamed of."

"What is your name?" Chrysis said.

The boy looked at her. He had eaten most of the broth and his colour was better and his eyes were less like a dog's and more like a boy's, and he was tired in a way that had nothing to do with sleep.

"Senno," he said.

Chrysis's hand went to her mouth. "Senno."

"You said it wrong," the boy said. "You always said it wrong. It is Sen-no. Two n's. You said Seno, like a Roman."

"I was eight," Chrysis said. "I did not know how to say anything."

"You said it wrong," the boy said again, and then he began to cry, without any noise at all, the way a person cries who has learned that crying is a thing that attracts attention, and Chrysis got up and went around the table and knelt beside him and put her arms around him, and the boy held on to her and shook.

Cassia sat very still. Hermeros looked at his plate. Thais looked at the wall. Nobody said anything for a long time, and the lamp burned, and the house was quiet around them.

Chrysis wiped her face with the back of her hand and looked at him, and the boy looked back at her, and something passed between them that had nothing to do with Cassia and nothing to do with the house and nothing to do with the price that had been paid in the market that morning.

The boy almost smiled. It was a small thing, a flicker at the corner of his mouth, and it was gone almost at once, but Chrysis saw it, and she put her hand over her mouth, and her eyes filled.

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Felix came at the ninth hour, when the lamps were lit and the house was warm and the streets outside were full of the noise of the evening.

He came with two men and a wax tablet and the smile of a man who has decided to be pleasant. Bathyllus showed him into the tablinum and stood by the door with his arms folded, and Cassia sat behind her desk with the accounts open in front of her and did not stand up.

"Domina," Felix said. "You are looking well."

"You are looking expensive."

"I have been fortunate."

"You have been paid." She closed the account book. "What do you want?"

"Straight to business. I admire that." He sat down without being invited. "You went to the market today."

"I go to the market every week. The household must eat."

"You bought a boy."

"I bought a boy. He was sick and I bought him. It is not a crime to buy a sick boy." Cassia's voice was mild. "What is it to you?"

The smile did not change, but something behind it did. "I have been looking for a boy," Felix said. "A boy of about that age, from the north, who was sold out of a household at Tibur some years ago. A boy who might be worth a great deal to the right person."

Cassia's hands were steady on the desk.

"There are a great many boys from the north who were sold out of households."

"There are. But this one is particular." Felix turned the tablet in his hands. "There is a potter on the Via Ostiensis, outside the Porta Trigemina, who has a son of twenty-four. The boy works in the shop. He has his father's name, which

proves nothing, but he has the look of the family, which proves less. I have not been to see him yet. I have been saving him."

"I have a midwife's word for it. And a physician's assistant. And an old steward with a bad chest who is willing to say what he remembers in exchange for a pension and a promise that his daughter will not be told." He looked up. "I am assembling a case, domina. Not against you. Against the senator. But a case is a house, and a house needs a foundation, and the foundation is a story that a court will believe. And the story I am building is that the senator's father was killed by his wife, and that the wife had help, and that the help came from a girl in the household who was pregnant by the son and who was sold to a brothel in Puteoli and who has spent twenty-four years buying her way back into respectable society."

The room was very quiet. Bathyllus moved, and Cassia raised one finger, and he stopped.

"That is a very good story," Cassia said. "It has everything. A noble house, a wicked mother, a slave girl, a bastard child. The only thing it lacks is proof."

"I am getting proof."

"Then get it." Cassia stood. "And when you have it, bring it to me, and I will tell you what it is worth. Until then, you will not come to my house at night with two men and a tablet and a story. You will not speak to my household. You will not go to Tibur, and if you do, you will find that the road is longer than you think." She came around the desk. "And Felix. If you go near the boy, or the midwife, or the senator's daughter, I will not pay you. I will not bargain with you. I will find out what you love and I will take it away from you, and it will not be a thing you can buy back with a tablet and a smile."

Felix rose. He was taller than her, and he used it, the way men do.

"You are threatening a Roman knight," he said.

"I am promising a Roman knight. There is a difference." Cassia smiled. "You have three days. After that, the price is off the table and the game changes."

He looked at her for a long moment. Then he laughed, and it was a real laugh, and there was something in it that was almost admiration.

"You are the most dangerous woman in Rome," he said.

"So I am told."

He went out with his two men, and Bathyllus bolted the door behind them, and Cassia stood in the tablinum with her hands shaking and the lamp burning and the whole house breathing around her.

"Domina," Bathyllus said. "He will go to Tibur."

"I know."

"He will get there before you do."

"I know that too." Cassia went to the strongroom panel and pressed the catch and took out the black book and set it on the desk. "Which is why you are going tonight, and not in the morning. Take the flower seller's boy, and the fast horse from the baker's stable, and ride through the night. You will be at Tibur by dawn. You will go to the house with the fig tree and you will bring the old woman out, and her box, and her granddaughter if she will come, and you will put them in a cart and you will bring them to Rome by the back road, and you will not stop for anything."

Bathyllus looked at her. "And if the old woman will not come?"

"Then you will tell her that the lady from Rome is coming, and that she is coming with a warrant and a magistrate and the whole weight of the law, and that if she wants to tell her story to a court she can tell it in Rome, in a room with a fire and a chair and a cup of wine, instead of in a stable in Tibur with a man from the city asking her questions." Cassia opened the book. "She has kept something for twenty-four years, Bathyllus. She has kept it because she was afraid. Tell her that the woman she was afraid of is dying, and that the son is not his father, and that there is a house in Rome with a warm room in it and a door that locks from the inside."

Bathyllus nodded. At the door he said, "And you, domina?"

"I will be here," Cassia said. "I will be here, and I will be visible, and I will be at the Senate tomorrow with the senator's wife, and every man in this city will see me being respectable." She looked up. "Go. And Bathyllus—"

"Yes?"

"If the old woman has a box, do not open it. Not for any reason. Bring it to me sealed."

He went out. Cassia sat alone with the black book open in front of her and the lamp burning and the house settling into the night. Then she turned to a page near the end, where the entries were not accounts but names, and she wrote: *Felix. Wife deceased. Two children, a boy of nine and a girl of six, in the*

*house of his sister on the Aventine. Sister's husband is a corn merchant named Sabinus, who owes money to three men and has been cheating the annona for two years.* She looked at it for a long time. Then she closed the book, and put it back in the panel, and went up to bed.

Thais came in with a cup of warm milk and set it on the desk without being asked.

"You have written something in the book," she said. "Something you are not proud of."

"I have written what I know."

"You know a great deal about a man's children."

Cassia looked at the page. "If he comes for my household, I will use it. A man who threatens a house should know that his own house is not safe."

"And will you use it? The sister on the Aventine? The boy of nine and the girl of six?"

"I do not know."

"You know," Thais said. "You are not that woman. You have never been that woman. You have done a great many things that would make a Vestal faint, and you have ruined men, and you have taken money from people who could not afford it, and you have kept secrets that ought to have been told. But you have never once hurt a child, and you will not start now, at forty-two, with a boy asleep in your kitchen."

Cassia was silent.

"I will keep the entry," she said at last. "It is useful. He does not know what I will do and neither do I, and that is the point of a threat." She closed the book. "But you are right. I will not touch the children. If it comes to it, I will find another way."

"Good," Thais said. "Drink your milk."

She did not sleep. She lay in the dark and listened to the house, and at some hour past midnight she heard the garden door open and close, and the sound of a horse on the stones, and then nothing. She thought about a boy with grey eyes and a bruise on his cheekbone, and about a midwife with a box under her bed, and about a cry in the night that had been going away from her for twenty-four years and was now, perhaps, beginning to come back.

CHAPTER

# NINE

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The dinner was Cassia's idea, and it was a dangerous one, and Tertulla told her so twice before the guests arrived.

"You are inviting a man into your house," she said, "who is trying to destroy the father of your child, who has threatened your household, and who has already been paid by someone we do not know. And you are giving him the best fish."

"I am giving him the best fish because the best fish costs money, and a man who is given the best fish understands that he is being given something." Cassia checked the arrangement of the couches for the third time. "A man like Felix has spent his whole life being let in through the service door. Tonight he comes through the front. He will be so grateful that he will tell me things he should not, and then he will go home and be unable to sleep, and in the morning he will write me a letter that begins 'Domina' and ends with an apology."

"And if he does not?"

"Then he is stupider than he looks, and I will have to do this the other way." Cassia straightened a cushion. "Which is more expensive and less pleasant for everyone."

The guest list was chosen with the care of a general disposing his troops. Proculus, because Proculus was a senator and a gossip and would tell the whole city that Felix had dined at the House of the Graces, which would make Felix feel elevated and make his patron nervous. Comptus, because Comptus owed her a favour and because his presence would suggest that the evening was about business, which would make Felix feel important. Tertulla, to leaven the company and to watch. Ione, because Ione was leaving in the spring and had asked to be present at one last dinner, and because a beautiful woman at the end of the table

makes men talk. And, at the last moment, Cassia had sent a boy to the Palatine with a note for Publius Sulpicius Corvinus, asking him to dine.

The young man arrived early, nervous, in his second-best tunic, and stood in the atrium looking at the painted walls as though he had never seen a house before.

"Domina," he said. "My father does not know I am here."

"Your father is not on the guest list."

"He would not approve."

"Your father does not approve of most things. It is what makes him so restful." Cassia took his arm. "Come. You are seated at the end, next to the lady Tertulla, who will be rude to you and will make you laugh. When the man named Felix speaks to you, you will be polite and you will tell him nothing. When he asks about your family, you will say that your grandmother is unwell and your sister is to be married and your father is busy with the Asian command. You will say it as though you were bored."

"I am not bored."

"Then you will pretend. It is a skill, like swimming." She looked at him. "And Publius. Whatever happens tonight, you will not lose your temper. Not for any reason. If he insults your father, you will smile. If he insults me, you will smile. If he says something about your mother, you will smile and you will change the subject to the games. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

"Say it."

"I will smile and change the subject to the games."

"Good boy," Cassia said, and saw his face change at the words, and understood that no one had called him a good boy in a very long time.

The dinner was a success. It was always a success; Cassia had built her reputation on the fact that a dinner in her house was never dull and never quite safe. The gustatio came in on silver: eggs, olives, mushrooms in garum, oysters from Baiae, bread from the bakery next door. The wine was Caecuban, and Proculus, who had been raised to believe that Caecuban was the only wine worth drinking, drank a great deal of it and became jovial. Comptus talked about the grain fleet and was listened to politely. Felix, seated at Cassia's right hand, ate slowly and watched everything.

Proculus, by the second cup, had begun to tell the story of the time he had been insulted by a man in the theatre, which was a story he told at every dinner and which had improved with the telling to the point where it now involved an emperor, two Vestals and a performing bear. Comptus listened with the fixed courtesy of a man who needs something. Tertulla listened with the expression of a woman who has heard the story four times and intends to say so before the evening is out. Publius looked at Dama.

"Tell me," Cassia said to Felix, while Proculus was drawing breath, "how does a man get into your trade?"

Felix looked at her over his cup. "You are asking about my family."

"I am asking about your life. There is a difference."

"My father was a schoolmaster in the Subura. He taught letters to the sons of freedmen for a copper a day and he died of a cough when I was twelve. My mother took in washing. I had a good memory and no money and no name, and I discovered at seventeen that a man with a good memory can make a living out of other people's mistakes." He ate an oyster. "There is no mystery to it, domina. It is the same trade as yours. You sell what people want to hear about themselves. I sell what they want to hear about other people."

"That is a very good answer."

"It is a true one. They are not always the same."

"You are quiet," Cassia said, when the fish came.

"I am listening."

"To what?"

"To the room." Felix cut a piece of fish. "You have arranged this evening very carefully, domina. The senator on your left, to show that you are respectable. The grain man across the table, to show that you are useful. The old lady at the end, to show that you have friends who are not men. And the boy." He ate the fish. "The boy is the interesting one."

"He is a guest."

"He is a son. There are three kinds of men in Rome, domina: men who have sons and are proud of them, men who have sons and are disappointed in them, and men who have no sons and would give a great deal for one. I have been watching you all evening and I cannot tell which kind you are."

"I am a woman. There is a fourth kind."

Felix laughed. "I am corrected."

At the second course Dama sang, and the room went quiet, because Dama's voice was a thing that made even Proculus stop talking. She sang a song about a girl who is turned into a laurel tree to escape a god, and the room listened, and Publius, at the end of the table beside Tertulla, did not look at his wine or at the dancers, but at Dama, with his mouth slightly open, the way the young look at beautiful things.

Ione leaned across the table to Felix and said something that made him laugh — a real laugh, surprised out of him — and Cassia watched the two of them together and thought that Ione would do very well in whatever life she chose, because she had learned the one thing that could not be taught, which was how to make a man feel that he had been clever in front of other people.

"Your Ione is wasted on you," Felix said, when Ione had turned away.

"Everyone is wasted on me. It is the tragedy of my house."

"She is leaving."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because she asked, and because I said yes." Cassia turned her cup. "You are surprised."

"I am surprised that you would let her go. A woman like that is worth a great deal."

"A woman like that is worth more than a great deal. She is worth what she decides she is worth." Cassia looked at him. "That is the difference between us, Felix. You see people as property. I see them as investments. An investment that is allowed to grow is worth more than a thing that is kept in a box."

Afterward, when the plates had been cleared and the fruit brought in and the lamps trimmed, Cassia leaned back and said, in a voice pitched to carry exactly as far as she wanted it to, "Felix. Tell us about your work."

The room went still. Tertulla put down her cup. Comptus looked at the table. Proculus, who was too drunk to be discreet, said, "Yes, do. I have always wanted to know how it is done."

"It is not complicated," Felix said. He was smiling, but his eyes had gone careful. "A man has a secret. A woman has a secret. A whole family has a secret. I find out what it is and I tell a magistrate, and the magistrate is grateful, and the state is grateful, and sometimes there is a reward. It is a public service."

"It is a business," Cassia said.

"It is a public service that pays."

"And who pays you?"

"The state, when the case succeeds."

"And when it does not succeed?"

"Then I do not eat." Felix turned his cup. "It is a hard trade, domina. Not everyone can do it. It requires patience and a good memory and a certain indifference to being disliked."

"I have all three," Cassia said, "and I have never once had to inform on anyone to pay my cook. That is because I sell pleasure, and you sell fear, and the market for pleasure is larger." She smiled at the table. "But I have always thought that a man in your trade must have a great many enemies, and that a man with enemies ought to have a great many friends."

The room was silent. Proculus looked from one to the other with the fat, happy confusion of a man who suspects a fight and is looking forward to it.

"I have friends," Felix said.

"Do you? Name one."

He opened his mouth, and then closed it. The silence went on a beat too long.

"I thought so," Cassia said. "You have clients and payers and men who use you and men who despise you. You do not have friends. I am offering you the chance to have one, and I am doing it in front of witnesses, which means that if you accept, everyone in this room will know that you were received at my table, and the next time a magistrate looks at you he will see a man with a friend in the Esquiline, and he will think twice."

"Why would you do that?"

"Because I want something."

"Of course you do." Felix set down his cup. "What?"

"Pactus," Cassia said. "And the man behind Pactus. And the petition that is going to be laid before the consul, and the names of the witnesses, and the date."

The room had gone very quiet. Publius was staring at her. Proculus had stopped chewing. Comptus was looking at his plate as though it might save him.

"That is a great deal," Felix said.

"It is. And I am offering a great deal in exchange. Not just money. Money is the least of it. I am offering you a place at this table, and the protection of this house, and the kind of introduction that no amount of money can buy." Cassia

leaned forward. “You are a clever man, Felix. You have spent your life climbing a wall that has no footholds, and you have climbed it with your fingernails, and you are still on the wrong side. I am telling you that there is a gate, and that I am standing beside it, and that the price of the gate is one name.”

Felix looked at her. In the lamplight his face was not handsome; it was tired and sharp and quite intelligent, and there was something in it that Cassia recognized, because she had seen it in her own mirror: the look of a person who has been alone for a very long time and has learned to call it independence.

“Think about what, exactly?” Cassia said. “About whether you would rather be a man who is feared or a man who is received? About whether the money you are being paid is worth more than the protection I am offering? About what will happen to you when Pactus has what he wants and no longer needs a delator?” She set her cup down. “Because I will tell you what will happen. He will pay you, and then he will be a consular with an Asian command, and he will look at you one day across a room and he will think: that man knows what I did. And then he will find a magistrate who owes him a favour and he will have you charged with extortion, and you will lose everything, and the man who paid you will be the man who signs the order.”

Felix’s face did not change. But his hand did, and Cassia saw it, and she knew she had found the place where he was soft.

“You do not know that,” he said.

“I know men. Your Pactus is a new man who has spent his whole life climbing, and a new man who has climbed is more afraid of falling than any old family in Rome. He will not tolerate a witness to his own beginning. He will pay you and then he will bury you, and he will do it politely, in the Senate, with a speech about the dignity of the equestrian order.” She leaned forward. “I will not bury you, Felix. I have no reason to. You are useful to me, and useful men are worth keeping. That is not friendship. It is arithmetic. But arithmetic is more reliable than friendship, and I have found that it lasts longer.”

“I will think about it,” he said.

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one you are getting at the table.” He rose. “You have been very generous, domina. The fish was excellent. I will send my answer tomorrow.”

He went out. Bathyllus showed him to the door, and the room let out its breath, and Proculus said, “Well,” and reached for the wine.

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The garden was cold and the fountain had been turned off for the winter, and Cassia stood by the dry basin with her arms wrapped around herself and watched the last of the guests go.

Tertulla came out with a cloak and put it around her shoulders. "He will not take it."

"He might."

"He will not. He is a man who has been bought by other men all his life. He does not know how to be bought by a woman." Tertulla stood beside her. "What did you see in his face?"

"Fear. And something else." Cassia pulled the cloak closer. "He is proud. That is the thing about men like Felix. They are not poor and they are not stupid and they are not without courage. What they are is proud, and the world has spent their whole lives telling them that they are nothing, and they have built a career out of proving the world wrong in the worst possible way." She looked up at the sky. "If I can persuade him that there is another way to be a man than the one he has chosen, he will come to me. If I cannot, he will go to Pactus and tell him everything I said tonight, and we will have a war."

"You should have let me be in the room."

"You were in the room."

"I mean with a knife."

Cassia laughed. It was a tired laugh, and it hurt somewhere in her chest, and she stopped.

"I am too old for this," she said.

"You are forty-two."

"That is exactly what I mean." She turned. "When I was twenty-five I thought that by the time I was forty I would be safe. I thought I would have a house and a fortune and a wall around me and no one would be able to touch me. And here I am, at forty-two, standing in a cold garden bargaining with a delator for the life of a man I have spent twenty-four years trying to forget."

"You are not bargaining for his life."

"I am bargaining for his life, and for the truth about my son, and for the safety of a household that depends on me, and for the future of a girl who came to me in a wine shop because she wanted to know what her family was." Cassia

shook her head. "They are all the same bargain. That is what no one tells you about power. You think it is a thing you hold. It is a thing that holds you."

Tertulla took her hand. "Come inside. It is cold, and there is wine, and there is a boy in the dining room who is pretending to be a man and doing it badly, and he needs to be sent home before his father finds out he was here."

They went in. Publius was standing by the table with a cup in his hand, looking at the three Graces in the alcove. He turned when they came in, and his face was flushed with wine and with something else.

"Domina," he said. "I want to ask you something."

"Ask."

"Felix said something tonight. About a potter on the Via Ostiensis. A boy of twenty-four." He looked at her. "I have heard my grandmother say something like it. She said it to my mother, when she was ill. She said, 'He is not to be found.' And my mother said, 'Who?' and my grandmother said, 'The potter's boy.'"

Cassia's face did not change. She had had years of practice.

"Your grandmother is dying," she said. "Dying people say a great many things."

"She is not mad."

"No. She is not mad." Cassia sat down on the couch. "Sit, Publius. This is going to be a long conversation, and I would rather have it sitting down."

He sat. He was twenty-one years old, and he had his father's eyes and his grandmother's jaw and his mother's stubbornness, and he was frightened, and he was trying not to show it.

"There is a story," Cassia said, "that belongs to your father and to me and to your grandmother, and it is not a story I am going to tell you tonight. But I will tell you this much, because you have earned it: there may be a man in this city who is your brother. Not your mother's son. Not your father's lawful son. A child born before you were born, to a woman who was told he had died." She looked at him. "If he is alive, he does not know who he is. If he is alive, he has been raised by people who may not know the truth either. And if he is alive, then everything you have been told about your family is a lie, and you will have to decide what to do with that."

Publius stared at her. His face had gone the colour of the plaster.

"Is he alive?" he said.

"I do not know. I am going to find out."

"Does my father know?"

"Your father knows as much as I do. Perhaps less." Cassia leaned forward. "And Publius. This is the most important thing I will ever say to you. You will not tell your grandmother. You will not tell your sister. You will not tell your mother until your father and I have decided how to tell her. If you tell anyone — anyone at all, even a friend, even a slave — you will put the boy in danger. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

"Say it."

"I understand."

"Good." Cassia stood. "Go home. And Publius—"

"Yes?"

"Your father loves you. He has a bad way of showing it, and he has spent your whole life being afraid that you would turn out like him, and it has made him cold. But he loves you." She said it, and knew it was true, and knew also that she had spent twenty-four years believing the opposite. "It is a poor sort of love that cannot say its own name. But it is not nothing."

He went out. Cassia stood in the dining room with the three Graces looking down at her and the lamps burning low, and Tertulla came and stood beside her and said nothing at all.

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She did not tell Corvinus about the box. She told herself it was because a message sent to the Palatine would be read by a dozen people before it reached him, and because his mother's household was full of eyes, and because the accusation was still hanging over him and any letter from her was a risk. All of that was true. It was not the reason.

The reason was that she wanted to open it alone.

Bathyllus came back on the third day, at dawn, with the box.

Cassia was in the tablinum when he came in. She had not slept; she had spent the night going over the accounts and the black book and the household lists, because there is a kind of comfort in columns of figures, and because she had found that a woman who is waiting for news can either wait well or wait badly, and waiting well consists of finding something to do with the hours.

He was dirty and tired and had a cut over one eye, and he set the box on the desk and stood back.

"Domina."

"You are hurt."

"A stone. On the road. It is nothing." He wiped his face with his sleeve. "The men from the city were at the inn at Tibur the night before we came. Two of them. They had been to the house with the fig tree and the granddaughter had told them nothing, and they had gone away, and they had come back with a magistrate's man and a piece of paper that said they had the right to search the premises."

"And?"

"And the magistrate's man was a boy of nineteen who did not know what he was doing, and I gave him a cup of wine and a little money and told him that the old woman was my mother's aunt and that she had a chest of my uncle's things that I had come to collect, and he looked in the chest and found linen and a broken lamp and a doll, and he went away." Bathyllus's mouth moved. "The men from the city were not pleased. They are still at the inn, waiting."

"The box?"

"The old woman gave it to me herself. She would not let the granddaughter carry it. She held it on her lap all the way to the gate and then she put it in my hands and said, 'Tell her I kept it. Tell her I kept it every day, and I am not afraid of her.'" He paused. "She would not come. She said she has lived in that house for fifty years and she will die in it, and that if the lady wants to hear the truth she can come and hear it in the place where it happened."

Cassia looked at the box. It was a small chest of dark wood, no bigger than two hands, with a bronze lock and a strip of leather around it, and it had been polished so many times that the grain had worn smooth.

"And the granddaughter?"

"Outside. In the kitchen. She is frightened, domina, and she has walked a long way, and she says she will not go back without the box."

"She will not have to." Cassia reached out and put her hand on the lid. It was cold. She thought about the night in the cell, and the cry, and the cart, and the fig tree. "What is her name?"

"Marcella."

"Bring her in."

Bathyllus went out. Cassia sat with her hand on the box and did not open it. She had waited twenty-four years. She could wait a quarter of an hour more.

Marcella was perhaps nineteen, with her grandmother's quick eyes and a countrywoman's hands and the look of a person who has been told all her life that there is a thing in the house that must not be spoken of. She stood in the doorway and looked at Cassia and then at the box and then at Cassia again.

"Domina," she said. "My grandmother says to tell you that the little master lived."

The room was very quiet. Outside, a cart went past on the stones, and a bird sang in the garden, and the house went on with its morning, and Cassia sat behind her desk with her hand on a wooden box and her heart going like a bird in a fist.

"Say it again," she said.

"The little master lived," Marcella said. "She gave him to a man. She has the paper. It is in the box."

Cassia's hand closed on the lock. She did not open it.

"Does she know where he is?"

"She knows the name of the man. She does not know if the boy is alive. She says the man was a potter, and that he lived in Rome, outside the gate, and that she has prayed for him every day for twenty-four years." Marcella's chin trembled. "She says she is sorry. She says she has been sorry every day, and that she could not tell you before because the old lady would have had her killed, and because she was afraid, and because she did not know whether you were alive."

Cassia sat very still. Then she said, "Take her to the kitchen and give her something to eat. Thais will find her a bed. She is to stay until I say otherwise."

Marcella went out. Cassia sat alone in the tablinum with the box in front of her, and the morning light coming in through the window, and the whole house going on around her, and she did not open it.

She did not open it because she was afraid, and because she had been afraid for twenty-four years, and because a woman who has spent her life building walls does not know what to do when a door opens.

Thais came in without knocking, which she had earned the right to do, and stood looking at the box on the desk.

"Is it what she says it is?"

"I do not know. I have not opened it."

"You should open it."

"I know."

"Then why do you not?"

Cassia looked at the box. "Because when I open it, I will know. And as long as I do not open it, he is alive and he is dead at the same time, and I have had twenty-four years of living with the dead, and I know how to do it. I do not know how to do the other thing." She put her hand flat on the lid. "There is a woman in a village at Tibur who has been keeping this box for twenty-four years. She kept it because she was afraid of an old woman in a chair. And I have been afraid of a wooden box on a desk."

"That is not the same."

"No," Cassia said. "It is worse."

She sat there until the light changed, and then she locked the box in the strongroom, and went out, and told Hermeros to have the travelling carriage prepared, and the horses fed, and a room taken at the inn at Tibur for the day after tomorrow.

And then she went into the garden, where the roses were beginning to put out their first green shoots, and she knelt down in the wet earth at the foot of the fig tree that she had planted there herself, six years ago, for no reason she had ever been able to explain to anyone, and she stayed there for a long time.

CHAPTER

# TEN

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The Senate met in the Curia Julia on a morning in March when the wind came up the Forum with dust in it and the light through the high windows was the colour of old honey. The house was full. It was fuller than it had been for a month, because the lot for the Asian command was to be drawn that day, and because the emperor's letter was to be read, and because every man in the chamber had heard, in one form or another, that there was going to be trouble.

Corvinus came in early and took his place on the benches with the other consulars. He had been in the Senate for twenty years and he knew its smells and its sounds the way a man knows his own house: the scrape of shoes on stone, the coughs, the murmur of the clerks, the way the noise dropped when the consul rose. He had spoken in this chamber a hundred times. He had never once come into it afraid.

He was afraid now. He could feel it in his hands. He put them in the folds of his toga and looked at the opposite benches and made himself breathe slowly, the way the physicians had taught his mother.

Pactus was already there, at the front of the benches, talking to a group of men with the easy confidence of a man who has arranged everything. He was dressed in a white toga of excellent wool, and his hair was combed forward, and he looked like a man who had never had a doubt in his life. He looked up as Corvinus came in, and smiled, and inclined his head, and turned back to his friends.

The consul called the house to order. The clerk read the prayer. The sacrifice had been made outside, and the augur had pronounced the omens favourable, and Corvinus, who was himself an augur, and who had spent his life reading the flight of birds and the appetite of chickens with a straight face, thought about how easy it was to make the gods say what you wanted them to say.

Then the consul read the emperor's letter.

It was a short letter. It praised the Senate, and the consuls, and the army, and the prosperity of the age. It spoke of the burden of empire and the need for men of experience in the provinces. And it recommended, for the proconsulship of Asia, the name of Lucius Sulpicius Corvinus, consular, augur, legate of the Second Dacian War.

There was a murmur of approval. Several men turned to look at him. Corvinus inclined his head. He did not allow himself to smile.

The consul folded the letter. "The house will proceed to the lot," he said.

Then Pactus rose.

He rose slowly, the way a man rises when he wants everyone to watch him do it, and he stood in the middle of the floor with his hands clasped behind his back and his chin lifted, and he said, "Conscript fathers. Before the lot is drawn, there is a matter that the house must hear."

The chamber went quiet. The consul looked at Pactus, and then at Corvinus, and then at the clerk.

"Speak," he said.

"I have this morning been informed," Pactus said, "that a formal accusation is to be laid against the man whose name the emperor has just recommended to this house. The accusation is one of parricide. It concerns the death of Marcus Sulpicius Corvinus, consul, censor, in his villa at Tibur, in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Silanus, twenty-four years ago."

The silence in the chamber was total. Corvinus sat very still. He had known it was coming and he had not known how it would feel, and it felt like a hand closing on his chest.

"The accuser," Pactus said, "is a Roman knight named Marcus Aquilius Felix, who has laid his information before the consul in the proper form. The witnesses are three: a physician's assistant, a steward, and a midwife. I do not know whether the accusation is true. It is not for me to know. But I know that this house cannot draw the lot for the richest province in Asia while one of the candidates stands accused of the murder of his father." He turned and looked at Corvinus. "I say this with regret. I have known Lucius Sulpicius all my life. But the dignity of this house is worth more than any man's career, including my own."

Old Servilius Paetus rose first, a consular of seventy who had been in the chamber since the year of the fire and who was known for two things: an inability to be brief and an absolute contempt for new men.

"Conscript fathers," he said, "I have known this house for fifty years, and I have never heard a man's name read out by the emperor and a charge of parricide read out in the same hour. It is indecent. It is worse than indecent; it is convenient. I do not know the knight Felix. I do not wish to. I know that a delator is a man who sells other men's misfortunes, and I know that in my father's time such men were whipped out of the Forum, and I know that the empire was no worse for it." He turned and looked at Pactus with the slow, deliberate contempt of a man who has nothing left to lose. "If the emperor has recommended Lucius Sulpicius for Asia, then the emperor has his reasons, and this house would do well to remember who recommended whom."

There was a rumble of approval from the old benches. Then a young man rose on the other side — a tribune, thirty, with the sort of voice that had been trained by a rhetor and the sort of confidence that had been trained by nothing at all — and said that the dignity of the house required that no man, however distinguished, should be permitted to stand for a province while under accusation; that the law was the same for the consular and the cobbler; and that he was sure the senator would welcome the opportunity to clear his name.

"He is sure," Corvinus murmured, to the man beside him. "He has been sure since he was born."

The man beside him, a fat consular named Rufus who had been his father's friend, did not laugh. "They will have you," he said, quietly. "Not today. Not this year, perhaps. But they will have you, and they will do it in the proper form, and the proper form is slower and crueller than a knife."

There was uproar. The consul called for order twice. Corvinus sat on his bench and listened to the noise, and it was like listening to the sea from a cliff: enormous, indifferent, and a long way down.

He rose.

The chamber went quiet again, in the way that chambers do when a man who has been accused stands up.

"Conscript fathers," he said. His voice was steady. He was surprised by how steady it was. "I will not waste the time of this house on a defence of my father's death. I will say only that I loved my father, that I was in Syria when he died, and

that I have never in my life done anything to harm him. I will say further that the accusation comes at a convenient moment, from a source that has every reason to wish me harm, and that I do not believe this house will allow a man's career to be destroyed by a rumour and a delator before a single witness has been heard."

He looked at Pactus.

"But I will not ask the house to draw the lot while the accusation stands. I will ask instead that this matter be decided quickly, in public, before this house, in the proper form. I have nothing to hide. Let the accuser bring his witnesses. Let them be examined. Let the truth be known." He paused. "And let the house remember, when it is over, who brought this accusation and why."

He sat down. There was a moment of silence, and then the benches erupted, and it was not all hostile. Several men came to him and shook his hand; others looked away. The consul struck the floor with his staff and called for order, and the clerk read out the procedure: the accusation would be received, a day would be set for the preliminary hearing, the witnesses would be summoned, and the lot for Asia would be deferred until the matter was resolved.

The lot was not drawn. The house rose. Corvinus went out into the wind and the dust of the Forum with his friends around him and a smile fixed on his face, and he did not allow himself to look up at the Palatine, where his mother was dying in a cold room, and he did not allow himself to think about a woman in a house on the Esquiline who was, at that moment, probably already being told what had happened by one of her dozen informants.

He walked as far as the steps of the basilica and then stopped, because his legs would not carry him any further, and stood with his hand against a column while the city went past him.

He had been sixteen when his father had taken him into the atrium and made him recite the offices of the masks. He had been twenty when his father had told him that the girl would be sold and the child disposed of, and he had believed, in that moment, that he had reached the bottom of the man. He had been wrong. The bottom was deeper, and it had taken him twenty-four years and a dying woman's confession to find it.

*I put something in his wine at dinner.*

His mother had said it in the same voice she used to order the linen. She had said it as though she were describing a household expense. And the terrible thing

— the thing he could not look at and could not look away from — was that he understood it. He had lived in that house. He had seen what his father did to the people in it, to his wife, to his son, to the girl in the kitchen. He had been too young and too frightened to stop it, and his mother had been neither, and she had done what she had done, and she had done it in the dark, and she had carried it for twenty-four years.

He did not know whether that made her a murderer or a survivor. He suspected it made her both.

He was right. She was.

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Cassia heard the news from three people before noon: from Hermeros, who had a cousin who was a clerk in the curia; from Comptus, who came himself, white-faced, in a litter, and stood in the atrium with his hands shaking; and from the flower seller in the Subura, who sent a boy with a message that said only, *It is done. P.*

She sent Comptus home with a cup of wine and a promise, and then she sat in the tablinum and did the arithmetic. The preliminary hearing would be in a month, perhaps less. The witnesses would be summoned. Felix had the midwife's name and the physician's assistant and the old steward; he had the story, and now he had a forum. The only thing he did not have was the box.

She called the household into the atrium and told them the truth, or as much of it as they needed.

"There is an accusation against the senator Corvinus," she said. "It will come to a hearing. Before it does, there will be men in this city asking questions about this house, and about me, and about all of you. Some of them will be magistrates. Some of them will be men who are paid to ask. Some of them will be your friends."

The household stood in a half-circle and looked at her. Twenty-three people, from Thais to the boy who fed the pigeons.

"You will tell them the truth," Cassia said. "The truth is not dangerous. What is dangerous is a lie that contradicts another lie. If a man asks you whether I received the senator Corvinus in this house, you will say yes, because I did, and because it was a public reception and half the city knew of it. If a man asks you whether I went to Tibur, you will say that I have business at Tibur. If a man asks

you about the past, you will say that you were not here, or that you do not know, and you will say it the same way every time."

She looked at them.

"And if a man threatens you, you will remember that a threat is not a beating, and that a beating is not a death, and that whatever happens to you, this house will not abandon you or your families. I have written it down. Hermeros has it. If I am taken, the paper goes to the lady Tertulla, and she will see that every one of you is freed and given money and a place to go." She paused. "That is not a kindness. It is a contract. You are not being asked to be brave for nothing."

There was a long silence. Then Celer, the cook, said, "Domina, we are not going to be brave. We are going to be sensible. There is a difference." And the household laughed, and Cassia laughed with them, and then she went into the tablinum and sat down and put her face in her hands for exactly as long as it took to count to ten.

She sent for Tertulla, and for Hermeros, and for Thais. She sent a boy to the Palatine with a note that said, *I know. Do not do anything. I will come to you tonight.* She sent another to the house of Aemilia Celsa, which was the same house, and which she had never in her life written to before, and which she wrote to now in the same terms, because she had learned long ago that a message sent to two people is more likely to be delivered than a message sent to one.

Proculus came at the second hour, in a litter, with his son in attendance and a face like a man who has been asked to pay for a funeral.

"I have heard," he said. "The whole city has heard. There is not a wine shop in Rome that is not discussing it." He sat down heavily. "I have come to tell you that I cannot be seen with you for a while. Not because I do not value the friendship of this house. Because a man in my position has to be careful, and because the consul has asked me to speak for the province of Asia in the debate, and because I cannot speak for a province and be seen dining with the woman who is at the centre of a scandal."

"I am not at the centre of anything."

"You are at the centre of everything, and you know it." Proculus wiped his face. "I am sorry. I am a coward. I have always been a coward. But I am a coward with a seat in the Senate, and a seat in the Senate is worth more to you than a brave man with no seat at all." He stood. "When this is over — if you are still

standing — send for me, and I will come, and I will bring the best wine I have, and we will pretend that this conversation never happened."

He went out. His son, Aulus, lingered in the doorway.

"Domina," he said. "My father is a coward. I am not."

Cassia looked at him. The boy who had put his hand on Chrysis's shoulder at a dinner in December, and who had been sent back to his seat like a child, was standing in her tablinum with his jaw set and his fists clenched, and she thought that he would either become a decent man or a dead one, and that there was no way of knowing which.

"Then do something brave," she said, "and do it quietly, and do not tell anyone you have done it. That is what courage is. It is not a speech in the Senate. It is a letter written at midnight to a man who can help, and a promise kept when it would be easier to break it." She turned away. "Go home, Aulus. Look after your father. He is more frightened than he knows."

Then she went to the strongroom and took out the box and set it on the desk and looked at it for a long time.

"Domina," Thais said, from the doorway. "The lady Aemilia is here."

Cassia turned. "Now?"

"Now. She came in a plain litter with one slave, by the garden door, and she is in the small dining room, and she has been crying."

Cassia put the box back in the strongroom and locked it.

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Aemilia Celsa was sitting on the couch in the small dining room with her hands in her lap. She had been crying, and she had stopped, and she had wiped her face and put her hair right, and she looked, in the grey light from the garden, like a woman who had come to the end of something and had decided to keep walking.

"They are saying he killed his father," she said.

"They are saying he is accused of it. It is not the same."

"It is the same in this city." Aemilia looked up. "I have been in that house for nineteen years. I have sat at that table and listened to that woman talk about honour and the family and the masks on the wall. And this morning my son came to me and told me that there is a woman in Rome who knew my husband before I did, and that there is a child somewhere, and that my mother-in-law has

been lying to all of us for twenty-four years." Her voice was steady. "I am not here to shout at you. I have done my shouting, in the litter, on the way here, at my own slave, who did not deserve it. I am here to ask you what I should do."

Cassia sat down opposite her. "You should decide what you want."

"I want my family to survive."

"That is not the same as wanting the truth."

"I know." Aemilia's hands tightened. "I have spent nineteen years wanting the truth and being told that it was not my business. Now it is my business, and I find that I do not want it. I want the house, and my children, and my husband, and the life I have made, and I do not want to know what it was built on." She looked at Cassia. "Does that make me a coward?"

"No," Cassia said. "It makes you a person who has something to lose."

"And you? What do you want?"

Cassia looked at her. The garden was grey beyond the window, and the first rain of March was beginning to fall, and somewhere in the house a door closed.

"I want the boy," she said. "I want to know whether he is alive. I want to know what he has been told and who has raised him and whether he is happy. And then I want to make sure that no one in this city can ever take him from me again." She paused. "And I want the man who paid Felix to be destroyed. Not killed. Destroyed. I want him to lose his money and his name and his friends and his seat in the Senate, and I want him to live a long time afterward, in a small house, with no one to talk to."

Aemilia stared at her. "You are not a good woman."

"No."

"You are not a bad one, either."

"I am a woman who has been pushed," Cassia said, "and who has decided to push back. Whether that is good or bad depends on who is writing the history." She leaned forward. "I will make you a bargain, Aemilia. I will do everything in my power to save your husband from this accusation, not because I love him, but because the accusation is a lie built out of a truth, and I will not let a lie win. And in return, you will do three things."

"Name them."

"You will not tell your mother-in-law anything I tell you. You will not prevent me from seeing your husband when I need to. And when this is over, you

will let me know the boy — if he is alive — in whatever way he wants to be known. Not as a scandal. Not as a secret. As a person."

Aemilia was silent for a long moment. The rain came down harder, and the gutters of the house began to run, and the garden smelled of wet stone and rosemary.

"I have one condition," she said.

"Name it."

"When this is over, you will not come to my house. You will not dine at my table. You will not be seen with my husband. Whatever there is between you, it ends when this is ended." She looked at Cassia steadily. "I am not a fool. I know what he is to you and what you are to him. I have known since the portico of the library. But I will not be a wife in a house where the other woman comes to dinner. I have my dignity, and it is not much, and it is all I have."

Cassia looked at her. In the grey light, with her hair coming down and her hands clasped in her lap, Aemilia Celsa was not beautiful and not clever and not kind, and she was, in that moment, the most formidable person in the room.

"Agreed," Cassia said.

Aemilia nodded. Then she said, "What do we do?"

"We make him tell the truth," Cassia said. "Not the whole truth. The part that can be proved. The delation says your husband killed his father. We will prove that he did not, because he did not, and because the person who did is dying in a room upstairs and has been waiting twenty-four years to say it."

Aemilia's face went white. "His mother."

"Yes."

"You are sure?"

"I am sure of the cup," Cassia said. "I am sure she gave it to me. I am sure she took my son out of the room. I am not sure what she put in her husband's wine. But I am going to find out." She stood. "Go home. Tell your husband I will come tonight. Tell him to say nothing to his mother until I am there. And tell your daughter—" She paused. "Tell your daughter that I am sorry she had to find out this way, and that she was right to come to me at the festival, and that when this is over I will tell her the rest."

Aemilia rose. At the door she said, "My daughter has been asking questions about you."

"She is a clever girl."

"She is a difficult girl." Aemilia's mouth moved. "I was difficult. It did not save me, but it kept me alive." She went out, her slave behind her, and Cassia stood in the small dining room and listened to the rain.

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Felix came at dusk, alone, with his hood up and no men behind him, and Bathyllus brought him to the tablinum and did not leave the room.

"I have thought about it," Felix said.

"And?"

"I will give you Pactus." He sat down. "Not for the money. The money is useful but I can get money. I will give you Pactus because I have been a delator for six years and no one has ever offered me a chair, and because I am tired, and because I have a boy of nine and a girl of six and I would like them to grow up in a house where their father is not spat at in the street." He looked up. "But I want something else. Something you will not want to give."

"Name it."

"I want a written agreement. Under seal. That I am under the protection of your house. That if I am ever accused, you will speak for me. That my children will never want." He watched her. "I know what your word is worth. I have spent six years learning what words are worth in this city. I want it in writing, witnessed, in a place where it cannot be burned."

Cassia looked at him. The rain had stopped, and the lamp was lit, and the black book was in the strongroom, and the box was beside it, and outside the streets were full of the noise of the evening.

"You will have it," she said. "Drawn up tonight, witnessed by my steward and by the lady Tertulla, sealed with my ring. And in exchange you will give me the name of the man who paid you, and the petition, and a written statement that you were paid, and the date of the hearing."

Felix nodded slowly. Then he said, "The man who paid me is not Pactus."

"I know."

"You know?"

"I have known since the Saturnalia. Pactus is a front. Pactus wants the Asian command, and he has debts, and he has been borrowing from a banker on the Via Lata who holds mortgages on half the Palatine." Cassia turned her cup.

"What I do not know is whether the banker is using Pactus or Pactus is using the banker."

"What do they have? Not the story. The proof."

"A copy of the physician's certificate, signed by a man who is dead. A statement from the steward, taken down by a clerk and signed with his mark. A statement from the physician's assistant, Faustus, who says that he was told by his master that the old man's death was not natural." Felix turned the cup. "And the midwife. She is the one they want most. A midwife who was in the room can say what she saw, and a court will believe her over a senator any day."

"Then we will have the midwife."

"She is old, domina. She is ill. She may die before the hearing, and then they will read her statement, and a statement read by a clerk is worth more than a living witness who contradicts it, because a clerk cannot be cross-examined."

"Then we will have her alive, and we will have her statement, and we will have something better than either." Cassia leaned forward. "The petition. You said it was laid before the consul in the proper form. Who drew it up?"

"A lawyer named Crispus. He works for Sittius."

"And where is the original?"

"With the consul's clerk. There is a copy in Sittius's strongbox and a copy in Pactus's house." Felix's eyes narrowed. "You are thinking of stealing it."

"I am thinking of proving that it was paid for." Cassia stood. "A delator's petition must be sworn before a magistrate. If we can prove that the witnesses were paid, and that the payment came from Sittius, then the petition is not a petition. It is a fraud. And a man who lays a fraudulent accusation before the Senate is not a prosecutor. He is a criminal."

"Both," Felix said. "The banker is a man named Sittius. He holds the mortgage on the Sulpicius house and the vineyard in Etruria and a warehouse on the Tiber. If the senator is ruined, the estate comes to him at a fraction of its value. Pactus gets the province. Sittius gets the house. And I get paid." He looked at her. "That is the whole of it. There is no great conspiracy. There is a banker who wants a house and a senator who wants a province, and they found a man who could put a story together."

Cassia sat very still. She had known it, or something like it, but knowing a thing and hearing it said are different, and hearing it said by a man who had been paid to say it was worse.

"Then we will give them a story," she said. "And it will be true."

She called for Hermeros and the wax and the seal, and they drew up the agreement that night, and Felix signed it and she signed it and Tertulla and Hermeros witnessed it, and when it was done Felix sat looking at the tablet in his hands with an expression that Cassia had never seen on him before.

"What is it?" she said.

"I do not know," he said. "I have never had a thing like this before. I do not know what to do with it."

"Put it somewhere safe," Cassia said, "and go home to your children."

CHAPTER

# ELEVEN

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The fire began a little after the third hour of the morning, in the storeroom behind the kitchen, where the oil jars were kept.

Cassia woke because the dog was barking. There was a dog in the alley behind the house that belonged to the bakery and barked at everything, so at first she did not move; she lay in the dark and listened to it and thought about the hearing and the box and the face of the man in the Senate. Then she smelled smoke, and she was out of bed and at the door before she had decided to move.

The corridor was full of it. Grey, thin, moving along the ceiling like water. She pulled her mantle over her mouth and went down the stairs, and the house was full of noise now: doors, voices, the crackle that is not like any other sound in the world.

"Fire!" Bathyllus's voice, from the service yard. "Bucket line! Domina — the storeroom!"

She got to the bottom of the stairs and the atrium was full of people. Thais with her hair down, carrying the strongbox. Sabina in her nightgown, standing still in the middle of the floor with her hands over her ears. The two kitchen boys dragging the water barrel. Celer in his apron, his face black with smoke, shouting at a slave who was trying to carry a chest out through the front door.

"Leave the chest!" Cassia said. "Get everyone into the street. Thais, count them. Bathyllus, the strongroom."

She went through the passage to the back of the house and the heat hit her like a wall. The storeroom door was open, and inside it was a furnace: the oil jars had gone, and the flames were running along the shelves, and the ceiling above was black and moving. The yard beyond was full of men passing buckets, and the water hissed and did nothing.

"The door," she said. "Shut the door. Cut off the air."

They shut it. The fire roared behind it. Bathyllus came through the smoke with the key to the strongroom and they went together into the tablinum, and the room was already hazy, and Cassia's hands were steady as she opened the panel and the lock and pulled out the strongbox and the black book and the wooden box.

"The linen," she said. "Get the linen out. And the wills. Leave the rest."

They got the strongbox and the book and the box and three bundles of documents out into the street, and by then the vigiles had come, too late as always, with their hooks and their buckets and their axes. The neighbours were in the street in their nightclothes. The baker was there with his sons. The flower seller. The old woman from the insula opposite. Somebody had brought a ladder. Somebody was shouting that the whole block would go.

It did not go. The fire had been confined to the storeroom and the passage behind the kitchen and part of the yard, and the vigiles pulled down the shed and soaked the wall, and by dawn it was out, and the house stood, blackened and stinking, with a hole in its side where the storeroom had been.

The fire had a sound that Cassia would remember for the rest of her life: not a roar, as she had expected, but a low, busy, eating noise, like a hundred people tearing paper. It filled the passage and the yard, and the smoke came off it in waves, and the water thrown on it went up in steam and did nothing.

She carried the strongbox out herself. It was heavier than she expected; she had never carried it before, and she staggered with it through the atrium and out into the street, and Hermeros took it from her and put it in the baker's cart, and she went back in.

"Domina!" Bathyllus, in the doorway, his face black. "You cannot—"

"The papers. The wills. There are three wills in that room and if they burn, three families lose everything." She pushed past him. "The linen can burn. The silver can burn. The wills cannot."

The tablinum was full of smoke. She went in with her mantle over her face and her eyes streaming, and she found the strongroom by touch, and the key would not go in the lock because her hands were shaking, and she stopped, and made herself breathe, and put the key in, and turned it.

The black book was on the shelf where she had left it. The wooden box was beside it. She took them both, and three rolls of documents, and a bag of coin, and she went out through the smoke with her arms full and her lungs burning,

and in the atrium she fell against the impluvium and lay there coughing while the household shouted her name.

"Domina. Domina." Thais, with water. "Drink. Drink."

"I am all right." She was not all right. She sat on the edge of the impluvium with the black book in her lap and the wooden box under her arm and the smoke rolling over her head, and she laughed, once, and it turned into a cough that went on for a long time.

The neighbours came. The baker's wife brought a blanket and put it around her shoulders. The flower seller stood in the street with her hands clasped and her lips moving, praying to whatever god looked after houses. The old woman from the insula opposite, who had not spoken to Cassia in six years because of a dispute about a drain, came across the street with a jug of water and stood beside her without saying anything, which was, in its way, an apology.

By dawn the street was full of people and the house was a black shell with a hole in its side, and the sun came up over the Esquiline and made the wet ash shine.

"Domina," Bathyllus said, from the passage.

She went.

That was when they found the boy.

Nolus was eleven years old. He had come to the house two years before, from the slave market, and he had been given the job of feeding the pigeons and sweeping the yard, and he slept in the passage behind the kitchen because it was warm there. He had not come out when the others came out. They found him at the far end of the passage, by the door to the yard, which had been bolted on the outside.

Cassia stood in the street and looked at the small, black, curled thing that had been a boy, and she did not look away, and she did not cry, and she thought: someone bolted that door. Someone bolted that door from the outside, and the boy went to it, and he could not get out.

"Domina," Bathyllus said, at her shoulder. "You should not be here."

"Who bolted the door?"

He was silent.

"Who bolted the door, Bathyllus?"

"It was bolted when I got there. The bolt was hot. I could not touch it." His voice was flat. "The yard door is bolted every night. It is the rule. The boy

should not have been in the passage. He was supposed to sleep in the kitchen with the others."

"Then someone put him in the passage."

"Domina—"

"Someone put him in the passage and bolted the door and set the fire in the storeroom, and they did it knowing that the boy would be there, and that the house would burn, and that everyone in it would be asleep." Cassia turned. "That is not an accident. That is a message."

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The household was taken to Tertulla's house on the Caelian, all of them, in the grey light, with what they could carry. Cassia stayed. She stood in the blackened yard with the vigiles and the smell of wet ash and looked at the storeroom, and the vigiles' captain, a thick man named Pudens who had been in the service for twenty years, came and stood beside her and said, "It was oil. There was a lamp broken on the floor and there was oil poured on the shelves. The fire started in three places. That is not an accident."

"I know."

"Someone wanted this house burned."

"Yes."

"Who?"

"If I knew that," Cassia said, "I would not need you."

Pudens looked at her. He was a man who had spent his life dealing with the small disasters of the city, and he had the flat, patient face of a man who had learned not to be surprised. "I will write it down as an accident. That is what I will write, unless you pay me to write something else, and I do not think you will, because you are not a fool." He spat. "If I write arson, there will be an inquiry, and the inquiry will be run by a man who is friends with a man who wants you ruined, and you will spend the next six months in a courtroom instead of in this house. If I write accident, the insurance will pay, and you will bury your boy, and you will find out who did it yourself. Which is what you are going to do anyway."

"You are a philosopher, Pudens."

"I am a captain of the vigiles. It is the same thing, with worse hours." He turned to go. "Bury the boy today. Do not wait. This heat will turn him by to-

morrow, and the whole street will smell of it, and then people will start asking questions that you do not want asked."

They buried Nolus that afternoon, in a grave outside the Porta Esquilina, in the ground where the poor were buried and the slaves were buried and the people no one claimed were buried. Cassia paid for a stone. It was a small stone, and it said his name and his age and the words *SERVUS FAMILIAE*, and she stood at the grave with the household around her and the smell of the fire still in her hair, and she thought about a boy in a passage with a bolted door, and about a cry in the night twenty-four years before.

Thais stood beside her. "It was not your fault."

"Yes it was."

"Domina—"

"I am the mistress of that house. A boy died in it because someone wanted to hurt me, and they knew that the way to hurt me was to burn what is mine." Cassia's voice was very quiet. "I have spent my life making sure that no one could touch me. I built walls and bought favours and made myself useful to men who could destroy me. And a boy who could not have been more than eleven years old is in the ground because a man with a lamp wanted to send me a message." She looked at the small stone. "That is the price of my house. I have been paying it for twenty-four years and I did not know it."

Tertulla came out to the Caelian in the afternoon and took charge of the household as though she had been born for it. She had the women put in the upstairs rooms and the men in the stables and the strongbox put in her own strongroom behind a curtain, and she had Celer brought into the kitchen and told to make something for twenty-three people, and Celer, who had been standing in the street in his apron for six hours without speaking, looked at her and said, "I burned the fish at the Saturnalia. I have never burned a fish in my life. I have been thinking about it all night, and I cannot remember how I did it."

"Celer," Tertulla said. "It was a fish. It does not matter."

"It matters," Celer said. "If I had not burned the fish, the mistress would not have sent me to the market on the second day, and I would have been in the storeroom when it happened, and I would have smelled the oil."

"You would have died."

"Perhaps," Celer said. "And the boy would not have been alone."

Tertulla took him by the shoulders and sat him down on a stool and gave him a cup of wine and stood over him until he drank it. Then she went out into the garden and found Cassia sitting on the bench by the rosemary with the wooden box in her lap.

"The boy is asking about you," she said. "Sabina. She has not spoken since the fire. She sat in the corner all morning with her hands over her ears. Thais says she will not eat."

"I will go to her."

"In a minute." Tertulla sat down beside her. "First tell me what you are going to do."

"About what?"

"About the fire. About the accusation. About the fact that a child is dead and a man paid for it." Tertulla's voice was steady and hard. "I have known you for six years. I have never seen you like this. You are sitting in a garden with a box in your lap and your house half burned and your face is the face of a woman who has already decided something and is waiting for the courage to do it."

Cassia looked at the box.

"He is alive," she said. "The midwife says he is alive. He is a potter's son on the Via Ostiensis, and he is twenty-four years old, and he does not know that I exist." She put her hand on the lid. "And someone has been asking about him. Someone who is not Felix and not Sittius and not Pactus. Someone who knew where to send men to Tibur to ask about a boy."

"Who?"

"I do not know. But there is a patron in the palace, and Pactus is frightened of him, and a man who is frightened does things he would not otherwise do." Cassia stood. "I am going to see my son."

Tertulla looked at her. "Now?"

"Now. Before someone else does."

"Cassia—"

"I am not going to speak to him. I am going to look at him. I am going to stand in the street and look at him and see what kind of man he is, and then I am going to come home and do what has to be done." She picked up the box. "I have waited twenty-four years. I can wait another month. But I cannot go another day without knowing what he looks like."

Sabina was in the small room upstairs, sitting on the bed with her knees drawn up, in a clean tunic that someone had put on her. She had not spoken since the fire. She looked up when Cassia came in and then looked down again.

Cassia sat on the bed beside her and did not touch her.

"When I was a girl," she said, "I saw a man killed in the street. He was a baker, and a cart went over him, and I was standing on the other side of the road with a basket of linen. I was nine years old. I could not speak for two days. My mother thought I had lost my wits." She looked at the wall. "I have thought about it for thirty-three years. Not every day. Not even every year. But sometimes, when I am tired, I see the cart and the man's arm and the bread rolling in the dust."

Sabina said nothing.

"There is no good way to see a thing like that," Cassia said. "There is no trick to it. It goes into you and it stays, and you carry it, and in time you find that you can carry it and do other things at the same time. That is all I can tell you. It does not get smaller. You get stronger."

The child's shoulders began to shake. Cassia put her arms around her and held her, and Sabina cried the way children cry, with her whole body, and Cassia held her and did not say anything else for a long time.

"Was it my fault?" Sabina said, at last.

"No."

"I was awake. I heard the dog. I did not get up."

"You are twelve years old. You could not have done anything. If you had got up, you would have been in the passage with Nolus." Cassia's voice was steady. "The fault is not yours. It is not Celer's, and it is not Thais's, and it is not the household's. It is mine, because I am the mistress of this house, and because I have enemies, and because I did not think they would go this far."

Sabina pulled back and looked at her. Her face was wet and her eyes were red and she was, in that moment, entirely a child and entirely a person.

"Are we going to be sold?" she said.

"No."

"Are you going to be killed?"

"No."

"How do you know?"

"Because I am going to make sure of it," Cassia said. "That is what I do. I make sure of things. It is not a kind of magic. It is arithmetic." She wiped the child's face with her thumb. "Now. You are going to eat something, and then you are going to sleep, and tomorrow you are going to help Thais with the linen, because there is a great deal of linen and it will not fold itself."

Sabina nodded. At the door she said, "Domina. Who is going to feed the pigeons?"

Cassia stood in the corridor for a moment with her hand on the doorframe.

"I will," she said. "Until we find someone else."

Tertulla rose. "I am coming with you."

"No."

"I am coming with you, and I am going to stand in the street beside you, and when you cannot speak I am going to hold your hand, and when you want to go in I am going to hold you back." She took Cassia's arm. "That is what friends are for. It is not a very exalted thing. It is mostly standing in streets."

She turned and walked back to the city.

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Sittius the banker kept an office behind the Basilica Julia, in a narrow building with a green door and a step worn into a curve by the feet of two generations of debtors. Cassia went there in the afternoon, alone but for Bathyllus, and she was kept waiting for a quarter of an hour in a room with a bench and a jug of water and no window, and then shown into the office.

Gaius Sittius was sixty and neat and entirely without warmth. He had a face like a closed account book and hands that did not move when he talked, and he had been a banker for forty years and had never in that time been known to lose his temper, raise his voice, or forgive a debt.

"Domina," he said. "This is an unexpected pleasure."

"Is it?"

"It is unexpected." He gestured to a chair. "Sit. You have come about the fire."

"I have come about the fire."

"I am sorry for your loss. I heard about the boy. It is a terrible thing." He said it in the tone of a man reading a weather report. "I hope you do not think I had anything to do with it."

"I think you paid for it."

Sittius looked at her without expression. "That is a serious accusation."

"It is not an accusation. It is a statement of fact, and you know it, and I know it, and the only question is what I am going to do about it." Cassia sat down. "You hold the mortgage on the Sulpicius house and the vineyard in Etruria and a warehouse on the Tiber. If the senator is ruined, the estate comes to you at a fraction of its value. You have been buying his debts for years, quietly, through intermediaries. You paid a delator to assemble a case, and you paid a man to burn my house, and you did it because you are a man who has spent his life acquiring things and has never once considered what it costs other people to be acquired."

Sittius's hands did not move. His face did not change. But something behind his eyes shifted, the way a fish moves under ice.

"You have no proof," he said.

"I have a delator who will swear to the payment. I have a copy of the petition with your lawyer's name on it. I have the statement of a clerk in the annona office who can show that your brother-in-law has been cheating the grain supply for two years." Cassia leaned back. "And I have a house full of people who have just watched a child burn to death, and who will say anything I ask them to say, because they are frightened and because they are angry and because they loved him."

Sittius was silent for a long moment. Then he said, "What do you want?"

"I want you to withdraw the accusation."

"I cannot withdraw it. It is not mine. It was laid before the consul by a Roman knight."

"You can tell your lawyer to lose the papers. You can tell your witnesses to forget. You can tell Pactus that the case is over." Cassia leaned forward. "And in exchange, I will not destroy you. I will not go to the prefect of the grain supply. I will not go to the emperor's freedman with a file of documents that would put your brother-in-law in a mine and you in a small house in the country with a very long walk to the nearest town."

"And if I refuse?"

"Then I will destroy you," Cassia said, "and I will do it slowly, and I will start with the people you love, and you will watch."

Sittius looked at her for a long moment. Then he smiled, and it was the first expression she had seen on his face, and it was worse than the blankness.

"You are a remarkable woman," he said. "I have been in this business for forty years and I have never met anyone who could do arithmetic and speak of love in the same breath." He stood. "I will consider your offer. It is a good offer. It is, in fact, the offer I would make in your position." He walked to the window. "But I did not burn your house, domina. I want you to understand that. I am a banker. Bankers do not burn houses. We foreclose on them, which is cheaper and legal and far more satisfying." He turned. "You have an enemy who is not me. And if I were you, I would find out who it is before you spend all your ammunition on a man who has no interest in killing you."

"Who?"

"I do not know. But I know that Pactus came to me a month ago with a proposal, and I know that he was more frightened than a man with a plan should be, and I know that he has a patron in the palace." Sittius smiled again. "That is the trouble with new men, domina. They always have a patron. And a patron is a man who can be blamed."

Cassia's hand tightened on the edge of the desk. "You are telling me that Pactus has a patron in the palace."

"I am telling you that Pactus has a patron, and that the patron has a reason to want the Sulpicii damaged, and that the reason is not the Asian command." Sittius's mouth moved. "The Sulpicii have a claim on a piece of land near the new forum. It was left to them by a man who died in the reign of Domitian, and the claim was contested, and the case has been in the courts for fifteen years. If the family is destroyed, the claim is worthless, and the land can be bought for a fraction of its value by a man who knows what it will be worth when the emperor extends the forum." He looked at her. "That man is not me. I am a banker. I lend money against land. I do not buy land that has a claim on it."

"Who buys land that has a claim on it?"

"A man who has been told that the claim will not survive the year." Sittius turned back to his window. "I have told you more than I should. I am telling you because I would like you to remember, when this is over, that I was useful to you, and that I did not burn your house."

Cassia rose. At the door she said, "If you did not burn my house, then who did?"

"I told you. I do not know." Sittius turned back to his window. "But I will tell you something for nothing, because you are the most interesting thing that has happened to me this year. The men who came to Tibur looking for your midwife were not mine. I sent one man, a clerk, to look at a ledger. He came back and told me that there were two other men there, and that they were not asking about a will. They were asking about a boy."

The room was very quiet. Cassia's hands were cold.

"What boy?"

"You know what boy." Sittius did not turn around. "If I were you, domina, I would go and see him before someone else does. And I would take money. A great deal of money. The kind of money that makes a man forget that he ever had another name."

She went out into the Forum with her heart going like a drum and the sun in her eyes and the smell of smoke still in her hair, and she stood on the steps of the basilica and looked across the crowded square, and for a moment the whole city seemed to her a machine made of appetite and debt and fear, grinding on and on, and she was inside it, and so was a boy on the Via Ostiensis who did not know that he had a mother.

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They went out through the Porta Trigemina at dusk, in a plain litter, with Bathyllus walking ahead and Tertulla beside her, and the streets beyond the gate were the streets of the workshops: tanners and rope-makers and potters and men who worked in leather and men who worked in clay. The smell was of smoke and wet earth and the river. The lamps were being lit. A dog barked somewhere. A woman was singing in a yard.

The potter's shop was on the corner of the Via Ostiensis and a narrow lane, with a tiled roof and a wide door and a yard behind it where the kiln stood. There was a lamp burning in the window, and the door was open, and as they came past, a young man came out into the yard with a board of cups on his shoulder and set it down on the trestle.

He was tall and broad-shouldered and had his sleeves rolled up over his forearms, and his hands and his forearms and the front of his tunic were grey with clay. His hair was the colour of dark honey, and he had the family's nose and the

family's jaw, and he moved with the unhurried competence of a man who has done the same work every day since he was a boy.

He turned to say something to someone inside the shop, and he laughed, and the laugh was a young man's laugh, surprised out of him, and it changed his face entirely.

Cassia stood in the street with her hand on Tertulla's arm and looked at her son.

She had imagined it a thousand times. She had imagined him dead, and she had imagined him as a baby, and she had imagined him as a young man in a senator's house with a senator's manners. She had not imagined this: a potter with clay on his arms, laughing at something in a doorway, in a street that smelled of the river.

She did not move. Tertulla's hand closed on hers.

"Cassia," she said, very quietly. "Do you want to go in?"

"No," Cassia said.

"Then we will stand here until you do."

They stood for a long time. The young man went back inside, and the lamp in the window moved, and someone inside the shop said something that made him laugh again. A small boy came out and chased a chicken around the yard. An older man came to the door and called the young man in to supper, and the young man said something over his shoulder, and the older man cuffed him lightly on the back of the head, and they went in together.

Cassia watched the door close. Then she turned away, and Tertulla turned with her, and they walked back up the Via Ostiensis in the dark, and Cassia did not say anything at all until they were through the gate and into the streets of the city again.

"He is happy," she said.

"Yes."

"He has a father who cuffs him on the head and calls him in to supper."

"Yes."

"I am glad," Cassia said, and then she stopped walking, and stood in the middle of the street with her hands over her face, and cried for the first time in twenty-four years, in the dark, in the street, with the noise of the city going on around her and Tertulla's arms around her, holding her up.

CHAPTER

# TWELVE

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They left Rome before dawn on the day after the funeral, in two carriages and a cart, with Bathyllus riding ahead and two of Tertulla's men behind. The sky was grey and the streets were empty and the city smelled of wet ash and the river. Cassia sat in the first carriage with the wooden box on the seat beside her and her hand on the lid, and she did not look back at the house as they passed the end of the street, because she had learned a long time ago that a woman who looks back is a woman who is followed.

Tertulla sat opposite her with a basket of bread and cheese and a flask of wine and the expression of a woman who has decided to be practical in the face of other people's grief.

"Eat something," she said.

"I am not hungry."

"You will be. The road to Tibur is eight hours and the inn is bad." Tertulla cut a piece of cheese and handed it across. "Eat it, or I will tell the driver to stop at every milestone and I will make you walk."

Cassia ate the cheese. It tasted of nothing.

They went out through the Porta Tiburtina and onto the Via Tiburtina, and the city fell away behind them in stages: first the tombs and the market gardens, then the villas of the rich with their walls and their cypresses, then the plain, wide and green and full of larks. The sun came up. The road was crowded with carts and mules and people walking with bundles, and once they passed a procession taking a body out to a family tomb, and the mourning women were wailing in the way that is half grief and half performance, and Cassia thought about a boy in a grave outside the Esquiline gate.

They stopped at an inn at the ninth milestone to water the horses, and the innkeeper's wife brought out a jug of wine and a plate of figs and told them that

the road ahead was clear and that there had been soldiers on it the day before, going north.

"Soldiers?" Tertulla said.

"Two. Not in uniform. They had good horses and they did not stop to eat." The woman wiped her hands on her apron. "They asked about a house at Tibur. The one with the fig tree."

Cassia set down her cup.

"Did they say why?"

"No. They paid for their wine and they went on." The woman looked at her curiously. "Are you going to Tibur, domina?"

"Yes."

"Then you will want to be careful. There are men on that road who are not what they seem."

At the ninth milestone there was a shrine to the springs, a small stone altar under a roof, with a cup and a jug and a great many rags tied to the branches of a tree. Travellers left offerings there for safe passage, and the rags were the clothes of sick children, and the place smelled of old water and dust.

Tertulla went to the altar and put down a coin and stood for a moment with her head bowed. Cassia stayed by the carriage.

"You should make an offering," Tertulla said, when she came back.

"To whom? The springs?"

"To whatever is listening." Tertulla climbed into the carriage. "I do not believe in the gods. I believe in the usefulness of pretending to, in front of the servants." She settled her skirts. "What are you going to do when you have the truth?"

"I do not know."

"You must have thought about it."

"I have thought about it for twenty-four years. I have thought about it so much that I have worn a groove in it." Cassia looked out at the road. "When I was in Puteoli I used to imagine finding him. I was twenty and I was nothing and I imagined walking into a house and saying, 'I am your mother,' and having him run to me. When I was thirty I imagined finding him and finding that he was dead, and I imagined standing at the grave and saying all the things I had never been able to say. When I was forty I stopped imagining it, because I had discovered that imagination is a kind of debt, and that the interest is very high."

She turned. "And now I am forty-two and I am on a road to Tibur with a box in my lap, and I find that I have no imagination left at all. Only arithmetic."

"What does the arithmetic say?"

"It says that I have a son who is alive, and a household that depends on me, and an accusation that will destroy the man I love if I cannot stop it, and an enemy who has already burned my house and killed a child." Cassia's voice was steady. "It says that I cannot afford to be a mother. Not this year. This year I have to be a woman with a knife."

Tertulla was silent for a moment. Then she said, "You are not a woman with a knife."

"I am a woman with a ledger and a house full of secrets and a great deal of money. It is the same thing, in Rome."

They drove on. The sun went higher and the day grew warm and the plain gave way to the hills, and the hills were green and wooded and full of the sound of water. Cassia looked out of the window at the road and did not see it. She was thinking about a summer twenty-four years before, and a garden, and a boy who came to the kitchen for bread, and the way the light had fallen through the vines.

The inn at Tibur was a long, low building with a stable and a yard and a fig tree by the gate, and they came into it in the late afternoon with the light going gold and the hills turning blue behind them. Bathyllus had been there before and had spoken to the innkeeper, and there were rooms ready, and a boy to take the horses, and a woman in the kitchen making something that smelled of onions and thyme.

Cassia did not go into the inn. She stood in the yard with her hand on the wooden box and looked up the hill.

The villa was still there. She could see the roofline above the trees, and a corner of the portico, and the terrace where she had stood with the cushions in her arms and looked down at a young man with dust on his boots. It was a different colour now, and there was a new wing at the east end, and the vineyard had been replanted, but it was the same house, and the sight of it went through her like a spear.

"Domina," Bathyllus said. "It is owned by a wine merchant now. He is away. The steward has been told that a lady from Rome may come to see the garden, and he has agreed, for a price."

"Not today."

"No."

"Tomorrow. I will go tomorrow." She turned away. "Take me to the village."

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She went up to the villa in the last hour of the afternoon, with Bathyllus and the steward and no one else.

The steward was a thin, nervous man named Faustillus who had been told that a lady from Rome wished to see the garden, and who had decided that a fee was a fee and that it was not his business to ask why. He walked ahead of her up the hill and talked about the vineyard and the new press and the difficulty of getting good labour, and Cassia walked behind him and did not hear a word.

The gate was the same gate. The hinge still squealed in the same place. The portico was the same portico, and the vine on it was a different vine, and the mosaic of dolphins in the bathhouse had been repaired again, badly, by someone who did not understand dolphins. The garden was smaller than she remembered, and the box hedges were leggy, and the fountain was dry.

"The mistress of the house is in Rome," Faustillus said. "She comes in the summer. The master is in Campania. The house is kept ready."

"Leave me," Cassia said.

"Domina—"

"Leave me. I will not steal the silver. I want to stand in the garden."

He went, reluctantly, and Cassia stood in the middle of the garden and turned around slowly, once, and the whole of it came back to her at once: the smell of the rosemary, the sound of the water from the falls, the way the light lay on the terrace in the late afternoon, the boy coming up from the vineyard with his boots dusty and his hair wet from the fountain.

She walked around the house. The kitchen door was the same. The bench by the door was the same bench, or a bench in the same place, and she stood and looked at it and remembered sitting on it with a book of poems in her lap and a young man beside her saying, *read me the one about the sparrow.*

The door to the corridor was open. She went in.

The cell at the back of the villa was a storeroom now. It had shelves in it and sacks of grain and a smell of mice. The small high window was still there. The whitewash had been redone, and the fish that a child had scratched into the

plaster was gone, covered over by a later coat, and Cassia stood in the middle of the floor and looked at the wall where it had been and put her hand flat against the plaster.

She had been eighteen years old in this room. She had been in labour in this room. She had heard her son cry in this room.

"Domina?" Faustillus, in the corridor, nervous. "Domina, is everything well?"

"Yes," Cassia said. "Everything is well. I have seen what I came to see."

She came out of the room and walked back through the garden and out of the gate, and at the gate she stopped and looked back at the house and said, to no one in particular, "It is a good house. Tell your master that a lady from Rome says it is a good house, and that he should fix the fountain."

She went down the hill to the village with the light going and the first lamps being lit in the cottages, and she did not look back again.

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The house with the fig tree stood at the end of a lane below the villaThe house with the fig tree stood at the end of a lane below the villa, where the ground flattened out and the stream ran between stone walls. It was small and old and had a tiled roof and a door painted a faded blue, and there was a chicken in the yard and a boy of six sitting on the step with a stick.

Marcella came out when she heard the carriage. She had walked back from Rome with Bathyllus and had been at the house for two days, and she looked tired and frightened and relieved all at once.

"She has been asking for you," she said. "She has not slept. She sits up in the chair by the fire and she will not go to bed."

"Take me in."

The room was low and dark and warm, and the smell of it was the smell of old age and woodsmoke and herbs. Psyche sat in a chair by the hearth with a blanket over her knees. She was smaller than Cassia remembered — much smaller, as though she had been left out in the sun too long and had shrunk — and her hands were twisted with the disease that old women get, and one eye was clouded. But the other eye was sharp and grey and it found Cassia the moment she came through the door.

"Domina," she said.

Cassia stood in the middle of the room and looked at her. Twenty-four years. She had imagined this meeting a thousand times, and in every version she had been eloquent, and in every version the old woman had wept, and in every version she had said the things that had been in her mouth for twenty-four years.

What she said was, "You told me he did not breathe."

The old woman's face worked. "I did."

"You told me he was buried under the fig tree."

"I did."

"You let them put me on a cart and send me to Puteoli, and you let me believe that my son was dead, and you have known for twenty-four years that he was alive." Cassia's voice was steady. "Why?"

"Because I was afraid," Psyche said.

"Of what?"

"Of her." The old woman's hands tightened on the blanket. "You do not know what she was like, domina. You were a girl in the kitchen. You saw her fan and her medicine box and her cold voice. I saw her in that room at night with the lamp in her hand and the child in her arms, and I saw her face when she told me what to do, and I have never in my life been so frightened of anyone." She looked at the fire. "She said that if I told you, she would have me killed. She said that if I told anyone, she would have my daughter sold and my granddaughter sold and my son-in-law put in a mine. She said that she had done worse things than that for less, and I believed her, because I had been in that house for twenty years and I knew what she was."

Cassia sat down on the stool by the fire. Her legs would not hold her.

"I have something else," Psyche said. "Something I did not put in the box."

She reached inside her dress and brought out a small folded cloth, and opened it on her knee. Inside was a curl of hair, fine and dark, tied with a thread.

"I cut it off him before she took him," she said. "I do not know why. I have never known why. I put it in my dress and I forgot about it, and I found it three days later when I was washing, and I have kept it ever since." She held it out. "It is all I have of him. I thought — I thought if I ever met you, I would give it to you. And then I thought you would kill me, and I did not know which I was more afraid of."

Cassia took the curl of hair. It was so light that she could barely feel it in her palm, and it was dark, dark as her own, not the honey colour of the young man in the yard on the Via Ostiensis. She closed her hand around it.

"His hair is lighter now," she said. "I saw him. I stood in the street and looked at him."

Psyche's face changed. "You have seen him?"

"Yes."

"Is he — is he well?"

"He is a potter. He has clay on his arms and a father who calls him in to supper and a laugh that I could hear from the street." Cassia put the curl of hair carefully into the box with the receipt. "He is alive, and he is well, and he does not know that I exist, and I am going to have to decide what to do about that."

"Tell him," Psyche said. "Tell him everything. He has a right to know."

"Does he?" Cassia closed the box. "He has a mother who died giving birth to him, as far as he knows. He has a father who raised him. If I go to him and tell him that his mother is a woman who runs a house of pleasure on the Esquiline, and that his grandmother is a murderer, and that his father is a senator who has spent twenty-four years believing him dead — what does he gain? A name? He has a name. A fortune? He has a trade. A family? He has one." She looked at the fire. "What he gains is the truth. What he loses is the life he has."

"That is not for you to decide," Psyche said.

"No," Cassia said. "It is not. But it is for me to offer, and I have been in this world long enough to know that a truth offered to a person who has not asked for it is not always a gift. Sometimes it is a stone thrown into a well." She put the box in her sleeve. "I will tell him. But I will tell him in my own time, and in my own way, and not because a frightened old woman in a chair thinks it would make her feel better."

"Tell me," she said. "From the beginning. Tell me everything."

And Psyche told her.

* * *

The night of the birth, the mistress had come to the room three times. The first time she had brought the cup. The second time she had stood in the doorway while the pains came and had said nothing at all. The third time she had come in with the steward behind her and had waited until the child was born.

"He was a fine boy," Psyche said. "Big. He came out yelling. I have delivered a hundred babies and I know a healthy one when I see it. I put him on your belly and he yelled, and you put your hand on him, and then she said, 'Give him to me.'"

"And you gave him to her."

"I gave him to her." The old woman's voice cracked. "I have thought about it every day for twenty-four years. I should have run. I should have taken him and run out of the door and down the hill. But there was a steward and there were two men in the yard and I was sixty years old and I had a daughter at home. So I gave him to her, and she wrapped him in a cloth, and she said, 'The girl is not to know. She is to be told it was stillborn. In the morning you will tell her, and you will tell her the same thing every day for the rest of your life, and if you ever tell her anything else I will know.'"

"And then?"

"And then she took him out of the room, and I gave you the poppy, and you slept. And in the morning she sent for me and she had a man with her — a dealer, a man who bought and sold children, a man named Caepio — and she gave the child to him and he gave her money and a paper, and she gave the paper to me."

"Why you?"

"Because she did not want it in the house." Psyche looked at the fire. "She said a paper in a house is a thing that can be found. She said I was to keep it, and that if I ever spoke of it she would have me killed, and that if I kept it and said nothing I would be paid a little every year, and that if I lost it she would have me killed anyway." She laughed, a dry, terrible sound. "So I kept it. I kept it under my bed for twenty-four years, and I have looked at it every year on his birthday, and I have prayed for him every day, and I have never once had the courage to go to Rome and find him."

Cassia sat very still. The fire moved. The boy outside said something to the chicken.

"Where is the grave?" she said.

"There is no grave."

"What do you mean, there is no grave?"

"There is a place under the fig tree where I dug a hole, and there is nothing in it. I put a stone there and I told the household that the child was buried, and

your mistress told the same story, and the household believed it because they wanted to." Psyche looked at her. "There is no grave, domina. There never was. Your son is not in the garden at Tibur. He is in Rome."

Cassia stood up. She walked to the window and stood with her back to the room and looked out at the yard, at the chicken, at the boy on the step, at the lane and the wall and the hill beyond.

"The paper," she said.

Psyche nodded at Marcella, who went to a chest in the corner and took out a small wooden box and brought it to Cassia. It was not the box that Bathyllus had brought to Rome. That box had come from under the old woman's bed and had been sealed with a leather strap and had contained, Cassia now understood, nothing but the things a frightened old woman keeps to remind herself that she is not mad.

This box was smaller. It had a lock. Marcella gave Cassia the key, and Cassia opened it.

Inside there was a receipt.

It was a single sheet of papyrus, folded twice, brown with age, and the ink was faded but legible. It said, in a clerk's careful hand:

*Received from the household of M. Sulpicius Corvinus, for one male infant, aged one day, of good health and no defect, the sum of four hundred sesterces. The infant is delivered to Gaius Vibidius, potter, of the Via Ostiensis, outside the Porta Trigemina, in the city of Rome, to be raised as his own. No claim upon the child shall be made by the seller or by any person on the seller's behalf. Witnessed by L. Caepio.*

And below, in a different hand, a line that had been added afterward:

*The child is called Gaius Vibidius Nestor.*

Cassia read it three times. Then she folded it and put it back in the box and closed the lid and held the box against her chest with both hands, and stood in the middle of the room with the fire behind her and the light going out of the sky, and she did not cry, because she had done her crying in a street in Rome with Tertulla's arms around her, and because there was no crying left in her now, only a hard, clear, cold thing that she recognized because she had felt it once before, on a cart on the road to Puteoli.

"Marcella," she said.

"Domina."

"Go to the inn and tell the lady Tertulla to have the notary brought from the town. Tell her I want a statement drawn up and witnessed and sealed, and I want it done tonight, before the old woman sleeps. Every word she has said. Every name. The cup, the child, the dealer, the money, the paper." She turned. "And tell Bathyllus to bring the carriage to the door at first light. We are going back to Rome tomorrow."

Psyche looked up at her. "You are not going to kill me."

"No."

"You should."

"I know." Cassia looked at her. "I have thought about it for twenty-four years. I have imagined it in a hundred ways. And now I am standing in your house with your fire at my back and your granddaughter in the next room, and I find that I cannot do it, because you are an old woman with a blanket over your knees who has been afraid for twenty-four years, and because I have spent my whole life trying not to become the sort of person who kills old women in their chairs." She put the box in her sleeve. "But I will not forgive you. Do not mistake me. I will put your statement before the Senate and I will let them decide what to do with you, and if they decide to punish you, I will not lift a finger. That is not mercy. It is arithmetic."

Psyche nodded slowly. "It is more than I deserve."

"Yes," Cassia said. "It is."

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The notary came at dusk with his tablets and his clerk and his seal, and the statement took two hours, and Psyche gave it in a steady voice with her hand on the arm of the chair and her eyes on the fire. When it was done she made her mark, and Marcella witnessed it, and Cassia witnessed it, and the notary sealed it and gave it to her with the air of a man who has just been paid a great deal of money and would like to be paid a great deal more.

They went back to the inn in the dark. Cassia did not sleep. She sat in the room with the statement on the table and the box beside it, and at midnight there was a knock at the door, and Bathyllus came in with his face set.

"Domina. There are men in the village."

"Felix's men?"

"Two of them. They came to the house with the fig tree an hour ago and asked for the old woman. Marcella told them she was asleep and would not be disturbed, and they went away, but they are at the inn at the crossroads and they have been asking about a carriage with a woman in it." He paused. "They have horses. Ours are tired. If we wait for the morning, they will follow us."

"Then we do not wait."

"Domina, the road at night is—"

"I have been on worse roads," Cassia said. "Wake the household. We leave in a quarter of an hour."

They left at midnight with the lamps lit and the horses fresh enough, and they went down the hill and onto the Via Tiburtina with the dark on either side and the stars overhead, and Bathyllus rode behind with a sword under his cloak and did not look back. They were three miles out of Tibur when the men came after them.

There were two of them, on good horses, and they came fast, and one of them shouted something that was lost in the wind. Bathyllus turned his horse and drew across the road. There was a scuffle in the dark, and the sound of hooves, and a cry, and then the carriage lurched and Tertulla caught Cassia by the arm and said, "Do not look. Do not look."

They did not stop. They went on at a gallop for a mile and then the horses were blown and they had to walk them, and Bathyllus caught them up at the milestone with blood on his face and a cut across his forearm and a riderless horse on a leading rein.

"One of them is in the ditch," he said. "The other has gone back for him. They will not follow tonight."

"You are hurt."

"It is a scratch." He wiped his face. "Domina. They were not trying to kill us. They were trying to stop the carriage. They wanted the old woman, or the paper, or both."

"They wanted the paper." Cassia put her hand on the box in her sleeve. "They will not have it."

They came into Rome at dawn, through the Porta Tiburtina, with the city waking around them and the smoke of a thousand fires going up into the grey air, and Cassia sat in the carriage with the box in her hands and the statement in her sleeve and looked at the walls of the city and thought: I have it. I have the pa-

per, and the woman, and the words. I have the truth in my hands for the first time in twenty-four years.

And then she thought: and it is not enough.

Because the truth, in Rome, was not a thing that set you free. It was a thing that had to be proved, in public, before men who had reasons of their own, and the men who had reasons of their own had money and horses and men in the palace and a fire that could be set in the night.

She came into the house on the Esquiline at the third hour, and the house was half black and half standing, and the household came out into the yard to meet her, and Thais said, "Domina, there is a letter from the Palatine."

Cassia took it. It was sealed with a raven, and the hand was Corvinus's, and it said:

*My mother is dying. She has asked for you. Come tonight. Bring what you have.*

She stood in the burnt yard with the letter in her hand and the ash under her feet and the morning light coming over the roof, and she said, "Tell the household to rest. Tell Hermeros to bring me the black book. And tell Bathyllus to have the horses ready at dusk."

"Where are we going?" Tertulla said.

"To the Palatine," Cassia said. "To see a woman who has been waiting twenty-four years to tell me the truth, and who is going to tell it to me whether she wants to or not."

CHAPTER

# THIRTEEN

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The house on the Palatine at night was a different house from the one Cassia had walked through in the daytime. The lamps were few and far between, and the corridors were full of shadows, and the masks in the atrium looked out of their cupboards with their painted eyes and their mouths that were neither smiling nor sad. She came in through the garden door with Corvinus beside her and Aemilia waiting at the end of the corridor with a lamp, and none of them said anything for a moment.

"She is bad tonight," Aemilia said. "She has been asking for you since the afternoon. She will not take the poppy, because she says it makes her stupid, and she will not have the physician, because she says he is a fool." She looked at Cassia. "She has eaten nothing since yesterday. I do not know how she is still alive."

"People like your mother-in-law do not die until they have finished what they are doing," Cassia said.

Aemilia's mouth moved. "That is the most comforting thing anyone has said to me all week."

Young Sulpicia was sitting on the stairs.

She was in her nightgown with a mantle over it and her hair loose, and she had a lamp on the step beside her and a book in her lap that she was not reading. She stood up when she saw them, and her face in the lamplight was her grandmother's face and her father's face and, in some way that Cassia could not have explained, her own.

"I heard you come in," she said.

"You should be in bed," Corvinus said.

"I am not a child."

"You are fifteen."

"I am fifteen and I am to be married in the summer, and I am the only person in this house who is not allowed to know what is happening in it." She looked at her father. "Grandmother has been asking for the lady all evening. Mother has been crying in the garden. There is a notary in the tablinum, and the slaves have been told to stay out of the west wing, and there is a woman in a burnt dress standing in our atrium." She turned to Cassia. "You are the woman."

"I am the woman," Cassia said.

"You are also the woman from the wine shop."

"Yes."

Her father looked from one to the other. "You have met?"

"At the Lupercalia," Sulpicia said. "I went to see her house and she caught me in the street and gave me hot wine and told me I was too young to know the truth." She lifted her chin. "I am not too young now."

Cassia looked at her. The girl was frightened; she could see it in the way she held the lamp, in the way her free hand was clenched at her side. But she was standing in the corridor of a house full of secrets and asking to be let in, and Cassia had done the same thing, once, at eighteen, in a garden, with a boy who came to the kitchen for bread.

"Your grandmother is dying," Cassia said. "She is going to tell us some things tonight that will be difficult to hear, and some of them are about your father, and some of them are about me, and some of them are about a boy who is twenty-four years old and who has nothing to do with any of this. You may come in, if your father permits it. But you will not speak until you are spoken to, and you will not repeat a word of what you hear to anyone, and when it is over you will go to bed and you will not ask me any questions until the morning."

Sulpicia looked at her father. Corvinus looked at Cassia, and then at his daughter, and his face did something complicated.

"Come," he said.

They went up the stairs together, and the room at the end of the corridor was lit with three lamps and a brazier, and the heat of it came out into the passage like a hand. Sulpicia Varia was propped up on her pillows with her hair in two thin braids and her hands on the coverlet, and the flesh had gone from her face so completely that she looked like a carving of herself, all bone and intention.

"Sit down," she said. "All of you. You look like a delegation."

Corvinus sat on the stool by the bed. Aemilia stood by the door with her arms folded. Cassia sat in the chair at the foot of the bed, where she could see the old woman's face and the old woman could see hers.

"You have brought the paper," Sulpicia said.

"I have brought the paper."

"Let me see it."

Cassia took the receipt from her sleeve and unfolded it and held it up. The old woman looked at it for a long time. Then she closed her eyes.

"Four hundred sesterces," she said. "I remember. I thought it was cheap."

The room was very quiet. The brazier ticked. Somewhere in the house a door closed, and a slave went past in the corridor with soft feet.

"I have been trying to decide," Sulpicia Varia said, "whether I am sorry." She opened her eyes. "I have had twenty-four years to decide, and I find that I am not. I am not sorry that I did it. I am sorry that it was necessary. There is a difference, and I would like you to understand it, because I am going to die in this room and I would like at least one person in it to understand me."

"Explain it," Cassia said.

"Your son was a scandal. A bastard child of a slave girl, born in a villa, with a father who was twenty years old and a fool. If the child had lived, my husband would have sold him or exposed him, and he would have died in a ditch, or he would have been raised a slave and sold south, and you would have been sold with him. I did what I did to save the family, and I did it to save the child, and I did it to save you, though you will not believe that." She looked at Cassia. "The man I gave him to was a potter with no children and a good trade. I had him investigated. I knew his name and his wife's name and the name of the street he lived in. I chose him because he was kind. I chose him because he would raise the boy as his own and the boy would grow up with a roof and a trade and a father, instead of a brothel and a grave."

"You sold a child," Cassia said.

"I saved a child."

"You sold my son for four hundred sesterces and you told me he was dead."

"Would you have preferred the truth? Would you have preferred to be sold to Puteoli knowing that your son was alive in Rome and that you would never see him?" The old woman's voice was thin and fierce. "I gave you a mercy. I gave

you a clean grief. I gave you the only thing a woman in your position could have been given, which was the ability to believe that the child was out of pain. And you have spent twenty-four years hating me for it, and I have spent twenty-four years knowing that you would hate me, and I did it anyway."

"I would have come for him," Cassia said. "I would have crawled out of Puteoli on my hands and knees. I would have found him and taken him and raised him in a room above a bakery and I would have been poor and I would have been nothing and he would have been mine."

"And he would have been a freedwoman's bastard in the Subura, with no name and no trade and no future, and every man who came to your door would have known what his mother was." Sulpicia Varia's eyes were wet. "You are a rich woman now, domina. You have a house and a fortune and the ear of half the Senate. But you were not rich then. You had nothing. You had a body and a debt. And I took the child out of that, and I gave him to a man who could raise him, and I have paid for it every day for twenty-four years, and I would do it again."

Cassia stood up. She walked to the window and stood with her back to the room and looked out at the dark garden and the lights of the city beyond it.

"His name is Gaius Vibidius Nestor," she said. "He works with his father. He has clay on his arms and a laugh that carries into the street. He is twenty-four years old and he does not know that any of us exist." She turned. "You took that from me. Not the poverty. Not the shame. The years. You took twenty-four years of him, and you cannot give them back, and no amount of explaining will make me forgive you."

"I do not want your forgiveness."

"Then what do you want?"

Sulpicia Varia looked at her for a long moment. The brazier ticked. The lamps burned.

"I have spent my life in this house," Sulpicia Varia said, "and I have watched it eat people. It ate my husband, and it ate my son's youth, and it ate my daughter-in-law's happiness, and it would have eaten you if I had let it." She looked at Cassia. "You think I am a monster. I have thought so myself, on some nights. But I am a woman who was given a house and a name and a husband, and I was told that my duty was to keep them, and I did what I had to do to keep

them, and the world did not offer me any other way to be a good woman than that."

"There was another way," Cassia said. "You could have let me go. You could have given me money and a passage to somewhere and let me take the child."

"And my husband would have found you. He had men. He had money. He would have found you within the month, and he would have taken the child and had you sold, and he would have done it in a way that would have made him feel like a just man." The old woman's voice was thin. "I knew him, domina. I knew him better than anyone alive. He was a man who could not bear to be disobeyed, and he would have hunted you to the ends of the earth, and when he found you he would have made an example of you. I did not save you because I could not save you. I saved the child because I could."

"You did not save him. You sold him."

"I sold him to a potter for four hundred sesterces, and I paid the dealer another two hundred to forget the address, and I have spent twenty-four years paying that man every year to keep his mouth shut." Sulpicia Varia's hands were shaking on the coverlet. "Do you think I do not know what it sounds like? Do you think I have not lain in this bed on a hundred nights and heard it in my own voice? I sold a child. I sold your child. I did it because the alternative was worse, and I have never been able to explain to anyone why the alternative was worse, because the only person who would have understood it is dead."

Corvinus stood up. "Mother—"

"Sit down." Her eyes did not leave Cassia's. "I am not asking for your absolution. I am telling you that I know what I did, and that I would do it again, and that I am sorry for the girl in the room and not sorry for the woman in this bed. You may make of that what you like."

"I want you to save my son," she said.

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The statement took an hour. Cassia had brought the notary from Tibur with her — the same nervous man, who had been paid enough to be brave — and he sat at the table by the window with his tablets and his seal and wrote down every word, and the old woman gave it all: the cup, the night, the dealer, the receipt, the payment, the threats, the twenty-four years of silence.

She did not confess to killing her husband. When the notary asked, she said, "I have nothing to say about that," and looked at Cassia with her cold pale eyes and said, "That is a different matter, and it belongs to a different paper, and I will give it when I am ready."

"You may not have time," Cassia said.

"Then you had better pray that I do."

The notary sealed the statement and gave it to Cassia, and Cassia put it in her sleeve with the receipt, and Sulpicia Varia lay back on her pillows and closed her eyes, and for a moment she looked like any old woman, tired and small and finished.

"Corvinus," she said, without opening her eyes.

"Yes, mother."

"Come here."

He went and knelt by the bed, and she put her hand on his head, the way a woman blesses a child, and her fingers moved once through his hair.

"You were a good boy," she said. "You were a better boy than your father deserved and a better man than I made you. Whatever happens, remember that I did what I did because I loved this house, and because I loved you, and because I did not know how to love anything else." Her hand fell back to the coverlet. "Now go away, all of you. I want to sleep."

They went out. In the corridor Aemilia said, "I will stay with her tonight," and went back in with her lamp, and Corvinus stood in the passage with his hand against the wall and his head bowed.

Cassia stood beside him and did not touch him.

"Come," she said. "I have somewhere to go."

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The Temple of Juno Lucina stood on the Cispian Hill, in a grove of old trees, and it was one of the oldest temples in Rome. Women went there to ask for children, and to give thanks for children, and to mourn children, and the temple was full of the small terracotta figures that mothers left: babies in swaddling clothes, hands, feet, eyes, the parts of the body that had been healed. There was a stone bench outside the door and a fountain, and the priestess was a freedwoman of sixty named Calpurnia, who had been in the temple since she was four-

teen and who knew more about the women of Rome than any magistrate in the city.

They came at the ninth hour, when the temple was empty and the lamps were being lit. Cassia had brought the lock of hair and a small cake and a jar of milk, because she had asked Thais what one brought to Juno Lucina and Thais had told her, and she stood at the altar with the offerings in her hands and found that she did not know what to say.

The priestess came and stood beside her.

"You have never been here before," she said.

"No."

"I would remember. I remember all of them." Calpurnia looked at the lock of hair in Cassia's palm. "How old?"

"Twenty-four years."

The priestess did not move. "And you are only now bringing him?"

"I only now know that he lived."

Calpurnia was silent for a moment. Then she took Cassia's hand and turned it over and looked at the lock of hair in it, and her face was not kind and not unkind; it was the face of a woman who has heard everything and has decided to keep listening.

"Put it on the altar," she said. "Tell the goddess what you have come to tell her. She has heard worse."

Cassia put the lock of hair on the altar with the cake and the milk. Then she stood there with her hands at her sides and said, in a voice that did not sound like her own, "I have a son. His name is Gaius Vibidius Nestor. He is a potter on the Via Ostiensis, and he is alive, and I have not seen him since the night he was born. I am told that he is well. I am told that he is happy. I do not know if that is true, because I have only seen him from the street." She stopped. The lamp on the altar moved in a draught. "I do not know what I am asking for. I do not think I am asking for anything. I think I am telling you because there is no one else I can tell."

The priestess said, "That is what the goddess is for."

"I thought the goddess was for children."

"The goddess is for women. Children are only one of the things that happen to them." Calpurnia picked up the cake and put it in the fire, and the smell of it went up with the smoke. "I had three children. Two died in the first year and

one lived to be a soldier and died in Dacia. I have been a priestess for forty-six years and I have listened to women tell me things they could not tell their husbands or their mothers or their gods. Do you know what they all say, in the end?"

"No."

"They say, 'I did what I could.'" Calpurnia turned. "And they are usually right. Not always. Some of them did what they wanted and called it what they could. But most of them, most of the time, did what they could with what they had, and the world took the rest." She looked at Cassia. "You did what you could. You were eighteen years old and you were a slave and you were in a room with a bolted door. There was nothing you could have done. And now you are a rich woman with a house and a name and money, and there is a great deal you can do. That is the difference between then and now. Not the guilt. The power."

Cassia looked at the altar. The lock of hair was beginning to singe at the edges, and the smell of burning hair was in the air with the smell of the cake.

"I do not feel powerful," she said.

"No," the priestess said. "No one ever does. That is how you know you are using it well."

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They went back to the house on the Esquiline, what was left of it, and Cassia had the strongroom opened and the black book brought out and set on the table in the small dining room with the three Graces looking down from the alcove. The burnt smell was still in the walls, and the roof over the kitchen wing was a patch of new tiles, and the storeroom was a black hole with a plank across it.

Corvinus stood in the doorway and looked at the room.

"It is a good house," he said.

"It was a good house. Now it is a good house with a hole in it." Cassia sat down and opened the black book. "Sit. We have work to do."

He sat. She turned the pages.

"Here," she said. "Felix. He has given me a statement, and the statement names Pactus and Sittius, and the payment, and the petition. Here. Psyche. She has given me a statement, and it names your mother and the dealer and the receipt, and it establishes that the child lived. Here. The receipt itself, which

names the potter and the child." She looked up. "And here, at the back, everything I know about Sittius, and his brother-in-law, and the annona, and the mortgage on your house. If we put all of it before the consul at the preliminary hearing, we can have the accusation dismissed and the delation turned back on the men who paid for it."

"Can we?"

"Yes. If we do it carefully, and if your mother gives us the other paper, and if nothing else goes wrong." Cassia closed the book. "But there is a problem."

"Only one?"

"Three. The first is Felix. He has given us a statement, but he is a delator, and a delator's word is worth very little in a court, and the moment Pactus offers him more money than I have promised him, he may change his mind. So we need to make it impossible for him to change his mind. We need a second witness who can corroborate the payment, and we need it in writing."

"Sittius's clerk."

"Sittius's clerk." Cassia nodded. "The second problem is your mother. Her statement about the child is good, but it does not clear you of parricide. In fact, it makes it worse, because it establishes that there was a death in that house that night and that she was in the room when it happened. If she does not confess to the poisoning, the prosecution will say that you did it, and that she is covering for you, and there is no paper in the world that will prove otherwise."

Corvinus was silent. Then he said, "She will confess."

"How do you know?"

"Because she is dying, and because she is proud, and because she has spent her whole life arranging things so that she would be remembered well." He looked at the table. "And because I asked her, in the corridor, before we left. I asked her to give the paper. She said she would think about it."

"Then we need the third thing," Cassia said.

"What is the third thing?"

"You." She looked at him. "You have to decide what you are going to say when they ask you about the child. Not about the murder. About the boy. Because the moment the receipt is read in that chamber, every man in the Senate will know that you had a son by a slave and that your mother sold him. They will not care about the law. They will care about the scandal, and they will use it, and it will be in every wine shop in Rome by the evening."

"I know."

"Do you? Because there is a way to do this that keeps the boy out of it. We can put the midwife's statement before the court in a closed session, and the receipt can be sealed, and the court can hear the evidence without the city hearing it. The accusation would be dismissed for lack of proof, and the boy's name would never be spoken in public." She paused. "Or we can do it the other way. We can put the whole thing before the Senate and the people, and let them see what your mother did and what Sittius paid for, and we can destroy Pactus and the banker in one afternoon. But the boy's name will be in every mouth in Rome, and his father's shop will be a place that people come to look at, and he will have to decide, at twenty-four years old, whether he wants to be a potter or a scandal."

Corvinus looked at her for a long time. The lamps burned. The three Graces looked down from the alcove with their painted hands on one another's shoulders.

"What do you want?" he said.

"I want the boy left alone," Cassia said. "I want him to have his life. I have waited twenty-four years to find him and I am not going to hand him to the city to be chewed up in the Forum." She closed the black book. "But I want Pactus destroyed more, and I want the men who burned my house to pay for it, and I want the truth to be told in a place where it cannot be buried again." She looked up. "So I am going to ask you to choose, and I am going to ask you to choose as a father and not as a senator."

Corvinus sat with his hands on the table. He was forty-five years old, and he had spent his whole life in the Senate, and he had never in that life been asked to choose between his family and his name.

"Can we do both?" he said.

"No."

"Then I choose the boy," he said. "The closed session. The sealed receipt. The truth told to the men who need to hear it and to no one else." He looked up. "And afterward, when it is over, I will go to the Via Ostiensis and I will stand in the street and look at him, the way you did, and I will decide then whether I have the right to speak to him."

Cassia looked at him. Then she reached across the table and took his hand.

"All right," she said. "Then that is what we will do."

Later, when the book was closed and the household had gone to bed, he came to her room.

She was sitting on the edge of the bed with her hair down and her hands in her lap, and she did not get up when he came in. He stood in the doorway for a moment and then came and sat beside her, and neither of them said anything for a long time.

"There is a room in this house," she said, "where I have never let anyone sleep. It is the room at the top of the stairs with the window that looks over the garden. I have kept it empty for twenty-four years. I told myself it was for guests. It was not for guests."

"I know," he said.

"I do not know what to do with it now. If he does not want to come. If he does not want to know us. If he is happy in his father's shop and his father's house and the life he has made." She turned to him. "What do I do with the room?"

"You leave it empty," Corvinus said. "And you wait. And if he never comes, you give it to someone else who needs it, and you do not make it a shrine, because a shrine is a thing that eats the people who keep it."

Cassia laughed, and it hurt. "You sound like the priestess."

"I sound like a man who has spent twenty-four years keeping a shrine." He took her hand. "I have a room in my house too. It is not a room. It is a name I do not say, and a year I do not think about, and a woman I do not look at in a crowd. I have carried it so long that I do not know what I would be without it."

"You would be a senator with a wife and two children and a house that is falling down and a mother who murdered your father."

"Yes," he said. "And I would be free."

She kissed him. It was not the desperate kiss of the garden room at Tertulla's house, and it was not the kiss of the vineyard. It was slower, and sadder, and it had in it the knowledge that they were both forty-something and both damaged and both standing in a burnt house with the smell of smoke in the walls.

Afterward she lay in the dark with her head on his shoulder and listened to the house. The window was open and the night air was cold and clean, and somewhere out in the city a dog was barking, and somewhere on the Via Ostiensis a young man was asleep, and she thought about the fact that she had found

him, and that she could not have him, and that there was a kind of peace in that, and a kind of grief, and that they were the same thing.

"Lucius," she said.

"Yes."

"When this is over. When the trial is done and the boy has decided what he wants and your mother is dead and the house is sold or saved. What will you do?"

He was silent for a long time. "I do not know. I have never been able to imagine a life after this. I have been living toward this for twenty-four years without knowing it." He turned his head. "What will you do?"

"I will keep the house," Cassia said. "I will keep the house and the people in it and the business and the books. And I will go to the baths on Sundays and I will dine with Tertulla and I will grow old and I will be rich and I will be lonely in the way that rich old women are lonely, and I will be all right."

"That is a very sad answer."

"It is a very honest one." She closed her eyes. "I have been lonely for twenty-four years. It is not the worst thing in the world. The worst thing is being lonely and poor."

They sat there for a long time in the burnt house with the lamps burning and the book open between them, and outside the city went on with its noise, and somewhere on the Via Ostiensis a young man was going to bed in a room over a workshop, and he did not know that two people in Rome had just decided the shape of his life.

CHAPTER

# FOURTEEN

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The games were given in April, in the new amphitheatre in the Campus Martius, and they were given by the emperor in honour of the dedication of the forum, which had been dedicated in January, and which no one in the crowd remembered by April, because a crowd remembers only the last spectacle and the next one.

Cassia had a seat in the second tier, on the women's side, with Tertulla and Thais and a cushion she had brought from home because the stone was cold in the morning. She had been to the games a hundred times. She had watched men kill each other in the morning and beasts kill each other at noon and men kill beasts in the afternoon, and she had learned, over the years, to watch the crowd instead of the sand, because the crowd was the real spectacle, and because a woman who understands a crowd can predict a great deal about a city.

The Sulpicii had a box on the senatorial side, near the front, with the other consular families. Corvinus was there in his white toga with the purple border, and Aemilia beside him in a dress the colour of wine, and Sulpicia between them, and Publius behind, and the whole box was a picture of a family that had nothing to hide. Cassia looked at it once and then looked away, and did not look at it again for a long time, because she had discovered that looking at a thing you cannot have is a way of torturing yourself, and she had had enough of that.

Pactus was three boxes along, with his wife and his brother and a group of clients, and he was laughing at something, and his laugh carried across the stone.

"He is very cheerful," Tertulla said.

"He has reason to be."

"Has he?"

"Felix was arrested this morning."

Tertulla turned her head. "What?"

"On a charge of calumny. The urban prefect's men took him from his house at dawn and sealed the door. His wife and children are with his sister on the Aventine." Cassia watched the sand. "Sittius's lawyer laid the information. They are calling it an extortion, a false accusation laid for money, and they have a witness who will swear that Felix demanded three hundred thousand sesterces from the senator Corvinus and threatened him with a prosecution if he did not pay."

"That is true."

"Yes. It is entirely true. That is the beauty of it." Cassia turned her cup in her hands. "A true thing can be used to destroy a man just as easily as a false one. They are not prosecuting him for the accusation. They are prosecuting him for the extortion. And once he is convicted of extortion, his evidence against them is worthless, because a convicted delator cannot be a witness, and the whole case against Corvinus falls apart — and with it, everything he knows about Sittius and Pactus and the money."

Tertulla was silent for a moment. "Then we have lost."

"We have lost our witness. We have not lost the case." Cassia looked at the sand. "I have the midwife's statement, and the receipt, and the notary's seal. I have the banker's own words, though I cannot prove them. And I have something else."

"What?"

"The truth," Cassia said. "It is not worth much in a courtroom. But it is worth something in a city."

The trumpets sounded. The crowd rose. The emperor came into his box with his guard behind him, and the whole amphitheatre stood and cheered, and the sound was like a wave breaking over stones, and Cassia stood with the rest and cheered too, because she was a woman who had learned that a person who does not cheer in a crowd is a person whom the crowd remembers.

"They have announced the betrothal," Tertulla said, quietly.

Cassia did not look at the box. "To whom?"

"Aulus Proculus. The herald read it out before the first fight, with the other notices. The marriage will be in June, and the dowry is the vineyard in Etruria, which is mortgaged to Sittius, and the bridegroom's father is to pay the debts." Tertulla's mouth twisted. "It is a very good match for a family with no money and a scandal coming. It is a very bad match for a girl of fifteen with a mind of her own."

Cassia looked at the box then, and at the girl in the wine-coloured dress sitting between her parents with her hands folded and her face perfectly composed, and thought about a wine shop in the Subura and a girl in a blue cloak who had wanted to know what she was marrying into.

"She knows," Tertulla said. "Look at her. She is sitting there like a Vestal at a funeral, and she is fifteen, and she knows exactly what her grandmother has sold her for."

"Then she will survive it."

"Will she?"

"Yes," Cassia said. "She has the hardness. You can see it in the way she holds her shoulders." She looked away. "It is not a good thing to be hard at fifteen. But it is better than the alternative."

The games began. In the morning there were the hunters, men with spears and nets against lions and bears, and a bull that went mad and had to be killed by six men with spears, and a leopard that escaped its handlers and ran around the arena with the crowd screaming with laughter until it was caught in a net. At noon there was an execution: three men condemned for treason, thrown to the beasts without weapons, and the crowd watched with the particular attention it reserved for death without skill. One of the men fought; the other two stood and waited, and the beasts took them quickly, and the sand was raked over, and the crowd called for the afternoon.

At the midday break a woman came down the steps of the women's gallery and sat beside Cassia without asking permission.

She was fifty, dressed in good but not expensive wool, with a plain face and red eyes and hands that would not keep still in her lap. Cassia knew her by sight; everyone in the second tier knew her by sight, because she was the wife of a man who had been a magistrate and had lost everything in a prosecution fifteen years before, and because she had spent the years since then doing penance in public.

"Domina," the woman said. "I am Junia. My husband was Lucius Junius, who was praetor in the year of the consulship of Silanus."

"I remember."

"Then you know what happened to us."

"I know that your husband was accused and that he lost his property and that he died the year after." Cassia turned. "What do you want?"

"I want to tell you something." Junia's hands twisted. "My husband was accused by Felix. Felix built the case out of nothing — a letter, a clerk, a slave who was promised his freedom. My husband was innocent. He was acquitted of everything but a technicality, and the technicality ruined him, and the state took the house, and the man who bought the house at a fraction of its value was a banker on the Via Lata." She looked at Cassia. "The same banker, domina. I have been watching him for fifteen years. I have been watching all of them."

Cassia was very still.

"Why are you telling me this?"

"Because my son is a clerk in the office of the urban prefect, and he told me last night that Felix is to be charged with extortion, and that the charge was laid by the same banker's lawyer, and that the whole thing is a trap." Junia's eyes were bright and hard. "And because I have hated that man for fifteen years and I have never had the power to do anything about it, and now there is a woman in this city who does."

"What can you give me?"

"Names. Dates. The deeds of the house he bought. The testimony of a clerk who is still alive and still frightened." Junia leaned closer. "And one thing more. Fifteen years ago, when Felix built his case against my husband, he used a forger. A man named Secundus, who lives now in a village near Fidenae, and who is dying of a disease of the lungs, and who told me last year, when he thought he was dying, that he had done it, and that he was sorry, and that he would swear to it in a court if anyone would listen."

Cassia looked at the woman beside her, and at the crowd, and at the sand where the beasts had died, and she felt the shape of the whole thing come together in her mind like a key turning in a lock.

"Write it down," she said. "Everything. Names, dates, the deed, the forger. Bring it to my house tonight, by the garden door, and I will pay you for your trouble, and your son will not be named in any of it."

Junia's face worked. "I do not want money."

"Everyone wants money. It is the only thing in Rome that everyone wants." Cassia put her hand on the woman's wrist. "Take the money. It will make you feel less like a suppliant, and it will make me feel less like a benefactor, and we will both be able to look at each other afterwards."

In the afternoon there were the gladiators.

Cassia had seen a thousand gladiators. She had seen the famous ones and the forgettable ones and the ones who died badly and the ones who died well. She had seen the crowd turn on a man who refused to die and the crowd turn on a man who killed too quickly, and she had learned that a crowd at the games is not a crowd of murderers; it is a crowd of people who have been told that this is the place where death is allowed, and who are discovering, together, what they are capable of.

The day's favourite was a retiarius named Bato, a big man with a net and a trident and a following of women who screamed his name, and he fought a murmillo called Niger who had been brought from Gaul and had a helmet with a fish on it. They fought for a long time. Bato was faster. Niger was stronger. The crowd began to shout, and the shouting turned into a rhythm, and the rhythm turned into a single voice, and the voice wanted blood.

Bato caught Niger in the net and knocked him down and stood over him with the trident at his throat, and the crowd screamed, and the referee looked to the emperor, and the emperor, who was tired, made the gesture that meant mercy, and the crowd groaned, and Bato lifted the trident and stepped back and offered his hand, and Niger, who was bleeding from the shoulder and the leg, took it, and the two men walked off the sand together to a storm of shouting and a great deal of thrown money.

"Mercy," Tertulla said. "There is a novelty."

"The emperor is in a good mood," Cassia said. "He has a forum and a bridge and a war coming in the East. He can afford to be merciful in April."

"He will not be merciful in May."

The fourth fight was between two men who had been condemned to the arena for crimes and had been given swords and no training, and it was the kind of fight that the crowd loved and that Cassia could not watch. One of them was killed within a minute. The other stood over the body with the sword in his hand and his face turned up to the crowd, and the crowd screamed at him, and he did not move, and after a long moment the referee took him by the arm and led him off the sand, and he went like a man in a dream.

"He will not live the year," Tertulla said.

"Who?"

"The one who won. They always kill themselves, the ones who are not gladiators. They cannot go back to whatever they were, and they cannot stay in the

arena, and there is nothing in between." She looked at the sand. "It is a very Roman thing, to give a man a sword and then take away every reason to use it."

Cassia said nothing. She was thinking about a boy on the Via Ostiensis with clay on his arms, and about the fact that he had a trade and a father and a laugh that carried into the street, and about how thin the line was between a life like that and a life like the man on the sand.

"No," Cassia said. "He will not."

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Between the third and fourth fights there was an interval, and the crowd stood and stretched and went to the food sellers and the latrines and the fountains, and Cassia went out into the corridor behind the women's gallery to get away from the noise.

Pactus was there.

He was standing by a column with a cup of wine in his hand and two of his clients at a distance, and he was looking at her as though he had known she would come out into that corridor at that moment. He probably had. He was a man who arranged things.

"Domina," he said. "A word."

"I have no words for you."

"Then listen to mine." He came closer. "Felix is in a cell under the prefect's house, and tomorrow he will be charged, and in a month he will be convicted, and after that he will be a man with a brand on his record and no one will ever believe a word he says again. Your witness is gone. Your case is gone. The only thing you have left is a midwife and a piece of paper, and a midwife can be discredited and a piece of paper can be called a forgery." He drank his wine. "I am offering you a way out."

"There is no way out of a hole you dug."

"I did not dig it. Your senator's father dug it, twenty-four years ago, when he put a child in a slave and his wife put a cup in his wine." Pactus's face was pleasant. "I know about the cup, domina. I have known for a month. I have a statement from the physician's assistant that says the old man's death was not natural, and I have another from the steward that says the wife was in the room, and I have been saving them, because a good prosecutor does not show his hand until the last moment."

Cassia's face did not change. "Then why are you offering me a way out?"

"Because I do not want to destroy the Sulpicii. I want the Asian command. There is a difference." He set his cup down on the ledge. "Withdraw the midwife. Seal the receipt. Let the accusation die for lack of evidence, and I will let the senator retire from public life with his name and his house and his family, and I will take the province, and everyone will be satisfied. The alternative is a trial. And in a trial, everything comes out. The cup. The child. The brothel. The boy on the Via Ostiensis." He smiled. "I have not been to see him. I have been saving him, as your friend Felix was saving him. But I will go, if I have to. And when I have finished with him, he will not be a potter any more. He will be the bastard of a senator and a whore, and every man in Rome will know it, and he will have to leave the city to escape it."

Cassia looked at him. She was aware, in a distant way, that her hands were cold and that her heart was going very fast and that the noise of the crowd in the corridor was like the noise of the sea.

"Say his name," she said.

"What?"

"Say his name. You have been talking about him for a minute. Say his name."

Pactus's smile did not change. "I do not know his name."

"Then you do not know him, and you cannot destroy him, and you have just told me that you are bluffing." Cassia stepped closer to him. "You are a new man, Pactus. You have spent your whole life being afraid that someone would find out that your grandfather was a farmer and your father was a tax collector. You have borrowed money you cannot repay and made promises you cannot keep, and you have hired a delator and a banker and an arsonist, and now you are standing in a corridor at the games telling a woman that you will destroy a boy you have never met." She smiled. "I have known men like you all my life. You are not dangerous. You are frightened. And frightened men make mistakes."

Pactus's face changed. It was a small change, a tightening around the mouth, and it was the first honest thing she had seen on it.

"You will regret this," he said.

"I have regretted worse," Cassia said, and walked away.

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She came back to her seat and the games went on, and she did not see any of it. She sat with her hands in her lap and her eyes on the sand and her mind on the boy, and after a while Tertulla leaned over and said, "You are pale. What did he say?"

"He threatened the boy."

"Then we go to the boy."

"We cannot. If we go to him, we make him visible. If we are seen at that shop, every man in Rome will know who he is by the Ides." Cassia looked at the sand. "We need another way."

"What way?"

"I do not know yet." She stood. "I am going home. Tell Thais to meet me there. Tell Hermeros to bring the black book and the household accounts and every letter I have ever received from a man in the Senate. And tell Bathyllus to find the boy's father — the potter, Gaius Vibidius — and bring him to the house tonight, by the garden door, and tell him nothing except that a lady wishes to speak to him about his son."

"His son?"

"His son," Cassia said. "The boy is twenty-four years old and his father is a potter who loves him, and if anyone is going to protect him from the men who want to use him, it will not be me. It will be the man who raised him."

She went out through the dark corridor and down the stairs into the street, and the roar of the crowd followed her out into the daylight, and behind her, in the amphitheatre, a man was dying on the sand for the pleasure of fifty thousand people who would forget him by supper.

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Felix's wife came at the seventh hour.

She came to the garden door with her two children and a bundle and no slave, and Bathyllus came to the tablinum with a face like a man who has been asked to choose between two duties.

"Domina. There is a woman at the door. She says she is the wife of the man Felix."

Cassia put down her pen. "Bring her in."

She was younger than Cassia had expected — thirty, perhaps, with the worn prettiness of a woman who has been pretty and has had no time for it lately —

and she came into the tablinum with a child on either side and her chin up and her eyes red.

"You are the woman my husband made the agreement with," she said.

"I am."

"He is in a cell under the prefect's house. They will not let me see him. They have sealed the door of our house and taken everything, and my sister will not have us any longer than a week, and I have no money and no one to turn to." Her voice was steady. "He told me, before they took him, that if anything happened I was to come to you. He said you were the only person in Rome who had ever kept a promise to him. He said you had signed a paper with your seal on it, and that the paper said his children would never want."

Cassia looked at the two children. The boy was nine, with his father's sharp face and his mother's eyes. The girl was six, and she was holding her mother's hand and staring at the three Graces on the wall.

"Show me the paper," Cassia said.

The woman took it from her sleeve. It was the agreement, sealed with Cassia's ring, and it was creased and soft from being carried against the body.

Cassia read it, and then she folded it and gave it back.

"Thais," she said. "Take the lady and the children to the room at the top of the stairs. The one with the window over the garden. Have Narcissus look at them. Have Celer make something hot. They are to stay until I say otherwise, and no one is to know they are here."

The woman stared at her. "You are giving us the room at the top of the stairs?"

"Yes."

"I thought —" She stopped. "I thought you would give us money and send us away."

"I thought so too," Cassia said. "It seems I am not the woman I was."

The potter came at the ninth hour, alone, with clay still under his fingernails and the look of a man who has been told that a lady wishes to speak to him about his son and has spent the afternoon imagining the worst.

Gaius Vibidius was fifty and broad and grey and entirely without pretension. He had a good, plain face, the face of a man who works with his hands and sleeps well, and he stood in the tablinum of the House of the Graces with his cap

in his hands and did not look at the silver or the paintings or the three Graces in the alcove.

"Domina," he said. "What has my boy done?"

"Nothing," Cassia said. "Sit down. There is wine, and there is a great deal to tell you, and none of it is his fault."

He sat. He did not drink the wine. And Cassia told him.

She told him about the villa at Tibur, and the girl in the kitchen, and the son who was born in a cell, and the woman who took him out of the room. She told him about the receipt, and the four hundred sesterces, and the dealer named Caepio, and the twenty-four years. She did not tell him everything. She did not tell him about the cup, or the trial, or the men who wanted to use the boy to destroy a senator. She told him enough.

The potter listened without moving. When she had finished, he sat for a long time with his hands on his knees.

"I bought him," he said at last. "From a man in the Forum. My wife could not have children, and we had prayed, and we had gone to the temple, and a man told us there was a child to be had, and we paid for him, and we took him home." He looked up. "I did not know he was stolen. I want you to understand that. I thought he was a foundling, or the child of a woman who could not keep him. I did not know he was taken from his mother."

"He was not stolen from me," Cassia said. "He was taken. There is a difference, and I do not hold you responsible for it."

"He is my son," the potter said.

"I know."

"I have raised him for twenty-four years. I taught him the wheel and the kiln and the price of clay. He calls me father." His voice was steady, and his hands were not. "I am not going to give him up because a lady in a big house has decided that she wants him back."

"I am not asking you to give him up." Cassia leaned forward. "I am asking you to protect him. There are men in this city who want to use him to destroy a senator, and if they cannot use him they may hurt him, and I cannot protect him from the inside of my own house because I am the woman they are trying to destroy. You can. You are his father. You can take him out of the city for a month, to the country, to a workshop somewhere, and you can keep him safe until this is over."

The potter looked at her. "And after it is over?"

"After it is over," Cassia said, "he can decide for himself whether he wants to know me. I will not come to your shop. I will not send for him. I will not tell him who I am. That is his to decide, when he is ready, and if he is never ready, then I will live with it." She paused. "But I would like to know that he is alive. That is all. A message, once a year, from you, to say that he is alive."

Gaius Vibidius looked at her for a long time. Then he picked up the cup of wine and drank it off, and set it down, and said, "You are not what I expected."

"What did you expect?"

"I do not know. A lady." He wiped his mouth. "He looks like you, you know. Around the eyes. I have seen it for years and I never knew what it was, and now I know." He stood. "I will take him to my brother's workshop at Praeneste. He will not like it; he has a girl in Ostia and he will complain about the clay. But he will go, because he is a good boy, and because I will tell him that the workshop needs him." He put on his cap. "And domina. When this is over. If he wants to know you. I will not stand in his way."

Cassia stood. "Thank you."

"Do not thank me. I have not done anything yet." He went to the door. "But I will tell you one thing. If you had come to my shop twenty-four years ago and asked for him, I would have given him to you. I would have hated it. But I would have given him to you, because he was yours before he was mine." He went out.

Cassia stood in the tablinum for a long time. Then she sat down and put her head in her hands, and Thais came in and stood beside her, and the house was quiet.

"The hearing is set," Thais said. "The consul's clerk sent word. The sixth day before the Kalends of July."

Cassia looked up. "Then we have three weeks."

"Three weeks," Thais said, "and one witness in a cell, and a banker with a lawyer, and a senator with a dying mother and a burnt house and a boy he has never met."

"Yes," Cassia said. "Three weeks."

There was a letter from the Palatine on the table, in Corvinus's hand.

*The notary has been again. My mother has given the second paper. She dictated it in the morning and signed it in the afternoon and then she slept for six*

*hours, which the physician says is a bad sign. She has asked for you. She says she has something else to tell you and that she will not tell it to me. I do not know what else there is. I am beginning to think that I have never known my mother at all.*

*The hearing is set for the sixth day before the Kalends of July. Pactus has been seen at the palace twice. Sittius has left the city for his villa at Baiae, which means he intends to be far away when it happens, and that he expects it to happen.*

*I am not afraid of the trial. I am afraid of what will be left of us afterwards. I have spent my whole life being a Sulpicius. I do not know how to be anything else.*

*L.*

Cassia read it twice. Then she folded it and put it in the drawer with the other letter, the one that had been in the cedar box for twenty-four years, and she sat for a moment with her hand on the drawer.

Then she took out a clean sheet of paper and wrote:

*You will learn. It is not as difficult as it looks. You begin by putting one foot in front of the other and doing the next necessary thing, and you do it again the next day, and after a while you find that you have become someone else, and that the someone else is not so bad.*

*I will come to the Palatine tomorrow. Tell your mother to save whatever she has to say. I have a great deal to do and very little time, and I am not going to spend it listening to an old woman's riddles.*

*C.*

She sanded the letter and sealed it and gave it to Bathyllus, and then she turned back to the accounts and worked until the lamps burned low.

CHAPTER

# FIFTEEN

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The wedding was set for the ninth day of June, and the whole of the Palatine knew it, and by the fifth of June the house of the Sulpicii had begun to look like a house under siege.

There were deliveries at every hour: baskets of flowers, bolts of cloth, jars of wine, a new couch for the bridal chamber, a chest of linen that had been ordered in March and arrived late. There were slaves in the atrium with ladders and garlands, and the steward in the tablinum with the accounts, and Aemilia in the garden with the cook, and Sulpicia Varia in her room, dying, giving orders.

The bride herself came to the House of the Graces on the morning of the seventh, before the sun was high, alone but for one slave, by the garden door.

Cassia was in the tablinum with the black book open and the accounts in front of her, and she looked up when Bathyllus brought the girl in and did not immediately understand who she was, because the girl was in a plain cloak with her hair tied back and no paint on her face, and she looked younger than fifteen and much more tired.

"Domina," Sulpicia said. "I have come to ask you for something."

"Sit down."

"I would rather stand."

"Then stand." Cassia closed the book. "What do you want?"

The girl's chin came up. "I am to be married in two days. My grandmother has arranged it, my father has agreed to it, my mother has told me that it is a good match and that I will learn to be happy. I have met the man twice. He is not stupid and he is not cruel and he has a great deal of money, and when he looks at me he sees a girl who will run his house and give him sons and make him look settled." She stopped. "I do not want to marry him."

"Then do not."

"You know that I cannot—"

"I know that you can." Cassia stood. "You are fifteen years old and the daughter of a consular and you have been told all your life that your marriage is a matter for your family. That is true. It is also true that women in this city have refused marriages before, and that the ones who refuse them pay a price, and that the price is sometimes worth paying." She came around the desk. "But you have not come here to ask me whether you should refuse. You have come here to ask me something else. What is it?"

The girl looked at her. Her eyes were her father's eyes, and they were frightened, and they were steady.

"How do I survive it?" she said.

Cassia looked at her for a long moment. Then she took her arm and led her to the garden, where the roses were in flower and the fountain was playing and the morning light was coming through the vines.

"You survive it by keeping something," Cassia said. "Not your freedom; you will not have that. Not your money; that will be his. Something else. A room in your house that is yours and no one else's. A friend you do not tell him about. A skill you learn that he does not know you have. A purse that no one knows about, hidden where he will not look, with enough in it to buy a passage out of the city if you ever need one." She looked at the girl. "I have known women who survived forty years of marriage on nothing but a purse and a friend. I have known women who had everything and survived nothing. The difference is not love. It is not beauty. It is the knowledge that there is one thing in the world that is yours."

"And if he beats me?"

"Then you come to me."

"And if he beats me and I cannot come to you?"

"Then you put a knife in your sleeve and you learn how to use it." Cassia said it without emphasis. "I am not going to tell you that it will not happen. I am going to tell you that you are not a child, and that you are not a fool, and that a woman who knows how to use a knife is a woman who is beaten less often than a woman who does not."

The girl looked at her. Then she laughed — a short, shocked, entirely genuine laugh — and put her hand over her mouth.

"My mother would faint," she said.

"Your mother is a better woman than I am and a worse strategist." Cassia reached into her sleeve and took out a small purse and put it into the girl's hand. "This is yours. It is not your dowry and it is not your father's money and it is no one's business but yours. There are two hundred gold pieces in it. Do not tell your husband. Do not tell your mother. Do not tell your brother, because your brother cannot keep a secret, and do not tell your grandmother, because your grandmother will take it off you and put it in the family strongbox where she thinks it belongs." She closed the girl's fingers around the purse. "And if you ever need to leave, there is a house on the Esquiline with a garden door, and the woman who lives in it does not judge."

Sulpicia looked at the purse in her hand. Her eyes were bright.

"Why are you doing this?" she said.

"Because a woman gave me nothing when I was fifteen," Cassia said, "and I have spent my whole life making up for it."

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The bride's toilette began at the second hour in the small room off the garden, with the shutters open and the morning sun coming in, and it was, in its way, the most political hour of the whole wedding.

Aemilia directed it. She had been up since before dawn and she was dressed in the wine-coloured stola she had worn at the games, and she had the keys at her belt and the household lists in her head and a face that gave nothing away. The women were hers: the two aunts from the country, the cousin from Ostia, the old nurse who had come out of retirement for the day, the hairdresser from the Subura who had been paid four times her usual fee to keep her mouth shut about the shape of the bride's head.

The bride sat on a stool in the middle of the room in her tunic with her hair loose and her hands in her lap, and let them work.

There was a ritual to it, and the ritual had been old when Rome was young. The hair was divided into six locks with the point of a spear — a spear that was kept in the house for this purpose and had been used at every Sulpician wedding for two hundred years — and each lock was coiled and pinned, and the whole was bound with woollen fillets, and the orange veil was laid over it and pinned with a brooch that had come down through four generations. The bride's tunic was woven in the old way, on an upright loom, and her shoes were the same red

as the veil, and her girdle was tied with the knot of Hercules, which the bridegroom was to untie, and which the women of the household had tied, that morning, with a great deal of laughing and a great many suggestions about what the bridegroom would do when he got to it.

Aemilia watched from the corner. She had done this herself, nineteen years before, in this same room, with a different set of women and a different brooch and a great deal of hope.

"Hold still," the hairdresser said, for the fourth time.

"I am holding still."

"You are not. You are breathing."

"People do."

"Not on their wedding day. On their wedding day they hold their breath and they faint, and then we have to start again." The hairdresser put a pin in with a good deal of force. "There. Now the veil."

The old nurse, who was ninety and had the voice of a woman who has never once been contradicted, came forward with the veil and laid it over the girl's head and said, "There. You look like your grandmother."

"Thank you," Sulpicia said.

"It was not a compliment," the old nurse said. "She was a difficult woman and she made everyone around her miserable, and you have her chin."

There was a silence. Then one of the aunts laughed, and then the whole room laughed, and the bride laughed too, and for a moment she was fifteen and not a marriage portion, and Aemilia, standing in the corner, felt something turn over in her chest.

When the others had gone to see about the flowers, she came and stood in front of her daughter.

"You will not have an easy time of it," she said. "The Proculi are not cruel people, but they are vain, and vanity is harder to live with than cruelty. You will be expected to be pretty and agreeable and to produce a son in the first year, and if you do not, they will be disappointed, and they will tell you so in a hundred small ways." She straightened the veil. "You will want to be liked. Do not be liked. Be necessary. A woman who is liked is a woman who can be replaced by someone prettier. A woman who is necessary cannot be replaced at all."

"Grandmother said the same thing."

"Your grandmother was right about a great many things and wrong about the only one that mattered." Aemilia took her daughter's hands. "She was right that the family is worth everything. She was wrong that a person is worth nothing. You are not nothing, Sulpicia. You are my daughter, and you are clever, and you are going to be a great deal more than a wife in a house on the Palatine." She kissed her forehead, under the veil. "Now. Do not cry. It will ruin the paint."

The girl did not cry. She looked at her mother with her father's eyes and her grandmother's chin, and she said, "Mother. Did you ever think of leaving?"

Aemilia looked at her for a long moment. The sun was high, and the house was full of the noise of the wedding, and somewhere in the garden the flute players were tuning up.

"Every day," she said. "And every day I found a reason not to." She let go of her daughter's hands. "That is the difference between you and me. You have a purse in your sleeve and you know how to use it. I had nothing but a reason not to, and I made it my whole life." She turned to the door. "Come. They are waiting."

The wedding was at the house of the Sulpicii, in the old atrium with the masks, and Cassia was not invited, and she went anyway.

She did not go in. She stood in the street outside with the crowd, in a plain cloak with her hair covered, and watched the guests arrive: the Proculi in their litters, the senators and their wives, the clients with their gifts, the flute players, the boys with the torches. The door of the house was hung with garlands and the whole street smelled of flowers and smoke.

Tertulla stood beside her. "We are going to be seen."

"Let them see."

"You said we were not to be seen together until the trial."

"I said I would not be seen with your husband," Cassia said. "You are not my husband. You are my friend, and I am standing in the street at a wedding, and there is nothing in the law against it."

Tertulla laughed. "You have an answer for everything."

"I have had a great deal of practice."

The bride came out of the house at noon, and the crowd pressed forward. Sulpicia was in the traditional dress — the white tunic, the orange veil, the elaborate arrangement of hair with the spear in it — and she looked small and stiff

and very young, and she was holding her father's arm so tightly that Cassia could see the knuckles of her hand go white.

Corvinus walked her through the crowd to the house of Aulus Proculus, and Aemilia walked behind with the bridesmaids, and Publius carried the torch, and the flute players played the wedding song, and the crowd sang the bawdy verses that were traditional and that were, that year, more than usually obscene.

Cassia watched the girl go. When she passed, for a moment, their eyes met, and Sulpicia's chin came up, and her hand went to her sleeve — to the purse that was hidden there — and she nodded, once, very slightly, and went on.

"She will be all right," Tertulla said.

"I know."

"How do you know?"

"Because she has something in her sleeve," Cassia said, "and because she knows it."

The procession went up the hill through the narrow streets, and the crowd grew as it went, because a wedding procession in Rome is a thing that gathers people the way a fire gathers people, and by the time it reached the top of the Palatine there were perhaps three hundred of them.

The flute players went first, and then the torchbearers, and then the bride with her father, and then the women, and then the clients and the neighbours and the children and the dogs. The songs were the old songs, the ones that were sung at every wedding in the city, and they were obscene in the way that the old songs are obscene, and the crowd sang them with the particular delight of people who have been given permission to be rude in public.

Cassia watched from the edge of it. She watched the torchlight on the cobbles and the garlands on the doorposts and the faces in the crowd, and she thought about all the weddings she had seen and all the ones she had not been invited to, and about the fact that she had never had one.

She had been married once, in a way. Antonius Felix had freed her in his will and left her his name and his fortune, and there had been no ceremony, no veil, no songs, no torch. There had been a lawyer and a tablet and an old man in a chair, and he had put his hand on her head and said, "You are a free woman now. Do not waste it." And she had gone out into the street with the tablet in her hand and the sun in her eyes and discovered that freedom was a thing that had to be paid for every day.

Corvinus came past with his daughter on his arm, and he did not look at Cassia, and Cassia did not look at him, and the whole exchange took a fraction of a second and contained a lifetime.

Publius came next, carrying the torch, and he did look at her — a quick, frightened, determined look — and then he turned his face back to the front and walked on.

Behind the bride, Aemilia walked with the married women, and she looked straight ahead, and her face was composed, and when she passed Cassia, she said, without turning her head, in a voice that only Cassia could hear, "The purse. Thank you."

Cassia said nothing. The procession went on up the hill.

At the door of the bridegroom's house the procession stopped, and the bridegroom came out, and the girl was lifted over the threshold amid a great deal of shouting, and the door closed behind them, and the crowd began to disperse.

Cassia turned away.

"Domina." Bathyllus, at her elbow. "There is a slave from the Palatine. He says the old woman is asking for you."

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The house on the Palatine was quiet in the way that a house is quiet when everyone in it is somewhere else. The atrium was empty. The masks looked out of their cupboards. The garlands from the wedding were still hanging, and the floor was still scattered with flowers, and the whole place smelled of crushed petals and wine.

Cassia went up the stairs alone. The door of the old woman's room was open, and the room was dark except for a single lamp, and Sulpicia Varia was lying propped up on her pillows with her eyes open and her hands folded.

"You did not go to the wedding," she said.

"I was in the street."

"Of course you were." The old woman's voice was a whisper now. "I have been listening to it from up here. The songs. The flute. The shouting. It sounds like a funeral, a little. The songs are the same, you know. The bawdy ones. At a funeral they sing the same ones, and everyone laughs, and then everyone cries." She turned her head on the pillow. "I have been waiting for you. I have something else to give you."

"I have the two statements."

"This is not a statement." Sulpicia Varia's hand moved under the pillow and came out with a letter, folded and sealed and brown with age. "This is a letter. It was written to my husband in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Silanus, by a man named Primus, who was then a clerk in the office of the treasury and is now the emperor's freedman, the a rationibus, the man who counts the emperor's money."

Cassia took the letter. The seal was broken. The hand was small and neat and careful.

"What does it say?"

"It says that a shipment of grain was diverted, and that the money from the sale was shared among three men, and that my husband's share was paid into the account of a banker on the Via Lata. It says that the clerk will keep his part of the bargain and expects my husband to keep his. It says that if anything happens to the clerk, he has taken precautions." The old woman's eyes moved to Cassia's face. "Does it say that? I cannot read anymore. My eyes are bad. It said that when I read it, twenty-four years ago."

Cassia read the letter. Then she read it again.

"Yes," she said. "That is what it says."

"Then you understand."

"I understand that your husband was a thief."

"My husband was a great many things. He was a thief and a bully and a man who could not bear to be crossed. But he was not the only one." Sulpicia Varia's voice was very quiet. "The clerk Primus is now one of the most powerful men in Rome. He controls the emperor's purse and the emperor's accounts and a great deal of the emperor's time. He has been paying me for twenty-four years not to publish this letter. And now my son is standing for the Asian command, and the clerk has decided that the Sulpicii have become a liability, and he has found a new man — your Pactus — who can destroy the family and get the letter at the same time."

Cassia sat down on the stool beside the bed. The letter was very light in her hand. It had been written twenty-four years ago by a clerk who was now one of the most powerful men in the empire, and it was worth more than the house and the vineyard and everything in them.

"The land near the forum," she said. "The claim. The case in the courts for fifteen years."

"The land is worth a fortune, and the claim is good, and the clerk wants it. He has wanted it for years. He thought he could buy it, and my husband would not sell, and then my husband died, and I would not sell, and then my son would not sell." The old woman closed her eyes. "We are a stubborn family, domina. It is the only thing we have that is worth anything."

"You should have burned this letter," Cassia said. "This letter is a death warrant. If Primus knows you have it, he will do anything to get it. He has already burned my house. He will kill you, and he will kill your son, and he will kill the boy on the Via Ostiensis, and he will do it from a desk in the palace without ever leaving his chair."

"I know."

"Then why have you kept it?"

"Because it is the only thing I have left that is worth dying for," Sulpicia Varia said. "I have spent twenty-four years keeping this house and this name and this family together. I have done things that I will answer for. And when they came for us, I had nothing to fight with except a letter and a dying woman's word." She looked at Cassia. "I am giving it to you. Not to my son. Not to the lawyer. To you. Because you are the only person I have ever met who understands what a thing is worth."

Cassia looked at the letter in her hand.

"What do you want in exchange?"

"Nothing."

"You always want something."

"Not this time." The old woman's eyes were wet. "This time I want to do one thing that is not for the family, and not for my son, and not for the house. I want to give you the weapon, and I want to see what you do with it." She turned her head away. "Now go. My granddaughter is being married tonight, and I am tired, and I would like to die in peace."

Cassia stood. At the door she said, "I have not forgiven you."

"I know."

"I will not forgive you."

"I know that too." Sulpicia Varia's voice was almost gone. "Go and save my son, domina. And when it is over, if you ever have a daughter, do not do what I

did. Do not make her a thing that can be traded. Make her a woman who can trade."

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The door of the bridegroom's house closed at last, and the crowd stood outside it for a while, singing and shouting and waiting for the bridegroom to come out and throw nuts to them, which he did, at last, laughing, with his hair tousled and his tunic already loosened, and the crowd scrambled for the nuts and the coins and the sweets, and then, slowly, began to disperse.

Cassia stayed until the street was almost empty. Then she walked down the hill alone, with Bathyllus behind her at a distance, and the city was quiet and warm and smelled of flowers and dust and the river.

At the corner of the Clivus Victoriae a man was waiting for her.

He was a small man in a plain tunic with the look of a palace clerk: neat hands, neat hair, a face that had been trained to be forgotten. He stepped out of a doorway as she passed and said, quietly, "The lady is to know that the letter is required."

Cassia stopped. Bathyllus came up behind her, fast, and the clerk did not move.

"Which letter?" Cassia said.

"The letter from the year of the consulship of Domitian and Silanus. The one the old woman has kept." The clerk's voice was polite and entirely without threat, and that was the most frightening thing about it. "My master is prepared to pay a great deal for it. He is also prepared to be patient. He is not prepared to be disobeyed."

"Who is your master?"

The clerk smiled. "The lady knows."

He went away down the hill, and Bathyllus started after him, and Cassia said, "No. Let him go."

"Domina—"

"He is a messenger. There is no point in killing a messenger." She stood in the street with the warm wind on her face and the letter in her sleeve. "But he is right about one thing. The letter is required. By him, by Pactus, by the consul, by the whole city." She began to walk again. "The only question is who gets it first."

She went back up the hill by the garden lane and in through the door that the steward had left unbolted for her, and the house was still full of noise, and she sat in the garden with the letter in her sleeve and waited for the wedding to end.

The wedding night went on until dawn, and the noise of it carried up the hill and into the streets, and Cassia sat in the garden of the Sulpicii house with Corvinus and did not go home.

The guests were gone. The torches had burned down. The slaves were clearing the atrium, and somewhere in the house the bride and groom were behind a closed door, and the whole city was asleep except for the two of them.

"Show me the letter," he said.

She gave it to him. He read it by the light of a single lamp, and his face did not change, and when he had finished he folded it and gave it back.

"Primus," he said. "I have known him for twenty years. He was at my father's funeral. He sent a wreath." He laughed, without any humour at all. "He has been in my house a hundred times. He has sat at my table. He has advised me on the Asian command."

"He has been managing you for twenty years."

"Yes."

"He is the man who is destroying you."

"Yes."

"And Pactus is his instrument, and Sittius is his money, and the fire was his message." Cassia looked at the letter. "And your mother has been holding this over his head for twenty-four years, and he has been paying her, and now he has decided that the Sulpicii are more trouble than they are worth."

Corvinus looked at the garden. The sky over the Palatine was beginning to go grey. Somewhere in the house a woman laughed, and a door closed.

"What do we do?" he said.

"We fight," Cassia said. "Not in the Senate. Not in the courts. In the palace. We take this letter to a man who can use it — not the prefect, not the consul, not any of the men Primus has bought. To the emperor's own secretary, or to the empress, or to a man in the guard who hates him." She folded the letter and put it in her sleeve. "We do not go to the trial with a family scandal. We go to the trial with the head of the man who has been robbing the emperor for twenty

years, and we put it on the table in front of the whole Senate, and we watch them eat each other."

"And if it does not work?"

"Then we lose everything," Cassia said. "And we will have lost it honestly."

"Honestly." He turned the word over. "I have been a senator for twenty years. I do not think I know what it means anymore. Every speech I have made has been a calculation. Every vote has been a favour or a debt. Every dinner has been a negotiation. I have not said a true thing in public since I was a young man, and I am not sure I said one then." He looked at her. "You are the only person I have ever told the truth to. I told it to you in a vineyard when I was twenty, and I told it to you in a room above a kitchen when I was forty-five, and both times it cost me everything."

"It cost you nothing," Cassia said. "It cost you the girl. That is not the same."

"It is exactly the same."

She looked at him. The lamp was burning low, and the garden was grey, and somewhere in the house the bride and groom were asleep behind a closed door.

"There is something I have never asked you," she said.

"Ask."

"Why did you not come back for me? Not in the first year. In the second, or the third, or the tenth. You came back to Rome. You saw the villa sold. You knew my name. You could have asked. You could have sent a man to Puteoli. There were a hundred men in this city who could have found me for the price of a dinner." Her voice was steady. "Why did you not?"

He was silent for a long time. The birds were louder now, and the sky was going from grey to gold.

"Because I believed I had killed you," he said. "Not with a sword. With my silence. I believed that I had stood in a room with my father and said nothing while he told me what he was going to do, and that you had died because of it, and that the child had died because of it, and that a man who has done a thing like that does not go looking for the woman he has killed." He looked at her. "I was twenty years old, and then I was twenty-five, and then I was thirty, and by then the silence had become a kind of house that I lived in, and I did not know how to leave it."

"You could have tried."

"Yes."

"You could have asked one question."

"Yes."

"One question, Lucius. That is all it would have taken." Cassia's eyes were bright. "I spent four years in that house at Puteoli. Four years. And every night I lay awake and thought about the fact that you did not come, and I made myself hate you, because hating you was the only thing I had that was mine. And now you tell me that you were grieving. That you were silent. That you were twenty." She stood up. "I do not know what to do with that. I have been hating you for so long that I do not know what I am without it."

"You are still you," he said. "You are the woman who built the house."

"I am the woman who built the house because of you," Cassia said. "Because of you and your father and your mother and the whole cold machine of that family. I built it to be safe. I built it so that no one could ever sell me again. And now I am standing in your garden with a letter in my sleeve that could destroy a man in the palace, and I am not safe, and I have not been safe for a year, and I find —" She stopped.

"What?"

"I find that I do not mind," she said. "I find that I would rather be unsafe with you than safe in the house alone."

He stood up. They looked at each other across the lamp, and the sky was gold now, and the first cart went past in the street below, and the day of the trial was seventeen days away.

"Then we will be unsafe together," he said.

"That is the worst speech you have ever made."

"I know. I am out of practice."

She laughed, and then she was crying, and he put his arms around her, and they stood in the garden of the house on the Palatine while the sun came up over the city and the masks in the atrium looked out of their cupboards at nothing at all.

CHAPTER

# SIXTEEN

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The strongroom was behind the panel in the tablinum, and it had a bronze door and a lock that had cost more than the couch in the dining room, and only three people in the house knew where the key was kept: Cassia, Hermeros, and Thais.

On the morning of the seventeenth of June, Cassia opened it and found the black book where she had left it, and the strongbox where she had left it, and the wooden box with the receipt where she had left it, and everything in its place. She stood in the little room with the lamp in her hand and looked at the shelves for a long moment, and then she crouched down and looked at the floor.

There was a mark in the dust by the bottom shelf. It was a small mark, the kind a knee makes when a person kneels down and then gets up again, and it was fresh, and it was not hers. She had not knelt in this room in a month.

She stood up slowly. She put the black book on the desk in the tablinum and opened it and went through it page by page, and the pages were all there, and the entries were all there, and nothing had been torn out or added. She held the book up to the window and looked at the edges of the pages, and on the last twenty pages there was a faint shine, a ghost of wax, the kind of mark that is left when a page has been pressed against a wax tablet and copied.

She sat down.

"Hermeros," she said.

He came. She showed him the book and the shine and the mark in the dust. He looked at all of it for a long time, and then he sat down opposite her and put his hands on his knees.

"When?" she said.

"Not this morning. The dust is fresh but the shine is old — three weeks, perhaps a month. It has been done more than once." He turned a page. "They were

careful. They did not take the book out of the room. They came in, they copied, they went out, and they put everything back where it was."

"Who has been in this room?"

"Everyone, domina. It is the tablinum. The whole household comes through it. The women bring the linen, the boys sweep the floor, Celer comes in to argue about the price of fish, the steward comes in with the accounts." He paused. "But the strongroom is another matter. The strongroom is locked, and the key is in your room, and only three people know where it is."

Cassia looked at him.

"Four," she said. "I told Sabina where it was, two years ago, when I was ill. I told her to fetch the strongbox."

"Sabina is twelve."

"Sabina is twelve and she would die before she stole from me, and she is not strong enough to open the door in any case." Cassia closed the book. "Who else has been in the house with time and quiet? Not the kitchen. Not the women upstairs. Someone who could come and go without being noticed, who could be in the tablinum for a quarter of an hour without anyone thinking it strange."

She sat for a long moment. Then she said, "Send for Ione."

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Ione came in with her hair half-dressed and a comb in her hand. She was to be freed at the end of the month; the papers were drawn up, and she had been making her arrangements, and she had been happier in the last three months than Cassia had ever seen her.

"You wanted me," she said.

"Close the door."

She closed it. Cassia did not ask her to sit.

"Someone has been copying the black book," Cassia said. "For a month, perhaps longer. Pages pressed onto wax, transcribed somewhere else, sold to someone. I want to know who."

Ione's face did not change. "And you think it was me."

"I think you are leaving in two weeks. I think you have been saving money for years. I think you have been seen twice in the last month with a man in the Subura, and I think you have been careful not to tell me who he is." Cassia's

voice was level. "I think you have the knowledge, the opportunity, and the motive."

"The motive." Ione's voice was low. "I have been with you for nine years. I have kept your secrets and I have sat with your clients and I have smiled at men who made my skin crawl, and I have never once asked you for anything that you did not offer. And you think I would sell you for money."

"I think people do a great many things for money."

"Yes," Ione said. "They do. I have seen it. I have been the thing that is sold." She put the comb down on the desk. "I did not take your book. I do not know who took your book. And I am not going to stand here and be questioned like a slave in a market."

"You are a slave."

The room was very quiet. Ione's face went white and then red and then white again.

"Yes," she said. "I am. Until the end of the month. And then I will be a freedwoman with forty thousand sesterces and no house and no name, and you will be a rich woman with a house and a book and a friend who has been with you for nine years, and you will have lost the friend because you could not bear to be wrong." She picked up her comb. "I will stay until the papers are signed, because I gave you my word. But I will not sleep in this house again. I will sleep in the kitchen with the boys, and I will not speak to you unless you speak to me, and when the papers are signed I will go out of that door and I will not come back."

"Ione—"

"No," Ione said. "You have made your accusation. Do not take it back because it has made you uncomfortable." She went out and closed the door quietly behind her.

Cassia sat at the desk for a long time.

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The truth came three days later, and it came from Philumena.

She came to the tablinum in the evening, when the house was quiet, and she stood in the doorway with her hands twisted in her apron and her face the colour of old wax, and she said, "It was me, domina."

Cassia looked up from the accounts.

"It was me," Philumena said again. "I copied the book. I did not take it out of the room. I pressed the pages onto wax and I copied them at night and I gave them to a man. I have been doing it for a month. I am sorry. I am so sorry." She began to cry. "They have my brother."

"Who has your brother?"

"The man. The man who paid me. He is a steward — he works for the senator Pactus. He came to me in the spring and he said that my brother was in the vigiles in the fourth cohort, and that my brother had been caught taking money from a shopkeeper, and that if I did not do what he asked, my brother would be dismissed and charged and sent to the mines." She wiped her face with her sleeve. "And I said I would do it. And he said it would be one page, and then it was another page, and then it was the names at the back, and then it was the accounts of the payments, and I did not know what to do. I could not tell you. If I told you, they would have killed him."

Cassia sat very still. The lamp burned.

"Where is your brother now?"

"They let him go. Last week. He came to see me and he did not know anything about it, and he laughed and said he had been given a warning and a fine and he was lucky." Philumena's hands were shaking. "So it was all for nothing. I sold you for nothing."

"You did not sell me. You gave them a copy of a book that is worth more than you can imagine, and they will use it to destroy this house and everyone in it, and the fact that your brother is safe does not change that." Cassia stood. "But you are not the first person to be frightened into doing something terrible, and you will not be the last, and I am not going to have you killed."

Philumena looked up. "You are not?"

"No." Cassia came around the desk. "You are going to write down everything. The man's name, his appearance, the place where you met, the dates, the words he used. You are going to sign it. And then you are going to leave this house tonight, with money, and you are going to go to your brother and tell him what you did, and he will be angry and then he will help you, and you will go somewhere far from Rome and you will not come back."

"Domina—"

"Do not thank me." Cassia's voice was hard. "You have cost me two weeks and a friend and the safety of everyone in this house. I am not being kind. I am

being practical. If I kill you, I lose the only witness I have to the man who bought you, and I need that witness more than I need the satisfaction." She held out a tablet. "Write."

Philumena wrote. It took an hour. When it was done Cassia read it through twice and then sealed it and put it in the strongroom and gave Philumena a purse and a cloak and a letter to a woman in Ostia who kept a lodging house and did not ask questions.

At the door Philumena turned and said, "Domina. The lady Ione. She did not do it."

"I know."

"She was crying in the kitchen two nights ago. She said you had accused her and she did not know how to prove that she had not." Philumena wiped her face. "She is a good woman. She is better than me."

"I know that too," Cassia said, and her voice was not steady. "Go. And Philumena — when you get to Ostia, do not write to me. Do not send word. Do not tell anyone where you are going. There are men who will be looking for you, and I cannot protect you if I do not know where you are."

Philumena went. Cassia stood in the tablinum with the lamp burning and the black book on the desk and the empty doorway.

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She sent for Corvinus that afternoon and met him at Tertulla's house, and they sat in the garden with the bees in the rosemary and the city noise coming over the wall, and she told him everything: the copies, the steward, the arsonist, the letter from Pactus, the boy gone from Praeneste.

He listened without interrupting. When she had finished he sat for a moment with his hands on his knees.

"The steward's name," he said.

"Anthus. He has been with Pactus for eleven years. He was a slave in the household and was freed in the year of the consulship of Palumbus, and he keeps a room above the gate of Pactus's house." Cassia turned her cup. "He is the weak point. A freedman who has done his master's dirty work for eleven years will be frightened, and a frightened freedman will talk if he is offered a better master and a place to hide."

"You want to turn him."

"I want to offer him a choice. He can go to the prefect's court and tell the truth and be given a pension and a house in a town far from Rome, or he can be arrested with his master and share his fate. It is not a difficult choice."

"It is if his master has something on him."

"Everyone has something on everyone," Cassia said. "That is what makes the world go round."

Corvinus looked at the garden wall. "The hearing is tomorrow. We have no time to turn a steward."

"Then we will do it without him." Cassia took a sheet of paper from her sleeve. "Junia's son is a clerk in the prefect's office. He has given me the names of the men who will hear the case, and their connections, and their debts. Three of the five are in the pocket of the palace. One is a cousin of Pactus. One is old Servilius Paetus, who hates new men and loves a good speech." She put the paper on the table. "That is our man. He will not vote for the palace and he will not vote for Pactus, and if we give him a reason to be angry, he will make a speech that will be remembered."

"How do we give him a reason?"

"We tell him the truth." Cassia folded the paper. "Not the truth about the boy. The truth about the grain. The truth about Primus and the money and the twenty years of theft. Paetus is an old republican. He will not care about a senator's bastard, but he will care a great deal about a freedman robbing the emperor and buying the Senate."

Corvinus was silent for a moment. Then he said, "If we do this, there is no going back. Not for me, not for my family, not for you. If we accuse a man in the palace of fraud, we had better be able to prove it, because if we cannot, we will be the ones in the mines."

"Then we had better be able to prove it," Cassia said.

She went to the kitchen. Ione was sitting on the bench by the door with a blanket around her shoulders and her hands around a cup.

"Ione."

"Domina."

"I was wrong." Cassia stood in the doorway. "It was Philumena. She was frightened. Her brother was threatened. I accused you because it was easy and because you were leaving and because I was afraid, and I have treated you badly, and I am sorry."

Ione looked at her for a long moment. Then she said, "I know it was Philumena."

"You knew?"

"I have known for a week. She has been crying in the linen room and she has not been able to look at you and she has been burning the candles down to nothing in the night." Ione turned her cup. "I did not tell you because I wanted to see whether you would believe me. And you did not."

"That is not fair."

"No," Ione said. "It is not. But it is what I did, and I am not sorry." She set the cup down. "You have spent your whole life being the cleverest person in the room, domina. You told me once that you never forgot anything and that you never trusted anyone and that it was the reason you were still alive. And I have watched you for nine years, and I have seen that it is true, and I have seen what it costs." She stood up. "I am going to be free in two weeks. And I am going to leave this house and I am going to be somebody else. But I want you to know that I would have stayed, if you had asked me. I would have stayed and run the house with you and grown old with you and none of it would have been yours alone. And now I am not going to stay, because you did not ask, and because you would not have believed me if I had said yes."

Cassia stood in the kitchen doorway with the lamp in her hand.

"I am asking now," she said.

Ione looked at her. For a moment something moved in her face — grief, or anger, or the last of a long affection.

"Too late," she said, and went past her, and up the stairs.

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The man who set the fire was called Verecundus, and Bathyllus caught him on the twenty-first of June, in a wine shop near the Porta Flumentana, drinking away the last of his fee.

He was a thin man of forty with a broken nose and a brand on his forearm, and he did not deny it. He had been paid by a steward to set a fire in a house on the Esquiline, and he had been told that the house would be empty, and he had not known about the boy in the passage. When Bathyllus told him about the boy, he put his cup down and sat looking at the table for a long time.

"I did not know," he said.

"There was a child in the passage and the door was bolted."

"I did not bolt it. I was told the door would be open. I was told the passage was empty." Verecundus wiped his mouth with the back of his hand. "I have done a great many things in my life, but I have never killed a child. I have children of my own."

Cassia came to the wine shop herself, with Bathyllus and two of Tertulla's men. She sat down opposite the arsonist and put her hands on the table and looked at him.

"You will write a statement," she said. "You will name the man who paid you and the man he works for. You will say what you were told and what you did and what you did not know. And then you will come with me to the prefect's court and you will say it again in front of a magistrate."

"And if I do not?"

"Then I will give you to my doorkeeper and my two friends, and they will take you out of the city and they will do to you what you did to my house." Cassia's voice was soft. "But I do not want to do that. I want the men who paid you. You are a tool. A tool is not worth destroying."

Verecundus looked at her. Then he picked up his cup and drank the rest of the wine and set it down and said, "Give me the tablet."

He wrote for an hour. His hand was shaking, and he could not spell, and the statement was full of holes and contradictions, but it named the steward and the steward's master, and it said the words *the senator Pactus*, and it was witnessed by Bathyllus and by the wine shop's owner and by a man at the next table who had been listening and had decided that he would rather be a witness than a suspect.

Cassia took it home and locked it in the strongroom with the others, and then she sat down at her desk and put her face in her hands.

"Domina," Hermeros said, from the doorway. "There is a message from the consul's clerk."

She looked up.

"The hearing has been moved," he said. "It will be held tomorrow."

* * *

The household came into the atrium at dusk, and Cassia stood on the step of the impluvium and told them what was happening.

"Tomorrow there will be a hearing in the Senate. The senator Corvinus will be accused of a crime he did not commit, and I will be called as a witness, and the men who are bringing the accusation will try to use this house and the people in it to destroy him." She looked at them. "I am not going to lie to you. Some of you may be questioned. Some of you may be taken to the prefect's house and asked the same questions over and over until you are tired enough to answer them. That is what the law allows. It is a filthy law, and it is the law we have."

Nobody spoke. The lamplight moved on the water of the impluvium.

"Thais will have a paper with the name of every one of you and the name of a person to go to if I do not come back. There is money in the strongbox for your freedom, and there is a letter to the lady Tertulla, and she will see that it is done." Cassia paused. "And if any of you wish to leave this house tonight, you may. I will not stop you and I will not hold it against you. Go to the door, tell Bathyllus, and he will give you a purse and a letter of introduction to a household in Ostia or Tibur."

There was a long silence. Then Celer said, "Domina, with respect, if I leave this house I will have to cook for strangers, and strangers do not appreciate the fish sauce."

Somebody laughed. Then somebody else. Then the whole household was laughing in the atrium, a little too loudly, the way people laugh when they are frightened, and Cassia laughed with them.

Nobody left.

Thais came to her room at the ninth hour with a cup of wine and a plate of bread and cheese and set them down on the table without asking.

"Eat," she said.

"I am not hungry."

"You never are. It is the most inconvenient thing about you." Thais sat down in the chair by the window. "I have been with you for twenty-two years. I have seen you in a brothel in Puteoli and in a room above a bakery and in this house. I have seen you buy your freedom and buy this house and buy every person in it. And I have never seen you frightened like this."

"I am not frightened."

"You are frightened and you are hiding it behind arithmetic, which is what you always do." Thais folded her arms. "What are you afraid of? Not the trial. You have been in worse rooms than a Senate."

"I am afraid of the boy," Cassia said. "I am afraid that Pactus has him, or that he has gone somewhere I cannot find him, and that the one thing I have wanted for twenty-four years is going to be taken away from me on the day before I have to stand up in front of the Senate and be called a whore." She put her hands flat on the table. "I am afraid that I have spent my whole life building a wall and that tomorrow I am going to find out that the wall was made of paper."

Thais was silent for a moment. Then she said, "Do you remember the first night you came to Puteoli?"

"I remember."

"You would not eat. You would not speak. You sat in the kitchen with your hands in your lap and you looked at the wall as though you were waiting for it to fall on you. And I said to you, 'You will not believe anything they tell you in the first month,' and you looked at me and you said, 'I do not believe anything anyone tells me.'" Thais's mouth moved. "I knew then that you would either die in that house or own it. There was no third thing."

"And now?"

"Now you are the woman who owns it, and you are sitting in the dark with a cup of wine you have not touched, and you are afraid." Thais stood. "You are allowed to be afraid. You are not allowed to be stupid. So eat the bread, and drink the wine, and tell me what you need me to do."

Cassia looked at her. Then she picked up the bread and ate it.

"The household," she said. "If I do not come back. The papers are in the strongroom. The will is in the box under the bed. The letter for Sabina is with the will. And the black book—" She stopped.

"The black book is the most dangerous thing in this house," Thais said. "If they take it, they will use it. Every name in it is a man who will be ruined, and every man who is ruined will blame you, and the ones who are not ruined will come for you to make sure they are not next."

"I know."

"Then burn it."

Cassia looked at the desk. The black book was lying there, open at a page of names.

"I have spent twenty-four years writing in it," she said. "It is the only thing I have that is entirely mine. Not the house. Not the money. The book. It is every favour and every debt and every secret and every lie, and it is the reason half the men in this city are afraid of me."

"It is the reason half the men in this city will hang you," Thais said. "Burn it."

Cassia sat for a long time. Then she picked up the book and carried it to the hearth and opened the door of the little bronze stove and put it in.

The pages caught slowly, because the book was thick and the paper was good, and she watched the names curl and blacken and turn to ash — Felix, Sittius, Pactus, Primus, a hundred others, a hundred secrets, a hundred small cruelties and large ones — and she felt nothing at all.

"Now the will," Thais said.

She wrote her will that night.

It was not a long document. The house went to Thais and Hermeros in trust for the household, with money for the manumission of everyone in it and enough to keep them for a year. The shipping venture went to Tertulla. The strongbox went to Sabina, with a letter that she was to open when she was eighteen. The black book she did not leave to anyone, because there was no longer a black book to leave.

The letter from Corvinus, the old one, the one that had been in the cedar box for twenty-four years, she did not burn. She put it in her sleeve.

Then she went up to her room and lay down in her clothes and did not sleep.

At dawn there was a knock at the garden door and Bathyllus came in with his face grey.

"Domina. The boy has gone from Praeneste. The potter's brother's workshop was visited yesterday by two men. The potter took the boy out through the back and they have not been seen since." He paused. "There is a message at the garden door. It is addressed to you."

Cassia took it. It was a single line, in a clerk's neat hand.

*The lady should consider whether a trial is worth a boy's life. P.*

She stood in the garden with the letter in her hand and the sun coming up over the burnt roof of the house, and she felt the whole of it come down on her at once — the fire, the boy, the black book, Ione, the trial, the letter in her sleeve — and for a moment she could not breathe.

Then she folded the letter and put it in her sleeve beside the other one.

"Bathyllus," she said. "Go to the Palatine. Tell the senator that the boy is missing and that Pactus has him, or knows where he is, and that I am going to the hearing, and that he is to do nothing until he hears from me." She turned. "And then go to Tertulla's house and tell her to find Junia's son, the clerk in the prefect's office, and to bring him to the court before the ninth hour."

"Domina—"

"Go."

She walked back into the house, through the burnt yard, into the tablinum, and she stood in front of the panel in the wall and looked at it for a moment.

Then she opened it and took out the receipt, and the two statements, and the letter from the palace, and the statement of the arsonist, and she put them all in a leather satchel and strapped it to her side.

"Thais," she said. "Bring me my veil. The dark one. And tell the household to bolt the doors and not to open them for anyone until I come back."

She went out into the street. The sun was up. The city was waking, and the whole of Rome was going about its business, buying and selling and arguing and dying, and somewhere in it a boy of twenty-four was hiding with a potter, and a senator was waiting in a cold house on the Palatine, and a consul was preparing to hear the most scandalous case of the year.

Cassia walked down the Clivus Suburanus toward the Forum with the satchel at her side and the two letters in her sleeve and the whole of her life behind her, and she did not look back, because a woman who looks back is a woman who is followed.

CHAPTER

# SEVENTEEN

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She had been up since the fourth hour, and she had spent the first hour of the day doing something she had not done in twenty-four years: she had stood in front of the silvered mirror in her room and looked at herself as though she were a witness.

She was forty-two years old. There were lines at the corners of her eyes and a softness under her chin that had not been there at thirty, and the scar on her thumb had faded to a thin white line, and her hair, which had been black, was black still, with a few grey threads at the temples that Philumena had been allowed to pull out and that Cassia had lately begun to leave alone. She was not beautiful. She had never been beautiful, exactly. She had been striking, and then she had been handsome, and now she was a woman whose face made men in the Forum lower their voices.

"You are staring," Thais said, from the doorway.

"I am inspecting."

"You are staring, and you are frightened, and you are doing the thing you do when you are frightened, which is to look at yourself as though you were a problem that could be solved with a better dress."

"I am not frightened."

"You are frightened. I have known you for twenty-two years." Thais came in and set a cup of hot water and honey on the table. "Drink that. You will not eat, and if you faint in the Curia they will say it is a confession."

Cassia drank it. Then she put on the plain stola and the dark veil and the ring with her seal, and she stood in the atrium while the household assembled to see her off, which was a thing she had not asked them to do and could not bring herself to stop.

Sabina had made her a knot of rosemary and lavender, which was the sort of thing a child makes, and which Cassia had seen her working on for two days. She tied it to the strap of the satchel.

"For luck," Sabina said.

"Rosemary is for remembrance."

"Then it is for remembering to come back."

Cassia looked at her for a moment. Then she bent down and kissed her on the forehead, which she had done perhaps three times in the child's life.

"I will remember," she said.

She went out into the street. The morning was hot and bright and the city was already full of the noise of the day, and she walked down the Clivus Suburanus with Bathyllus behind her and the satchel on her shoulder and the smell of rosemary and lavender rising from the knot at her side.

At the corner of the Vicus Cyprius there was a crowd outside a wine shop, and she stopped, because the crowd was looking at something, and because a woman who is on her way to the Senate should know what the city is looking at.

It was Felix.

He was being taken from a cell to the prefect's house for his own hearing, and he was in chains, and he was walking between two men of the guard with his head up and his hair in his eyes, and he looked smaller than she remembered, and older, and entirely without the smile.

He saw her. He stopped, and one of the guards pushed him, and he did not move.

"Domina," he said.

The crowd turned. Cassia stood at the edge of it and looked at him.

"I kept my word," Felix said. "I gave you the statement. I told them everything I knew. And they came for me the next morning, and they took my house, and my wife is with her sister, and my children—" He stopped. "You said my children would never want."

"They will not."

"Then why am I in chains?"

"Because you were a delator for six years," Cassia said, "and because the men you served have decided that you are more useful to them in a cell than at a witness stand, and because I am not the only person in Rome who can keep a prom-

ise." She stepped closer. "I will not forget your children. I will not forget what you did. And when this is over, if I am still standing, I will come for you."

Felix looked at her for a long moment. Then he laughed — the old laugh, the one with the knife in it, but tired now, and without much hope.

"You are the only honest person in this city," he said, "and they are going to crucify you."

The guard pushed him on. The crowd closed behind them. Cassia stood in the street with the knot of rosemary and lavender at her side and her heart going like a drum, and then she turned and walked on toward the Forum.

The Curia Julia was full before the seventh hour, and the crowd outside it filled the Forum from the rostra to the basilica, and the whole city had the air of a festival that had gone wrong.

Cassia came on foot, because a litter would have been a provocation, with Bathyllus behind her and the satchel strapped to her side. She wore a plain stola and no jewellery except the ring with her seal on it, and her hair was bound up in the old way, and she had made Thais promise not to come, and Thais had promised, and Thais was somewhere in the crowd anyway.

The crowd parted for her and did not part kindly. There were voices. Somebody laughed. Somebody said a word that she had not been called in sixteen years, and Bathyllus turned his head, and she said, "No," and walked on.

At the door of the Curia the lictor stopped her.

"Women are not admitted."

"I am a witness."

"Women are not admitted."

"I am a witness summoned by the consul," Cassia said, "and if you turn me away, you will have to explain to him why the principal witness in the case of the century is standing in the Forum with the fishwives." She held out the summons. "Read it, if you can read."

The lictor read it. Then he stood aside.

The interior of the Curia was cool and dim and smelled of stone and wool and the particular smell of a great many nervous men. The benches were full. The consuls sat on their curule chairs at the end of the hall, and the clerks sat below them with their tablets, and the senators sat in their ranks in their white togas with the purple borders, and the whole thing looked, for a moment, exactly

like what it was: a room full of old men who had spent their lives learning how to destroy one another with words.

Corvinus was on the front bench with his supporters. He was pale and composed, and he wore the white toga, and he had the look of a man who had not slept and had decided that it did not matter. Aemilia was not present; women were not admitted, and Cassia was admitted only because she was a witness, and she understood, walking up the aisle of that chamber, exactly how much of a favour it was and exactly how much it would cost.

Pactus sat on the other side with the prosecutor's bench, and beside him was a lawyer named Crispus with a thin face and a good voice, and behind him were the witnesses, and among them Cassia saw, for the first time in twenty-four years, a small, bent, frightened old woman in a good cloak, with a stick, and a granddaughter beside her.

Psyche looked at her. Cassia looked back. Neither of them moved.

The consul called the house to order. The clerk read the charge: that Lucius Sulpicius Corvinus, consular, augur, had procured the death of his father, Marcus Sulpicius Corvinus, by poison, in the villa at Tibur, in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Silanus; and that the said Lucius Sulpicius had done so in order to inherit his father's estate and to conceal his own misconduct with a slave of the household.

The chamber was very quiet when the clerk finished. Then the murmuring began, and the consul struck the floor with his staff and called for silence.

Crispus rose. He was a good lawyer, and he made a good speech: measured, reasonable, full of references to the dignity of the house and the sanctity of the family and the duty of the Senate to root out impiety wherever it was found. He spoke for half an hour. He did not mention the slave girl by name. He did not mention the child. He said that the prosecution would prove that the accused had been in the house on the night in question, that he had quarrelled with his father, that he had been heard to threaten him, and that after the death he had inherited the estate and had gone to Syria within the week.

All of it, Cassia thought, was true except the first and the last. Corvinus had not been in the house that night; he had been three days gone. But the rest — the quarrel, the threat, the inheritance, the flight — the rest was true, and it was the truth arranged in the shape of a lie, and she understood, watching the faces of the senators, that the shape was what mattered.

Then it was Corvinus's turn.

He rose. He did not use a written speech. He stood in the middle of the floor in his white toga and said that he had loved his father, that he had been in Syria when his father died, that he had received the news at Antioch and had wept, and that he had spent twenty-four years believing that his father had died of an apoplexy, as the physician had certified. He said that he did not know what had happened in that house on that night, and that he had come to the Senate to find out, and that he asked only for the truth.

It was a good speech. It was better than good; it was the speech of a man who had spent his life in that room, and it moved several of the older senators visibly, and Cassia saw old Paetus nodding.

Then Crispus rose again and said, "The house will hear the first witness. The midwife Psyche, of Tibur."

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The old woman was helped to the stand by her granddaughter. She was so thin that her cloak hung on her like a shroud, and she held the stick with both hands, and when the consul told her to speak she spoke in a voice that carried, because she had spent forty years delivering babies in a village and a woman in that trade learns to be heard.

She told the truth. She told all of it: the cup, the night, the child, the cry, the mistress with the lamp, the dealer, the receipt, the twenty-four years. She did not spare herself. When Crispus asked her whether she had been paid to tell this story, she said, "I have been paid to keep silent for twenty-four years. Nobody has paid me to speak."

The chamber erupted. The consul struck the floor three times. Cassia sat very still and watched the faces of the senators, and saw what she had expected to see: not horror, not pity, but calculation. Every man in that room was working out what the story meant for him, and for his faction, and for the Asian command, and for the emperor.

When Psyche was done, Crispus rose and said, "The house has heard the midwife. The prosecution asks that the woman Antonia Cassia be called, the freedwoman of the household, the mother of the child."

The consul looked at Cassia. "The witness will come forward."

She came forward. The floor of the Curia was cold through her shoes. She stood where the old woman had stood and looked up at the consuls and then at the benches, and she thought: I have been in this city for twenty-four years and I have never once been allowed in this room, and now I am here, and I am here because of him.

"State your name and status," the clerk said.

"Antonia Cassia. Freedwoman. I keep a house on the Esquiline and I have done so for sixteen years."

"You are the mother of the child described by the witness?"

"I am."

"You were a slave in the household of Marcus Sulpicius Corvinus at Tibur in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Silanus?"

"I was."

"Tell the house what happened on the night in question."

She told it. She told it in the same voice she used for the household accounts: flat, precise, without ornament. The cup. The pain. The cry. The woman with the lamp. The morning. The cart. The house at Puteoli. She did not look at Corvinus while she spoke, and she did not look at Pactus, and she did not look at the old woman with the stick.

When she had finished, the chamber was silent.

Crispus rose. "The witness has told the house that the accused was not present at the birth."

"He was not."

"And that she was sold to a house of prostitution in Puteoli three days later."

"She was."

"And that she has spent twenty-four years building a fortune in this city, and that she now keeps a house frequented by senators, and that she has been for many years the intimate friend of the accused."

"The accused is a client of my house, as half the Senate is a client of my house," Cassia said. "If the Senate wishes to know which of its members have been in my dining room, I will be happy to provide a list. I do not think it will improve the dignity of this debate."

There was laughter, and the consul struck the floor, and Crispus's thin face tightened.

"You are a freedwoman," he said. "You are not a Roman matron. Your word in this house is worth what the word of a freedwoman is worth."

"Then it is worth exactly as much as the word of a freedman," Cassia said, "and there are three of them in this room who count the emperor's money."

This time the laughter was louder, and the consul had to stand to restore order, and Cassia saw Paetus laughing openly on the front bench.

Crispus waited for the noise to die. Then he said, "The house will note that the witness is hostile. The prosecution asks that the household of the woman Cassia be handed over for questioning, as the law allows, in order that the truth of her testimony may be tested."

The chamber went quiet.

"The law allows it," Crispus said, "because a freedwoman's household is not a Roman household. Her slaves are not the slaves of a citizen. They may be questioned under torture, and their evidence may be taken, and this house may judge for itself whether the testimony of the freedwoman is true."

Cassia stood very still. She had known it was coming. She had known it since the moment she had agreed to testify, and she had told herself that knowledge was the same as preparation.

The consul looked at her. He was an elderly man with a tired face, and he had been consul twice, and he had the look of a man who had seen a great deal and wanted to go home.

"The request is within the law," he said. "The household will be handed over to the prefect's office tonight, and the questioning will begin tomorrow. The trial will be held in thirty days." He struck the floor with his staff. "The house is dismissed."

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The crowd outside the Curia was waiting for her.

They had heard, somehow, already — the city was like that, the city had a thousand mouths and every one of them was at the door of the Curia — and they pressed in on her as she came down the steps, and the noise was like a wave.

"Whore!" a man shouted. "Murderer's whore!"

"Where is the boy?" a woman screamed. "Where is the poor child?"

"Did you kill the old man too?"

Bathyllus put himself between her and the crowd, and two of Tertulla's men came out of nowhere and made a wall, and they got her across the Forum to the edge of the Sacra Via, and there the crowd thinned and the shouting faded and she was able to breathe.

Aemilia was waiting at the corner, in a plain litter, with the curtains drawn.

"Get in," she said.

Cassia got in. The litter moved off. Aemilia sat opposite her with her hands in her lap and her face white.

"Publius was in the gallery," she said. "He heard all of it. He came out before the crowd and he is at home now with his sister, and his sister is asking questions that I cannot answer." She looked at Cassia. "They will take your household tonight."

"I know."

"Children. Old women. The boy from the market."

"I know."

"And you will let them."

"I have no choice." Cassia's voice was steady. "If I resist, they will take them anyway and they will charge me with obstruction, and then they will have an excuse to put me in a cell, and then there will be no one to stand up in that chamber in thirty days and tell the truth."

Aemilia stared at her. "You are a cold woman."

"Yes," Cassia said. "It is the only way I have found to stay alive."

The litter stopped at the corner of the Clivus Suburanus. Cassia got out. Aemilia caught her sleeve.

"My husband did not do it," she said.

"I know."

"Then save him."

"I am trying."

"Try harder," Aemilia said, and the curtains closed, and the litter went up the hill.

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They came at the ninth hour, as the lamps were being lit: a magistrate's clerk and eight men of the urban cohorts, with a warrant and a cart.

Cassia had prepared them. They stood in the atrium in their clean tunics with their bundles at their feet, all of them, from Thais to the smallest kitchen boy, and she had spoken to each of them alone that afternoon and told them what to say and what not to say and what to do if they were frightened.

The clerk read the warrant. Cassia listened without expression.

"The household is to be sold to the state for the duration of the questioning," the clerk said. "They will be housed in the prefect's cells and returned to you at the conclusion of the trial, less the costs of their maintenance."

"Less the costs," Cassia said. "And if they do not survive the questioning?"

The clerk looked at her. He was a thin man of fifty with the face of a clerk who has read a great many warrants.

"Then they will not be returned," he said.

Thais came forward first. She had put on her best cloak and her hair was done, and she looked, in the lamplight, like a woman going to a funeral that she had arranged herself.

"Domina," she said. "The keys."

Cassia took the keys from her belt and gave them to her. It was a small ceremony, and it meant nothing, and both of them knew it.

"Come back," Cassia said.

"I will come back," Thais said. "I am too old to die in a cell. It would be undignified."

Sabina came next. She was twelve years old and she was white to the lips, and she walked across the atrium with her bundle in her arms and her chin up, and when she reached Cassia she stopped.

"Domina," she said. "What do I say?"

"Nothing," Cassia said. "You say nothing at all. You are a child and you do not know anything and you have never heard of Tibur. If they ask you questions, you cry. If they hurt you, you cry louder. If they tell you that I have said something, you say that you do not believe them, because I would never say anything that would hurt you." She knelt down and took the child's face in her hands. "And Sabina. Whatever happens, you do not tell them about the black book. There is no black book. There never was."

"There is no black book," Sabina said.

"Good girl."

Chrysis came with Senno. The boy had been in the house for four months and had put on weight and colour and had begun to work in the garden, and he stood in the atrium with his bundle and looked at the men with the sticks and did not move.

"Domina," Chrysis said. "He is not a slave."

"He is a slave of this household. The warrant does not care that I bought him for you." Cassia looked at the boy. "Senno. You will go with your sister. You will do what she says. And when this is over, I will buy you again if I have to, and I will free you, and you will have a trade and a name."

The boy looked at her for a long moment. Then he said, "You said you did not own me."

"I did not own you," Cassia said. "The law did. It is a difference I have been explaining to people for twenty years, and I am beginning to think that no one is listening."

They went out one by one, into the street, into the cart. Celer went, and the kitchen boys, and the women from upstairs, and the old gardener, and the boy who fed the pigeons. The clerk counted them twice. The men of the cohort stood in the street with their sticks and their bored, patient faces.

Bathyllus stood in the doorway with his arms folded. He was a freedman; they could not take him.

The last to go was Thais. She stopped at the door and looked back at the house — the atrium, the impluvium, the three Graces in the alcove, the burnt patch on the wall where the fire had been — and then at Cassia.

"Twenty-two years," she said.

"Twenty-two years," Cassia said.

"Keep the lamps burning," Thais said. "I do not want to come back to a dark house."

She went out. The cart moved off. The door closed.

Tertulla came at midnight, alone, by the garden door, with a basket of food and a flask of wine and a face like a woman who had been crying and had decided not to.

"You did not eat," she said.

"I am not hungry."

"You never are. It is the most inconvenient thing about you." She set the basket down on the table in the small dining room. "I have been to the prefect's

house. They are in the cells under the courtyard — the men on one side and the women on the other. The clerk says they will be questioned tomorrow morning, beginning with the oldest." She paused. "That is Thais."

Cassia sat down slowly on the couch.

"I know."

"They will question her first because she has been with you longest and knows the most, and because they think an old woman will break quickly." Tertulla sat down opposite her. "Do you want me to try to buy the clerk?"

"No. If we bribe him now, he will report it, and they will question her harder." Cassia's voice was flat. "There is a way these things are done. They will question her, and she will give them nothing, and then they will question the next one and the next, and at some point one of them will break, and that is what they are counting on. It is not a search for truth. It is a machine for producing a statement."

"And you are going to let it run."

"I am going to let it run, and I am going to be in that chamber in thirty days with the statements I have, and I am going to put the men who did this in front of the Senate and watch them explain themselves." Cassia looked up. "And I am going to hate every hour of it. Is that what you want to hear?"

Tertulla looked at her. Then she reached across and took her hand.

"No," she said. "I want to hear that you have a plan that does not require a twelve-year-old girl to be questioned by men with rods."

Cassia was silent.

"I have a plan," she said at last. "I do not know if it will work. It requires a man in the palace, and a woman I have never met, and a letter that could get us all killed." She looked at Tertulla. "And it requires me to ask you to do something that you will not want to do."

"Name it."

"I need you to go to the house of the empress's steward. Your cousin's wife is a client of his sister. I need you to get me an audience with the empress, before the trial, alone, without the knowledge of the consul or the prefect or Pactus."

Tertulla's face did not change. "The empress does not receive freedwomen."

"The empress receives whoever her steward lets through the door. And the empress is a woman who has spent thirty years married to a soldier and has no children of her own, and who has a reputation for caring about justice, and who

is bored." Cassia leaned forward. "I am going to give her the letter from Primus, and I am going to tell her what her husband's money has been paying for, and I am going to ask her for one thing: that the trial be held in the Senate with the emperor's secretary present, and that the witnesses be heard without the rack."

"And if she refuses?"

"Then I will go to the trial with what I have, and I will probably lose, and my household will be sold, and the boy will be a scandal, and you will be the only person left in Rome who will speak to me." Cassia's mouth moved. "So I would prefer that she does not refuse."

Tertulla was silent for a long moment. The lamp burned. In the empty house the silence was enormous.

"I will go tomorrow," she said. "And Cassia—"

"Yes?"

"When this is over, if we are still alive, I am going to take you to Baiae for a month, and I am going to make you eat, and sleep, and sit in the sun, and you are going to be bored, and it will be the best month of your life."

Cassia laughed, and it hurt, and she said, "I do not know how to be bored."

"I know," Tertulla said. "That is why it will be the best month of your life."

Cassia stood in the empty atrium with Bathyllus and listened to the cart go down the hill, and the sound of it got smaller and smaller and then stopped, and the house was quiet in a way that it had never been quiet before.

"Domina," Bathyllus said.

"Leave me."

"Domina—"

"Leave me," Cassia said, and her voice broke on the second word, and Bathyllus went out into the yard and stood there in the dark with his back to the door, and Cassia sat down on the edge of the impluvium in the empty house and put her hands over her face.

CHAPTER

# EIGHTEEN

◆ ◆ ◆

The prefect's house stood at the foot of the Viminal, behind a wall and a gate, and it had a courtyard with a fig tree in it and a portico and a set of cells under the north wing that the clerks called the cellar and everyone else called the question room.

Cassia came at the second hour and was not admitted. She came at the fourth hour and was not admitted. She came at the sixth hour and stood in the courtyard with the fig tree and the portico and the clerks walking past her with their tablets, and she was still not admitted, and at the eighth hour a clerk came out and told her that the magistrate would see her for five minutes.

The magistrate was a man named Valerius, fifty, thin, with the neat hands of a man who had spent his life writing down other people's words and the flat eyes of a man who had stopped reading them.

"Domina," he said. "You have been here since dawn."

"I have."

"It will do no good. The questioning is a legal procedure. It is not a spectacle and it is not a negotiation, and there is nothing you can say to me that will change what happens in that room."

"I know," Cassia said. "I am not here to change it. I am here to ask you for something."

"Ask."

"The child. Sabina. She is twelve years old and she knows nothing, and I will give you anything you want if you will question her last, or not at all." Cassia's voice was steady. "I will give you a statement. I will sign it. I will say whatever you want me to say, in my own hand, and you may put it before the Senate and I will not deny it, if you will leave the child alone."

Valerius looked at her for a long moment. He did not look surprised, or moved, or contemptuous. He looked like a man doing arithmetic.

"Your statement would be worthless," he said. "You are the principal witness for the defence. A confession from you would be read as fear for your household, and the court would discount it, and my superiors would want to know why I had accepted it." He turned a page. "The child will be questioned with the others. She will be questioned last, and she will be questioned gently. That is the most I can do, and I am doing it because I have a daughter of my own and because you have been standing in my courtyard for six hours and it is bad for the dignity of the office."

"Gently."

"Gently means the questions will be simple and the restraints will be light and the questioner will be a man who is used to children." Valerius closed his tablet. "It does not mean she will not be frightened. It does not mean she will not cry. And it does not mean she will not be hurt, if she does not answer." He stood. "Go home, domina. There is nothing for you here."

While she waited, the courtyard filled and emptied and filled again.

There were petitioners there for every kind of business: a man whose brother had been taken for debt, a woman whose son had been arrested in a brawl, a merchant with a claim against a ship owner, two slaves with a letter from their master, a young man who had been waiting so long that he had begun to write on the wall. They sat on the benches along the portico and watched the clerks and exchanged the small, bitter currency of people who have been waiting a long time: who to bribe, which door to use, which magistrate was honest and which was not, how many days it took for a letter to reach the prefect's desk.

Cassia sat among them and said nothing, and after a while the woman with the son came and sat beside her.

"You have been here since dawn," she said.

"I have."

"Who is yours?"

"My household," Cassia said. "Twelve of them. Eleven now."

The woman nodded. "They took my son in the spring. He was a porter at the docks and he was in the wrong place at the wrong time, and now he is in the cellar and I have been here every day for three months." She looked at the gate.

"They will not tell me anything. They will not let me see him. I have brought him bread every day and they take it and I do not know whether he eats it."

"They take the bread and they eat it themselves," Cassia said.

"I know." The woman's hands were in her lap. "But I bring it anyway. It is the only thing I can do."

Cassia looked at her. She was perhaps fifty, with the face of a woman who had worked outdoors all her life, and she had the same flat, patient look that Cassia had seen in the faces of the people on the slave platform, and in the face of a boy in a market, and in her own face, once, in a mirror in a brothel at Puteoli.

"What is your son's name?" she asked.

"Lucius. He is twenty-six. He has a wife and a little girl."

"Then he will come home," Cassia said, "and you will bring him bread, and he will complain that it is stale, and you will tell him that it is the best bread in Rome, and he will laugh at you." She paused. "That is what happens. It is not always what happens. But it is what happens often enough that we have to keep bringing the bread."

The woman looked at her for a long moment. Then she said, "You are not from the docks."

"No."

"I thought not. You have the look of a woman who has money and is not using it." She stood. "I hope your household comes home, domina. I hope you do not have to bring bread to a gate for three months."

She went back to her bench. Cassia sat under the fig tree until the light began to go, and then she heard, from under the north wing, the sound of a door opening, and the flat, patient voice of a man reading out a list of names.

She did not go home. She sat in the courtyard under the fig tree all day, and the clerks brought her water and did not speak to her, and the sun moved across the portico, and in the afternoon she heard, faintly, from under the north wing, a sound that she would not allow herself to identify.

◆ ◆ ◆

Sabina had been in the cell for a day and a half, and she had learned three things.

The first was that the cell was cold. It was June, and the city outside was hot enough to make the stones sweat, but the cell was under the ground and the walls were old and the cold came up out of the floor and into her bones.

The second was that the men were not all the same. There was the fat one who brought the food and did not look at her, and the thin one who took her to the latrine and told her to hurry, and the one with the good voice who came in the morning and asked her questions in a way that made her want to answer them.

The third was that she must not answer them.

The good-voiced man was called Rufus. He was fifty and he had a kind face and he had been doing this work for twenty years, and he began each session by asking her whether she had slept and whether she was hungry.

"Sabina," he said, on the second morning. "You have been very brave."

She said nothing.

"You have not said a single word to me. Do you know how unusual that is? Most girls your age cry and tell me everything in the first hour. Their mothers, their mistresses, what they had for dinner. Everything. But you have not said a word." He sat down on the stool opposite her. "I am going to ask you some questions, and you are going to answer them, and if you answer them truthfully, this will be over very quickly and you will go back to your cell and have something to eat. Do you understand?"

She nodded.

"Good. What is your name?"

"Sabina."

"Sabina. A pretty name. How old are you?"

"Twelve."

"Twelve. And how long have you been in the house of the woman Cassia?"

"Four years."

"Four years. That is a long time." Rufus turned a page. "And in those four years, did you ever see the woman Cassia writing in a book? A large book, with a dark cover?"

Sabina's heart began to beat very fast. She had been told, in the atrium, on the night they were taken: *There is no black book. There never was.*

"No," she said.

"No?"

"No."

"Are you sure? Because I have been told by another member of the household that there is a book, and that the woman Cassia writes in it almost every night, and that she keeps it in a room behind the tablinum." Rufus's voice was gentle. "It is not a crime to have a book, Sabina. There is nothing wrong with a book. I only want to know what is in it."

"I do not know anything about a book."

"You see, I do not believe you." Rufus sighed. "And when I do not believe a person, I have to take other measures. Do you know what those measures are?"

She shook her head.

"Then I will tell you. There is a rope, and there is a rack, and there is a man who turns the rack. It is not a pleasant thing. It is not a thing I enjoy. But it is the law, and the law is the law, and if you do not tell me the truth, I will have to use it." He looked at her. "Would you like that?"

"No."

"Then tell me about the book."

Sabina began to cry. She did not want to cry; she had promised herself that she would not cry; but the tears came anyway, and her nose ran, and she wiped it on her sleeve, and she thought about the warm kitchen and Celer's bread and Thais's hands and the way the mistress had knelt down in the atrium and taken her face in her hands and said, *You are a child and you do not know anything.*

"There is no book," she said. "There is no book. There is no book."

Rufus looked at her for a long time. Then he made a small mark on his tablet and said, "Very well. We will try again tomorrow."

They did not use the rope that day. They did not use it the next day either. They used it on the third day, when the other members of the household had given them nothing and the magistrate was beginning to ask why the questioning was taking so long, and Sabina heard the men in the corridor outside her cell arguing about it, and then the door opened, and Rufus came in with two other men and a look on his face that was almost apologetic.

"I am sorry," he said. "I truly am."

They did not rack her. They tied her hands to a ring in the wall and they raised her until her feet left the floor, and they asked her the same questions, and she could not answer them because she was crying, and after a while they let her

down, and she lay on the floor of the cell and shook, and Rufus knelt beside her and said, "There. That was not so bad, was it? Now. The book."

"There is no book," Sabina said.

He looked at her. Then he stood up and said, "Take her back. We will try again tomorrow."

She was returned to the house on the ninth day, with the others, and she was thinner and quieter and she did not cry when she saw Cassia, and she did not let go of her hand for a long time.

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Thais was questioned on the first day and on the second and on the third.

She told Cassia about it afterward, in pieces, over the following weeks, in the way that people tell the things that have been done to them: not all at once, but sideways, in the middle of other conversations, in the pauses before sleep.

They began with her name and her age and her years of service, and she answered those. They asked her about the household accounts, and she gave them the accounts — every figure, every merchant, every debt — because the accounts were honest and there was no reason to lie. They asked her about the black book, and she said there was no black book. They asked her again, and she said it again. They asked her a third time, and she said it a third time, and then they tied her hands and raised her, and the pain was worse than she had expected, and she screamed, and then they let her down and asked her again.

"There is no black book," she said.

They did it three times that day. On the second day they did it twice, and on the second night she lay in the cell and could not feel her fingers, and she thought about a kitchen in Puteoli twenty-two years before and a girl in a cart with no shoes who would not eat, and she thought: I have been in this house since before there was a house, and I am not going to be the one who ends it.

On the third day they brought in the child.

They did not question Sabina in front of Thais. That would have been too much even for the prefect's office. But they let Thais hear it: the door of the next cell, and the voices, and then the crying, and then the silence.

She told Cassia about that afterward, too. She said, "I heard her crying, and I knew that if they asked me again I would tell them everything. I would have told them about the book and the boy and the senator and the letter and the whole

of it. I would have sold the house and everyone in it to make them stop." She looked at her hands. "But they did not ask me again. They had finished with me. And by the time they came back, I had remembered that the book was burned and that there was nothing to tell them, and that the child had gone quiet because she had stopped crying and not because she had broken."

Cassia sat with her in the kitchen that night and held her hands, and did not say anything, because there was nothing to say.

They questioned Celer on the second day. He was in the cellar for four hours and came out with his apron still on and his face the colour of suet, and he was questioned about the fire, and about the oil, and about who had been in the kitchen that night.

He told them the truth, which was that he had been asleep, and that the storeroom was locked at night, and that the key was on a nail by the kitchen door, and that anyone in the household could have taken it.

They asked him whether his mistress had ever spoken of burning the house.

Celer said no.

They asked him again, and then again, and on the fourth time he said, "My mistress would burn her own hand before she burned this house. She built it out of nothing. She has spent sixteen years in it. If you want to know who burned it, ask the men who paid for it."

They did not ask him again. They sent him back to the cell, and he sat on the floor with his back against the wall and shook for an hour, and then he was sick, and then he was all right.

They questioned Chrysis on the third day, and they asked her about the senator, and about the visits, and about the book, and she told them that she was a slave and did not know anything about the affairs of the household, in Greek, and then in Latin, and then in Greek again, with a blankness that Cassia would have admired if she had been there to hear it.

She was not there to hear it. She was in the courtyard under the fig tree, and she heard nothing, and that was the worst of it.

They questioned Senno on the fourth day. He was fifteen and he had been in the house for four months and he had learned to sweep the yard and carry water and read three letters of the alphabet, and when they asked him about the book he said, in his bad Latin, "I do not know. I am new. I sweep."

The questioner wrote it down. It was the most truthful thing anyone said in that cellar all week.

They came back in a cart in the evening, and Cassia was at the door with Bathyllus and Tertulla and a physician and a table laid in the atrium with bread and wine and hot water, because she had decided that they would come back and she had decided that they would be hungry.

They came back eleven. There had been twelve.

The old gardener, Marcus, had died on the fifth night. He had been sixty-eight and he had a bad chest and he had been in the cold cell with the damp and the fear, and he had died in his sleep, and the clerk had told Cassia at the gate in the tone of a man reporting a broken dish.

"He was old," the clerk said. "It happens."

Cassia looked at him for a long moment. Then she said, "His name was Marcus. He had been with me for eleven years. He had a daughter in Ostia and two grandchildren, and he sent them half his wages every month, and he was the only person in my house who could make the roses grow." She paused. "Write that in your book. Write it down, so that when the men who did this are standing in front of the Senate, someone can read it out."

The clerk looked at her and did not write anything.

Thais came out of the cart last. She walked slowly, and her hair had gone white at the temples in nine days, and she held herself carefully, the way a person holds herself when something inside is broken. Cassia went to her and put her arms around her, and Thais stood in the street with her face against Cassia's shoulder and did not speak for a long time.

"I told them nothing," she said at last. "I want you to know that. I told them nothing."

"I know."

"They asked about the book, and about the boy, and about the senator, and I told them that I was an old woman who cooked and kept the accounts and did not know anything about the affairs of my mistress." Thais pulled back. "They did not believe me, but they could not make me say anything else, because there was nothing else to say." She looked at Cassia. "They had Sabina on the rope."

Cassia closed her eyes.

"She did not break," Thais said. "She is twelve years old and she did not break. She said there was no book, over and over, and they let her down, and she

said it again the next day." Her voice cracked. "She is the bravest person I have ever known, and she is twelve years old, and she will never be the same."

Cassia went into the house. Sabina was sitting on the bench in the kitchen with a cup of hot milk in her hands, and she looked up when Cassia came in, and her face was the face of a child who has been somewhere that no child should go.

"Domina," she said.

Cassia knelt down in front of her and took her hands, and they were cold, and there was a red mark around her wrist that would fade in a week and would not fade in a lifetime.

"I am sorry," Cassia said. "I am so sorry. I should have sent you away. I should have sent you all away the moment the accusation was laid, and I did not, because I was proud, and because I thought I could protect you, and I could not."

Sabina looked at her. Then she said, "Did they find the book?"

"No."

"Did I do it right?"

"Yes," Cassia said. "You did it exactly right."

"Then it was worth it," Sabina said, and drank her milk.

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On the eighth day, a man came to the house on the Esquiline with a letter and a proposal.

He was a neat, quiet man in a good cloak, and he would not give his name, and he sat in the tablinum with his hands on his knees and said, "My master is prepared to end this."

"Which master?"

"The senator Pactus, and the men who stand behind him. They do not want a trial. A trial is expensive and public and it makes enemies. They are prepared to withdraw the accusation, release your household, and return the boy to his father, if you will do three things."

"Name them."

"You will surrender the receipt. You will surrender the two statements. And you will leave Rome with your household and not return for five years."

Cassia looked at him for a long moment. The lamp was lit, and the house was empty, and somewhere in the cellar of the prefect's house her people were being questioned, and this man was sitting in front of her with his hands on his knees, offering her a way out.

"And if I refuse?"

"Then the trial will proceed. The boy will be found and brought to Rome and his name will be read out in the Senate, and your household will be sold at the end of it, and you will be a freedwoman with a record and no house and no money." He said it without malice. "My master is not a cruel man. He is a practical one. He would rather have your silence than your blood."

Cassia sat very still. She thought about Thais with her white hair, and Sabina with the marks on her wrists, and Marcus in a grave outside the Esquiline gate, and the room at the top of the stairs with the window over the garden, and the boy in the yard with clay on his arms.

Then she thought about Sittius in his office, and Primus in the palace, and the letter in her sleeve, and the fact that a man who offers you a way out is a man who is frightened of what will happen if you stay.

"No," she said.

The man's face did not change. "You are refusing?"

"I am refusing. And you may tell your master something for me." Cassia leaned forward. "Tell him that I have been offered a way out by better men than him, and that I have refused those too, and that the reason is not courage. The reason is arithmetic. He cannot afford a trial and I cannot afford a silence, and one of us is going to be destroyed in the Senate in twenty-two days, and I have decided that it is not going to be me."

The man stood. "He said you would say that."

"Did he?"

"He said you were the most stubborn woman in Rome, and that you would rather be burned alive than give in, and that I was to tell you one more thing if you refused." He went to the door. "He said to tell you that the boy is not with his father. He said to tell you that the boy is with a man of his, in a place you will not find, and that if you appear in the Senate on the day of the trial, the boy will be sold to a farm in the south, and you will spend the rest of your life looking for him."

He went out. Cassia sat in the tablinum for a long time, and her hands were shaking, and she did not allow herself to cry.

The questioning produced one statement that mattered, and Cassia learned of it that night from Junia's son, the clerk in the prefect's office, who came to the garden door at midnight with his face grey and a copy of the summary in his sleeve.

"A kitchen boy," he said. "The youngest one. He was questioned on the fourth day and he said that you had quarrelled with a merchant in the spring, and that you had said, in his hearing, that the man would be sorry, and that you had spoken of fire."

Cassia read the summary. It was three lines long, and it was in the boy's own words, or in the words the clerk had put into his mouth.

"He did not say that," she said.

"No."

"He is nine years old. He does not know the word 'quarrel.'"

"No." The clerk looked at her. "But it is in the record, and the record is what the court will read. The prosecution will say that you burned your own house for the insurance, and that the fire killed a slave, and that you are a woman who destroys property for money. It will not be the main charge. It does not need to be. It only needs to be in the record, so that when the senators look at you they will remember that a boy died in your house and that you profited from it."

Cassia folded the paper and gave it back to him.

"Thank you," she said. "You have been a good friend to a woman you do not know."

"My mother says you are the only person who ever listened to her about my father," the clerk said. "She says you are going to destroy the man who destroyed us." He put the paper in his sleeve. "I hope she is right."

He went out. Cassia stood in the garden with the roses and the fountain and the dark house behind her, and then she went inside and found Tertulla in the tablinum with a lamp and a cup of wine and a letter in her hand.

"The empress will see you," Tertulla said. "Tomorrow, at the fourth hour, at the palace. Alone. You are to bring the letter and nothing else, and you are not to tell anyone where you are going."

Cassia looked at the letter. It was sealed with the empress's own seal, and the wax was the colour of old wine.

"Then we have one day," she said, "and one chance, and a boy in a cell and a dead gardener and a child with marks on her wrists."

"Yes."

"Then let us not waste it."

She wrote to Corvinus that night, and gave the letter to Bathyllus to carry to the Palatine before dawn.

*They have taken the household and the child has been on the rope and the old gardener is dead. I have not broken and neither have they, but I do not know how much longer I can ask them to hold. The boy is not with his father. Pactus has him, or says he has him, which in this city is the same thing.*

*I am going to the palace tomorrow to see the empress. If it works, the trial will be held in the Senate with the emperor's secretary present, and the witnesses will be heard without the rack, and Primus will be finished. If it does not work, I will be arrested at the palace gate and you will read about it in the Acta, and you will know that I tried.*

*Do not come to the house. Do not send anyone. Do not do anything brave or stupid. If I am taken, go to Tertulla and do what she tells you, because she is cleverer than both of us and she has no pride left to get in the way.*

*And Lucius. If this goes badly, and if the boy is found, do not let him be alone. Whatever it costs you. Whatever it does to your name. Sit in a room with him and tell him the truth and let him hate you for it if he wants to. A person who has been lied to all his life does not need a father. He needs a witness.*

*C.*

She sealed it and gave it to Bathyllus, and then she went to bed and slept, and in the morning she put on the plain stola and the dark veil and the ring with her seal and the knot of rosemary and lavender that Sabina had made her, and she went to the palace.

She went to bed, and slept, for the first time in nine nights, and dreamed of nothing at all.

CHAPTER

# NINETEEN

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The palace on the Palatine was not one building. It was a hill covered with buildings, added to by every emperor for a hundred years, and by the reign of Trajan it had become a city inside the city: halls and courtyards and gardens and bathhouses and barracks and offices, connected by corridors and stairways and passages so complicated that men who had lived there all their lives still got lost in it.

Cassia had never been inside it. She had stood outside the gates on festival days, and she had seen the crowds go in and out, and she had known a dozen men who came and went through those doors every week, and she had never once been inside, because there was no reason for a woman like her to be there, and because a woman like her did not go where she was not wanted.

She went in through the gate on the Via Sacra with the empress's letter in her hand and a steward in front of her and two guards behind, and she walked through corridors of marble and porphyry and gilt with her heart going like a drum and her face as still as a painted wall.

The palace smelled of incense and wax and hot stone. There were slaves everywhere, silent, moving in and out of doorways with trays and papers and messages. There were soldiers of the guard at every turning, standing in their scale armour with their hands on their spears. There were clerks in little rooms off the corridors, bent over desks, and the sound of their pens was like the sound of insects. And there were works of art, more of them than Cassia had ever seen in one place: statues and paintings and mosaics and tables of coloured marble, and ceilings of gilded bronze, and a fountain in a courtyard that was made of a single block of porphyry and had been brought from Egypt at a cost that could not be counted.

She thought, walking through it: I have spent twenty-four years building a house that would make men lower their voices, and this is what the men who own the world live in. And then she thought: and they are just as frightened as I am. Every one of them. You can see it in their faces.

The steward stopped at a door at the end of a long corridor and said, "The empress will see you in the garden room. You will not speak until you are spoken to. You will not sit until you are told to sit. You will not touch anything. You will keep your eyes down." He looked at her. "And domina. She is not like the other one. She does not want flattery and she does not want cleverness. She wants the truth, and she has very little patience with people who take a long time to get to it."

"Then we will get on very well," Cassia said.

She waited for an hour in a room off the corridor with a bench, a fountain, and a view of a courtyard where the guard was drilling.

There was one other person waiting: a Greek of about seventy, in a clean but threadbare cloak, with a scroll case under his arm and the patient, faintly amused expression of a man who had been waiting in palaces for fifty years.

"You are here to see the empress," he said.

"I am."

"Then you will wait an hour. She is reading in the garden and she does not like to be interrupted before the fourth hour." He shifted on the bench. "I am here to see the emperor's secretary. I have been here every day for a month. I am a teacher of philosophy, and I have written a book about the education of princes, and I have been told by three different freedmen that it is excellent and by none of them that it will be read."

"I am sorry," Cassia said.

"Do not be. It is an old story." The philosopher looked at her. "You are the woman with the house on the Esquiline."

"I am."

"I have heard of you. I have heard that you keep a good table and a dangerous book and that half the Senate owes you money." He smiled. "I have also heard that you are being destroyed by a delator, and that the whole city is watching to see whether you will survive it. It is the most interesting thing in Rome this month. More interesting than the games."

"And what do you think will happen?"

"I think you will survive," the philosopher said. "You have the look of a survivor. I have seen it in soldiers and in slaves and in one or two philosophers. It is not courage. It is a kind of stubbornness that has been beaten into a person until it becomes a virtue." He stood, because a steward had appeared at the end of the corridor. "When this is over, domina, and you are rich and safe and bored, send for me. I will come and dine at your table and tell you about the education of princes, and you will tell me about the education of a woman in Puteoli, and we will both learn something."

"What is your name?"

"Epictetus," he said, and went out.

The garden room was small, by the standards of the palace, and it was open on one side to a courtyard with a fountain and a fig tree and a great many roses. The empress Pompeia Plotina was sitting in a chair by the open side with a book on her knee and a slave behind her with a fan. She was perhaps sixty, with grey hair drawn back plainly, and a long, grave, intelligent face, and she was dressed in a plain stola of undyed wool with no jewellery at all.

She looked up when Cassia came in and looked at her for a long moment without saying anything.

"Domina," Cassia said, and bowed her head.

"Sit down," the empress said. "You have been standing in corridors for an hour and you are not as young as you were."

Cassia sat. The empress closed her book and put it on the table beside her.

"You have brought the letter," she said.

"I have."

"Give it to me."

Cassia took the letter from her sleeve and handed it over. The empress unfolded it and read it, slowly, once, and then again. Her face did not change. When she had finished she folded it and put it on the table and sat for a moment with her hands in her lap.

"This is my husband's money," she said. "This is the grain of Egypt and the taxes of Gaul and the rents of the imperial estates. It has been stolen by a clerk and shared with a senator and hidden in a bank on the Via Lata, and the clerk is now the man who counts the money for the man who owns the world." She looked up. "Do you know what happens to a woman like me who brings this to the emperor?"

"I do not."

"He will be angry. He will be angry with the clerk, and he will be angry with the senator, and he will be angry with me for telling him, because I will have made him look a fool, and a man who has been made to look a fool does not thank the person who showed him the mirror." Plotina's mouth moved. "I have been married to him for thirty years. I know exactly how angry he will be, and I know exactly how long it will last, and I know that it will be worth it."

"Then you will help me."

"I will help you," the empress said, "but first I will tell you something, because you are going to hear it from someone else if I do not, and because I would rather you heard it from me." She set the letter down. "The emperor is not well. He has not been well since the Dacian war. His feet swell and his breath is short and he cannot sleep, and the physicians say it is the dropsy and the physicians say a great many other things that they do not say in front of him. He is fifty-nine years old. He has been emperor for fifteen years, and he has spent them in the saddle, and there is not much of him left."

Cassia said nothing.

"When he dies," Plotina said, "there will be a question about who follows him. There is a man in the East, a general, who has been winning battles and making friends, and there is a boy in the palace who is clever and charming and who has been waiting for twenty years for someone to die, and there is the Senate, which would like to choose one of its own and knows that it will not be allowed to." She looked at Cassia. "In the year after the emperor dies, every man who has a secret will be in danger. Every clerk, every senator, every freedman, every woman with a house and a book. The men who survive will be the ones who have made themselves useful to the right people and dangerous to the wrong ones, and who have not made a spectacle of themselves."

"Then you are telling me to be quiet."

"I am telling you to be careful," the empress said. "A trial in the Senate with the whole city watching is a very loud thing. It will make you famous, and fame in this city is a kind of debt, and the interest is collected by whoever is in power when it comes due." She leaned forward. "I can protect you for a year. I cannot protect you for ten. So take the trial, and win it, and then go home and be dull and rich and keep your household safe, and let the men in the palace destroy each other in their own time."

Cassia looked at her. In the courtyard the fountain played, and the roses moved, and somewhere beyond the wall a soldier was shouting a command.

"You are telling me to survive," she said.

"Yes."

"Everyone tells me to survive. My steward tells me to survive. My friend tells me to survive. The old woman who sold my son tells me that she did it so that I would survive." Cassia shook her head. "I have survived for twenty-four years. I have survived Puteoli and the fire and the questioning and the whole of it, and I am beginning to think that survival is a very small ambition."

The empress looked at her for a long moment.

"What would you have instead?"

"I would have justice," Cassia said. "Not for me. For the gardener who died in a cell because a banker wanted a house. For the child who was put on a rope because a delator wanted a fee. For the boy on the Via Ostiensis who has been hidden and hunted and used as a threat for six months, and who does not even know why." She stopped. "I have spent my whole life being sensible. You are asking me to be sensible again, and I will do it, because you are right and because I have a household and a house and a business and I cannot afford to be a hero. But I want you to know what you are asking."

The empress was silent. Then she said, "I know exactly what I am asking. I have been asking it of myself for thirty years." She picked up her book again. "You will have your arsonists. You will have your trial. And when it is over, you will send me a list of the men who burned your house and killed your boy, and I will make sure that they are not forgotten in whatever quiet arrangement is made about the rest." She looked up. "That is the most I can do. It is more than most women in this palace get."

"Then you will help me."

"I will help you," the empress said, "because it is my husband's money and because I do not like thieves, and because a man who has been robbing the emperor for twenty years is a danger to the empire, and because I am bored." She picked up the letter again. "But I will not do it your way. You want a trial in the Senate, with the whole city watching and the whole story told. That is a woman's idea of justice. It is not how these things are done."

"Then how are they done?"

"Quietly." Plotina set the letter down. "The clerk will be removed from his office. He will be given a house in the country and a pension and a very clear understanding that if he ever returns to Rome he will be prosecuted for fraud. The senator Pactus will be told that his patron has fallen and that he would be wise to withdraw his accusation and retire to his estates. The banker Sittius will be investigated by the prefect of the grain supply and will pay a fine that will ruin him. And your senator will be acquitted, and his household will be released, and the boy will be left alone, and no one will ever know why."

"And the truth?"

"The truth will be known to the people who need to know it." The empress looked at her. "You are a woman who has spent her life in a house where men tell you things they would not tell their wives. You know that the truth is not a thing that is announced. It is a thing that is used."

Cassia sat very still. The fountain played in the courtyard. The roses moved in the warm wind.

"And if I refuse?" she said. "If I insist on the trial?"

"Then you will have your trial," Plotina said, "and you will probably win, because you have a letter and a receipt and a midwife and a dead gardener, and because the Senate loves nothing more than the destruction of a man who has risen too fast. And when you have won, the clerk will be executed, and the senator Pactus will be exiled, and the banker will hang himself in his bath, and the emperor will be humiliated in front of the whole city, and he will remember that it was a freedwoman with a grudge who did it to him." She paused. "And then, in a year or two, when the scandal has been forgotten, he will find a reason to destroy you. He will not do it himself. He will find a magistrate who owes him a favour, and there will be a charge, and your house will be seized, and your household will be sold, and the boy on the Via Ostiensis will be a slave before he is thirty. That is what happens to people who win too publicly in Rome."

Cassia looked at the empress. She had spent her whole life believing that the truth was a weapon, and here was a woman who had spent her whole life in the palace telling her that the truth was a tool, and that the difference between the two was the difference between a soldier and a surgeon.

"What do you want me to do?" she said.

"I want you to give the trial to the Senate," Plotina said, "with the emperor's secretary in the chamber and the emperor's name kept out of it. I want the clerk

Primus to be tried and condemned for fraud, and I want it done in public, because a public condemnation is a warning to every other clerk in the palace. And I want the senator Pactus to be ruined by his own accusation, in front of the men he has spent his life trying to impress." She leaned forward. "I do not want a quiet little arrangement in a back room. I want a spectacle. But I want it to be a spectacle about the theft of the emperor's money, and not about the private life of a senator and a freedwoman and a boy on the Via Ostiensis."

Cassia understood. She understood entirely, and she felt the shape of the bargain close around her like a hand.

"You will give me the trial," she said, "and in exchange I will keep the boy out of it."

"Yes."

"And the midwife?"

"The midwife will testify to the child, because the child is the foundation of the accusation, and without the child there is no case. But she will testify in a closed session, and her evidence will be sealed, and the receipt will be read to the Senate and then sealed and put in the archive, and the name of the potter and the name of the boy will not be spoken aloud." Plotina picked up her book. "That is the bargain. It is not perfect. It is the best that can be done in this city by a woman in your position, and I am offering it to you because I have been in this palace for thirty years and I have never once been able to help a woman like you, and because I am tired of watching clever women destroyed by stupid men."

Cassia sat for a moment. Then she said, "I have one condition."

"Name it."

"The men who burned my house and killed a child will not be part of the quiet arrangement. The arsonist has given a statement, and the steward who paid him has been named. I want them tried and punished, in public, before the trial of the senator. I want the city to know that a boy died in my house and that the men who did it were not important enough to be protected."

The empress looked at her for a long moment. Then she said, "That is a very Roman condition."

"I am a very Roman woman."

"Yes," Plotina said. "I can see that." She stood. "You will have your arsonists. And you will have your trial. And now you will go home, domina, and you will

tell no one where you have been, and you will wait for a message from my steward. It will come within three days."

Cassia stood. At the door she turned and said, "Domina. May I ask you something?"

"You may."

"Why are you doing this? Not the fraud. The other thing. The boy. You have no reason to care about a potter on the Via Ostiensis."

The empress looked at her. In the light from the courtyard, with the roses behind her and the book in her hand, she looked like a woman who had been beautiful once and had put it away, and who had spent thirty years learning to be useful instead.

"I had a child," she said. "A girl. She lived three days. It was a long time ago, and the emperor does not speak of it, and neither do I." She opened her book. "I have spent my life in this palace being sensible. It is a great comfort to be unreasonable once."

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She was halfway down the corridor when a man stepped out of a doorway in front of her.

He was sixty, small, neat, with the hands of a clerk and the face of a man who had not been refused anything in twenty years. He wore a plain tunic of excellent wool and no jewellery, and he stood in the middle of the corridor with his hands clasped behind his back and said, "Domina."

Cassia stopped. The steward behind her had stopped too, and had gone very still.

"You are Primus," she said.

"I am." He inclined his head. "I have been watching your career with great interest."

"And I have been watching yours."

"I doubt that. No one watches a clerk." He smiled. "I have a proposal for you."

"I have had a great many proposals this month."

"This one is simple. You have a letter. I have a great deal of money. You give me the letter, and I give you three million sesterces and a house in Campania and a guarantee that no one in your household will ever be questioned again." He

said it in the tone of a man offering a seat on a bench. “It is a good offer. It is more money than you will make in ten years of senators.”

“It is a good offer,” Cassia said. “But I have just spent an hour with the empress, and she has offered me something better.”

The clerk’s face did not change, but something behind it did — a small movement, like a fish under ice.

“The empress,” he said, “is a woman with a book and no power.”

“The empress,” Cassia said, “is the wife of the man whose money you have been stealing for twenty years, and she is very bored, and she has just decided to be unreasonable.” She stepped around him. “You should have taken the house in the country when you had the chance, Primus. It is a very pleasant house. I have seen it from the road.”

She walked on down the corridor. Behind her, the clerk stood without moving, and the steward followed her, and the guards followed the steward, and the whole palace went on around them with its incense and its marble and its clerks and its silence.

At the gate on the Via Sacra, Bathyllus was waiting with his face grey.

“Domina,” he said. “The household has been released. All of them. They came back an hour ago.”

Cassia stopped. “All of them?”

“All of them. The prefect’s clerk came himself with a paper and a cart, and he would not say why, and he would not look at anyone.” Bathyllus took her arm. “And domina. There is a message from the Palatine. The old woman is dying. The senator says to come at once.”

Cassia stood in the street with the sun on her face and the letter in her sleeve and the smell of the palace still in her clothes.

“Take me home first,” she said. “I want to see them.”

“Domina—“

“Take me home, Bathyllus. I have been in the palace for an hour and I have not seen my household in nine days and I am going to see them before I go anywhere else.”

On the way home Bathyllus told her what had happened at the prefect’s gate.

“The clerk came out himself,” he said. “He had a paper in his hand and he read it twice, and then he told the guards to open the cells, and they brought

them out one by one. He would not say who had sent the order. He would not say anything at all. He looked like a man who had been told that the ground under his feet was not as solid as he had thought."

"Was there a man with him? A small man, neat, in a good cloak?"

"There was a man in the courtyard who did not come forward. He stood by the fig tree with his hands behind his back and watched them come out, and when they were all out he turned and walked away." Bathyllus paused. "I have seen him before, domina. He was at the Curia on the day of the hearing. He was standing behind Pactus."

Cassia looked out of the litter at the streets going past.

"He was counting them," she said. "He was making sure that all twelve came out. He wanted to know that the order had been obeyed."

"Eleven," Bathyllus said. "Eleven came out."

"Yes," Cassia said. "Eleven."

He took her home. They were all in the atrium, all eleven of them, with Thais in the middle and Sabina holding her hand, and when Cassia came through the door they did not cheer and they did not weep; they stood in a line and looked at her, and Thais said, "There you are," and Cassia said, "Here I am," and then she went around the line and put her hand on each of their heads, one by one, like a woman counting her stock.

Then she went to the Palatine.

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The house on the Palatine was full of lamps and quiet people.

They had put the sedan chair down in the street and Cassia had walked up the hill on foot, because the litter could not get through the crowd of servants and clients and neighbours who had gathered outside the door in the way that Romans gather outside a house where someone is dying, and by the time she reached the atrium she had been recognized three times and had said nothing to anyone.

Aemilia met her at the foot of the stairs. She was in a plain dress with her hair down and no jewellery, and she looked as though she had been awake for two days.

"She has had a turn," she said. "The physician says it is the end. He says she may last the night or she may last an hour, and he says there is nothing to be

done but keep her warm and give her the poppy when the pain is bad." She looked at Cassia. "She has been asking for you since noon. She will not have anyone else in the room. Not me, not the children, not her son. She says she has something to say to you and that she will not say it to anyone else."

"Where is Corvinus?"

"In the garden. He has been walking up and down for an hour." Aemilia's mouth moved. "He is afraid. He has spent his whole life being afraid of that woman and now he is afraid of losing her, and he does not know what to do with either."

Cassia looked up the stairs. The corridor was lit with lamps, and the door at the end of it was open, and she could hear, faintly, the sound of a woman breathing.

"Does she know about the empress?" Cassia said.

"No one knows about the empress. You told me not to tell anyone, and I have not told anyone, not even my husband." Aemilia paused. "Did it work?"

"It worked."

Aemilia closed her eyes for a moment. When she opened them they were wet.

"Then go up," she said. "She has been waiting for you, and she is dying, and whatever there is between you, she is dying, and I have discovered in the last two days that I do not want to hate a dying woman. It is a waste of the little time I have left with her."

Cassia went up the stairs.

At the door of the room she stopped. The brazier was lit, and the lamps were low, and the old woman was propped up on her pillows with her eyes closed, and her face was the colour of the wax on the masks in the atrium below. The physician sat on a stool in the corner with his bag at his feet, and the slave who had been with her for thirty years sat by the bed with a cloth in her hand.

Cassia went in and stood at the foot of the bed.

Sulpicia Varia opened her eyes.

"You came," she said.

"I came."

"Good." The old woman's hand moved on the coverlet, a small, impatient movement. "Send them out. All of them. I have something to tell you, and I do not want it heard by a physician or a slave or my daughter-in-law, because they

will all tell someone, and the someone will tell the city, and the city will tell the Senate, and by the Ides the whole of Rome will know what I did."

Cassia looked at the physician. He rose and went out without a word, and the slave followed, and the door closed, and the room was quiet except for the brazier and the old woman's breathing.

"Sit down," Sulpicia Varia said. "This will take a while."

CHAPTER

# TWENTY

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The old woman talked for two hours.

She talked slowly, in a voice that was barely above a whisper, and Cassia sat on the stool by the bed with her hands in her lap and listened, and the brazier ticked, and the lamps burned down, and outside the window the night went on over the Palatine.

She had begun to plan it in the spring. Not the poison — the poison had been in her mind for years, in the way that a woman who has been humiliated for twenty-six years keeps a thing in her mind and takes it out sometimes and looks at it. But the plan, the actual plan, had begun in the spring, when her husband had come back from Rome in a rage about a debt and had struck her across the face in front of a slave.

"He had done it before," she said. "He had done it a hundred times. But that time there was a slave in the room, and the slave looked at me, and I saw myself in her face. I saw what I looked like. And I thought: I am fifty-three years old and I have been married to this man for twenty-six years and he will do this to me until one of us dies, and it is not going to be him."

She had a physician who was in debt. She had a steward who was in debt. She had a cook who could be frightened. She had a knowledge of herbs that she had learned from her own mother, who had learned it from hers, and she had a garden at Tibur with a bed of poppies and a bed of hellebore and a corner where the monkshood grew.

She had not used the monkshood. She had used something slower and kinder and easier to explain: a little in his wine at dinner, a little more in the posset he took before bed, a third dose in the morning when he complained of a headache. His heart was bad. The physician had told him two years before that

he must not excite himself, and he had ignored it, as he ignored everything that did not suit him.

"I did not know whether it would kill him," she said. "I knew that it might. I knew that if it did not, he would beat me within an inch of my life and I would have to try again. And I lay in my bed that night and listened to him breathing in the next room and I thought: please. Please let it be tonight." She closed her eyes. "And it was."

Cassia sat very still.

"Your mother," the old woman said. "Daphne. I have not thought about her in years, and now I cannot stop."

Cassia went very still.

"She was a good servant and a bad laundress and she sang when she worked," Sulpicia Varia said. "She had a temper and a laugh and she could not sew. She died in the winter of the year I was thirty-five, of a fever, in the room over the laundry, and I paid for the funeral and I kept you in the household because she had asked me to and because I do not like to be in debt to a dead woman." Her eyes were closed. "She asked me to look after you. She said, 'Domina, she is clever, she will be worth something to you.' I said I would. And I did, in my way. I taught you to read, I put you in my own rooms, I let you sit at the foot of my chair and listen to the poets." She paused. "And then I sold you to a brothel and told you your child was dead. I have thought about that too. I have spent twenty-four years thinking about the difference between what I promised a dying woman and what I did."

Cassia said nothing. She was thinking about lavender and a song about a boat and hands that were red and cracked and always gentle, and about the fact that the old woman in the bed had known her mother better than she did.

"Did she suffer?" she said.

"No. The fever took her in four days. She was not in pain at the end; she was delirious, and she talked about a boat." The old woman's mouth moved. "She called for you. She called for you for two days, and I sat with her, and I told her that you were asleep, and I sent for the physician twice, and there was nothing to be done."

The brazier ticked. The lamp burned. Cassia sat on the stool with her hands in her lap and did not move for a long time.

"Thank you," she said at last. "For sitting with her."

"It was the least I could do."

"Yes," Cassia said. "It was."

"And the cup you gave me?"

"Poppy and honey and a little wine, and three drops of bitter almond for the taste, the way a cook puts it in a cake. Nothing more than that. I wanted you asleep, and I wanted you quiet, and I wanted the birth to happen without a great deal of noise." The old woman's mouth moved. "It was not cruelty. It was the opposite. If you had been awake, you would have fought, and they would have held you down, and you would have remembered it for the rest of your life. I gave you the only mercy I had left to give."

"And then you took my son."

"And then I took your son." Sulpicia Varia opened her eyes. "I had planned that too. Not the child — the child was a complication. But when the midwife told me that you were in labour, I understood that the child was the answer to everything. A living child would have been a scandal and a weapon. A dead child was a grief. A child given to a potter in Rome was a debt that could be paid." She looked at Cassia. "I chose the potter myself. I sent the steward to the market to find a man with a good trade and no children and a wife who could not conceive. It took him three weeks. He found Gaius Vibidius, who was known in the trade as an honest man, and who had been to the temple of Juno Lucina six times in five years and had gone home every time with nothing."

"You chose him," Cassia said, "because he was kind."

"I chose him because he was kind," the old woman said. "I want you to know that. Whatever else I have done, I did not give your son to a cruel man. I chose the kindest man I could find, and I paid the dealer to forget the address, and I have spent twenty-four years paying him to keep his mouth shut, and I have prayed every day that the boy would have a good life." She stopped. "That is not an excuse. I know it is not an excuse. It is the truth."

Cassia looked at her. In the low light the old woman's face was the colour of ash, and her hands were like birds on the coverlet, and there was nothing left of the woman who had terrified a household for fifty years except the voice and the eyes.

"Why did you not tell me?" she said. "After he was dead. After you had done it. Why did you let me go to Puteoli believing that my son was dead, when you could have told me the truth and given me money and sent me to Rome?"

"Because I was afraid," Sulpicia Varia said. "Not of you. Of the world. If you had known, you would have come back, and you would have wanted the boy, and the boy would have been a scandal, and the scandal would have destroyed my son. I had just killed my husband to save this family. I was not going to let a slave girl destroy it the week after." She paused. "And because I did not think you would survive. I thought you would be dead within the year. I thought Puteoli would kill you, or a client would, or the pox, and that the boy would be safe and the secret would die with you." Her eyes moved over Cassia's face. "You did not die. You bought the house and you bought the business and you came back to Rome and you built a fortune, and I have watched you for sixteen years, and every year I have thought: she is going to find out. She is going to come for me. And you never did, and I began to think that the gods had decided to be merciful, and then my son stood for the Asian command, and the clerk in the palace decided that we were a liability, and it all came apart."

"The clerk," Cassia said. "Primus. He knew about the child?"

"He knew about the death. He did not know about the child. He knew that my husband had died in suspicious circumstances and that the physician had signed a certificate and that the steward had been paid. He has been holding it over me for twenty-four years, the way he holds everything over everyone. When he decided to destroy the family, he gave the information to Pactus, and Pactus gave it to a delator, and the delator found the midwife." She closed her eyes. "It was not the boy they wanted. It was the death. The boy was a gift they found on the way."

Cassia sat with that for a moment.

"Tell me what he looks like," the old woman said.

Cassia looked at her.

"Please," Sulpicia Varia said. "I have never seen him. I have thought about him for twenty-four years and I have never seen him. Tell me what he looks like."

Cassia was silent for a moment. Then she said, "He is tall. Taller than his father, I think, or he will be. He has the family nose and the family jaw, and he has his hair, which is the colour of dark honey, and he has a laugh that carries." She stopped. "He works with clay. His arms are grey with it to the elbow. He has a father who calls him in to supper and cuffs him on the head, and a shop on the

Via Ostiensis with a kiln in the yard, and when I saw him he was carrying a board of cups on his shoulder and laughing at something in the doorway."

The old woman's eyes were closed. Two tears ran down her face and into the pillow.

"He is happy," she said.

"He is happy."

"Then it was worth it."

"No," Cassia said. "It was not worth it. But he is happy, and that is a thing that happened, and I am not going to pretend it did not." She stood up. "You do not get to decide that it was worth it. You do not get to make this a story in which you were right. You made a choice. It cost me twenty-four years. And it gave him a life. Both of those things are true, and you will have to die with both of them, and so will I."

"What do you want from me?" she said.

Sulpicia Varia opened her eyes. They were wet.

"I want you to tell him," she said. "The boy. When this is over, when he knows who you are, and who his father is, and what was done — I want you to tell him that his grandmother chose a kind man to raise him. I want you to tell him that she was a monster and that she was sorry, and that she thought about him every day for twenty-four years, and that she hoped he was happy." Her voice cracked. "I know you will not forgive me. I am not asking for that. I am asking you to carry one true thing about me to a boy I will never meet."

Cassia looked at her for a long time. The brazier ticked. The lamp guttered.

"I will tell him," she said. "I will tell him all of it. Not the version that makes you a saint. The version that makes you a woman who did something terrible and knew it, and who chose the kindest man she could find, and who paid for it for twenty-four years." She stood. "And I will tell him that you asked me to tell him you were sorry. Because you did ask. And because it is true."

The old woman closed her eyes. Her hand moved on the coverlet, and Cassia, after a moment, took it.

"Thank you," Sulpicia Varia said.

"Do not thank me. I am not doing it for you."

"I know," the old woman said. "But I am thanking you anyway. It is the last thing I have left to do."

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She died at dawn, with the whole family in the room.

They had come in one by one in the last hour: Aemilia first, because she was the mistress of the house now and because she had decided that she would not be kept out; then Publius, who stood at the foot of the bed with his hands behind his back and his face white; then young Sulpicia, who had come from her husband's house in the middle of the night and who sat on the floor by the bed and held her grandmother's other hand; then Corvinus, who came in last and stood by the door and did not move.

The old woman did not speak again. She lay with her eyes closed and her breathing getting smaller and smaller, and the physician came and felt her pulse and shook his head and went out, and the slave woman lit the last lamp, and the sky outside the window went from grey to rose.

At the end she opened her eyes and looked around the room, at all of them, and her mouth moved, and Cassia, who was closest, leaned down and heard her say, "The masks. Polish the masks."

Then she died.

There was a silence in the room. Then Aemilia began to cry, quietly, with her hand over her mouth, and Publius went out, and young Sulpicia put her head down on the bed and sobbed, and Corvinus stood by the door with his face in his hands.

Cassia stood up. She looked at the dead woman for a moment, and then she went to the window and opened it, and the morning came in, and the city was waking below the hill, and somewhere a cart went past on the stones.

"The masks," she said. "Someone had better polish the masks."

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The funeral was three days later, and it was the largest funeral on the Palatine that year.

The old woman had left instructions, and the instructions were precise. The procession was to go from the house to the tomb on the Via Appia, and the ancestors were to be represented by actors wearing the wax masks, and the actors were to be hired from the best troupe in the city, and the eulogy was to be delivered by her son and not by a hired orator, and there was to be no display of

grief by the hired mourners beyond what was customary, because she had always thought the professional wailing was vulgar.

The whole of the Palatine came. The whole of the Senate came. The consul came, and the prefect, and a dozen men who had been her husband's friends and had not spoken to her in twenty years, and a hundred clients who owed their fortunes to the family, and a crowd of the poor who came for the bread that was distributed in her name.

Cassia stood at the back of the procession with Tertulla and watched the masks go by: the Sulpicii, four hundred years of them, carried on the shoulders of actors who had been paid to look like them, and behind them the bier with the old woman's body, and behind that the family in black.

Corvinus walked behind the bier with his son on one side and his daughter on the other, and his face was the face of a man who had been asked to carry something too heavy for him, and who was carrying it anyway.

"He is going to be all right," Tertulla said.

"How do you know?"

"Because he is still walking."

At the tomb, the eulogy was spoken. Corvinus spoke for a quarter of an hour, and it was a good speech, and it was, Cassia thought, entirely honest: he spoke about his mother's courage and her hardness and her devotion to the family, and he did not pretend that she had been kind, and he did not pretend that she had been easy, and at the end he said, "She did what she thought was necessary, and she paid for it, and she did not ask for anyone's forgiveness. I ask it for her, because she cannot."

There was a murmur of approval. The old men nodded. The women wept. The body was put in the tomb with the ashes of her husband and the ashes of four generations of Sulpicii, and the stone was sealed, and the family went home.

Pactus was there.

He stood at the edge of the crowd in a black cloak with his clients behind him, and he listened to the eulogy with his head bowed and his hands clasped, and when it was over he came forward and put a handful of earth on the tomb and said something to Corvinus that Cassia could not hear.

"What did he say?" she asked Tertulla.

"I could not hear it either. But look at his face."

Corvinus's face was white. He said something back, short and hard, and Pactus inclined his head and moved away, and the crowd closed around him.

"He is not here for the funeral," Tertulla said. "He is here to be seen at the funeral. There is a difference. A man who is seen at the funeral of his enemy's mother is a man who is saying to the city: I am not afraid of him, and I am not his enemy, and when I destroy him it will be the law that does it and not me."

"It is a good performance."

"It is a very good performance. He has been rehearsing it for a month." Tertulla took her arm. "Come. The family is going back to the house, and there will be food, and you are not invited, and we are going to your house to eat bread and cheese and drink too much wine and talk about something other than death."

They went. But before they did, Cassia looked back at the tomb, and at the masks on their stands, and at the crowd dispersing into the Via Appia, and she thought about an old woman who had spent her life keeping a house and a name and a family together, and who had died asking for the masks to be polished.

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The will was read that evening in the tablinum, with the family and the freedmen and the chief clients present, and the lawyer read it in the flat, careful voice of a man who has read a great many wills and has learned not to be surprised by any of them.

The house and the estate went to Corvinus, with a life interest to Aemilia. The money in the strongbox was divided among the children and the grandchildren. The vineyard in Etruria, which was mortgaged to Sittius, was to be sold and the proceeds used to pay the debts, and if there was anything left, it was to go to the poor of the Palatine district.

The slaves of the household were to be freed. All of them. Every one, with a sum of money for each, and a letter of recommendation, and the freedom of any children they might have in the future.

There was a bequest to the midwife Psyche of Tibur, of a hundred thousand sesterces, "for services rendered and silence kept."

And there was a bequest to Antonia Cassia, freedwoman, of a small wooden chest, "which is in my room and which is to be given to her unopened."

The lawyer read it out and looked up. "That is the whole of the will," he said. "There is a codicil, which is sealed, and which is to be opened only if the legatee requests it."

"I request it," Cassia said.

The lawyer broke the seal. He read the codicil to himself first, and his face did something complicated, and then he read it aloud.

*To Antonia Cassia. I have watched you for sixteen years and I have never once spoken to you. You have done what I could not do, and you have done it without a husband and without a name, and I have envied you every day. The chest contains the jewellery of my marriage, which my husband gave me and which I have not worn since the year he died. It is worth a great deal. Sell it and give the money to the boy, and tell him it is from his grandmother, and tell him that she hopes he has a good life and that he does not have to be afraid of anything.*

*I am not asking for your forgiveness. I am asking you to be better than me. You will be. You have already been.*

The lawyer folded the codicil. The room was silent. Corvinus was looking at the table. Aemilia was looking at Cassia.

Aemilia came to her as the room was emptying.

"The jewellery," she said. "It is worth a great deal. It should have gone to my daughter."

"It was hers to give."

"It should have gone to my daughter," Aemilia said again, and her voice was not angry; it was tired. "I have spent nineteen years in that house, and I have kept it running while she sat in her chair and gave orders, and I have borne her cruelty and her coldness and her contempt, and at the end she left the only thing of value to a woman she met once in a garden." She looked at Cassia. "Do you understand what that means?"

"I understand that she was trying to make amends."

"To you."

"To the boy," Cassia said. "Not to me. She could not make amends to me. She knew that. This was the only amends she could make."

Aemilia was silent. Then she said, "Sell it. Give the money to the boy. I do not want it." She turned to go, and then stopped. "But Cassia. My daughter is fifteen years old and she has been married for a month to a man she does not love, and she has just watched her grandmother die, and she is going to hear the

whole story in the Senate in twelve days. When this is over, she will need someone who is not her mother and not her father and not her husband. She will need you."

"I know."

"Then do not let her down."

Cassia stood.

"Where is the chest?" she said.

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She took it home that night and opened it in the tablinum with the lamps lit and the household around her.

It was a chest of cedarwood with a bronze lock, and inside it was every piece of jewellery the old woman had ever owned: the gold necklace with the cameo of a woman's head, the emerald earrings, the bracelet of twisted gold, the rings, the brooch with the brooch that had pinned the bridal veil at four generations of weddings. It was worth a fortune. It was worth more than the house.

Cassia looked at it for a long time. Then she closed the lid and locked it and said, "Thais. Put it in the strongroom. We will sell it in the autumn, when the trial is over and the city has stopped talking, and the money will go to the boy." She paused. "And when he is ready to hear it, I will tell him that his grandmother left it to him, and that she hoped he would not be afraid of anything."

Thais took the chest. At the door she said, "Domina. The trial is in twelve days."

"I know."

"The whole city is talking about the funeral. They are saying that the old woman's death is a judgment on the family, and that the senator will not survive the trial, and that the whole house will fall." Thais paused. "And they are saying that you were in the palace last week, and that the empress received you, and that the emperor's secretary has been asking questions about the grain accounts."

Cassia looked up.

"Who is saying that?"

"Everyone," Thais said. "It is in the wine shops. It is in the baths. It is in the market. Someone is spreading it, and it is not us."

Cassia sat for a moment. Then she laughed — a short, hard, entirely unexpected laugh.

"Primus," she said. "He is trying to make me look like the emperor's woman. He is trying to make the Senate think that the trial is a palace plot, so that the senators will vote for his man out of spite." She stood. "It is a good move. It is exactly the move I would have made."

"What do we do?"

"We do nothing," Cassia said. "We let him spread it, and we let the city talk, and in twelve days we go into that chamber with the receipt and the statements and the arsonist and the midwife, and we tell the truth in front of the whole Senate." She looked at the locked chest in Thais's arms. "And we do not mention the empress once. Not a single time. Because a woman who is accused of being the emperor's creature is a woman who is finished in this city, but a woman who says nothing and produces the documents is a woman they have to listen to."

She went to bed.

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On the ninth day after the old woman's death, four days before the trial, the freed slaves of the Palatine house came out to the tomb for the rites, and there were forty of them, and they stood in a rough half-circle in the road and said the words and poured the wine and went away again.

Cassia went out to them. She had not intended to; she had come to the tomb alone, early, before the family, with a jar of wine and a handful of flowers, and she found them already there, cooks and porters and a woman who had been the old woman's dresser for thirty years, and a boy of about fourteen who held the dresser's hand.

"You are the lady from the Esquiline," the dresser said. "The one who came to the house at the end."

"I am."

"She talked about you." The dresser looked at the tomb. "Not to us. She talked to the steward, and we heard it through the door, the way we always heard everything through that door. She said you were the only person in Rome who had never asked her for anything, and she did not know what to do with you."

Cassia looked at the flowers in her hand.

"She gave me a great deal," she said.

"She gave everyone a great deal. That was the trouble with her." The dresser turned. "We are free, then. All of us. She put it in the will, and the lawyer has read it, and my son is free and I am free and we have money for the first time in our lives." She paused. "And I do not know what to feel. I have been in that house since I was sixteen. I have hated her and I have loved her and I have washed her and fed her and lied for her, and now she is dead and I am free and I am standing in a road outside a tomb with a boy who does not know how to be free either."

"You will learn," Cassia said.

"How?"

"The way I did. Badly, and slowly, and with a great deal of help from people who had no reason to give it." Cassia put the flowers down. "Come to my house on the Esquiline. Not today. In a month, when the noise has died down. I will find you work if you want it and I will leave you alone if you do not, and there will be no debt."

The dresser looked at her for a long moment. Then she said, "Why?"

"Because someone did it for me once," Cassia said, "and I have been trying to pay it back for sixteen years, and I am nowhere near finished."

In the morning she began, very carefully, to prepare for the trial, and she did not come out of the tablinum for three days.

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The dresser came to the house on the Esquiline in September, when the trial was over and the city had found other things to talk about, and Cassia gave her the linen room and a wage and a contract, and she stayed eleven years.

CHAPTER

# TWENTY-ONE

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The trial was held in the Senate house on the sixth day before the Kalends of August, and the city had been waiting for it for a month.

They had begun to gather before dawn. By the first hour the Forum was full, and by the third the crowd had overflowed into the basilicas and the porticoes and the steps of the temples, and the shopkeepers had put up their shutters and the wine sellers had brought out their barrels and the pickpockets had come down from the Subura in force. There were food sellers and water sellers and a man with a performing monkey and a woman selling little clay figures of the principals — Corvinus with a sword, Pactus with a scroll, Cassia with a purse — and the whole thing had the air of a festival that everyone was slightly ashamed of enjoying.

Cassia came at the fourth hour with Bathyllus and Tertulla and the leather satchel, and she was not stopped at the door this time. The lictor stepped aside. The clerk looked at her summons and nodded. And she walked up the aisle of the Curia with her head up and her hands steady, and the whole chamber turned to look at her.

Aemilia was in the gallery.

Women were not admitted to the floor, but the gallery above the benches had been opened for the families of the accused, and she was there with young Sulpicia beside her and a slave behind them, and she was dressed in black for her mother-in-law and she had the composure of a woman who had decided that she would not be seen to be afraid.

Cassia looked up at her as she came in, and Aemilia inclined her head, once, and young Sulpicia did the same, and the small movement went through the chamber like a rumour.

He is not alone, it said. Whatever else is true, he is not alone.

The benches were full. The consuls sat on their curule chairs. The emperor's secretary sat on a chair to one side with a clerk and a tablet, and he was a thin, grey, careful man who looked as though he had spent his life reading documents and had never once been surprised by one. The senators sat in their ranks. The prosecutor's bench was full of lawyers. The defence bench had Corvinus and two advocates and a row of empty seats where his supporters should have been, and the emptiness was a statement in itself.

Pactus was there, in his white toga, at the front of the prosecutor's bench. He looked rested and calm and entirely at ease.

The consul called the house to order. The clerk read the charge. And then the prosecution rose.

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Crispus spoke for an hour and a half.

It was a good speech. It was better than good; it was the speech of a man who had been paid a great deal of money and had spent a month polishing every sentence. He spoke about the sanctity of the family, and the duty of a son to his father, and the terrible crime of parricide, which the law punished not with a fine or an exile but with the sack and the river and the viper and the dog. He spoke about the evidence: the physician's certificate, the assistant's testimony, the steward's statement, the midwife's account of the night. He spoke about the quarrel between the accused and his father, and the threats that had been overheard, and the haste with which the accused had left for Syria within the week. And then he spoke about the woman.

He did not name her. He did not need to. He spoke about a freedwoman who kept a house on the Esquiline, and who had made a fortune out of the appetites of senators, and who had been for twenty years the intimate of the accused; and he said that it was she who had corrupted the household at Tibur, she who had seduced the young man, she who had been present at the death, and she who had spent twenty-four years buying silence and influence and the friendship of men who should have known better.

"Conscript fathers," he said, "this is not a trial about a poisoned cup. It is a trial about a family that was destroyed from within by appetite and by money. The cup was the means. The woman was the cause."

He sat down. There was a murmur of approval from the benches, and a rumble of something else from the galleries, and the consul struck the floor.

The defence rose. Corvinus's advocate was a young man named Sura, who had been chosen because he was clever and because he was cheap and because he was the only advocate in Rome who had agreed to take the case.

Sura was good. He was better than good; he was brilliant, in the way that young men are brilliant when they have nothing to lose. He took Crispus's speech apart piece by piece: the physician's certificate was signed by a man who had been paid; the assistant had been paid; the steward had been paid; the midwife had been paid; every witness in the prosecution's case had been paid by somebody, and the somebody was a banker on the Via Lata who held the mortgages on the estate. He spoke about the fire on the Esquiline, and the boy who had died in it, and the arsonist who had been paid by a steward, and he said that the men who had burned a house and killed a child were the same men who had brought this accusation, and that the Senate should ask itself why.

There was a roar from the galleries. The consul struck the floor three times.

Then Corvinus rose to speak for himself.

He had not been required to. His advocate had advised him against it; a defendant who speaks is a defendant who can be trapped. But he rose anyway, and the chamber went quiet in the way that a chamber goes quiet when a man who has been silent for a long time stands up.

"Conscript fathers," he said. "I am not going to make a speech. I have made a great many speeches in this room and most of them were designed to make men vote for something, and this one is not. This one is a statement of fact." He paused. "I did not kill my father. I was in Syria when he died. I received the news at Antioch and I wept, and I have the letter I wrote to my mother in reply, and it is in the archive of this house, and any man who wishes may read it."

He looked at the benches.

"But I did something worse than kill him, and I want the house to know it, because the house is going to hear it from the prosecution before the day is out. When my father told me that he intended to sell the girl I loved and dispose of her child, I did nothing. I did not go to the governor. I did not go to the courts. I did not take her away in the night, though I could have, and though she would have come. I stood in a room and I listened to a man tell me what he was going to do, and I said nothing, and I got on a ship, and I did not come back for two

years." He looked at Cassia. "That is the truth about me. It is worse than the charge. And I have carried it for twenty-four years."

The chamber was silent.

"The prosecution will say that I am a man who covered up a death to keep his inheritance. I am a man who covered up a life — the life of a woman who was sold, and the life of a child who was given away — because I was twenty years old and I was a coward, and because I believed that if I said nothing, the world would let me keep the things I had." He paused. "It did not. It never does. The world has a way of collecting."

He sat down.

In the gallery, young Sulpicia had gone very still.

She had been told, at home, in the careful words that families use, that her father had done nothing wrong and that the trial was politics. She had believed it, or had decided to believe it, which is not the same thing. And now she was sitting in a gallery above the Senate house and listening to her father say that he had stood in a room and let a man sell a girl and give away a child, and that it was worse than the charge, and she was sixteen years old and the floor of the world had moved.

Aemilia put her hand over her daughter's hand. She did not say anything. There was nothing to say that would have helped, and she was wise enough to know it.

Crispus rose at once. "The accused has made a very moving speech. But the house will observe that it is not evidence. It is an admission of moral failure, not a denial of the charge. The fact that a man is a coward does not mean he is not a murderer."

"No," Corvinus said. "But the fact that a man is a coward does not mean he is a murderer either. And the house will have to decide which of us it believes: a delator who has been convicted of extortion, a steward who has been paid, a physician's assistant who has been paid, and a prosecutor whose banker holds my mortgage — or a woman who has lost everything she had and who has no reason to lie."

The consul struck the floor. "The house will hear the witnesses."

Then the witnesses were called.

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The midwife Psyche was called first, and she gave her evidence in a closed session, with the galleries cleared and the doors shut and the clerks sworn to silence.

She told the story again, as she had told it in June: the cup, the night, the child, the cry, the mistress with the lamp, the dealer, the receipt, the twenty-four years. She was older and weaker than she had been, and she had been brought from Tibur in a litter, and she gave her evidence sitting down, which was against the rules and which the consul allowed because she was seventy and could not stand.

When she had finished, the receipt was produced and read aloud. The clerk read it slowly, in the flat voice of a man reading a shopping list, and the chamber listened in absolute silence.

*Received from the household of M. Sulpicius Corvinus, for one male infant, aged one day, of good health and no defect, the sum of four hundred sesterces. The infant is delivered to Gaius Vibidius, potter, of the Via Ostiensis, outside the Porta Trigemina, in the city of Rome, to be raised as his own. No claim upon the child shall be made by the seller or by any person on the seller's behalf. Witnessed by L. Caepio.*

*The child is called Gaius Vibidius Nestor.*

The clerk stopped. The chamber was silent. Then the consul said, "The name of the child and the name of the potter are to be struck from the record and sealed. They are not to be spoken outside this chamber. Any man who speaks them will answer to the house for contempt."

The clerk struck them out. The receipt was sealed and put in the archive. And the Senate of Rome sat in a silence that was, for a moment, almost decent.

Then Crispus rose.

"The house has heard the midwife," he said. "The house has heard the receipt. And the house will observe that the receipt proves nothing about the death of Marcus Sulpicius. It proves that a child was born and sold. It proves that the household at Tibur was a place of vice and secrecy. It does not prove that the accused did not kill his father. In fact, conscript fathers, it proves the opposite: it proves that there was a secret in that house worth killing for."

He called the physician's assistant, Faustus. He called the old steward, who was brought in on a chair and who gave his evidence in a whisper and contradicted himself twice. He called a slave from the Tibur household who had been bought by the prosecution and who said that he had heard the young master

threaten his father. He called them one by one, and each of them added a small stone to the wall he was building, and Cassia sat in her seat and watched the wall go up.

The prosecution's witnesses did not do as well as Crispus had hoped.

Faustus, the physician's assistant, was a nervous man of forty with a twitch in his left eye, and he gave his evidence in a voice that was too loud. He said that his master had told him that the death was not natural. He said that his master had been paid to sign the certificate. He said that he had been paid to leave Rome and had come back when the money ran out.

"Who paid you?" Cassia asked.

"The knight Felix."

"Out of whose purse?"

"I do not know."

"You do not know, or you do not wish to say?"

"I do not know." Faustus wiped his face. "The money came from a steward. I never met the man who paid for it."

"Was the steward's name Anthus?"

"I do not know his name."

"Was he a thin man, fifty years old, with grey hair and a mole on his cheek?"

Faustus stared at her. "Yes."

"Then you do know his name," Cassia said. "It is Anthus, and he is the steward of the senator Pactus, and he has this morning admitted in this chamber to paying for the burning of my house. The house will draw its own conclusions about the reliability of a witness who has been paid by a man who pays for fires."

There was a rumble of laughter. Crispus objected. The consul allowed the question and the chamber to draw its own conclusions.

The old steward was worse. He was eighty and he had a bad chest and he had been brought from Ficulea in a litter, and he gave his evidence in a whisper that the clerk had to repeat. He said that he had been in the house on the night of the death. He said that he had seen the mistress go into the master's room with a cup. He said that he had been paid to keep silent, and he named the man who had paid him — not Pactus, not Sittius, but a clerk in the palace whose name he did not know.

Then Cassia produced the statement of the forger.

It was a single sheet of papyrus, taken down by Junia's son in the presence of two witnesses, and it said that a man named Secundus had forged a letter in the year of the consulship of Silanus at the request of the knight Felix, and that the letter had been used to destroy the family of Lucius Junius, praetor, and that he was dying of a disease of the lungs and wished to clear his conscience before he met his maker.

The clerk read it. The chamber listened. And Crispus, for the first time that day, looked at Pactus.

Pactus did not look back.

Then the consul called a recess, and the chamber emptied into the porticoes to eat and drink and tell each other what they had heard.

Cassia went out into the colonnade with Tertulla and stood in the shade with a cup of water she did not drink. The crowd moved around her. Nobody spoke to her. A senator she had dined with four times that year went past with his eyes on the columns. A woman she had lent money to at a rate that would have made a Carthaginian blush looked at her and then looked away. Two young men in the doorway turned their backs.

"You see," Tertulla said.

"I see."

"Does it surprise you?"

"No." Cassia watched the crowd. "It surprises me a little that it does not hurt more. I have known these people for sixteen years. I have fed them and lent them money and found husbands for their daughters. And this morning I am a whore who has been bought by a banker, and by this evening I will be something worse."

"You will be the woman who told the truth to the Senate," Tertulla said. "Some of them will hate you for it, and some of them will be ashamed for the rest of their lives, and one or two will remember that you were the only person in this whole affair who did not lie." She paused. "And when it is over, half of them will come back to your table as though nothing had happened, and you will let them, because you are a businesswoman, and because you have a house to run."

"And I will let them," Cassia said.

"Yes."

They stood in the shade for a while.

At the far end of the colonnade, Pactus's wife was standing with her women. She was a small, handsome, tired woman of about forty who had been married to Pactus for twenty years and had borne him six children, and she had never once spoken to Cassia in all that time. She looked across the colonnade now, and she looked at Cassia for a long moment, and then she inclined her head — the smallest possible movement, and not a friendly one, and not an unfriendly one either. It was the nod of a woman who had heard her husband lie in a public place and had already known that he would.

"She knows," Tertulla said.

"She has known for years." Cassia set the cup down on the parapet. "That is the thing nobody tells you about the wives. They always know. They know before the mistress does."

The bell rang for the afternoon session.

Then it was her turn.

She stood in the middle of the floor with the satchel at her side and the whole chamber looking at her, and she answered the questions.

Yes, she had been a slave in the household. Yes, she had been the mistress's maid. Yes, she had been pregnant by the son. Yes, she had been sold to Puteoli. Yes, she had bought her freedom and built a house and a business. Yes, the senator had come to her house. Yes, she had received him. Yes, she had received half the men in that chamber, and if the house wished to pursue that line of inquiry she would be happy to provide a list, and she was sure the Senate would find it instructive.

There was laughter. The consul did not strike the floor.

Crispus rose again. "The witness has admitted that she is the accused's mistress."

"I have admitted that I am the accused's friend," Cassia said. "There is a difference, and it is the difference between a woman who is paid and a woman who is trusted. I have been paid by a great many men in this city. The senator Corvinus is not one of them."

"You have admitted that you were present at the death."

"I have admitted that I was present at a death in a house where I was a slave, and that I was given a cup by the mistress of that house, and that I woke to be told that my son was dead and that I was to be sold." Cassia's voice was steady. "If the house wishes to know who killed Marcus Sulpicius, I suggest it ask the

woman who gave me the cup. But she is dead, and her son is on trial, and it seems to me that the prosecution has chosen the easier target."

The chamber stirred. Crispus's face tightened.

"The witness is hostile," he said. "The prosecution asks that her household be questioned again —"

"The household has been questioned," the consul said. "The questioning produced nothing. The prefect's report is before the house."

"The prefect's report is incomplete."

"Then it is incomplete," the consul said. "The house will not order a second questioning on the word of a prosecutor who has already had one. Proceed."

Crispus's mouth was a thin line. He turned back to Cassia.

"You have a document," he said. "A statement, signed by the knight Felix, who is now convicted of extortion and calumny, and whose word is worthless. You have a statement from an arsonist, who is a criminal. You have a letter that you claim was written by a clerk in the palace, and which you have not produced." He stepped closer. "You have nothing, domina. You have a story, and a ruined reputation, and a great deal of money. And you are standing in the Senate of Rome asking the Senate to believe that a banker and a senator and a clerk in the palace conspired to destroy a consular family in order to steal a house."

"Yes," Cassia said. "That is exactly what I am asking."

"Then produce your proof."

Cassia opened the satchel.

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She produced the statement of the arsonist first.

It was read aloud by the clerk, and it named Anthus, the steward of the senator Pactus, and it said that Anthus had paid Verecundus four thousand sesterces to burn a house on the Esquiline on the night of the eleventh of March, and that he had been told the house would be empty, and that he had not known about the boy in the passage.

There was uproar. Pactus rose to his feet. The consul struck the floor.

"This is a fabrication," Pactus said. "The man is a criminal and a liar, and he has been paid by the woman to say my name."

"He has not been paid by me," Cassia said. "He has been paid by your steward. And your steward is in this chamber."

The chamber went silent.

"He is standing at the back, by the door," Cassia said. "I saw him when I came in. He has been here all morning, listening to the evidence, and he has been getting paler and paler for an hour." She turned. "Anthus. Stand up."

There was a long, terrible pause. Then, at the back of the chamber, a man in a plain tunic stood up.

He was fifty, thin, grey, with the look of a man who had spent his life in corridors, and he stood with his hands at his sides and his face the colour of clay.

"Anthus," the consul said. "Is this true?"

Anthus looked at Pactus. Pactus looked back at him, and his face was calm, and his eyes were not.

"Anthus," Pactus said. "Tell the house that you have never seen this man. Tell the house that you have never paid anyone to burn anything. Tell the house the truth."

Anthus opened his mouth. Then he closed it. Then he said, in a voice that could barely be heard, "I paid him."

The chamber erupted.

The consul struck the floor again and again, and the lictors moved in, and above the noise the emperor's secretary rose from his seat and said, in a voice that was not loud but that carried, "The house will be silent."

The chamber went silent. Every man in it turned to look at the thin grey man with the tablet.

"The emperor's household has an interest in this matter," the secretary said. "Not in the guilt or innocence of the senator Corvinus, which is for this house to decide. In the conduct of a steward who has admitted in open session to paying for the destruction of a Roman house and the death of a Roman slave. That is a crime against the peace of the city, and it will be tried, and it will be tried before this house, with the emperor's secretary present." He looked at Pactus. "The senator Pactus will be examined tomorrow on his knowledge of his steward's actions. He will not leave the city until he has been examined."

Pactus's face did not change. But he bowed, and said, "I am at the service of the house," and sat down.

The chamber erupted.

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The consul adjourned the trial to the following day. The guards took Anthus into custody. Pactus was escorted from the chamber by two lictors, and he walked out with his head up and his toga straight and his face entirely composed, and the crowd outside, when they saw him, began to shout.

Cassia came out of the Curia into the late afternoon with Tertulla on one side and Bathyllus on the other, and the crowd pressed in on her, and this time it did not shout. It made a sound she had never heard before, a low, rising, hungry sound, and it took her a moment to understand that it was cheering.

"Say something," Tertulla said.

"No."

"Say something. They will remember it."

Cassia stopped on the steps. The crowd went quiet, or as quiet as a crowd of ten thousand people can go.

"I am not going to make a speech," she said. "I am a freedwoman and I have been on trial in this city for six months, and I am tired, and I want to go home." She paused. "But I will say one thing. A boy died in my house in March. His name was Nolus. He was eleven years old and he fed the pigeons and he was in a passage with a bolted door. The men who paid for that fire are going to be tried tomorrow, and I am going to be in that chamber, and I am going to watch." She looked at the crowd. "If you want to cheer for something, cheer for him. He is the only person in this whole affair who did nothing wrong."

Before she went out, she found Corvinus in the corridor behind the chamber, alone but for one lictor, with his back against the wall.

He looked exhausted. His toga was crumpled and his hair was out of place and there was a mark on his cheek where he had been pressing his hand.

"You spoke well," she said.

"I spoke the truth. It is easier than speaking well." He looked at her. "Tomorrow they will come for me with everything they have. Pactus will take the prosecution himself; he cannot afford not to. He will say that I killed my father and that you are my whore and that the child was a fiction invented to win sympathy."

"Then we will answer him."

"With what?"

"With the truth," Cassia said, "and with the arsonist, and with the steward, and with a letter from a clerk in the palace that I have not yet produced." She

looked at him. “I am saving it. A man like Pactus will hang himself if you give him enough rope, and tomorrow he will have a great deal of rope.”

Corvinus looked at her for a long moment. Then he laughed — a tired, surprised laugh — and said, “You are enjoying this.”

“No,” Cassia said. “I am not enjoying it. I am good at it. Those are different things, and it has taken me forty-two years to learn the difference.”

She went down the steps and into the crowd, and the crowd opened for her, and the sound that followed her was not cheering any more. It was something older and stranger, and it followed her all the way to the edge of the Forum.

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At home, the house was in an uproar. The household had heard the news before she got there — the city was like that — and they were in the atrium, all of them, and Thais was crying, and Celer was shouting, and Sabina was standing on the impluvium with her arms out.

Cassia stood in the doorway and looked at them.

“Tomorrow,” she said, “is the second day. It will be worse than today. There will be more shouting, and more lies, and at some point a man will say something about me that is true and that I would rather not have said in public. And then it will be over, and we will come home, and we will eat something, and we will sleep.” She paused. “And then, the day after, we are going to have a proper funeral for Nolus. Not the one we had in March. A proper one, with a stone with his name on it and a priest and a feast, and everyone in this house will be there.”

Thais wiped her face. “Domina. The stone will cost money.”

“Let it cost money,” Cassia said. “We have a great deal of money, and we have just discovered what it is for.”

She went into the tablinum and sat down and put her hands on the desk and closed her eyes. And then she opened them and took out a clean sheet of paper and began to write the speech she would make the next day, because she had learned a long time ago that the only way to survive a thing like this was to prepare for it as though it were an account.

CHAPTER

# TWENTY-TWO

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She did not sleep the night before the second day.

She sat in the tablinum with the lamps burning and the papers spread out on the desk and went through them one more time, and then she put them in the satchel and strapped it and sat with her hands in her lap and listened to the house.

The house was awake too. She could hear the kitchen — Celer had been up since the third hour, making bread that nobody would eat — and the women upstairs, and the soft, endless pacing of Bathyllus in the yard. At some point in the middle of the night Thais came in with a cup of hot wine and sat down opposite her and did not say anything for a long time.

"Are you frightened?" she said at last.

"Yes."

"Good. You should be." Thais turned her cup. "A woman who is not frightened on the night before a thing like this is a woman who has not understood it. Fear is not a weakness. It is a kind of intelligence."

"I have been frightened for six months."

"Then you have been intelligent for six months." Thais looked at her. "Do you remember what I said to you in Puteoli? The first night?"

"You said not to believe anything they told me in the first month."

"And you said you did not believe anything anyone told you." Thais's mouth moved. "You were a girl in a cell with no shoes and a fever, and you looked at me as though I were a wall you were calculating how to climb. And now you are a woman with a house and a fortune and a senator and a son, and you are sitting in the dark with a cup of wine you have not touched, and you are still calculating how to climb the wall." She stood. "You will win tomorrow. I

have known it since the day you bought the house. But I want you to remember something when you are standing in that chamber."

"What?"

"That you are not the girl in the cell. You are not the woman in the brothel. You are not even the woman who built this house. You are the woman who is going to walk into the Senate of Rome and tell the truth in front of the men who have been lying about her for six months." Thais put her hand on Cassia's head for a moment. "And when it is over, you are going to come home and eat something, and sleep for a week, and then you are going to be bored, and it will be the best thing that has ever happened to you."

Cassia laughed. "Tertulla said the same thing."

"Then it must be true." Thais went to the door. "Drink the wine. Sleep for an hour. And domina—"

"Yes?"

"Wear the dark veil. It makes you look like a woman who has come to bury someone."

She came to the Curia at dawn and found the woman from the prefect's courtyard sitting on the steps.

She was in the same good but not expensive wool, and she had a basket on her arm and a look on her face that Cassia recognized because she had worn it herself, in another life: the look of a person who has been waiting a long time for something and has decided to wait one more day.

"Domina," the woman said. "I heard that you won."

"I have not won anything yet."

"You were in the chamber yesterday for six hours and the whole city knows what happened." The woman stood up. "My son is out. They let him out the day after they let out your household. He came home and he ate a whole loaf of bread and then he slept for two days, and now he is back at the docks and he is complaining about the weight of the sacks." She held out the basket. "I brought you bread. It is not much. It is what I have."

Cassia looked at the basket. Then she took it.

"What is your name?" she asked.

"Marcia."

"Marcia. I will eat this bread today, in the chamber, while a man is telling the Senate that I am a whore." Cassia tucked the basket under her arm. "And it will remind me of what I am actually doing."

The woman laughed — a surprised, unguarded laugh — and went down the steps, and Cassia stood in the doorway of the Senate house with the basket on her arm and the satchel at her side and the sun coming up over the rooftops.

The second day of the trial began with Pactus on his feet.

He had spent the night preparing, and it showed. He spoke for two hours, and he did not use a single note. He spoke about the sanctity of the family and the duty of a son; he spoke about the poisoned cup and the sack and the river; he spoke about the woman on the Esquiline and the house of pleasure and the fortune made out of the appetites of senators. He spoke about the child, and he said that the story of the child was a fiction invented by a clever woman to win the sympathy of the house, and that the receipt was a forgery, and that the midwife was a paid witness, and that the arsonist's statement had been obtained by threats.

And then he said something that changed the temperature of the room.

"The house will observe," he said, "that the woman Cassia has been in the palace. She was received by the empress in June, alone, without the knowledge of the consul or the prefect. She has been seen since in the company of the empress's steward. And the emperor's secretary sits in this chamber today, not as an observer, but as a participant." He turned. "I ask the house: is this a trial, or is it a palace arrangement? Is the Senate judging a man, or is it being told what to think by a woman who has the ear of the empress?"

The chamber stirred. The emperor's secretary did not move.

"The senator Pactus will confine himself to the evidence," the consul said.

"The house will observe that this woman has made a career out of the weaknesses of senators. She has kept a house of pleasure for sixteen years. She has taken money from men who could not afford it. She has collected secrets the way a banker collects interest, and she has used them to make herself the most powerful woman in Rome who has never held an office and never been elected to anything." He looked around the chamber. "And now she has climbed into the palace, and she has persuaded the empress to receive her, and she has brought the emperor's secretary into this chamber to sit in judgment on a Roman senator. If this house acquits the senator Corvinus on the word of such a

woman, then it is not the Senate of Rome. It is the antechamber of the palace, and we are all of us servants of a freedwoman's ambition."

The chamber stirred. Several senators nodded. Cassia, watching from her seat, understood exactly what he was doing: he was not trying to prove that Corvinus had killed his father. He was trying to make the Senate afraid of her.

She rose.

"The senator Pactus has said that I am the most powerful woman in Rome who has never held an office," she said. "I am flattered. But I would remind the house that the last woman who was accused of ruling Rome was Livia, and she was the wife of an emperor, and she had an army. I have a house on the Esquiline, a cook, and a bookkeeper." She paused. "If that is power, then power in this city is even cheaper than I thought."

The chamber laughed. Pactus's face tightened.

"The house may also observe," Cassia went on, "that the senator Pactus has spent the last six months telling anyone who would listen that I am the emperor's creature, and the last ten minutes telling the house that I am a whore. I would like to know which of those accusations he would like the house to believe, because they cannot both be true, and because a man who makes two contradictory accusations in the same speech is a man who is not interested in the truth."

"I am confining myself to the evidence. The evidence is that this woman has spent six months buying witnesses, bribing clerks, and climbing into the palace through the empress's private door. The evidence is that she has a document that she says was written by a clerk in the palace, and that she has not produced it, because it does not exist." Pactus turned to Cassia. "Produce it, domina. Produce your letter. Or admit to this house that you have been lying."

Cassia stood.

"The house has asked for the letter," she said. "The house shall have it."

She took it from her sleeve and gave it to the clerk.

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The clerk read it aloud.

It was not long. It was four hundred words, in a neat clerk's hand, dated in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Silanus, and it concerned a shipment of grain that had been diverted at Ostia and sold at a profit in Campania, and it

named three men: the clerk Primus, the senator Marcus Sulpicius Corvinus, and a banker on the Via Lata named Sittius. It said that the money had been divided, and that the senator's share had been paid into an account, and that the clerk would keep his part of the bargain.

And it said, at the end, in the same neat hand: *If anything happens to me, I have taken precautions.*

The chamber was silent when the clerk finished.

"The letter is a forgery," Pactus said. "It is a clumsy forgery. The hand is not the hand of the emperor's secretary."

"The hand is the hand of a clerk," Cassia said. "The secretary was a clerk twenty-four years ago. He was not the man he is now. He was a slave in the treasury, and he was bought and freed by the emperor's father, and he has been in the palace ever since." She turned. "The house may compare the letter with the secretary's own hand. There are a hundred documents in the archive with his signature on them. The clerks of this house can do it in an hour."

The consul looked at the emperor's secretary. The secretary rose.

"The letter is mine," he said.

The chamber erupted.

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It took an hour to restore order, and by the time it was restored, the shape of the trial had changed entirely.

The secretary did not deny it. He stood in the middle of the chamber, a thin grey man with a tablet in his hand, and he said, "I was a slave in the treasury in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Silanus. I was twenty-four years old. I was offered money to divert a shipment of grain and I took it, and I have regretted it every day since. The senator Marcus Sulpicius was my partner in the fraud. The banker Sittius held the money. And I have spent twenty-four years paying the old woman at Tibur to keep silent, and twenty-four years waiting for the day when it would come out."

He turned to the Senate.

"I have served the emperor for forty years. I have counted his money and kept his accounts and I have never taken a copper since that year. I am not asking for mercy. I am telling the house the truth, because the truth is going to come out anyway, and because I would rather tell it myself than have it dragged

out of a midwife and a delator and a woman who has been trying to bury it for a quarter of a century." He paused. "The trial of the senator Corvinus is a fraud built on a fraud. The accusation was paid for by Sittius, who wanted a house. It was brought by Pactus, who wanted a province. And it was concealed by me, because I wanted to keep my place. That is the whole of it. The house may do with me what it likes."

He sat down.

There was a long silence. Then Pactus rose, and his face was white, and he said, "This is a conspiracy. The secretary has been bought by the woman —"

"By whom?" the consul said.

"By the woman Cassia, by the empress, by —"

"The senator will be silent." The consul struck the floor. "The senator will sit down and he will remain silent until he is called to answer for his steward, his banker, and his accusation."

Pactus sat down.

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Anthus was called next.

He had spent the night in a cell under the Curia, and he came into the chamber in the morning grey-faced and shaking, and he told the truth. He told it in a flat, exhausted voice, without ornament, without excuses. He told them about the payments to Felix, the payments to the forger, the payments to the arsonist. He told them about the visit to Tibur, and the men at the inn, and the old woman in the house with the fig tree who would not be frightened. He told them about the boy.

"The boy was taken from the workshop at Praeneste on the fifteenth of June," he said. "He is being held at a farm near Aricia, on the estate of the banker Sittius. He has not been harmed. He has been told that he is being kept for his own safety, and that his father will come for him when it is safe."

"Who gave the order?" the consul asked.

"The senator Pactus."

Pactus did not move. His face was the face of a man who had been carved out of stone.

"Have the boy brought to Rome," the consul said. "At once, and safely, and with a physician. And have the senator's steward taken to the prefect's house

and held on a charge of arson and murder." He struck the floor. "The house will vote."

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The vote took an hour.

The senators voted one by one, in the old way, each man rising and speaking his verdict aloud, and the clerks wrote them down. Cassia stood at the back of the chamber with her hands folded and listened to the words, and the words were, in the end, exactly what she had expected: not a verdict on the truth, but a verdict on the politics.

Corvinus was acquitted of parricide. The vote was overwhelming; no man in the chamber was willing to convict a consular on the word of a convicted delator and a steward who had confessed to arson.

But the house did not stop there. Old Paetus rose and said that while the senator was innocent of his father's death, he was not innocent of the concealment, and that a man who had allowed a woman to be sold and a child to be given away, and who had spent twenty-four years in the enjoyment of an inheritance that had been obtained by fraud, was not fit for the Asian command. He moved that the senator be censured by the house and that his name be struck from the list of candidates for the proconsulship.

The motion passed.

Pactus was convicted of calumny, of suborning witnesses, of procuring arson and murder, and of conspiracy to defraud. He was condemned to exile, his property was confiscated, and his name was struck from the rolls of the Senate. He heard the verdict standing, and when it was read he did not speak, and he did not look at anyone, and he walked out of the chamber between two lictors with his head up and his face like a mask.

Sittius was condemned in his absence. His bank was confiscated, his house on the Via Lata was sealed, and a warrant was issued for his arrest. The prefect's men found him three days later at his villa at Baiae, in his bath, with his wrists opened and a letter on the table that said, *I have been a banker for forty years and I have never lost an argument. I do not intend to begin now.*

Primus was removed from his office by the emperor's order. The order was read in the Senate by the secretary himself, in the same flat voice in which he had confessed, and it said that the emperor thanked the house for its diligence, that

the clerk would be retired to a house in Campania with a pension, and that no further action would be taken against him. The Senate received it in silence. No one was surprised.

The arsonist Verecundus was condemned to the mines. His companion, a man named Rufus who had held the lamp, was condemned to the games. Anthus, who had confessed and given evidence, was condemned to exile and the confiscation of his property.

And the household of Antonia Cassia, freedwoman, was declared free of all suspicion, and the costs of the questioning were remitted by order of the house.

Cassia stood at the back of the chamber while all of it was read, and when it was over she did not cheer and she did not weep. She turned and walked out into the sunshine, and the crowd in the Forum was waiting for her, and this time it made the sound she had heard on the steps the day before, and this time she let it wash over her.

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The emperor's secretary was waiting for her in the portico.

He was standing by a column with his tablet in his hand and his clerk three paces behind him, and he had the look of a man who has been waiting for some time and does not intend to be kept waiting much longer.

"Domina," he said. "A word."

"Secretary."

"I have been in the service of three emperors," he said, "and I have read a great many records of a great many trials, and I have never in forty years seen a house vote a man's name out of a document." He looked at her. "The names are struck. The sheet is sealed. It is in the archive, and it will stay there, and in fifty years a clerk will open it and find two lines cut out of a receipt and a note in the margin in my hand, and he will wonder what was so dangerous about a potter."

"Will the seal hold?"

"The seal will hold as long as the men who ordered it are alive, and after that it will hold because nobody will care." He put the tablet under his arm. "I am going to Campania in the autumn. I am told there is a house and a pension and a garden, and that I am to be grateful. I am grateful. I have spent my life counting other men's money, and now I am to spend the rest of it counting figs." He

paused. "I have one thing to say to you before I go, and then I will not trouble you again."

"Say it."

"You won," he said. "You won because you were the only person in that chamber who did not want anything. The prosecutor wanted a conviction. Pactus wanted a province. The banker wanted a house. The senator wanted to be forgiven. Even the old woman in the bed wanted to be told that she had done the right thing." He looked at her. "You wanted the boy, and you wanted the truth, and you were willing to lose both. That is why they could not touch you. It is also why you will never be safe in this city again, because the one thing Rome cannot forgive is a person who does not want what it is selling."

Cassia looked at him for a long moment.

"That is the most honest thing anyone has said to me in sixteen years," she said.

"I am a good accountant," the secretary said. "Honesty is a kind of bookkeeping." He inclined his head. "Goodbye, domina. I hope you find him."

He walked away down the portico with his clerk behind him, and Cassia stood by the column and watched him go.

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Aemilia was waiting in the portico with her daughter.

She had heard the verdict from a clerk before it was read, because the wives of senators always hear things before they are read, and she stood with her hands folded and her face composed, and when Corvinus came out she looked at him for a long moment and then said, "You are acquitted."

"I am."

"And censured."

"And censured." He stopped in front of her. "And finished. The Asian command is gone. The augurate will go too, in a month, when the house votes on it. I will be a consular who cannot hold an office and a senator who cannot speak without being reminded of his father's fraud and his mother's poison and the boy he did not raise." He looked at his wife. "I am sorry. I am sorry for all of it. For the years I was not there. For the lies. For my mother. For the house. For all of it."

Aemilia looked at him. Then she said, "Do you know what I have been thinking, all through this trial? I have been thinking that I have spent nineteen years in a house where no one told me the truth, and that I would rather have a husband who is finished and honest than a husband who is successful and a lie." She took his hand. "You are not finished, Lucius. You are forty-five years old. There is a great deal of life left, and I intend to spend it with a man who has finally stopped pretending to be his father."

Young Sulpicia came forward. She was fifteen, and married, and she had been in the gallery for two days, and she looked at her father with her grandmother's eyes.

"The boy," she said. "Is he alive?"

"He is alive. He is on a farm near Aricia and Bathyllus is already on the road."

"Then bring him home," Sulpicia said. "And let me meet him. He is my brother. I have a right to meet him."

Corvinus looked at his daughter for a long moment. Then he said, "You have a right to a great many things, and I have given you almost none of them." He put his hand on her head. "I will bring him home. And then we will see what he wants."

An hour later Corvinus came and found her standing by the fountain at the edge of the Forum with Tertulla and Bathyllus. He had sent his wife and daughter home in the litter and had walked the length of the Forum alone, and he looked ten years older than he had that morning.

His toga was crumpled and his face was grey and there was something in his eyes that she had not seen there before: not relief, not triumph. Emptiness.

"Well," he said.

"Well."

"I am acquitted."

"You are."

"And censured, and struck from the list, and finished." He laughed, without any humour. "I have spent my whole life wanting the Asian command. I have mortgaged the house and borrowed from a man who wanted to destroy me and married a woman I did not love and lied to my mother and lied to my wife and lied to myself, and I have got what I wanted, which is to be alive and free and to have nothing left to want."

Cassia looked at him. The crowd was going past them, and the sun was on the fountain, and somewhere a man was selling the little clay figures again, and a woman was shouting that the senator was innocent and the gods were just.

"You have a son," she said. "Two sons. And a daughter who is married to a fool and a wife who has been braver than either of us. And a house that is falling down and a name that has been dragged through the Forum and a woman who has been in love with you since she was eighteen years old." She paused. "You have a great deal left to want."

He looked at her. Then he put his hand over his face and stood in the middle of the Forum and wept, and the crowd went past and did not notice, because in Rome a man weeping in the Forum is not a remarkable thing.

Cassia stood beside him and did not touch him, and waited.

After a while he wiped his face and said, "The boy. Anthus said Aricia."

"Bathyllus is already on the road. He will be there by nightfall."

"Then I am going with him."

"Lucius—"

"I am going with him," Corvinus said. "I have spent twenty-four years not going. I am not going to spend another night in this city while my son is on a farm in Aricia being held by a banker's men." He looked at her. "You said I had to choose. I am choosing."

Cassia looked at him for a long moment. Then she said, "Take the fast horses. Take Bathyllus and two of Tertulla's men. And Lucius—"

"Yes?"

"Bring him home," she said. "Not to me. To his father. Bring him home to the Via Ostiensis, and tell him what he needs to know, and let him decide what happens next." She paused. "And when it is done, come back and tell me."

He nodded. Then he turned and went, and the crowd closed around him, and Cassia stood by the fountain with Tertulla and watched him go.

"He will bring the boy home," Tertulla said.

"Yes."

"And then?"

"And then we will find out what the truth is worth," Cassia said. "We have spent six months fighting for it. Now we have to live with it."

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They buried Nolus on the third day after the trial, in the ground outside the Porta Esquilina where the poor and the slaves were buried, and this time it was not a small stone and a hurried prayer.

Cassia paid for a proper funeral. There was a procession from the house to the gate, with the household in front and the flute players and the mourning women, and there was a stone with his name on it and his age and the words *A GOOD BOY, WHO FED THE PIGEONS*, which Cassia had chosen herself, and there was a feast afterward in the courtyard of the house for everyone who had come.

The whole household was there. Thais and Hermeros and Celer and Bathyllus and Sabina and Chrysis and Senno and the kitchen boys and the women from upstairs and the old gardener's daughter, who had come from Ostia with her two children and who cried through the whole of it and then ate a great deal of bread and cheese.

Tertulla came. Aemilia came, with young Sulpicia, who stood at the back and looked at the stone and did not say anything. Corvinus was still on the road to Aricia, and Cassia stood at the grave and thought about the fact that he had never met the boy in life and was now going to meet him in a farmhouse with a physician and a banker's men.

When the priest had finished and the earth had been put in, Cassia said a few words. She had not prepared them.

"Nolus was eleven years old," she said. "He came to this house two years ago from the market, and he was given the pigeons and the yard, and he did it well. He was not a clever boy and he was not a beautiful boy and he did not have a great future ahead of him. He had a broom and a bucket and eleven pigeons, and he fed them every morning before he ate his own breakfast, because he said they were always hungry and he was not." She paused. "He died because someone wanted to hurt me. That is the truth of it, and I am not going to pretend otherwise. He was killed to send me a message. And the men who killed him have been sent to the mines and to the games, and that is justice, of a kind, and it does not bring him back, and it never will."

She looked at the stone.

"But he is not a message. He is a boy who fed the pigeons. And every year, on the day of his death, this house will make an offering for him and say his name, and the pigeons will be fed, and anyone who wants to remember him will be

welcome at my table." She paused. "That is all. That is the whole of it. A boy lived and a boy died and we are going to remember him, because that is the only thing any of us can do for the dead."

They went back to the house and ate and drank and told stories about Nolus, and Celer got drunk and wept and was put to bed by Thais, and Sabina fell asleep on the bench by the fountain with her head on Chrysis's shoulder, and the sun went down over the garden, and the house was full of people who had come through something together and were still, all of them, alive.

Cassia sat on the bench by the roses and watched them.

"Domina," Thais said, sitting down beside her. "The boy. What will you do if he does not want to come?"

"I do not know."

"You must have thought about it."

"I have thought about nothing else for six months." Cassia looked at the dark garden. "If he does not want to come, I will let him go. I will leave him the money from the chest and a letter, and I will not go to the shop, and I will not send anyone. And once a year I will have a message from his father to say that he is alive, and once a year I will send him something that he can throw away if he wants to." She paused. "And I will be the woman with the house on the Esquiline, and he will be the potter on the Via Ostiensis, and the city will go on, and that will be the end of it."

"And if he does want to come?"

"Then I will have a son," Cassia said, "and a house with a room at the top of the stairs that is no longer empty, and a great deal of explaining to do." She looked at Thais. "And I will probably make a mess of it."

"Probably," Thais said. "That is what mothers do."

Cassia laughed, and then, unexpectedly, she cried — briefly and furiously, with her hands over her face, the way she had not allowed herself to cry since the morning in the prefect's courtyard. Thais sat beside her and did not say anything and did not touch her, and after a while Cassia stopped and wiped her face and said, "Well. That was undignified."

"It was very dignified," Thais said. "You did it in the dark, in your own garden, in front of one person. That is the most dignified way there is."

CHAPTER

# TWENTY-THREE

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The city forgot the trial in three weeks, which was longer than Cassia had expected.

At first it was everywhere: the wine shops and the baths and the barbers and the steps of the temples, and every man in Rome had an opinion about the woman who had brought down a consul and a banker and a clerk in the palace, and half of them had been in her house and the other half had wanted to be. For a fortnight she could not walk down the Clivus Suburanus without being pointed at, and there were people who came to the garden door and asked to see her, and one man who came with a lyre and wanted to sing her praises, and whom Bathyllus removed with a firmness that was almost courteous.

Then the emperor dedicated another monument, and the games were announced, and a grain ship went down off Sicily with a cargo of Egyptian wheat, and the city found something else to talk about.

That was how it went. Cassia had known it would. She had lived in Rome for twenty-four years, and she had seen the city forget a fire, a plague, a war and a murder in less time than it took to forget a trial. It was not cruelty, exactly. It was appetite. There was always something new to eat.

The consequences did not go away, though. They arrived one by one over the following months, like the bills after a wedding.

The first was the clients. On the day after the verdict, half the men who had dined at her table for years did not send their usual messages. By the end of the week, two of them had sent letters explaining that they were going to the country for the summer. By the end of the month, the house was taking a third of what it had taken in the spring, and Celer had begun to complain about the waste of food, and Thais had begun to look at the accounts in a way that Cassia did not like.

The second was Corvinus. The Senate stripped him of the augurate in September, by a vote that was not close. The Asian command went to a man named Verus, who had no qualifications except a good name and a wife with connections. Corvinus took the news quietly. He had expected it. But Cassia saw him afterward, in the garden of the Palatine house, standing under the masks with his hands behind his back, and she knew that something in him had gone out.

The third was the house on the Palatine. The mortgage had been held by Sittius, and Sittius was dead, and his heirs — a nephew and a cousin and a bank in Alexandria — had no interest in the Sulpicii. They called in the loan in October. Corvinus could not pay it. The house was sold at the end of November to a man who had made his money in bricks and who intended to knock it down and build an insula on the site, and the family moved into a smaller house on the Esquiline, two streets from Cassia's, with a garden and a portico and no history at all.

The masks went into the new atrium. There was nowhere else to put them.

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Young Sulpicia came in September, alone, in a plain cloak, with a basket of figs.

She was sixteen now and she had been married for three months, and she had the look of a woman who had discovered that marriage was not the end of the world and not the beginning of one either, but a long room that had to be furnished. She sat down in the tablinum and put the figs on the desk and said, "I have come to ask you something, and I want you to tell me the truth."

"I will try."

"Did my grandmother kill my grandfather?"

Cassia looked at her. The girl's face was steady and her hands were steady and she had her grandmother's chin.

"Yes," Cassia said.

"Did my father know?"

"No. He suspected, at the end, but he did not know until she told him."

"Did you know?"

"I knew that she gave me a cup on the night my son was born, and that my son was taken from me, and that she was in the room. I did not know about your grandfather until the spring." Cassia turned her cup. "Your grandmother

told me herself, in the last week of her life, and I have not told anyone what she said except your father and the Senate. I am telling you now because you asked and because you are old enough to know and because a person who is lied to by her family for sixteen years has a right to the truth."

Sulpicia was silent for a long time. Then she said, "I loved her."

"I know."

"She was cruel to my mother and cold to my father and she arranged my marriage without asking me, and I loved her. She used to let me sit in her room when I was small and she would tell me about the masks. She knew the name and the office of every one of them. She used to say that a family is a thing you carry, like a lamp, and that it is your job to carry it without dropping it." Her eyes were wet. "And she killed my grandfather and sold your son. How do I hold both of those things?"

"You hold them the way you hold everything," Cassia said. "You stop trying to make them into one thing. She was a woman who loved you and who did something terrible. Both of those things are true. You do not have to choose."

Sulpicia wiped her eyes. "My husband is a fool," she said.

"Yes."

"He is not a bad man. He is just — he talks about the games all the time. All the time. He has an opinion about every gladiator in Rome and no opinion about anything else." She blew her nose. "My mother says I should be patient and manage the house and have a son and he will improve. My grandmother would have said the same. What do you say?"

"I say have the son, and manage the house, and take the money, and keep the purse I gave you, and learn something that he does not know you can do." Cassia leaned forward. "And when you are thirty, and he is still talking about the games, you will have a life of your own that he has never once looked at, and you will be able to be kind to him, because you will not need him to be anything other than what he is."

Sulpicia looked at her. "That is a very cold answer."

"It is a warm answer that has been in the cold for a long time." Cassia picked up a fig and ate it. "Now. Tell me about the house. Is the cook any good?"

Ione came back in October.

She came to the garden door in the evening, alone, with a bag over her shoulder and a cloak that had seen better days, and Bathyllus came to the tablinum with a face that was trying very hard to be neutral.

"There is a woman at the door," he said. "She says you will know her."

Cassia put down her pen.

"Show her in."

Ione came in. She was thin and brown from the sun and she had cut her hair short in the way of a woman who has decided to stop being decorative, and she stood in the middle of the tablinum with her bag still on her shoulder and looked at Cassia.

"I heard," she said. "About the trial. About the house. About the old woman. About the boy." She set the bag down. "I was in Baiae. I was keeping a house for a man who did not want a house, and it ended badly, as those things do. I have spent the summer being somebody else and I find that I do not like her very much."

Cassia stood up.

"I am sorry," she said. "For what I said in the kitchen. For what I did not say. For —"

"Stop." Ione held up her hand. "I did not come back for an apology. I came back because I heard that you had lost half your clients and that the house was in trouble and that Thais was doing the accounts on her own, and because I am good at accounts, and because I have nowhere else to go, and because — " She stopped, and her voice changed. "Because I have been free for four months and I have discovered that freedom is a great deal of work and very little fun, and that I was happier in your kitchen than I have been anywhere since."

Cassia looked at her for a long moment. Then she said, "You are hired. The pay is bad and the hours are worse and the household is full of people who have been through too much, and the cook is impossible."

Ione's mouth trembled. "That is the best offer I have had all year."

"Then take it." Cassia came around the desk. "And Ione. I was wrong. I was wrong about the book and I was wrong about you and I was wrong to accuse you, and I have thought about it every day since you left. You were the best thing in this house and I did not see it until you were gone."

Ione looked at her. Then she put her bag down on the floor and said, "Well. I am back now. You will have to be cleverer than that if you want to get rid of me."

They embraced in the middle of the tablinum, and Thais came in and saw them and stopped, and then came and put her arms around both of them, and the household gathered in the doorway and someone began to laugh, and someone else began to cry, and Celer said, "Does this mean I have to cook for one more?" and Ione said, "Yes, Celer, and I want the fish tonight, with the sauce, not the other sauce," and the whole house settled back into itself like a thing that had been holding its breath.

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Aemilia came in the last week of October, to the new house, and asked Cassia to help her hang the masks.

The new house on the Esquiline was smaller than the old one and newer and had no history at all, and the atrium was bright and low and the cupboards for the masks had been made by a carpenter in the Subura who had never made one before. Aemilia stood in the middle of the floor with her hands on her hips and looked at the wall.

"They do not fit," she said. "The old ones were made for a wall three feet higher. They look like a row of provincial ancestors."

"They are the same ancestors."

"They are the same wax and the same names and they look ridiculous." Aemilia sighed. "My mother-in-law would have had the carpenter flogged."

"Your mother-in-law is dead."

"Yes," Aemilia said. "That is the only good thing about this house."

Cassia laughed. She had not expected to like Aemilia, and she had discovered over the summer that she did, in the way that two women who have been through the same war like each other: not with affection, exactly, but with a shared and slightly grim understanding.

"The jewellery," Aemilia said, when the masks were hung. "Have you sold it?"

"Not yet. I have a buyer in mind for the winter. The emeralds are worth more than the rest put together, and there is a woman in the Subura who deals in old stones and does not ask questions."

"Give the money to the boy."

"I intend to."

"Give it to him as money, not as a story," Aemilia said. "A potter with a workshop needs a kiln and a cart and a boy to turn the wheel. He does not need a chest of his grandmother's jewellery and a letter about the old days. Give him the tools of his trade and let him think that the lady in Rome is a patron with more money than sense." She paused. "And when he is older, and when he asks, tell him the rest."

Cassia looked at her. "You have thought about this."

"I have thought about nothing else since the funeral. I have a son who is twenty-two and a daughter who is sixteen and a husband who has lost everything, and I have discovered that the only thing I am good at is arranging things so that the people I love are not hurt any more than necessary." Aemilia straightened a mask. "It is not a noble talent. But it is mine."

The potter came in November, on a wet afternoon, with clay under his nails and a letter in his hand.

Gaius Vibidius had aged in the six months since Cassia had last seen him. He was greyer and thinner and there was a tremor in his hands that had not been there before, and he sat down in the tablinum and put the letter on the desk between them.

"He is home," he said. "They brought him back from Aricia in August. He was not hurt. They had told him that he was being kept for his own safety, and he believed them, because he is a trusting boy and because he had no reason not to." He paused. "He knows there is something wrong. He has known since the men came to the workshop at Praeneste. He has been asking questions, and I have been lying to him, and I am not a good liar."

Cassia looked at the letter. It was unsealed and it was addressed to her, in a careful, awkward hand.

"He wrote that," the potter said. "Himself. He asked me to bring it to you. He does not know who you are. He thinks you are the lady who paid for his apprenticeship, or a patron of the shop, or something of that kind. He has been told that a great lady in Rome took an interest in him, and he has decided that he wants to thank her." The potter's mouth twisted. "He is a good boy. He does not know that he is in the middle of anything."

Cassia picked up the letter.

*Domina. My father says you are the lady who paid for my apprenticeship and for the new kiln. I do not know why you did it and I do not know who you are, but I want to thank you. The kiln is very good. I have made a set of cups that I am proud of, and if you would like them I will send them to you. My father says I am not to ask questions, and I am trying not to, but I would like to know your name, if it is not a secret. Yours, Gaius Vibidius Nestor.*

She read it twice. Then she put it down on the desk and looked at the potter.

"What have you told him?"

"That you are a patron. That he should be grateful. That he should not ask questions." The potter's hands were on his knees. "I have lied to him for four months, domina, and it is eating me alive. He is twenty-four years old. He has a right to know who he is. But if I tell him, he will want to know why I did not tell him before, and then he will want to know what happened to his mother, and then —" He stopped.

"And then he will want to know about me."

"Yes."

Cassia sat for a moment. The rain came down on the roof. Somewhere in the house Ione was arguing with Celer about the fish.

"There is a thing I have not told you," she said. "And I am going to tell you now, because you have earned it and because I cannot ask you to lie to your son for me."

She told him about the trial. She told him about the receipt and the sealed record and the names struck out and the promise she had made to the empress. She told him about the chest of jewellery and the money that was waiting for the boy. And she told him what she had decided.

"I am not going to take him from you," she said. "Not now, not ever. He is your son. You have raised him and fed him and taught him the wheel and the kiln and the price of clay, and I will not undo twenty-four years of that because I happen to have given birth to him." She paused. "But he has a right to know. Not today. Not tomorrow. But some day, when he is ready, and when you are ready, and when I can tell him the whole truth in a room with a door that locks and a cup of wine in his hand. And then he can decide what he wants to do with it."

The potter looked at her for a long time. Then he said, "And if he wants to know you?"

"Then I will be here."

"And if he does not?"

"Then I will be here anyway," Cassia said. "That is what a mother is. It is not a thing you earn or a thing you deserve. It is a thing that happens to you, and then you spend the rest of your life standing in a room waiting for someone to come through the door."

The potter wiped his eyes with the back of his hand and said, "I am sorry. I am not a man who cries in front of ladies."

"You are not in front of a lady," Cassia said. "You are in front of a woman who has been crying in kitchens for twenty-four years." She stood. "Now. Tell me about the kiln. And tell me about the cups. And then go home and tell your son that the lady in Rome was very pleased with his letter, and that she would like the cups, and that she will write to him herself."

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She wrote to him that night.

It took her four hours and eleven drafts, and the letter she finally sent was three lines long.

*Gaius Vibidius Nestor. I am glad the kiln is good. I would like the cups. Send them to the house on the Esquiline with the green door, and tell the doorkeeper that they are from the potter on the Via Ostiensis, and he will bring them to me. Your name is not a secret. It is a good name and you should be proud of it. A friend.*

She sealed it and gave it to Bathyllus to take to the Via Ostiensis in the morning, and then she sat in the tablinum with the lamps burning and the rain on the roof and her hands in her lap.

Thais came in with a cup of hot wine and set it down.

"You have written to him," she said.

"I have written to him."

"What did you say?"

"Nothing. Everything. I do not know." Cassia picked up the cup. "I said I would like the cups and that he should be proud of his name."

Thais sat down opposite her. "It is a beginning."

"It is not a beginning. It is a letter about cups."

"Everything is a letter about cups," Thais said, "until it is not."

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The house on the Esquiline began to fill again in November.

It was not the same as before. The great men did not come back; they had found other houses, or they were afraid of the empress's shadow, or they had simply moved on to the next amusement. But the men who came now were different: merchants with money and no name, equestrians who had made their fortunes in the provinces, a young senator from Gaul who wanted to be seen at the right tables, two of the new consuls' clerks, a shipowner from Ostia with a wife who was cleverer than he was.

They came because the house had been through the fire and had come out the other side, and because in Rome a house that has survived a scandal is more interesting than a house that has never had one.

Cassia did not enjoy it. She had enjoyed the old house, in the old days, when she had been building something and every dinner was a brick. Now she sat at the head of the table and watched the new men talk and thought about the fact that she had spent twenty-four years building a wall and that the wall had burned and been rebuilt and that she was still, at forty-two, sitting at the head of a table, listening to men.

The cups came at the end of November, four days before the Kalends of December.

There were six of them, wrapped in straw in a wooden box, and they were red-glossed and thin-walled and good, better than anything in Cassia's kitchen, and on the bottom of each one, pressed into the clay before firing, there was a small mark: a bird.

Bathyllus brought the box into the tablinum and set it on the desk, and Cassia took the cups out one by one and set them in a row and looked at them.

"They are very good," Thais said, from the doorway.

"They are better than good. They are the work of a man who knows what he is doing and is proud of it." Cassia turned one over in her hands. "He has been making cups since he was a boy. He has been making them for fifteen years, in a yard on the Via Ostiensis, and no one in this city knows his name, and he is better at his trade than half the men in the Senate are at theirs."

She put the cup down.

"There is a letter," Bathyllus said.

It was short, and it was in the same careful, awkward hand.

*Domina. These are the cups. I hope they are what you wanted. My father says I am to thank you again for the kiln and for the apprenticeship and for everything, and I am thanking you. I would still like to know your name. Not because I am ungrateful, but because a man likes to know who his friends are. Yours, Gaius Vibidius Nestor.*

Cassia read it twice.

"Are you going to tell him?" Thais said.

"Not yet."

"He has asked you twice."

"I know." Cassia folded the letter and put it in the drawer with the other one, the old one, the one that had been in the cedar box for twenty-four years. "A name in a letter is a strange thing. It arrives without a face. He would read it in his yard and look up and see nothing but the racks and the kiln, and he would have to imagine the woman who wrote it, and he would imagine someone smaller and quieter and kinder than I am." She closed the drawer. "There is a great deal that has to be said before he knows my name, and I am not going to say it in a letter about cups. I am going to say it to his face, in a room, with his father there."

"So what will you write?"

"That the cups are the best I have ever owned. That is true, and it is not the whole truth, and it will do for now."

She wrote the letter that night. It was four lines long: the cups, the price of the clay, a request that he send six of the red-glossed ones, and a line at the end that took her an hour and said only that his father was a good man and that she hoped the kiln was drawing well. She did not sign it with her name. She signed it as she had signed the first: *a friend.*

She sealed it and gave it to Bathyllus, and then she went and stood in the garden in the cold, with the roses cut back to stumps and the fountain turned off, and she thought about a boy in a yard with clay on his arms, and about the fact that he had asked her name twice and she had given him nothing but cups.

The house on the Palatine was sold on the last day of November, and Cassia went to see it empty.

Corvinus took her through it himself: the atrium with the empty cupboards where the masks had been, the tablinum where his father had told him what he

was going to do, the garden where he had stood with his wife and watched the light go out of the sky, the room where his mother had died.

"It is a good house," he said. "It was a good house for four hundred years. And now a man who sells bricks is going to knock it down and build a block of flats, and in fifty years no one will remember that it was ever anything else."

"That is what happens to houses," Cassia said.

"Yes." He looked around the empty atrium. "That is what happens to everything."

They went out together into the street, and the door was closed behind them, and a workman was already chalking a mark on the wall.

"Where are you going?" Cassia said.

"To the new house. Aemilia has been there since Tuesday, arranging the furniture and complaining about the drains." He paused. "And then, when the potter agrees to see us, to the Via Ostiensis. To meet my son."

"And what will you say to him?"

"I do not know." Corvinus looked at the street. "I have been a senator for twenty years and I have made a hundred speeches, and I do not know what I will say to a potter of twenty-four who has my eyes and my father's jaw." He looked at her. "What will you say to him?"

"I wrote about cups," Cassia said.

He laughed — a real laugh, the first she had heard from him in months — and took her arm, and they walked down the hill together through the crowds and the noise and the ordinary business of the city.

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"You are melancholy," Tertulla said, one night in December, when the guests had gone.

"I am tired."

"You are melancholy. I have known you for seven years and I can tell the difference." Tertulla sat down beside her. "What is it?"

"I do not know." Cassia looked at the three Graces in the alcove. "I have everything I wanted when I was thirty. The house, the money, the name, the freedom. And I sit at the table and I listen to a man from Ostia talk about his ships and I think: is this it? Is this what I spent twenty-four years building?"

"What else would you have?"

"I do not know." Cassia turned her cup. "I think I would like to be bored. I have never been bored. Not once, in forty-two years. And I think that a person who has never been bored has not really been alive."

Tertulla looked at her for a long moment. Then she said, "In January I am going to Baiae. There is a house there, with a garden and a view of the sea and a cook who is not as good as Celer and a great many old women who talk about their ailments. Come with me. For a month. We will do nothing. We will sit in the sun and be bored and you will complain about it every day."

"And the house?"

"The house will keep. It kept while you were in the palace and in the Senate and in the prefect's courtyard. It will keep while you are in Baiae." Tertulla took her hand. "You have spent your whole life being necessary. Try being unnecessary for a month. It will not kill you."

Cassia looked at the garden, and the roses, and the three Graces with their painted hands on one another's shoulders.

"Perhaps," she said. "In the spring. When the boy has decided."

"Then in the spring," Tertulla said, and poured her another cup.

They sat up for another hour, talking about the shipping venture and the price of Egyptian wheat and a senator's wife who had run off with a charioteer, and then Tertulla called for her cloak and her litter and went home, and the house settled.

After she had gone, Cassia went out into the garden with a lamp.

It was a clear night and cold enough for a cloak, and the roses were cut back and the fountain was off and the fig tree stood in the corner like a man with his hands in his pockets. She set the lamp on the wall and stood for a while in the dark, and then she went back inside and up the stairs and opened the door of the room at the top.

It had been dusted that morning, because it was dusted every morning. There was a bed with clean linen on it and a stool and a chest and a small window that looked out over the roof of the bakery next door, and on the chest there was a cup: one of the six, red-glossed and thin-walled, with a bird pressed into the bottom of it.

She had put it there in November, on the day the box came, and she had not told anyone. It was not a shrine. It was not a claim. It was a cup on a chest in a

room that nobody used, waiting for a man who had asked her name twice and had been given nothing but cups.

"Some day," she said, to the room, to the cup, to nobody at all. "Some day I will tell him."

Then she shut the door and went down to the accounts.

CHAPTER

# TWENTY-FOUR

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There was no speech. She had thought about writing one, and had got as far as the second line, and had put the tablet in the fire, because she had learned that speeches are for the Senate and that a room with a potter in it is not the Senate.

She spent the night before in the kitchen with Thais and Ione and Celer, and they drank wine and did not talk about the visit, and at midnight Celer made a cake that nobody wanted, and at one in the morning Sabina came down in her nightgown and sat on the bench and said, "Is he nice?"

"I do not know," Cassia said. "He makes cups and he laughs at things in doorways and he has a father who calls him in to supper."

"That does not tell you if he is nice."

"No," Cassia said. "It tells you that he is loved. It is not the same thing, but it is a good start."

At two in the morning Thais sent everyone to bed and sat with Cassia in the empty kitchen.

"There is a room at the top of the stairs," she said. "It has been empty for twenty-four years. If he comes, it will not be a room for him. He has a room. He has a house and a father and a trade. He does not need a room."

"I know."

"Then why have you been up there all week, dusting?"

Cassia looked at her hands. "Because it is the only thing I can do," she said. "I cannot give him back the twenty-four years. I cannot make his mother alive again. I cannot undo what was done to him or to me or to his father. I can dust a room and put clean linen on the bed and open the window, and that is all, and it is ridiculous, and I am going to do it anyway."

Thais reached across the table and took her hand.

"It is not ridiculous," she said. "It is the most sensible thing you have done in a year."

It had taken three weeks to arrange, and it had been arranged in the way that everything important in Cassia's life was arranged: by letter, by patience, and by other people's courage.

She had written to Gaius Vibidius three days after the cups came, in the last week of November, and he had not answered. She had written again a week later, and he had come to the house in the rain at the beginning of December and stood in the tablinum with his apron in his hands and said, "I cannot do it. I have tried four times. The words will not come out of my mouth."

"Then I will say them," Cassia said.

"He will hate me."

"He will not hate you. He may hate me. He has a right to." She had looked at him across the desk. "But he is twenty-four years old, and he has a father who has lied to him for four months, and every day that we wait is a day that he spends knowing that something is wrong and being told that it is not. He is not a child. He is a man with a trade and a girl in Ostia and a great deal of patience, and he deserves better than a lie."

The potter had cried then, quietly, into his apron, and Cassia had sat with him until he stopped.

"Bring him to the shop on the day before the Ides," she said. "I will come in the morning. Tell him that a lady is coming who has been his patron, and that she has something to tell him, and that he is to hear her out and not to speak until she is done. And be there. Whatever he says to me, be there, because he will need to look at a face he trusts."

The potter had nodded and gone out into the rain.

The Via Ostiensis was loud in the morning. Carts going down to the river and carts coming up from it, porters with sacks on their shoulders, a man with a wheelbarrow full of fish, two women arguing over a basket of onions, a dog asleep in the middle of the road and refusing to move. The potter's shop stood on the corner of a lane with a fig tree beside the door and a yard behind it where the kiln was, and the smoke from the kiln went up into the grey December air and smelled of hot clay and wood ash.

Cassia came on foot, with Bathyllus behind her and Corvinus beside her, and they stopped at the corner of the lane and looked at the shop.

"I do not know if I can do this," Corvinus said.

"You can."

"I have spoken in the Senate a hundred times. I have stood in front of the emperor. I have been accused of murdering my father and I did not shake." He looked at the door. "And I am standing in a street on the Via Ostiensis and my hands are shaking."

"That is because the Senate did not matter," Cassia said. "This does."

Gaius Vibidius came out of the shop and saw them and wiped his hands on his apron and came to meet them.

"He is in the yard," he said. "I have told him that there is a lady who has been his patron, and that she has something to tell him, and that it is important and that he is to listen. He thinks it is about money." The potter's mouth twisted. "He asked me if he was to be apprenticed somewhere else. He asked me if I was selling the shop."

"Did you tell him anything else?"

"No. I said that I would be there, and that his mother would have wanted him to hear it, and that was all." He looked at Corvinus. "You are the senator."

"I am."

"You look like him." The potter said it without warmth. "He has your jaw. I have been looking at it for twenty-four years and I did not know what it was until this summer."

Corvinus said nothing. The potter turned and led them through the shop and out into the yard.

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The yard was small and busy: racks of drying pots, a table with tools, a boy of twelve turning a wheel in the corner, a shed with the kiln in it, and a great heap of clay under a wet cloth. The young man was standing at the table with a cup in his hand, turning it over, looking at the rim.

He looked up when they came in.

He was tall — taller than Corvinus, taller than Cassia had remembered — and he had his sleeves rolled up over his forearms and his hands and his arms were grey with clay to the elbow, and his hair was the colour of dark honey and needed cutting. He had the family jaw and the family nose and his father's eyes, and he was, Cassia thought, the most beautiful thing she had ever seen.

"Domina," he said, and put the cup down. "My father says you have something to tell me."

"Sit down," Cassia said.

"I would rather stand."

"Then stand." She looked at him. "My name is Antonia Cassia. I keep a house on the Esquiline. I am a freedwoman and I have been free for sixteen years, and before that I was a slave, and before that I was a girl in a kitchen at a villa in Tibur." She paused. "And twenty-four years ago, in the autumn, I gave birth to a son in a cell at the back of that villa, and I was told that he had died, and I was sold to a house in Puteoli three days later."

The young man looked at her. His face did not change.

"I do not understand," he said.

"You are the son," Cassia said. "Your name is Gaius Vibidius Nestor, and you were born on the twenty-eighth of September in the year of the consulship of Domitian and Silanus, and you were sold to Gaius Vibidius, potter, of the Via Ostiensis, for four hundred sesterces, and you have been raised by him as his own." She paused. "And I have spent twenty-four years believing you were dead."

The yard was very quiet. The boy at the wheel had stopped turning. The kiln hissed. The young man looked at her, and then at his father, and then at Corvinus, and his face was doing something complicated: not disbelief, not grief, but the slow, terrible work of a mind rearranging everything it had ever known.

"My mother," he said. "My mother is dead. She died when I was small."

"Your mother is the woman who raised you, and she is dead, and I am sorry for it," Cassia said. "I am not her. I am the woman who gave birth to you. There is a difference, and I do not know yet what it is worth."

"Who are you?" He turned to Corvinus. "Who is he?"

Corvinus stepped forward. "My name is Lucius Sulpicius Corvinus. I am a senator. I was twenty years old in the summer of eighty-eight, and I was in love with the girl in the kitchen, and I was told that she had died in childbirth and that the child had died with her." His voice was steady. "I did not know you existed until this year. I did not know that she was alive. I have spent twenty-four years believing that I had killed you both."

The young man looked at him for a long time. Then he said, "You are my father."

"Yes."

"And you"—he turned to Cassia—"are my mother."

"Yes."

"And my father"—he turned to Gaius Vibidius—"is my father."

"Yes," the potter said. "I bought you, and I raised you, and I have loved you every day since I carried you through that door in a basket, and I did not know that you had a mother who was alive, and if I had known I would have told you." His voice broke. "I would have told you. I want you to believe that."

The young man looked at the three of them standing in the yard.

"I need to sit down," he said.

* * *

They sat in the back room of the shop, on stools, with the door open to the yard and the smell of clay coming in. The potter brought a jug of water and a cup for each of them, and they sat in a row like people at a funeral.

Cassia told him everything. She did not spare herself and she did not spare Corvinus and she did not spare the old woman. She told him about the vineyard and the store-room and the book of poems. She told him about the night and the cup and the cry. She told him about Puteoli, and the green door, and Thais, and the four years. She told him about the fire and the trial and the empress and the sealed record. She told him about the chest of jewellery and the money that was waiting for him and the letter the old woman had written with a shaking hand.

It took an hour.

The young man listened without interrupting. Twice he got up and walked to the door and stood looking out at the yard, and came back and sat down. Once he put his face in his hands and sat like that for a long time.

"Tell me about her," he said, when Cassia had finished the first part. "My mother. The one who raised me. What did she look like?"

Cassia looked at Gaius Vibidius. The potter's face was working.

"She was small and brown and she had a laugh that carried," the potter said. "She could not have children of her own and she prayed at the temple of Juno Lucina for six years, and when I brought you home in a basket she sat down on

the floor of the kitchen and cried for an hour, and then she got up and made you a bed in a drawer." He wiped his face. "She died when you were seven. She had a fever and it took her in three days. She called for you at the end. She made me promise to keep you and raise you and never tell you that you were bought, because she was afraid that if you knew, you would think that she had loved you less."

The young man's face was wet.

"I do not remember her," he said. "I remember a woman singing. I remember a hand on my forehead."

"That is her," the potter said. "That is all any of us get."

Cassia sat very still. She had spent twenty-four years imagining this room, and in every version of it she had been the mother, and the boy had been hers, and the woman who had raised him had been a shadow. She had not imagined this: a boy with two mothers and a father who had bought him, and all of them sitting in a room with a jug of water, and nothing to be done about any of it.

"Tell me about the girl," Cassia said, when the worst of it was out. "Your father says there is a girl in Ostia."

The young man looked up, startled, and then his face changed in a way that Cassia would remember for the rest of her life: the face of a man who has been braced for blows and is offered a chair.

"Her name is Vibia," he said. "She is a potter's daughter too. Her father has a yard by the river and he is getting old, and she runs the accounts and the slaves and the carting, and she shouts at the porters." He stopped. "She is not beautiful. She is better than beautiful. She is the sort of woman who walks into a yard and everyone stops arguing."

"She will need to be," Cassia said.

"She does not know anything about any of this."

"Then you will have to tell her. Not tonight. But you will have to tell her, because a secret like this one does not keep, and because if you marry her and she finds out from someone else, she will never forgive you, and she will be right." Cassia paused. "And when you tell her, tell her all of it. Not the version that makes me look well. The version that is true."

The young man looked at her for a moment. Then he said, "You are very like my father. He says the same thing. He says, 'Tell it all, and let them decide.'"

"Then he is a wise man, and you should listen to him."

He was quiet for a while. The kiln hissed, and somewhere beyond the wall a cart went by, and the boy at the wheel began to sing under his breath.

"Did you look for me?" he said.

"Yes," Cassia said. "Every day. For twenty-four years. I did not know your name or where you were, and I looked for you in every crowd, in every street, in every face. I have a room at the top of my house that I have kept empty for twenty-four years because I could not bear to give it to anyone else." She paused. "And I did not look hard enough. I should have gone to every potter in Rome. I should have walked the Via Ostiensis twenty years ago. I did not, because I was afraid, and because I had built a house and a business and a wall, and because I told myself that the child was dead and that looking for him was a kind of madness." She looked at him. "I was wrong. I have been wrong for twenty-four years, and I am sorry."

He looked at her for a long time.

"Why did you give me up?" he said.

"I did not give you up. You were taken from me while I was asleep. I woke up and the room was clean and the midwife told me that you had never breathed, and I was on a cart to Puteoli three days later." Cassia's voice was steady. "I have spent twenty-four years believing that you were dead. I did not give you up. I was robbed of you. There is a difference, and I need you to understand it, because if you go away from this room thinking that I chose to leave you, then the woman who sold you will have won."

The young man put his face in his hands and sat like that for a long time.

"I am angry," he said, at last. "I do not know at who. At her, I suppose. At the old woman. At the banker and the senator and the men with the farm. At you, a little. At my father, a little. At the whole of it." He looked up. "Is that allowed?"

"It is allowed," Cassia said. "It is the most sensible thing you have said all morning."

Then he said, "What do you want from me?"

"Nothing," Cassia said.

"Everyone wants something."

"Yes," she said. "Everyone does. But I am not going to ask you for anything today. I am going to tell you that I am here, and that I have been here for six months, and that I will be here in the spring, and that if you want to know me,

you know where I live. And if you do not want to know me, I will understand, and I will not come to this shop again, and once a year your father will send me a message to tell me that you are alive, and that will be enough."

The young man looked at her. His eyes were his father's eyes, and they were wet.

"You have been here for six months," he said.

"Yes."

"You paid for the kiln."

"Yes."

"You wrote to me about the cups."

"Yes."

"And you did not tell me your name."

"No."

"Why?"

"Because I did not want to give you a name that you had not asked for," Cassia said. "Because a person who is told that his whole life has been a lie does not need a stranger at the door with a story. He needs time." She paused. "And because I was afraid."

The young man laughed — a short, broken, entirely unexpected laugh. "You were afraid?"

"I have been afraid every day for twenty-four years," Cassia said. "I was afraid in the cell. I was afraid in Puteoli. I was afraid in the Senate. And I was afraid of you, because you are the only person in the world whose opinion of me matters, and because I did not know whether you would hate me."

He looked at her for a long moment. Then he said, "I do not hate you."

"You may, in a week. It is a great deal to take in."

"I know." He stood up. "I need to work. I need to put my hands in the clay and make something, and think about it, and I cannot do that with three people looking at me." He looked at each of them. "I am not going to say anything today. I am not going to decide anything today. I am going to go out into that yard and make cups, because that is what I do when I do not know what to do."

"That is a very good way of dealing with it," Cassia said.

"It is the only way I know." He stopped at the door. "Domina. Cassia. If I come to the house on the Esquiline. If I want to know you. What do I call you?"

Cassia looked at him. In the doorway, with the light behind him and the clay on his arms and his father's jaw and his grandmother's eyes, he looked like the answer to a question she had been asking for twenty-four years.

"You call me whatever you like," she said. "I have been called a great many things. I have been called a whore and a freedwoman and a patron and a friend. I have never once been called a mother." She paused. "You may call me Cassia, if you like. That is my name. It is the only thing I have that no one gave me."

He nodded. Then he went out into the yard and picked up a lump of clay and sat down at the wheel, and the boy who had been turning it moved aside, and the wheel began to spin.

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They came out into the shop, and Gaius Vibidius followed them to the door.

"Domina," he said. "A word."

Corvinus went out into the lane. The potter stood in the doorway of his own shop with his apron in his hands and his face grey.

"I have had him for twenty-four years," he said. "I taught him to walk and to read and to throw a pot. I sat up with him when he was sick and I beat him when he was lazy and I have been prouder of him than of anything I have ever made with my hands." He stopped. "And now there is a lady in Rome and a senator on the Palatine and a chest of jewellery and a story about a villa at Tibur, and I am a potter on the Via Ostiensis with a bad chest and a workshop that is mortgaged to my brother."

"You are his father," Cassia said.

"I know that. I am telling you that knowing it does not help." He wiped his face with his apron. "I am afraid that he will go to your house and see the silver and the paintings and the three Graces and the cook and the garden, and he will think: this is what I could have had. And he will look at me and see a man with clay under his nails."

Cassia looked at him. Then she said, "Do you know what he said when I asked him what he does when he does not know what to do?"

"No."

"He said, 'I go out into the yard and make cups, because that is what I do.'" She paused. "That is not a thing he learned from a senator. That is not a thing he learned from a woman with a garden and a cook. That is a thing he learned from

a man who taught him to throw a pot." She put her hand on his arm. "You have given him the only thing that cannot be taken away from him. Not the shop. Not the trade. The knowledge that when the world falls apart, there is something he can do with his hands. I could not have given him that. I could have given him a name and a fortune and a great deal of trouble, and you gave him a craft. Do not tell me that you are less than me. You are the reason he is the man he is, and if he goes to my house and sees the silver, he will come home to yours and tell you about it."

The potter looked at her for a long moment. Then he nodded, once, and went back into the shop.

Cassia and Corvinus stood in the lane outside the shop.

"Well," he said.

"Well."

"He did not throw us out."

"He did not." Cassia looked at the door. "He is a good man. He has a trade and a temper and a father who loves him, and he is going to go out into that yard and make cups, and in a week or a month or a year he will come to the house on the Esquiline and we will have to explain it all over again." She paused. "And I am going to make a mess of it."

"Probably."

"You are supposed to tell me that I will not."

"I have known you for twenty-four years," Corvinus said. "You will make a mess of it, and he will forgive you, and you will make a mess of it again. That is what families are." He looked at her. "I should know. I have been making a mess of mine for twenty years."

They walked back up the Via Ostiensis in the cold, and at the gate of the city Cassia stopped and looked back at the lanes and the workshops and the smoke.

"I am not going to Baiae," she said.

"What?"

"Tertulla wants me to go to Baiae in the spring. To be bored. To sit in the sun." Cassia turned. "I am not going. I am going to stay in Rome, and I am going to be here when he comes, and if he does not come, I am going to be here anyway."

Corvinus looked at her. Then he took her arm, and they went through the gate together into the city.

That evening Corvinus came to the house, and they sat in the tablinum with the lamp between them and did not say anything for a while.

"He asked me what I did," Corvinus said. "In the yard, when you were talking to his father. He asked me what a senator does all day, and I said that a senator listens to other men talk and then talks himself, and he looked at me as though I had told him that I spent my days counting clouds." He laughed. "He asked me if I had ever made anything with my hands. I said that I had made speeches. He said that was not the same thing, and he was right."

"He is twenty-four," Cassia said. "At twenty-four everyone is certain of everything."

"At forty-five I am certain of nothing." He turned the cup. "I have lost the Asian command and the augurate and the house on the Palatine and the name that my father spent his life protecting. My mother is dead and my father is a fraud and my son is a potter who thinks I am useless. And I am sitting in a room with a woman I have loved since I was twenty, and I am happier than I have been in twenty years." He looked up. "What does that make me?"

"A man who has finally got what he wanted," Cassia said.

"I did not want any of this."

"No," she said. "That is why it is funny."

Two days later, a boy came to the green door on the Esquiline with a parcel wrapped in cloth.

There was no letter. Inside the cloth there was a cup — the same red-glossed ware, thin-walled, with the bird on the bottom — and round the rim, scratched into the clay before firing, in a rough and unpractised hand, were four words.

*For the house. From Gaius.*

Cassia stood in the kitchen with the cup in her hands and looked at it for a long time. Then she set it on the shelf above the hearth, next to the cups that had cost her a fortune, and she said, "Nobody is to use this cup. Nobody is to wash it. It is to stay on that shelf until I die, and then it is to be given to my son."

Thais looked at the cup. "He did not call you mother."

"No."

"He did not call you Cassia either."

"No."

"He called himself Gaius."

"Yes," Cassia said. "He called himself by his own name. He did not call himself my son and he did not call himself yours. He called himself Gaius, and he wrote *from* Gaius, as though the house were his to send things from." She turned the cup over. "That is more than I had this morning."

She went out into the garden. The roses were black stumps and the fountain was off and the sky was the colour of pewter, and she stood in the cold with her hands in her sleeves and looked at the fig tree that she had planted there six years before for no reason she had ever been able to explain to anyone.

Young Sulpicia came on the morning of the Saturnalia, and asked to meet her brother.

She came to the house with her mother, and she sat in the tablinum and said, "He is my brother. I have a right to meet him."

"You have a right to ask," Cassia said. "He has a right to refuse."

"Then ask him."

"I will ask him. But you will have to be patient, and you will have to understand that he has had a great deal to take in in a very short time, and that he does not owe you anything." Cassia paused. "And Sulpicia. If he agrees to meet you, you will not call him your brother. Not the first time. You will call him Gaius, and you will ask him about his work, and you will not tell him about the masks or the house on the Palatine or the trial. He knows about all of it. He does not need to hear it from a girl of sixteen who has had a comfortable life and a good marriage and a grandmother who loved her."

Sulpicia's chin came up, and then went down again.

"That is fair," she said.

"Yes."

"I do not like it."

"No," Cassia said. "But you will do it, because you are clever, and because you have discovered this year that being clever is not the same as being right, and because you want to meet him more than you want to be right."

Sulpicia looked at her. Then she said, "You are a very difficult woman."

"So I am told."

When they had gone she went and sat with Thais and Ione, who were arguing about the seating for that evening, and took the list out of Thais's hand and began to write.

CHAPTER

# TWENTY-FIVE

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The Saturnalia began on the sixteenth day before the Kalends of January, and by the morning of the first day the house on the Esquiline smelled of pine and baking and hot wine and the particular smell of a household that has decided to be happy.

The whole house had been turned upside down, which was the point of the festival. The slaves were served at table by their masters; the children were allowed to give orders and were obeyed with exaggerated solemnity; the cooks were praised and the doorkeepers were given the best seats and the women wore whatever they liked. There were garlands of pine and ivy on every door, and lamps in every window, and a great many small gifts wrapped in cloth and straw and piled on a table in the atrium, and a clay figure of a little man — a sigillum, for the season — on the hearth, which Celer had made and which was, Cassia thought, the ugliest thing she had ever seen.

"You are not to say that in front of him," Thais said. "He is very proud of it."

"It has no face."

"It has a face. It has a face in the style of the old sigilla. It is a Saturnalian figure and it is not supposed to have a face."

"It has one eye and a nose and no mouth."

"That is how you know it is Saturnalian," Thais said, and went to see about the wine.

Cassia stood in the atrium and watched the household. Sabina was thirteen now, and she had been given the keys to the linen for the day and was taking her authority extremely seriously. Chrysis and Senno were arranging the presents, and Senno was arguing with her about the order in which they should be given, in a mixture of Latin and his own language that only the two of them understood. Celer was in the kitchen, shouting. Ione was at the accounts, because

Ione had discovered that she liked accounts and that a woman who controls the accounts controls the house. Bathyllus was at the door in a new cloak, greeting the guests, because at the Saturnalia the doorkeeper was the master of ceremonies and Bathyllus had taken to the role with a gravity that was entirely unironic.

She had not always loved the Saturnalia.

When she was a girl in the kitchen at Tibur, the festival had been a day of extra work: the good dishes brought out, the wine mulled, the household fed and the slaves given a cup of the cheap wine and a piece of meat and told to be merry. When she was in Puteoli, the festival had been the busiest night of the year, and she had learned to smile through it and to count the hours until the green door closed. When she had bought the house, she had made the festival her own: the first year, there had been four of them at the table — Cassia, Thais, Hermeros, and a cook who had been paid too much and had left in the spring. Now there were thirty.

She stood in the atrium and watched them arrive and thought about the fact that she had spent twenty-four years making this day into something, and that the something had turned out to be a house full of people who were not obliged to be there.

There was a letter on the table by the door, brought by a palace slave at dawn, and she had not opened it. She opened it now.

It was from the empress's steward, in a careful, correct, wholly impersonal hand. It said that the emperor was well and that the preparations for the Eastern expedition were proceeding. It said that the clerk Primus had died in Campania in November, of a disease of the liver, and that his estate had been confiscated and his name struck from the rolls. And it said that the empress had heard how the household of Antonia Cassia had conducted itself in the summer, and that she had been minded, in the autumn, to write and say so, and had not, because a letter from the palace is a gift with a price on it, and she did not wish to put a price on that one.

And it said: *The empress has read the record of the trial. She thinks the boy has his mother's sense and his father's jaw, and she wishes him a good life. She asks me also to say that a house which frees its people is a house that will be spoken of for a hundred years, and that she is glad to hear that yours has done it.*

Cassia folded the letter and put it in her sleeve.

"Who is it from?" Thais said.

"A woman I have met twice," Cassia said. "She sends her regards, and a suggestion, and she is too well bred to call it one."

The first guests arrived at the fourth hour. Tertulla came with a basket of figs and a new book of poems and a bottle of wine from her own estate. Aemilia came with Corvinus and with young Sulpicia and Aulus, who had grown a beard and had become, since the summer, slightly less of a fool. Publius came late, with a girl on his arm whom nobody had met and whom he introduced as Calpurnia, and who turned out to be the girl from the Subura, the sailor's promised bride, who had not gone to Ostia after all.

Cassia looked at Publius. Publius looked back at her, and his chin came up, and his arm tightened around the girl's waist.

"Domina," he said. "This is Calpurnia. She is my wife."

There was a silence in the atrium.

"Since when?" Cassia said.

"Since the Kalends of November. We were married quietly. My father knows. My mother does not, and I would be grateful if no one told her until after the wine." He swallowed. "I paid the sailor. It took everything I had and a loan from my grandmother's jewellery, and I have not regretted it for a moment."

Cassia looked at the girl. She was perhaps twenty, with a plain, honest, frightened face and a good cloak and her hand in Publius's, and she was looking at the three Graces on the wall as though she expected them to come down and eat her.

"Calpurnia," Cassia said. "Come here."

The girl came. Cassia took her hands.

"Are you happy?" she said.

"Yes, domina."

"Does he make you laugh?"

"He makes me laugh a great deal. He is very foolish."

"Good," Cassia said. "A husband who cannot make you laugh is a husband who will make you cry." She looked at Publius. "You have done a stupid, brave, expensive thing, and I am proud of you, and your father is going to be impossible about it later, because he will be relieved and he does not know how to be relieved without giving a speech."

Publius laughed. Calpurnia looked at Cassia as though she had been told that the monster under the bed was actually a friend of the family.

Aemilia had not moved from her couch.

"Mother," Publius said.

"Calpurnia," Aemilia said, and her voice was perfectly level. "Come here."

The girl went. Aemilia looked at her for a long moment — the plain face, the good cloak, the hands that had been in a poor house and were not ashamed of it — and then she said, "You paid the sailor."

"Publius paid the sailor."

"With my mother-in-law's jewellery."

"With a loan," Publius said, from across the room, "which I am repaying at a rate that would make a Carthaginian blush."

Aemilia closed her eyes for a moment.

"Then you had better be good to her," she said, "because she is the only thing in this family that has not been bought and sold." She held out her hand to Calpurnia. "Sit by me. I have a great many questions, and I intend to ask all of them, and then I intend to be very kind to you for the rest of my life, because I have discovered that being kind is cheaper than being right."

Corvinus, at the head of the table, put his face in his hand.

"You see," he said to Cassia, "this is what my family is. We arrive at a Saturnalia dinner with a secret wife and a scandal and no money, and my wife decides to be gracious about it, and now I have to make a speech."

"You do not have to make a speech."

"I am going to make a speech."

"Please do not make a speech."

He made the speech. It was short and it was very bad, and it ended with the words "and I love all of you, even the ones I have not met," and the whole room drank to it, and Calpurnia cried, and Publius looked at his father with an expression that Cassia had not seen on his face before and would see on it many times afterward.

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Aemilia found her in the garden before dinner, standing by the dry fountain with a cup of wine she had not drunk.

"I have sold the jewellery," Cassia said. "The emeralds went to a woman in the Subura for a sum that would have bought a small house. The rest went to a dealer on the Via Sacra. The money is in the strongbox, and it will go to the boy in the spring, when he has decided what he wants to do with the shop."

"He will be rich," Aemilia said.

"He will be comfortable. There is a difference." Cassia turned. "I have been thinking about your mother-in-law."

"So have I. I think about her every day. I think about her sitting in that chair and giving orders and never once apologising for anything." Aemilia's mouth moved. "And I think about the fact that she left the jewellery to you and not to my daughter, and that I have been angry about it for six months, and that I am not angry any more."

"What changed?"

"You did. You sold it and gave the money to the boy, and you did not keep a single piece, and you did not make a speech about it." Aemilia looked at her. "I would have kept the emeralds. I would have told myself that I was keeping them for my daughter, and I would have kept them, and I would have been wrong." She paused. "You are not a good woman, Cassia. But you are a better one than I am, and I have decided to stop pretending otherwise."

Cassia laughed. "That is the nicest thing anyone has said to me all year."

"It is not a compliment."

"No," Cassia said. "It is better."

The dinner was in the garden room, because the painted dining room was still being repaired, and the garden room had been hung with so many lamps and garlands that it looked like a cave in a fairy tale. There were thirty people at three tables, which was too many, and the food was too much, and the wine was excellent, and at some point in the second course Bathyllus stood up and made a speech about the dignity of doorkeepers that reduced the whole table to tears of laughter.

Cassia sat at the head of the middle table with Corvinus on one side and Tertulla on the other, and she looked down the room at the faces: Aemilia, who had become, over the year, something between a friend and an ally and a sparring partner; young Sulpicia, who was arguing with her husband about a gladiator; Publius and Calpurnia, who were feeding each other figs in a way that would have been nauseating if it had not been so obviously sincere; Sabina, who had

been allowed a glass of wine and was behaving as though she had been given the keys to the city; Chrysis and Senno, who were sitting together and laughing at something Celer had said; Ione, who was wearing a dress the colour of a peacock and looking, for the first time in years, entirely at home.

"It is a good house," Corvinus said, quietly.

"It is a good house," Cassia said.

"Last year at this time I was in my mother's atrium, listening to her complain about the arrangements, and you were here, eating with your household, and neither of us knew that the other was alive." He turned his cup. "It has been the worst year of my life."

"And?"

"And the best. Both. I do not know how that is possible."

"It is possible," Cassia said, "because the worst things and the best things are usually the same things, seen from different ends."

At the end of the meal, when the tables had been cleared and the lamps were burning low, Cassia stood up and said, "I have a gift for the household. It is not the sort of gift that is usually given at the Saturnalia, and I am going to give it now because I am the mistress of this house and because I am too old to wait for the last day."

She took a roll of papers from her sleeve.

"These are manumission papers. There are nine of them. Thais and Hermeros and Bathyllus are already free and have been for years. But Sabina, Chrysis, Senno, Celer, and the five others whose names are on these papers are free as of today, by my hand, before witnesses, with the money for their freedom paid out of my own account and a sum for each of them to start a new life." She paused. "You may stay in this house, all of you, as free people, with wages and a contract and the right to leave. Or you may go, with my blessing and my recommendation and my friendship. There is no condition. There is no debt. There is nothing to be paid back."

The room was silent.

Sabina was the first to move. She stood up, white-faced, and said, "Domina. Are we to be turned out?"

"No," Cassia said. "You are to be free. It is not the same thing."

"But where will I go?"

"Wherever you like. You are thirteen years old and you can read and write and do sums and you have a purse of your own and you will always have a room in this house." Cassia's voice was not quite steady. "You can stay here until you are grown and then you can go and be a bookkeeper or a merchant or the wife of a ship's captain or anything you like, and no one will ever be able to sell you, and no one will ever be able to put you on a rope, and you will never have to stand in a market with a placard around your neck."

Sabina stared at her. Then she burst into tears and ran around the table and threw her arms around Cassia, and then the whole room was on its feet, and Celer was crying openly, and Chrysis had her hand over her mouth, and Senno was standing very still with a look on his face that Cassia would remember for the rest of her life.

Bathyllus did not move from the door. He stood with his hands folded in front of him, in his new cloak, with the gravity of a man who has been given the keys to the city.

"Bathyllus," Cassia said.

"Domina."

"You have been free for eleven years. Why are you still standing at my door?"

"Because it is my door," Bathyllus said. "I have been offered better doors. There was a man in Ostia who wanted me to run his warehouse, and a man on the Caelian who offered me twice the money and a house of my own, and I turned them both down and did not tell you, because you would have made a speech about it." He looked at the room, at the crying and the laughing and the papers in people's hands. "A freedman who works for wages at a door he chose is not the same as a slave who stands at one he was given. I wanted to choose it. I have chosen it. I will go on choosing it until I am too old to open the door."

Cassia looked at him. Then she said, "You are the best man in this house."

"I am the doorkeeper," Bathyllus said. "It is nearly the same thing."

Thais came and stood beside her and said, quietly, "You did not tell me."

"I did not want you to talk me out of it."

"I would not have talked you out of it." Thais looked at the room. "You have just given away your entire household."

"No," Cassia said. "I have just hired a household. It is more expensive. It is also better."

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The boy came at the end of the evening, when the lamps were low and the guests were going and the house was full of the warm, tired, satisfied noise of a feast that has gone well.

He came to the garden door with his father, and he was wearing a clean tunic and his hair was wet from being combed, and he stood in the doorway of the garden room with a parcel in his hands and looked at the thirty people and the lamps and the three Graces on the wall.

"Gaius," Cassia said.

"Domina." He held out the parcel. "I made this. For the Saturnalia. It is not much."

She unwrapped it. It was a small clay lamp, well made, with a handle and a spout and a pattern of vine leaves around the rim, and on the bottom, pressed into the clay, was the bird.

"It is beautiful," she said.

"It is a lamp," he said. "It is the thing I make most of. Everyone needs a lamp." He looked around the room again. "My father said I should come. He said that a man who is invited to a house at the Saturnalia and does not go is a man who is afraid."

"Are you afraid?"

"Yes." He looked at her. "But I came."

Cassia looked at him. Then she set the lamp down on the table and said, "Come and meet the household. There are a great many of them and they have all been asking about you, and they will all want to tell you their opinions, and you do not have to listen to any of them."

She took him into the room. Thais was the first to come forward, and then Celer, and then Sabina, who had been crying and had washed her face and was now very composed, and then Ione, who looked at him for a long moment and said, "You have your mother's eyes," and then young Sulpicia, who had been waiting all evening and who came forward and said, "I am Sulpicia. I am your sister. I have been told not to say that, but I am going to say it anyway."

He looked at her. Then he laughed — the same laugh, the young man's laugh, surprised out of him — and said, "I have never had a sister."

"Now you have two," young Sulpicia said. "I am the difficult one."

The room filled up around him. Somebody gave him a cup of wine. Somebody asked him about the kiln. Somebody else asked him about the price of clay, and he began, hesitantly at first and then with more confidence, to explain the difference between the clay from the Tiber and the clay from the hills, and the whole room listened as though he were describing the campaigns of Caesar.

Cassia stood at the edge of it and watched.

"Look at him," Corvinus said, at her shoulder.

"I am looking."

"He is talking about clay to a room full of senators and their wives."

"Yes."

"And they are listening."

"Yes," Cassia said. "That is because he is the only person in this room who knows what he is talking about."

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The guests went at midnight. The household went to bed. The lamps were put out one by one, and the house settled into the dark with the particular peace of a house that has been full and is now empty and is glad of both.

Cassia went out into the garden. It was cold and clear and the stars were very bright, and the fountain was turned off for the winter and the roses were black stumps, and she stood in the middle of it with her hands in her sleeves and looked up at the sky.

Corvinus came out and stood beside her.

"You should be in bed," he said.

"So should you."

"I am too old to be told what to do."

"You are forty-five. You are not old."

"I am old enough to know what I have missed." He looked at the house. "The boy is asleep in the room at the top of the stairs. He came to the door an hour ago and asked whether he might stay, because his father's house is on the other side of the city and it is cold and he has had a great deal of wine. And you said yes, and he went up the stairs, and I stood at the bottom and watched him go, and I thought: that is my son, going up the stairs of my — of her house, to sleep in a room that has been empty for twenty-four years."

"It is not empty now," Cassia said.

"No." He was quiet for a moment. "What happens now?"

"What do you mean?"

"Next year. And the year after. The emperor is going East; there is a war coming with Parthia, everyone says so. My son is a potter who has just discovered that his father is a senator and his grandmother was a murderer and his mother is the most famous woman in Rome. My daughter is married to a fool and is cleverer than all of us. My wife has discovered that she likes running a house and does not like me very much, and I do not blame her." He turned. "What happens now?"

Cassia looked at the sky.

"Now we get up in the morning," she said, "and we eat breakfast, and the boy goes back to his workshop, and you go to the Senate and vote for something you do not care about, and I go to the market and argue about the price of fish, and life goes on." She paused. "That is what happens. It is not a story. There is no ending. There is just the next day, and the next, and the next, and you fill them with what you can."

"That is a very bleak answer."

"It is a very honest one," Cassia said. "I have spent my whole life waiting for the ending. The moment when I would be safe. The moment when the past would be buried. The moment when the boy would come home and everything would be resolved. And what I have discovered, at forty-two, is that there is no such moment. There is only the house, and the people in it, and the work, and the fact that you have to keep doing it." She looked at him. "I used to think that was a tragedy. Now I think it is the only thing worth having."

Corvinus looked at her for a long time.

"I love you," he said.

"I know."

"You are supposed to say it back."

"I love you," Cassia said. "I have loved you since I was eighteen years old, and I have hated you for most of that time, and I am going to go on doing both for the rest of my life, and you are going to have to live with it."

"That seems fair."

"It is not fair at all. It is what there is."

He laughed. They stood in the garden for a while longer, and then the cold got into their bones, and they went inside, and Cassia went up the stairs and

stopped at the door of the room at the top of the stairs and listened to the boy breathing.

Then she went to her own room and slept.

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In the morning, the boy came down to breakfast.

He came into the kitchen with his hair standing up and his tunic creased, and he sat down at the table with the household, and Celer gave him bread and honey and a cup of hot wine, and Sabina asked him a question about the kiln, and Thais told her to let him eat, and Ione asked him whether he had slept well, and he said that he had, and that the bed was very soft, and that he had never slept in a bed that soft in his life.

Cassia came down late. The household was at the table, all of them, and the boy was in the middle of it, and he looked up when she came in and said, "Domina. Good morning."

"Good morning, Gaius."

"I have been thinking," he said. "About the shop. My father is getting old and his chest is bad, and he cannot manage the kiln on his own. I am going to need a partner, or an apprentice, or someone who can keep the accounts." He paused. "And I have been told that you are very good at accounts."

Cassia stood in the doorway of the kitchen with the cold air behind her and the warm room in front of her.

"I am the best in Rome," she said.

"Then perhaps we could do business," the boy said. "Not as mother and son. As two people who make things and sell them." He looked at her. "We could start there."

Cassia looked at him for a long moment. Then she came into the kitchen and sat down at the table and said, "We could start there."

The household went on with its breakfast. Outside, the city was waking up, and the New Year was a fortnight away, and the emperor was preparing a war in the East that would take him away from Rome and would not bring him back, and the boy in the kitchen was talking about clay, and the woman at the head of the table was listening.

The house on the Esquiline had a hole in its wall that had been patched with new tiles, and a room at the top of the stairs that was no longer empty, and a shelf above the hearth with a cup on it that nobody was allowed to use.

On the last day of December she took him out through the Porta Esquilina to see the grave.

It was a small stone, well cut, with the inscription that had cost her more than the stone: A GOOD BOY, WHO FED THE PIGEONS. There was a jar of dried flowers at the foot of it, and a bowl of water for the birds, and the ground around it had been swept.

"Who was he?" Gaius said.

"A boy in my house. He was eleven years old and he came to me from the market two years before he died, and he had the pigeons and the yard, and he did it well." Cassia looked at the stone. "In March there was a fire in this house. It was set by men who wanted to frighten me. Nolus was in a passage with a door that had been bolted from the other side, and he could not get out."

The boy was silent for a while.

"You put up a stone for a slave."

"I put up a stone for a boy who fed the pigeons." She looked at him. "You will hear, in the next year or two, a great many things about me. Some of them will be true. Some of them will be the kind of thing that is said about a woman who has money and no husband. And in the middle of it there will be this: that I had a boy in my house who was eleven years old, and he died in a fire that was meant for me, and I have never once been able to make that right." She paused. "I have spent my whole life trying to buy my way out of that. I bought a house and a business and a name and a great many other things, and none of it has worked. The only thing that has ever worked is a stone and a bowl of water and a morning in the year when the whole household comes out here and stands in the cold."

Gaius put his hand in his sleeve and brought out something wrapped in cloth.

"I made this," he said. "I did not know what it was for. I made it in the summer, when I did not know what to do with my hands."

It was a pigeon. Small, rough, fired in the kiln until it was the colour of a wet roof, with its head turned and its feet tucked in, and it was not a beautiful object, but it was exactly a pigeon.

"You made this in the summer," Cassia said.

"Yes."

"Before you knew about me."

"Yes." He turned it over in his hands. "My father said I should bring you something for the Saturnalia. I brought the lamp. But I brought this as well, and I did not know why, and I have been carrying it around for a week trying to think of a reason to give it to you, and I could not think of one." He set it at the foot of the stone, beside the bowl of water. "I still cannot. But it belongs here, I think."

Cassia looked at the small rough pigeon on the ground, and at the boy standing beside her with clay under his nails, and she did not say anything for a long time, because there was nothing to say that was not either too much or too little.

"His name was Nolus," she said, at last. "You will come out here with us in March. Every year. The whole household comes, and we stand in the cold, and Celer says something that makes everyone laugh when they should be crying, and then we go home and eat too much."

"All right," Gaius said.

"All right?"

"All right." He looked at the stone. "I did not know him. But I know what it is to be a boy in a house that is not your own, and to be given a thing to look after." He crouched down and straightened the jar of flowers. "I will come in March."

They walked back through the gate in the grey afternoon, and the city closed over them, and Cassia did not look back at the grave, because she had learned, after twenty-four years, that looking back at a thing you cannot change is a way of torturing yourself, and she had had enough of it.

She lived another twenty-two years.

She saw the emperor leave for the East in the autumn of the following year, and did not see him come back; he died at Selinus in the summer of 117, and the empire passed to a man nobody had expected, and the city held its breath and then let it out again and went on buying and selling and arguing as it always did. She saw the new emperor build a wall in Britain and a temple in Rome and a great many buildings in between. She saw the boy marry Vibia, the potter's daughter from Ostia, and have three children, and she saw the eldest of them learn to throw a pot on his grandfather's wheel. She saw Sabina grow up and go

into business with a ship's captain and come back every Saturnalia with a purse full of money and a great many opinions. She saw Ione buy a house of her own and run it as a lodging house for respectable women and make a fortune at it. She saw Aemilia and Corvinus grow old together in the small house on the Esquiline, in a marriage that was not a love story and was something better: a partnership of two people who had been through a war and had decided to be kind to each other afterward.

She never married. She never left Rome. She went to Baiae once, in the spring of 114, and was bored for a month, and came home and said that she had been right about being bored and that she intended to be bored again the following year, and did not go.

She kept the house until the end. She kept the accounts until the end; Ione did the sums, but Cassia read every page. She kept the three Graces in the alcove, and the cup on the shelf above the hearth, and the room at the top of the stairs, which was never empty again after the Saturnalia of that year.

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It was a good house. It had been built out of appetite and debt and fear and a great deal of money, and it had been burned and rebuilt and dragged through the courts and the Senate and the streets, and it was still standing, and the people in it were free, and the past had come due and been paid.

That was all. That was the whole of it. A woman had built a house, and the house had held, and the people in it had lived.

# AUTHOR'S NOTE

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This is a novel, and almost everyone in it is invented. The city is not.

The Rome of this book is the Rome of Trajan: a city of roughly a million people, of whom perhaps a third were slaves or freed people; a city of insulae six and seven storeys high, of narrow streets and open sewers and the constant noise of carts, of a grain supply that could starve it in a fortnight if the ships from Egypt were late. It was a city with a Senate that had lost most of its power and all of its illusions, and a bureaucracy of imperial freedmen who had never held office and ran everything. It was a city where a woman like Cassia — a freedwoman with money, a household, and no husband — could own property, make contracts, lend at interest, and be received by the great, and could still be reminded at any moment, by any man, exactly what she had been.

The procedures in the novel are as close as I could make them. A charge of parricide was tried before the Senate, sitting as a court, with a consul presiding; the prosecutor and the defence spoke; witnesses were examined; the verdict was delivered by the house and the penalty by the emperor's discretion. The *poena cullei* — the sack, the serpent, the water — was a real punishment for the murder of a parent, and it had been on the statute book for centuries, and men as sophisticated as Pliny still discussed it seriously. The *delatores*, the informers who brought prosecutions for a share of the condemned man's property, were the plague of the age, and every senator knew that a rival's ambition could arrive at his door in the shape of a clerk with a tablet.

The law of status is the quiet engine of the book. A slave had no name of his own that the law recognised, no property, no marriage, no children who belonged to him. A freedman took the name of the man who had freed him and wore it for the rest of his life, and his children after him. A child born to a slave woman belonged to her master, and could be sold, given away, or exposed at the door, and none of this was murder or kidnapping or anything at all. What happens to Cassia at Tibur happened to women constantly, and the men who did it

were not villains by the standards of their world. That is the horror of it, and I have tried not to soften it.

A few liberties, declared honestly. The villa at Tibur, the Sulpicii, the banker Sittius, the informer Pactus, the clerk Primus, Psyche, the potter and his son, and Cassia herself are all invented. The events of 88 are invented. The emperor's household in the novel is drawn from what is known of Trajan's court and Plotina's influence, and no more than that; the emperor's secretary is a fiction of a real type. Nolus's grave is invented; the ground outside the Porta Esquilina where the poor were buried is not. The names of the months, the days of the festival, and the counting of the Kalends have been checked as carefully as I could manage, and if a date is wrong it is my error and not the calendar's.

The book's central question is not who killed Marcus Sulpicius Corvinus. It is what a woman does with the twenty-four years she is given after everything has been taken from her. Cassia's answer — the house, the accounts, the clients, the garden, the three Graces in the alcove, the door with the green paint — is not a heroic answer. It is the answer most people give, in one form or another, and I have come to think it is the better for that.

I owe thanks to the staff of several libraries, to the translators of Pliny's letters and Juvenal's satires, to the epigraphers whose work on the *columbaria* of the great households made the household in this book possible, and to the friends who read the manuscript in pieces and told me, kindly and repeatedly, where it sagged.

Any errors are mine. The pigeons are Nolus's.

# A GLOSSARY OF TERMS

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**Amphora —** a tall two-handled clay jar for wine, oil, or fish sauce. Made in millions, stacked in warehouses, and broken up for rubble when empty.

**Annona —** the grain supply of the city, and the department that ran it. A prefect of the annona was a senior equestrian official; a delay in the Egyptian fleet could empty the bakeries in a week.

**A rationibus —** literally "for accounts": the imperial freedman in charge of the emperor's finances. One of the most powerful men in Rome, and, by law, a nobody.

**Atrium —** the main hall of a Roman house, opening off the street, where clients were received and the masks of the ancestors were displayed.

**Augur —** a member of the college of augurs, who took the auspices. An augurate was a great honour and, for a man like Corvinus, the whole of his public identity.

**Caldarium —** the hot room of a bath complex.

**Client —** a man who attended a patron in the morning, accompanied him in the forum, and voted as he was told, in return for legal help, loans, and a dinner. The morning *salutatio* was a performance of rank, and the size of a man's crowd was the measure of his standing.

**Cognomen —** the third name of a Roman citizen, often a family nickname: Corvinus, "the raven."

**Consular —** a man who had held the consulship. The senior rank in the Senate, and the one that gave its holder the right to speak first.

**Delator —** an informer who brought a prosecution in the hope of a share of the condemned man's estate. Loathed, feared, and employed.

**Denarius —** a silver coin, roughly a day's wage for a skilled workman. A sestertius was a quarter of a denarius; a hundred thousand sesterces was a comfortable fortune.

**Eques —** a knight, the second rank of Roman society, below the Senate and above everyone else. Knights ran the treasury, the fleets, and the banks.

**Freedman, freedwoman —** a slave who had been manumitted. Free before the law, a citizen if the manumission was formal, and never quite free of the stain. A freedman took his patron's name; his children were born free and unmarked.

**Insula —** a block of flats, let floor by floor, built high and badly, and burned or fell down with depressing regularity.

**Kalends, Nones, Ides —** the three anchor days of the Roman month. The Kalends was the first; the Nones fell on the fifth or seventh; the Ides on the thirteenth or fifteenth. Days

were counted backwards from the next anchor, inclusively, so that the sixteenth day before the Kalends of January is the seventeenth of December.

**Lictor** — a magistrate's attendant, carrying the fasces, who cleared the way and carried out arrests.

**Manumission** — the formal freeing of a slave, by the rod (*vindicta*), by will, or by census. The master's hold on his slaves was called *dominica potestas*; over his children it was *patria potestas*, and the two were spoken of in the same breath.

**Patron** — the senior partner in the relationship described under *client*. Also the term a freedman used for the man who had freed him, for life.

**Peculium** — the small fund a master allowed a slave to keep and trade with. Legally the master's; in practice the seed of a slave's purchase price, and of his freedom.

**Poena cullei** — "the punishment of the sack": the murderer of a parent was sewn into a leather sack with a dog, a cock, a snake, and a monkey, and thrown into deep water. An ancient and savage penalty, still on the books under the emperors, and debated by jurists with perfect calm.

**Praetor** — a senior magistrate, chiefly concerned with the courts. A praetor's widow is a woman of standing and no money.

**Praefectus annonae** — the prefect of the grain supply, who commanded the harbour police and the river barges and answered for the city's bread.

**Proconsul** — the governor of a province, usually an ex-consul, usually for a year. The Asian command was one of the two or three richest postings in the empire.

**Sestertius** — the standard unit of reckoning: a small brass coin. Fortunes were counted in hundreds of thousands of them; a legionary's annual pay was twelve hundred.

**Sigillum** — a small figurine, usually of clay, given at the Saturnalia. The festival of the sigilla was the *Sigillaria*, the last two days of the holiday.

**Tablinum** — the study or record room of a Roman house, opening off the atrium. Where business was done, letters written, and money counted.

**Triclinium** — the dining room, named for its three couches.

**Vigiles** — the night watch: seven cohorts of freedmen, stationed across the city, whose duties were firefighting, night patrol, and, when required, rough justice.

## A NOTE ON THE SEQUENCE

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The novel opens in December of the year 111, and the trial at its centre takes place in the following summer, in the year in which Gaius Vibidius Nestor turns twenty-four.

The dates in the text are given the Roman way, as the characters would have given them: by the consuls of the year, by the day counted back from the Kalends. For the reader who wants the plain arithmetic: the events at Tibur took place in September and October of 88, in the last years of Domitian; the novel takes place twenty-four years later, in the last years of Trajan; and the epilogue carries the story to the Saturnalia of 112 and beyond it, briefly, to the end.

# ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

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For everyone who has ever kept a house, kept accounts, and kept going.